A Parent's Guide to Education in Alberta

Scripts, not sentiment.

What the school has to do, what to say when it doesn't, and where to go next.

- Plain Language
- Real Scripts
- The Rules and Where to Find Them
- Next Steps



The Alberta Disability System Breakdown
We fight for change

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Edition:
2026–27
SCHOOL YEAR

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✦

CHANTAL TREPANIER

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown
St. Albert, Alberta

A Parent's Guide to Education in Alberta

First edition. Edition: 2026–27 school year.

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Last verified: October 2026. Each chapter carries its own "Last verified" date. Rules change. If the date is more than a year old, check the chapter's live page before you rely on it.

This book is information, not legal advice. It describes what Alberta's published rules say. It cannot tell you what to do about your own child's situation, and it is no substitute for advice from a lawyer, an advocate, or anyone else qualified to give it. If you need advice, get it from someone who can be accountable for giving it to you.

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Set in Cambria.

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What this book is for

It closes one gap: the distance between what an Alberta school is required to do and what a parent knows to ask for.

That gap is not the invention of any one school. The rules exist. They are written down. They are also spread across an Act, a set of regulations, standards from 2004, a ministry guide from 2006, a newer provincial framework and your own division's policy manual — and almost none of it is ever put into a parent's hands. Most of us assemble it the hard way, one meeting at a time, across years we do not get back.

This book puts it in one place, in plain words, before you need it.

On every page, it answers four questions:

— What is actually happening here?

— What does the rule say, and how binding is it?

— What do I say out loud, right now, in under forty words?

— What do I ask for in writing — and what do I do if I don't get it?

It is organised by what you are hearing, not by what the system calls it. When someone is talking at you across a small table, you do not have time to look up "Grade Level of Achievement." You have time to find the words you just heard.

It isn't angry. That is deliberate. A book that argues can be argued with. A book that tells you what the rule says and where it is written can only be answered.

It will not fix the system. It closes the gap between what a school is required to do and what a parent knows to ask for. That gap is where most of us lost our first years.

Who it's for

Parents and guardians of a child with a disability, a diagnosis, a delay — or no label at all yet. At any point from the first "we've noticed something" to the last year of high school.

Parents at the beginning, who have just been handed a form with a word on it they have never heard before.

Parents a long way in, who have been told "it's ongoing" so many times they have stopped expecting a date.

Foster and kinship carers, and grandparents raising grandchildren — anyone who sits in the chair the school calls "the parent".

Advocates, support workers and family navigators who need to point someone at the rule, by name, today.

Teachers, educational assistants and school administrators who would rather parents arrived knowing what the process actually is. Nothing in this book asks a school for more than the province already requires of it.

And it is for anyone who has been told that what they were asking for was too much, and wanted to know, on paper, whether that was true.

You do not need a diagnosis, a lawyer, an advocate or a good day to use this book. You need the page that matches what you were just told.

Foreword

The information every parent wished they had from the beginning.

There is a moment every parent in this book knows.

You are sitting in a small chair at a small table. Someone slides a document across to you. It has your child's name on it and a word you have never heard, and everyone in the room seems to already know what it means. You nod. You sign where they point. You go home and wonder what you just agreed to.

Nobody told you what that document was supposed to contain. Nobody told you that you could take it home and read it first. Nobody told you there were rules, written down, that the school had to follow — or where to find them, or what to say when the answer was "it's ongoing."

That's the gap.

✦

I fell into it. Years of my children's schooling went into it before I understood what I was standing in. I asked the questions I knew how to ask, and I got answers that sounded like answers and weren't. I thought the problem was me. I thought I was asking too much, or asking wrong.

I wasn't. I just didn't have the information. Almost nobody does, at the start.

It exists. It is scattered across an Act, a set of regulations, standards from 2004, a ministry guide from 2006, a new framework and your own division's policy manual, most of which you will never be shown. The only parents who put it together are the ones who fight long enough to find it, piece by piece, at kitchen tables, at two in the morning. By then, their children have lost the years it took.

I did the fighting. I read the Act. I read the regulations. I compared one document to another until the gaps between them were the only thing I could see. And somewhere in all of that I realised that the thing I was building for my own family was the thing every family needed on day one.

✦

So this is it. The information every parent wished they had from the beginning, in one place, in plain words.

It tells you what the rules say and how binding they are. It tells you what to say out loud, in under forty words, when your hands are shaking. It tells you exactly what to ask for in writing, and what to do when you don't get it.

It won't fix the system. But you don't have to lose your first years finding out how it works.

Chantal

A note on the stories in this book

The situations and phrases in these pages come from my own family's years in Alberta schools, and from the parents who write to The Alberta Disability System Breakdown.

Every name, school, place, date, grade, score and diagnosis has been removed. The phrases under "You might be hearing" are written the way any parent in any division might hear them, not as quotes from any one person. Nothing in this book says why anyone did anything. It records what was said, and what the documents show.

The one thing to know about this book

This book is information, not legal advice. If you need advice about your own situation, get it from someone qualified to give it.

How to use this book

Find the page by what you're hearing. You don't need to know what the system calls your problem. Each chapter opens with "Turn here when you're hearing": the words staff say, and the entry that answers them. The deflection dictionary at the back lists them all.

Every entry has the same shape. Once you have used one, you can use them all.

You might be hearing — the words that sent you here.

What's going on — what it means, in plain words.

What the rules say — the rule, where it comes from, and how binding it is.

Say this — what to say out loud, in under forty words.

Ask for this in writing — the exact thing to request afterwards, with a date in it.

If you don't get it — your next step, and the entry where it lives.

Write this down — one line for your notebook.

Your division may also have — where your own division's rules may add to the province's.

Entries are numbered, not paged. 4.7 is the seventh entry in chapter 4. Numbers never change between editions, so "turn to 4.7" means the same thing in every copy. An entry that stops being true is retired, not deleted, and points you to its replacement.

How hard is the rule? Every "What the rules say" names the kind of rule it is. In order of strength:

Law — an Act, such as the Education Act. Binding.

Regulation — rules made under an Act. Binding.

Ministerial order or standard — rules the Minister makes under the Education Act, such as the Standards for Special Education. Binding on school boards.

Provincial policy and guidance — documents such as the Guide to Education, the 2006 IPP resource and the Student Support Policy

Framework. They say what the province expects. Where they say *should*, they are guidance, not law — and this book says so.

Division policy — your division's own administrative procedures. Binding on its staff.

School practice — "how we do it here". Not a rule unless it is written in one of the above.

Where no rule exists, the entry says so plainly. That is a finding too.

Live pages. Each chapter has a live web page where corrections go up first. The address is printed under the chapter title.

The phone card

Cut this page out, or take a photo of it.

Fill in your own

School office .....

Principal .....

Learning support lead at the school .....

Division student services contact .....

Superintendent's office .....

Your ward trustee .....

Your child's doctor .....

FSCD worker, if you have one .....

Province

Alberta Education and Childcare, general inquiries — **780-427-7219**. Toll-free in Alberta: dial 310-0000, then the number.

Alberta Supports, includes FSCD — **1-877-644-9992**. Monday to Friday, 7:30 am to 8 pm.

Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner, access to records and privacy — **780-422-6860**, toll-free **1-888-878-4044**.

Alberta Human Rights Commission, confidential inquiry line — **780-427-7661**.

Alberta Teaching Profession Commission, complaints about a teacher's or school leader's conduct or competence — online complaint form at alberta.ca. Read chapter 12 before you use it.

Health and crisis, any time, day or night

Emergency — **911**

Health Link — **811**

Mental Health Help Line — **1-877-303-2642**

Kids Help Phone — **1-800-668-6868**

Suicide Crisis Helpline — **988**

211 Alberta, community services — **211**

Ten things to know on day one

1. **Support starts with a decision.** The board decides whether your child needs specialized supports and services. Once it has, your child is entitled to them. Ask whether that decision has been made, and get the answer in writing. See 4.1 and 2.2.
2. **Every identified student gets an IPP, and Alberta says what goes in it.** The form is the division's. The contents are not. See 4.2.
3. **Your signature is consent, not a receipt.** You can read the plan first, and you can withdraw consent later. See 4.6.
4. **"Ongoing" is not a date.** Alberta's 2006 IPP resource says IPP reviews line up with the school's reporting periods: "These are generally scheduled three to four times per year." It adds that vague terms such as "ongoing" "do not adequately describe what a student has achieved" (chapter 1, page 14). That is guidance, not law. See 4.4.
5. **If it isn't written down, it didn't happen.** Follow every meeting and phone call with a short email saying what was agreed, by whom, by when. See 10.13 and letter L.7.
6. **You can see your child's student record and get a copy.** The IPP and every amendment to it must be on it. See 3.3 and 11.5.
7. **Keep your registration form, every year.** It is the only copy you control of what you told the school. See 3.2.
8. **Ask which section they are relying on.** We read the whole Education Act and found no section that lets a school put one child on a shortened day on its own say-so. A child can lawfully miss part of a day through a suspension from class periods (five school days at most, with a written report), an excusal the parent asks for, or a ministerial exemption order. Get the answer in writing. See 8.8 and 2.9.
9. **A failure to decide is a decision you can appeal.** Know the ladder and the deadlines before you need them. See 12.5 and 12.15.
10. **At 18, your rights pass to your child.** Start planning at 16. See 14.12 and 16.10.

Chapter 1: How school works in Alberta

Who decides what, the different kinds of schools, and how to tell a binding rule from someone's preference.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/1

Turn here when you're hearing

- "That's above my pay grade." → 1.1
- "I'll have to check with the division." → 1.1
- "That's a division decision." / "That's really a school-level matter." → 1.2
- "That's division policy." → 1.3
- "Our procedures don't allow that." → 1.3
- "That's just how we do it here." → 1.4
- "Alberta Education requires it." → 1.4
- "Under the School Act..." → 1.5
- "Bring it to school council." → 1.6
- "Our learning support teacher handles the IPP." → 1.7
- "I just do what I'm told." → 1.8
- "We're a Catholic school, it's different here." → 1.9
- "We're a charter school, those rules don't apply." → 1.10
- "We're a private school." → 1.11
- "Once you home school, it's up to you." → 1.12

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
1.1	You don't know who decides what
1.2	The principal says it's a division decision and the division says it's the school's
1.3	They say it's division policy: ask to see it
1.4	Is this a rule or a preference?
1.5	The rule they're quoting is out of date

Entry	Title
1.6	You're told to take it to the school council
1.7	Nobody can tell you who is in charge of your child's plan
1.8	The EA says they can't change anything
1.9	Your child goes to a Catholic (separate) or francophone school
1.10	Your child goes to a charter school: which rules apply
1.11	Your child goes to a private (independent) school
1.12	You're home educating or using an online school

1.1 You don't know who decides what

You might be hearing

— "That's above my pay grade."

— "I'll have to check with the division."

— "That comes from downtown."

— "It's out of my hands."

What's going on

Alberta schools have layers, and each layer decides different things. A division (also called a school board or school authority) is the body that runs a group of schools. Most of the time the person in front of you is not the person who decides. That isn't a problem in itself. The problem is not knowing who is, because then you can't ask them.

Here is who's who, from the top down. The ministry is Education and Childcare, led by the Minister of Education and Childcare. It sets curriculum, standards and funding. The school board is a group of elected trustees. The superintendent runs the division day to day for the board. The principal runs the school. Teachers teach and report on progress. EAs (educational assistants) are adults who work with students under a

teacher's direction. The school council is a parent-majority group that advises the principal and the board.

What the rules say

— Trustees are elected. The Minister sets how many each board has, never fewer than 3 (Education Act s.78(1)).

— The board is responsible for appropriate programming for all its students and for "a continuum of supports and services to students that is consistent with the principles of inclusive education" (s.33(1)(a) and (e)).

— "The superintendent is the chief executive officer of the board and the chief education officer of the school division" (s.222(3)).

— The principal must "direct the management of the school" and "supervise the evaluation and advancement of students" (s.197(e) and (h)).

— A teacher must "regularly assess students and periodically report the results of the assessment to the students, the students' parents and the board" (s.196(1)(e)).

— The Minister can review some board decisions, including decisions about specialized supports and services (s.43(1), s.44).

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.33, 43, 44, 78, 196, 197, 222, consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (none of these sections was amended by the 2026 amending Act, checked against its bill text 23 October 2026). Law.

Say this

"Before we go on, who makes this decision? Can you give me their name and role, and how I reach them?"

Ask for this in writing

The name and role of the person who will decide [the matter], and the date they expect to decide it by.

If you don't get it

If nobody will say who decides, or nobody decides, that silence counts. The Education Act treats a failure to make a decision as a decision you can appeal. See 1.2, then chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · what you asked about · who you asked · the name and role they gave you as the decision-maker · the date they said a decision would come.

Your division may also have

An organization chart or "who to contact" page. Ask for it if it isn't on the website.

1.2 The principal says it's a division decision and the division says it's the school's

You might be hearing

— "That's a division decision."

— "That's really a school-level matter."

— "You'll need to work that out with the principal."

— "Central office doesn't get involved in individual students."

What's going on

Each office is telling you, truthfully, that it isn't the only one involved. But the job isn't shared out by mood. Under the Education Act the board holds the power, and it can hand pieces of it to staff. When it does, it has to do that formally, by a board resolution (a recorded decision of the trustees). So for any decision there is an answer to "who has it", and someone in the division can find it.

The one thing that can't happen is nobody deciding. The Act deals with that directly.

What the rules say

A board may authorize its employees to do most things the board may do (a few powers, such as making bylaws or closing a school, can't be handed down). "An authorization by a board under subsection (1) must be in the

form of a resolution of the board." When an employee acts under that authority, the law treats it as the board acting.

"The failure of a person to make a decision is deemed to be a decision that may be appealed under this section." A decision by a board employee that "significantly affects the education of a student" can be appealed to the board. First you must follow the board's own school-level dispute policy, which every board must have.

For special education, the 2004 Standards make principals "accountable for the delivery and implementation of school-based special education programming and services". Boards must also make public "written descriptions of the role of boards and staff who provide programming and services to students with special education needs".

Source: Education Act ss.41, 42(1) to (3), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026; s.52(1) to (3), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(b) p.10 and Standard 12(c) p.12, made under Ministerial Order 015/2004 (standard).

Say this

"I've been told it's the school's call and the division's call. Who has the authority to decide this? The Act says if nobody decides, I can appeal that."

Ask for this in writing

The name of the person with authority to decide [the matter], the board resolution or procedure that gives them that authority, and the date of their decision.

If you don't get it

Write to the principal and the division contact in one email, so both see it. Ask for a decision by a date. If the date passes, follow the board's school-level dispute policy, then appeal to the board (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · who said "school" · who said "division" · their exact words · the date you asked for a decision by.

Your division may also have

A published list of what the board has delegated to the superintendent and principals. Ask for it by name.

1.3 They say it's division policy: ask to see it

You might be hearing

— "That's division policy."

— "Our procedures don't allow that."

— "One-to-one support goes against our processes."

— "It's an administrative procedure."

What's going on

Divisions write their own rules on top of the province's. Many divisions publish two layers on their websites: board policies, which the trustees adopt, and administrative procedures (some call them administrative regulations), which say how staff carry the policies out. Those bind the division's own staff.

A policy you can't see can't be checked. Sometimes the document says what you were told. Sometimes it says something narrower. Sometimes there isn't one, and what you heard was a habit or a preference. Asking to read it is not a challenge. It's how you find out which.

What the rules say

For special education, boards must "ensure that (consistent with this standards document, provincial legislation, and provincial policies) local written policies and procedures are developed, kept current, implemented and available to the public". They must also make public "written descriptions of local programming and service options for students with special education needs", and ensure their policies "provide for access, appropriateness, accountability and appeals".

The Education Act separately requires some division documents to be public, including the student code of conduct (s.33(3)(a)) and the school days and dates for the year (s.60).

A division rule can't take away something a higher rule gives. See 1.4.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 12(a), (b) and (d), p.12, made under Ministerial Order 015/2004 (standard). Education Act ss.33(3)(a) and 60, consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law).

Say this

"Can you send me the policy or procedure you're relying on, with its name and number? I'd like to read the exact wording."

Ask for this in writing

The title, number and date of the board policy or administrative procedure relied on for [the decision], the clause that applies, and a link or copy.

If you don't get it

If nothing is produced, ask in writing whether the answer is a policy or a practice. A practice isn't binding the way a policy is (see 1.4). If a policy exists but isn't public, that is a gap in Standard 12; say so plainly in your next letter, then see chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · what you were told the policy says · who said it · the policy name and number they gave, or that they gave none.

Your division may also have

A searchable policy page on its website. Save a copy of the version in force on the date you were told about it.

1.4 Is this a rule or a preference?

You might be hearing

— "That's just how we do it here."

— "Alberta Education requires it."

— "It's best practice."

— "We're not allowed to do that."

What's going on

Not every "rule" is the same strength. Some are law. Some are standards the Minister makes binding. Some are advice. Some are a school's habit. They all get said in the same tone of voice, which is why it helps to know the ladder. The higher the rung, the harder the rule. A lower rung can add to a higher one but can't cut below it.

What the rules say

From hardest to softest:

1. **Acts.** Laws passed by the Legislature, like the Education Act and the Alberta Human Rights Act. They bind everyone they name. Every other Alberta law is "inoperative to the extent that it authorizes or requires the doing of anything prohibited by" the Human Rights Act, unless it expressly says otherwise.
2. **Regulations.** Detailed rules made under an Act, such as the Student Record Regulation. They bind.
3. **Ministerial orders and standards.** The Minister may "by order ... adopt or approve goals and standards applicable to the provision of education in Alberta" (Education Act s.18(2)(b)). Examples: the Standards for Special Education (2004), the seclusion and restraint standards (MO 042/2019), the Teaching Quality Standard (MO 015/2026). They bind the boards, schools and staff they apply to.
4. **Provincial policy and guidance.** The Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026), whose release says it "does not create new legislative requirements". The 2006 IPP resource, written in "should". The Guide to Education labels some provincial policies "mandatory" while leaving schools "some flexibility in choosing the methods".
5. **Division policies and administrative procedures.** Bind that division's staff. See 1.3.
6. **School practice.** How a school usually does things. Not a rule unless something above it says so.

Source: Alberta Human Rights Act s.1(1), current as of 1 April 2023 (law). Education Act s.18(2)(b), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare,

22 October 2026, and its news release (guidance). Guide to Education ECS to Grade 12, 2025-26, Policies introduction (provincial policy).

Say this

"Is that a law, a regulation, a provincial standard, a division policy, or how this school does things? Which document is it in?"

Ask for this in writing

The name of the document the requirement comes from, and the section, page or clause.

If you don't get it

An answer like "it's best practice" puts it on rung 4 or 6. You can then ask what the school will do instead, given your child's needs. If you're told it's law, ask for the section number; every Alberta statute is published by King's Printer.

Write this down

Date · the "rule" you were told · who told you · the document they named · which rung it sits on.

1.5 The rule they're quoting is out of date

You might be hearing

- "Under the School Act..."
- "The Act says every school has to be welcoming."
- "That's in the Standards."
- "The FOIP Act says we can't release that."

What's going on

Alberta's rules change, and old wording lives on in documents and in people's heads. Three changes catch people out. The School Act was replaced by the Education Act. The FOIP Act was replaced in June 2025 by two new laws. And the Education Act itself was amended in 2026, changing some well-known phrases.

This works in both directions. Staff sometimes quote old wording. So do parents. Before you rely on any rule, yours or theirs, check that it is the current version.

What the rules say

The 2004 Standards for Special Education are still listed as current, and they still apply. But they cite the old School Act, so their School Act section numbers are not current law. The 2006 IPP resource has the same problem.

The FOIP Act was replaced on 11 June 2025 by the Access to Information Act and the Protection of Privacy Act.

The 2026 amending Act, in force 1 September 2026, changed section 33(1)(d). A board must now ensure each student and staff member "is provided with a safe and caring environment that fosters and maintains respectful and responsible behaviours". The older words "welcoming", "respects diversity" and "fosters a sense of belonging" are no longer in that clause. The same new wording now appears in the student and parent sections (ss.31(c), 32(d)). The principal's duties use the same words: a principal must "provide a safe and caring environment that fosters and maintains respectful and responsible behaviours" (s.197(a.1)).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword (standard, under MO 015/2004). Guide to Education ECS to Grade 12, 2025-26, Student Record Regulation note (provincial policy). Education Act ss.31(c), 32(d), 33(1)(d), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026 (law). Education Act s.197(a.1), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026 (law). Amended by SA 2026 c13, in force 1 September 2026.

Say this

"Can you tell me which Act and section that's from, and the date of the version you're reading? I want to make sure we're both looking at the current one."

Ask for this in writing

The name of the Act, regulation or standard, the section, and the "current as of" date of the copy relied on.

If you don't get it

Look it up yourself. Current Alberta Acts and regulations are on the King's Printer website with a "current as of" date at the top. If a letter quotes a repealed law, reply asking which current provision they mean. See chapter 11 for keeping copies.

Write this down

Date · the rule quoted · the Act and section given · the "current as of" date you checked.

1.6 You're told to take it to the school council

You might be hearing

— "Bring it to school council."

— "Parent council can raise that."

— "Maybe join the council and push for it."

What's going on

A school council (often called parent council) is a group at each school, mostly parents, that advises the principal and the board about the school as a whole. It's a good place to raise things that affect many children, like how the school handles supervision at pickup. It is not set up to deal with your child's program, and it isn't a private room: other families sit on it.

If your concern is about your child, the route is the board's school-level dispute policy, not the council.

What the rules say

Every school operated by a board must have a school council, and "the majority of the members of a school council must be parents of students enrolled in the school." A council may, at its discretion, advise the principal and the board "respecting any matter relating to the school", and do what the board delegates to it.

The province describes school councils as focused "on what is best for all students in the school".

For a dispute about your own child, every board must have "a policy respecting the resolution of disputes or concerns at the school level

between parents and school staff". You must follow it before appealing to the board.

Source: Education Act ss.41, 42(3), 55(1), (2) and (4), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Alberta.ca, School councils, published 14 February 2025 (provincial information).

Say this

"This is about my child, not the whole school. Can you send me the division's dispute resolution policy so I can follow it?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the board's school-level dispute resolution policy (Education Act s.41), and the name of the first person it says to raise a concern with.

If you don't get it

Every board must have this policy, so ask the division office directly. Then follow it step by step and keep dated copies of each step. See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · what the concern is about · who suggested council · the dispute policy name and number.

1.7 Nobody can tell you who is in charge of your child's plan

You might be hearing

- "Our learning support teacher handles the IPP."
- "The inclusive ed lead is only here two days a week."
- "That's the resource room's area."
- "We all work on it together."

What's going on

Schools use many job titles for the person who coordinates special education: learning support teacher, inclusive education lead, resource teacher, student services. The titles vary by division. The IPP (Individualized Program Plan, the written plan for a student with special

education needs) still needs a named person who writes it, carries it out and checks it.

"We all work on it" may be true, and it still leaves you with nobody to ask. You're entitled to know who the principal has made responsible.

What the rules say

Alberta's Standards don't name the job title. They name the duty. Boards must "identify principals as accountable for the delivery and implementation of school-based special education programming and services", and "ensure principals identify teachers whose responsibility it is to coordinate, develop, implement, monitor and evaluate student IPPs". Each school must have "a process and learning team to provide consultation, planning and problem-solving".

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(b), (d) and (e), pp.10 to 11, made under Ministerial Order 015/2004. Standard.

Say this

"Which teacher has the principal named as responsible for coordinating my child's IPP this year? I'd like to know who to go to."

Ask for this in writing

The name of the teacher identified by the principal as responsible for coordinating, developing, implementing, monitoring and evaluating your child's IPP for this school year, and the members of the learning team.

If you don't get it

The duty sits with the principal, so ask the principal directly. If the IPP itself lists no responsible person, see 4.2.

Write this down

Date · who you asked · the name and role of the IPP coordinator · the learning team members listed.

1.8 The EA says they can't change anything

You might be hearing

— "I just do what I'm told."

— "You'd have to ask the teacher."

— "EAs aren't on the IPP team list."

— "I'm not allowed to talk to parents about that."

What's going on

An EA (educational assistant, sometimes called an aide) often spends more time with your child than anyone else. But an EA doesn't set the program. They carry out what a teacher directs. So when an EA says they can't change something, they're usually right, and the question belongs with the teacher.

What you can ask is that the EA's role is written down somewhere you can see it. A person doing daily work with your child should appear in the plan, even if the software's team list can't hold their name.

What the rules say

Boards must "ensure teacher assistants work under the direction of a certificated teacher to realize students' goals, as outlined in their IPPs."

The province's new framework lists educational assistants as members of the school-based team that plans a student's supports. That framework is guidance.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(g), p.11, made under Ministerial Order 015/2004 (standard). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, Glossary "School-based teams" and s.6(4.1) (guidance).

Say this

"Who directs my child's EA day to day? And where in the IPP is the EA's role written down?"

Ask for this in writing

The name of the teacher who directs the EA's work with your child, and where in the IPP the EA's role, hours and daily tasks are described.

If you don't get it

If the IPP doesn't say who does each support, see 4.2. For EA hours, coverage and absences, see chapter 7.

Write this down

Date · EA's role as described to you · the directing teacher's name · where it appears in the IPP.

1.9 Your child goes to a Catholic (separate) or francophone school

You might be hearing

— "We're a Catholic school, it's different here."

— "Our board has its own approach."

— "Francophone schools have their own rules."

What's going on

A separate school division (in practice, most are Catholic) and a francophone regional authority (the bodies that run French first-language schools) are school boards under the same Education Act as public divisions. Faith and language shape a lot about these schools. They don't switch off the duties to students with disabilities.

So the same chapters of this book apply, and the same appeal routes.

What the rules say

The Education Act sets up separate school boards the same way it sets up public ones, and the duties in it apply to "a board". A student enrolled in a francophone school is entitled to instruction in French, and the francophone authority must "ensure that the student is provided with an education program consistent with the requirements of this Act and the regulations".

The 2004 Standards for Special Education say their requirements "apply to grades 1–12 special education in public and separate school boards, including Francophone regional education authorities". The Student Support Policy Framework covers "public and separate school divisions, francophone regional authorities, and public charter school operators".

Source: Education Act ss.4(4), 14(3), 15(1)(b), 77(2), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword (standard). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.1 (guidance).

Say this

"I understand the school's faith or language matters here. Which of the Education Act or the special education standards do you say don't apply, and where is that written?"

Ask for this in writing

The specific provision, if any, that the school says exempts it from a requirement in the Education Act or the Standards for Special Education.

If you don't get it

If no provision is named, the general rules apply. Continue with the entry for your problem in this book. Appeal routes are in chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · what you were told is different · who said it · the provision they named, or that they named none.

1.10 Your child goes to a charter school: which rules apply

You might be hearing

— "We're a charter school, those rules don't apply."

— "We have our own model."

— "This program might not be the right fit."

What's going on

A charter school is a public school run by a society or company under a charter from the Minister, usually with a particular teaching approach. It can't charge tuition to resident students, the same as a public school. The Education Act lists which parts of itself apply to charter schools. Most of the parts that matter for a child with a disability do.

One gap is real: the 2004 Standards for Special Education leave charter schools out. The 2026 provincial framework includes them.

What the rules say

Education Act s.27(1) applies most of the Act to charter schools, reading "board" as the charter operator. It applies Part 1 except ss.4, 4.1, 10, 11(1), 14 and 15. So s.11(2) to (5), the specialized supports and services section, applies. It applies Part 3 except ss.33(1)(k) and 34, so the board responsibilities in s.33 and the dispute and appeal routes in ss.41 to 44 apply. The student record section, s.56, also applies.

Cabinet may exempt a charter school from most provisions by order (s.27(2)(a)).

A charter school "shall not charge a fee that may not be charged by a board" and "shall not be affiliated with a religious faith or denomination" (s.26(5) and (6)).

The 2004 Standards apply to public and separate boards "but excluding charter schools". The Student Support Policy Framework names "public charter school operators" as covered.

Source: Education Act ss.26, 27, consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law; the 2026 amending Act changed only s.27(1)(f), on a subject unrelated to this entry). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword (standard). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.1 (guidance).

Say this

"My understanding is section 27 of the Education Act applies section 11 and the appeal routes to charter schools. Is there an order exempting this school from any of them?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation of whether any order under Education Act s.27(2) exempts this charter school from any provision of the Act, and if so, a copy.

If you don't get it

Charter school decisions can be appealed to the charter's board under s.42, then reviewed by the Minister under s.43 where they concern specialized

supports. See chapter 12. For choosing or leaving a charter school, see chapter 15.

Write this down

Date · the rule said not to apply · who said it · whether any s.27(2) order was named.

1.11 Your child goes to a private (independent) school

You might be hearing

— "We're a private school."

— "We're not set up for that."

— "We can't accept students with that level of need."

— "You signed our enrolment agreement."

What's going on

Alberta calls private schools independent schools. There are three kinds: registered, accredited, and accredited funded. Some are approved as designated special education independent schools, which exist only to serve students with disabilities. The rules that bind a public board apply to independent schools far less. Before enrolling, it is worth asking in writing what the school will provide.

Most of the appeal routes in this book don't reach an independent school. The Education Act lists the few parts of itself that apply to these schools, and the appeal and Minister review routes for special education aren't among them. So ask the school for its written dispute process before you sign.

What the rules say

The province states: "Independent schools are not required to enrol students with disabilities." Registered schools receive no government funding and need not use certificated teachers or the Alberta programs of study. Accredited funded schools must do both. A designated special education independent school is a funded school where "the sole purpose of the school is to serve students who are identified with a mild, moderate or severe disability."

The operator must ensure students "are provided with an education program consistent with the requirements set out in the Act and the regulations" (s.28.1). An accredited school must have "the capacity ... to deliver an appropriate education program to its students" (s.29(2)(b)(ii)).

Section 30(1) lists the parts of the Act that apply to registered and accredited independent schools. The list does not include the specialized supports section (s.11), the school-level dispute policy (s.41) or Minister review (s.43). The board appeal in s.42 applies only to appeals about religious instruction and about notices on religion or sexuality topics in class. The student record section, s.56, does apply.

The provincial framework says independent schools "are not expressly required by the Education Act to provide a continuum of supports and services" and are "encouraged to use this Framework".

Source: Alberta.ca, Independent schools, published 19 May 2026 (provincial information). Education Act s.30(1), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026 (law); ss.28.1, 29(2), 58.2, consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.3(3) (guidance). The Independent Schools Regulation was not checked for this edition.

Say this

"Before we sign, can you tell me in writing what supports you'll provide for my child, who provides them, and what happens if you decide you can't?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's written description of the supports it will provide your child, its process for resolving disagreements, and the conditions under which it may end enrolment.

If you don't get it

A school that won't put this in writing has told you something useful before you've paid. For designated special education schools, tuition and access, see chapter 15. For the Human Rights Act, see 2.10.

Write this down

Date · school type (registered, accredited, funded, designated) · what supports were promised in writing · the dispute process named.

1.12 You're home educating or using an online school

You might be hearing

— "Once you home school, it's up to you."

— "We don't offer supports to home ed students."

— "Online students get the same as everyone else."

What's going on

These are two different things. In home education, you deliver the program, usually supervised by an associate board or associate school that you notify. In an online school, a school authority's teachers deliver the program online. The rules that apply to an online school depend on who runs it: a public, separate or francophone board, a charter, or an independent school. See 1.9 to 1.11.

Home education changes your child's position. The duty to provide specialized supports and services in s.11 is written for students enrolled in a school operated by a board. A home-educated child isn't one. The supervising board still owes you something smaller: information.

What the rules say

A parent "may provide, at home or elsewhere, a type of home education program for the student in accordance with the regulations" (Education Act s.20(1)).

An associate board or associate independent school supervising a home education program must "advise parents ... of the services and resources of the associate board or associate independent school that are available for use by the parents and students" (Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019, s.5(d)).

In online programs, "Alberta certificated teachers employed by school authorities supervise and instruct students."

Source: Education Act ss.11(2) to (4), 20(1), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019, s.5(d), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Alberta.ca, Online learning, published 21 September 2026 (provincial information).

Say this

"Section 5 of the Home Education Regulation says you have to tell me what services and resources are available to us. Can you send me that list?"

Ask for this in writing

A list of the associate board's or school's services and resources available to home education families, including assessment and specialist services, as at [date].

If you don't get it

Ask again in writing, citing AR 89/2019 s.5(d). For choosing between home education, online and other paths, see chapter 15.

Write this down

Date · associate board or school · what you asked for · the list of services they named.

Chapter 2: Your child's rights and the school's duties

What the law says your child is owed at school, what the school and board must do, and where those duties run out.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/2

Turn here when you're hearing

- "School isn't the right place for them right now." → 2.1
- "We don't have to provide that." → 2.2
- "There's no funding for that." → 2.2
- "Inclusion is a philosophy, not a requirement." → 2.3
- "We think a specialized program would suit them better." → 2.3
- "The team has already decided." → 2.4
- "It's in the code of conduct." → 2.5
- "Parents have responsibilities too." → 2.6
- "You need to work with us." → 2.6
- "Under the new provincial framework..." → 2.7
- "We can't meet their needs here." → 2.8
- "Let's try half days for now." → 2.9
- "Can you pick them up at lunch?" → 2.9
- "We're accommodating them as much as we can." → 2.10
- "Other kids with special needs get the same as your child." → 2.11
- "There's no room in that program." → 2.12
- "French immersion isn't a good fit for kids with IPPs." → 2.12

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
2.1	Your child's right to go to school, and how long it lasts
2.2	"We don't have to provide that"

Entry	Title
2.3	They want to move your child to a special class or another school
2.4	They decided without talking to you
2.5	They point to the code of conduct
2.6	"Parents have responsibilities too"
2.7	They quote the new provincial framework at you
2.8	"We can't meet their needs here"
2.9	They want your child on a shortened or partial day
2.10	Is this discrimination? The Human Rights Act
2.11	They compare your child to other kids with special needs
2.12	Your child is turned away from the school or program you chose

2.1 Your child's right to go to school, and how long it lasts

You might be hearing

— "School isn't the right place for them right now."

— "They've aged out."

— "We can take them once they're more ready."

— "Attendance is optional at this point."

What's going on

In Alberta, school is both a right and a duty. Your child is entitled to an education program, and between certain ages they are also required to attend. The ages for the two are different. The right is not unlimited: the Act says every right in it is subject to limits that are reasonable in the circumstances. But "reasonable" is a test someone has to meet, not a door that's already shut.

If you're being told your child shouldn't be at school, the starting point is that they're entitled to be.

What the rules say

Every person who on September 1 is 6 or older and younger than 19, lives in Alberta and has a parent living in Canada "is entitled to have access in that school year to an education program in accordance with this Act." A board may also admit someone younger than 6 or older than 18 (s.3).

School is compulsory from 6 until 16 (s.7(1)). "A board shall make all reasonable efforts to ensure that a student who is a resident student of the board or who is enrolled in a school operated by the board attends school" (s.7(3)).

A board can't charge tuition to its resident students (s.13(1)).

"The exercise of any right or the receipt of any benefit under this Act is subject to the limitations that are reasonable in the circumstances under which the right is being exercised or the benefit is being received" (s.2).

Source: Education Act s.7(1) and (3), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026; ss.2, 3, 13(1), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (not amended by the 2026 amending Act, per its bill text). Law.

Say this

"My child is entitled to an education program under section 3 of the Education Act. What is the school offering, starting when?"

Ask for this in writing

The education program the board will provide your child from [date], including the school, the hours each day, and the supports.

If you don't get it

Any decision to limit your child's attendance should come in writing with its legal basis. See 2.9 for shortened days and 2.8 for "we can't meet their needs". For age 19 and leaving school, see chapter 14.

Write this down

Date · what you were told about attendance · who said it · the legal basis they gave, or that they gave none.

2.2 "We don't have to provide that"

You might be hearing

— "We don't have to provide that."

— "There's no funding for that."

— "They don't qualify for specialized supports."

— "The screener results don't show a need."

What's going on

The Education Act has one section that does most of the work for a child who needs more help: section 11. "Specialized supports and services" is the Act's phrase for help beyond what most students get. It works in three steps. The board decides whether your child needs specialized supports. If it decides yes, your child is entitled to access them. And before providing them, the board must consult you.

The first step is the board's decision, and the Act gives you no direct way to trigger it. What you can do is ask, in writing, whether it has been made. A "no" is a decision you can challenge. A "we haven't looked" is a different answer, and you'll want to know which one you have.

What the rules say

"If a student's behavioural, intellectual, learning, communication or physical characteristics, or a combination of any of them, impair the student's ability and opportunity to learn, a board may determine that the student is in need of specialized supports and services" (s.11(3)).

"Subject to section 40, a student who is determined by a board to be in need of specialized supports and services is entitled to have access to those supports and services in an education program provided in accordance with this Act that will give the student the opportunity to meet the standards of education set by the Minister" (s.11(4)).

Before providing them, a board "shall (a) consult with the parent of the student, and (b) where appropriate, consult with the student" (s.11(5)).

A board "shall not use the results of a literacy and numeracy screening assessment to make a determination under section 11(3)" (s.30.51(3)).

A board decision about providing specialized supports and services can be reviewed by the Minister if you ask in writing within 60 days (s.43(1)(a) and (2)).

Source: Education Act ss.11(3) to (5), 30.51(3), 43, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"Has the division decided whether my child needs specialized supports and services under section 11? If so, what was decided, when, and by whom?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether a determination under Education Act s.11(3) has been made for your child; if yes, its date, who made it and the supports it covers; if no, who will decide and by what date.

If you don't get it

A refusal, or no decision at all, can be appealed to the board after the school-level process (s.42), then taken to the Minister within 60 days (s.43). See chapter 12. For getting your child assessed, see chapter 5. For "funding", see chapter 6.

Write this down

Date · what you asked for · who said "we don't have to" · their exact words · whether a s.11(3) decision exists.

2.3 They want to move your child to a special class or another school

You might be hearing

- "We think a specialized program would suit them better."
- "Inclusion is a philosophy, not a requirement."
- "There's a congregated class at another school."
- "They'd get more support in a smaller setting."

What's going on

Placement means where your child is taught: their neighbourhood classroom, a specialized class, or another school. Alberta's rule is that the neighbourhood school is considered first, with you involved, and that the decision rests on your child's best educational interest and current assessment. That doesn't mean a specialized setting is never right. It means it has to be weighed, with you, against the inclusive option first.

"Inclusive education" in the Act is not only a philosophy. It shapes a duty the board holds.

What the rules say

A board must "provide a continuum of supports and services to students that is consistent with the principles of inclusive education" (Education Act s.33(1)(e)).

Boards must "ensure that educating students with special education needs in inclusive settings in neighbourhood or local schools shall be the first placement option considered by school boards, in consultation with parents, school staff and, when appropriate, the student" and "determine the most enabling placement ... in consultation with parents, and based on current assessment data" (Standard 10). "In every case, the best educational interest of the student is the paramount consideration for decision-making and programming" (Foreword).

The 2026 framework says a specialized setting should be considered "only when essential to support access to learning, based on documented rationale, parent consultation, and review of available supports", with "regular review of placement suitability". It is guidance.

Source: Education Act s.33(1)(e), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026 (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword p.1 and Standard 10, p.10 (standard, under MO 015/2004). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.5.3(8.6) and (8.7) (guidance).

Say this

"Before we talk about another placement, can you show me how the neighbourhood option was considered first, and what current assessment this is based on?"

Ask for this in writing

The documented reasons for the proposed placement, the assessment data (with dates) it relies on, the supports considered in the current school, and the date placement will next be reviewed.

If you don't get it

A placement decision that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed to the board (s.42). See chapter 12. For specialized classes and what to ask about them, see chapter 7.

Write this down

Date · placement proposed · reason given · assessment it relied on · whether the inclusive option was discussed.

2.4 They decided without talking to you

You might be hearing

- "The team has already decided."
- "We'll let you know what we come up with."
- "We met and agreed this is best."
- "This is a staffing decision."

What's going on

Consultation means you get a real chance to help make the decision, before it's made. Being told the outcome afterwards isn't consultation, even if it's done kindly. Alberta's rules require consultation in several places: before specialized supports are provided, before a placement is decided, and in planning and decision-making about special education programming.

Some decisions, like how a division assigns staff across schools, may not need your agreement. Decisions about your child's program do need your input.

What the rules say

Before providing specialized supports and services, a board must consult the parent (Education Act s.11(5)).

The Standards define consultation as "a process that gives parents of students with special education needs and, where applicable, students the opportunity to assist in making decisions about all aspects of programming and placement." Boards must "ensure parents have the opportunity for participation in decisions that affect students' education", "ensure parents have information needed to make informed decisions", and "invite meaningful involvement of parents in planning, problem-solving and decision-making" (Standard 8).

The Act calls the parent the child's "primary guide and decision-maker with respect to the child's education" (s.32(a)). Since the 2026 amendments, a board must also "establish and implement methods that facilitate the meaningful involvement of parents in student learning and decisions respecting non-instructional school activities" (s.33(1)(b.1)). The province has said school authorities have "additional time ... to comply with several of the new requirements", without saying on that page which ones.

Source: Education Act ss.32(a), 33(1)(b.1), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026; s.11(5), unchanged in that consolidation (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.3 and Standard 8, p.9 (standard). Alberta.ca, Removing politics and ideology from Alberta classrooms, published 5 October 2026 (provincial information).

Say this

"I wasn't part of this decision. The standards say I get a chance to help make it. Can we reopen it and meet before anything changes?"

Ask for this in writing

The date the decision was made, who made it, what information it was based on, and a meeting date before it takes effect.

If you don't get it

Reply in writing that you were not consulted and that you don't agree. That puts your position on record. Then use the school-level dispute policy and appeal (see chapter 12). For running the meeting, see chapter 10.

Write this down

Date of the decision · date you were told · who decided · whether you were asked beforehand.

2.5 They point to the code of conduct

You might be hearing

— "It's in the code of conduct."

— "The same rules apply to everyone."

— "Consequences have to be consistent."

— "We have to think about the other students' safety."

What's going on

Every board must have a student code of conduct. It sets out expected behaviour and consequences. Staff sometimes present it as a single rule applied the same way to every child. But the Act requires something more specific: consequences must take account of a child's age, maturity and individual circumstances, and must ensure support for a child whose behaviour is the problem, not only for those affected by it.

The code must also address discrimination, including on the ground of disability.

What the rules say

A board must ensure each student is provided with "a safe and caring environment that fosters and maintains respectful and responsible behaviours" (s.33(1)(d), wording as amended in 2026). It must have a code of conduct that addresses bullying (s.33(2)).

The code must be publicly available, "be reviewed every year", and be given to all parents. It must contain statements addressing the prohibited grounds of discrimination in the Alberta Human Rights Act, and statements about consequences of unacceptable behaviour "which must take account of the student's age, maturity and individual circumstances, and which must ensure that support is provided for students who are impacted by inappropriate behaviour, as well as for students who engage in inappropriate behaviour" (s.33(3)). Since 2026 it must also address the student responsibility to refrain from violence (s.33(3)(d)(v)).

Source: Education Act s.33(1)(d), (2) and (3), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026. Law.

Say this

"The Act says consequences have to take account of my child's individual circumstances and include support for them. Can you show me how this one does that?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the current code of conduct with its last review date, and how the consequence given on [date] took account of your child's individual circumstances and what support was provided.

If you don't get it

For suspensions, being sent home, and safety plans, see chapter 8. A suspension can't exceed 5 school days except where expulsion is recommended (s.36(5)).

Write this down

Date · the incident · the consequence · the code clause cited · what support was offered to your child.

2.6 "Parents have responsibilities too"

You might be hearing

— "Parents have responsibilities too."

— "You need to work with us."

— "This isn't very collaborative."

— "We need you to trust the process."

What's going on

It's true: the Act lists duties for parents, students and boards, and calls each a "partner in education". What gets left out is that the parents' list begins with a right, and that asking for information is part of the collaboration it describes. Writing to ask for the plan, or for a reason, is you doing your part, not stepping outside it.

Students have a list too. It's written for every student, and the code of conduct consequences in 2.5 must still account for your child's individual circumstances.

What the rules say

"A parent has the prior right to choose the kind of education that shall be provided to the parent's child, and as a partner in education, has the responsibility to (a) act as the primary guide and decision-maker with respect to the child's education". The list goes on to include ensuring regular attendance, and to "co-operate and collaborate with school staff to support the delivery of supports and services to the child" (s.32).

Students' responsibilities include attending regularly, following school rules and, since 2026, refraining "from engaging in violence of any kind at school and during school-related activities" (s.31).

The board's own responsibilities as a partner are in s.33, including programming "to meet the needs of all students" (s.33(1)(a)).

Source: Education Act ss.31, 32, 33(1)(a), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026. Law.

Say this

"I want to work with you. Asking for the plan and the reasons in writing is how I do my part as my child's primary decision-maker."

Ask for this in writing

The specific thing you've been asked to do as a parent, and the specific thing the school will do in return, each with a date.

If you don't get it

Keep your own requests short, dated and in writing. That is your record of co-operation (see chapter 11). If "you're not collaborating" is used to delay a decision, see 1.2.

Write this down

Date · what you were told you hadn't done · what you had done (with dates) · what you were asked to do next.

2.7 They quote the new provincial framework at you

You might be hearing

— "Under the new provincial framework..."

— "The province says we have to try universal and targeted supports first."

— "Reasonable limitations apply."

— "If you won't consent, that limits what we can do."

What's going on

On 22 October 2026, Education and Childcare published the Student Support Policy Framework. It describes a "continuum" of support in three layers: universal (for every student), targeted (short-term help for small groups), and individualized (for one student). It is guidance. It does not replace the 2004 Standards.

Parts of it will be quoted to you. Some parts help you. Read the exact words before agreeing with any summary of it.

What the rules say

The release says the framework "does not create new legislative requirements". The framework says it "does not replace the Standards for Special Education (2004)".

Parts worth knowing, quoted from the framework:

— "Access to individualized supports and services does not depend on completing a prescribed sequence of universal or targeted supports and services" (s.5.3(7)).

— "When behaviour is connected to a disability or protected characteristic, decisions must be reasonable, rights-aligned, and focused on access to education" (s.5.3.1.2(2.3)).

— "Parents receive written explanations of adjustments, curricular adjustments, and/or specialized setting, credentialing, or programming implications" (s.7(3.1)).

— "In circumstances where a parent withholds consent, the decision will influence what the applicable school authority can consider as reasonable alternatives" (s.5.3.1(2.2)).

— For medical supports: "Reasonable limitations may be considered related to the student profile and capacity, including attendance, stamina, readiness to learn, and continuity of programming" (s.5.3.1.1(3.1)).

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026, ss.2, 5.3, 5.3.1, 5.3.1.1, 5.3.1.2, 7, and its news release of the same date. Guidance.

Say this

"Can you show me the section of the framework you're relying on? It also says access doesn't depend on going through the tiers in order."

Ask for this in writing

The section number of the Student Support Policy Framework relied on, and the written explanation the framework says parents receive (s.7(3.1)).

If you don't get it

The framework is guidance. The binding rules are in the Education Act (2.2) and the 2004 Standards. For "try the lower tiers first", see 4.13.

Write this down

Date · what part of the framework was quoted · the section number given · what it says when you read it.

2.8 "We can't meet their needs here"

You might be hearing

- "We can't meet their needs here."
- "We don't have the resources for a child like this."
- "Have you looked at other options?"
- "This isn't the right environment for them."

What's going on

This sentence can mean different things. It might mean "we'd like to try a different setting in the division" (see 2.3). It might mean "we won't provide what was asked for" (see 2.2). Or it might mean the division has formally decided it can't educate your child at all. The Education Act has a specific process for that last meaning, called the Complex Education Needs Tribunal. A division that makes that decision can't simply stop. It must refer the matter on.

No published instrument establishing a Complex Education Needs Tribunal was found for this edition. So ask, in writing, which of the three meanings you're hearing.

What the rules say

"A board may determine that a student requires specialized supports and services that cannot be met in an education program that may be provided by the board" (s.40(1)). If it does, "the board shall refer the matter to a Complex Education Needs Tribunal, which shall confirm the board's determination or determine that the board is able to provide the student with an education program that is appropriate" (s.40(2)). If the Tribunal finds the board is able, "the board shall provide the student with that education program" (s.40(4)). If it confirms, it develops or approves a plan and splits the cost between the board and the Government (s.40(3)).

"The Minister may establish one or more Complex Education Needs Tribunals" (s.40(7)). The word is "may". Only a board can make the s.40(1) determination; the Act gives a parent no way to start it.

Source: Education Act s.40, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 13 October 2026. Law. Search for an establishing instrument recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"When you say you can't meet their needs, is the division making a decision under section 40 of the Education Act? If so, I'd like it in writing."

Ask for this in writing

Whether the board has made a determination under Education Act s.40(1) for your child; if so, its date and the Tribunal it has been referred to; if not, what the division is offering your child and from when.

If you don't get it

If there's no s.40 decision, your child's entitlement under s.11(4) still stands (2.2). Any decision that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed (chapter 12). For the Human Rights Act, see 2.10.

Write this down

Date · who said it · their exact words · whether they confirmed a s.40 decision · what was offered instead.

2.9 They want your child on a shortened or partial day

You might be hearing

— "Let's try half days for now."

— "Can you pick them up at lunch?"

— "We'll build up to full days."

— "It's a modified schedule, not a suspension."

— "Maybe keep them home tomorrow."

What's going on

A shortened day means your child attends for part of the school day, usually because the school says it can't manage the rest. It's often described as temporary and kind. The question to ask is which rule allows it.

We read the whole Education Act, the In-person Learning Regulation and the 2004 Standards for Special Education. None of them sets up a shortened day for one child at the school's choice, limits one, requires your consent to one, or requires a plan to end one. Three narrow routes do exist, and each has its own limits: a suspension from class periods (5 school days at most, with a written report), an excusal the parent asks for, and a ministerial exemption order. Entry 8.8 sets them out. If the school names one, the limits that come with it apply. If it names none, you're entitled to ask.

What the rules say

A student is excused from attending if (a) sick or another unavoidable cause, (b) a religious holiday, (c) suspended, (d) expelled and not yet enrolled elsewhere, or (e) the board "determines that the parent of the student has shown sufficient cause as to why the student should not be required to attend school" and excuses them "for a prescribed period of time" (s.7(4)). That last route starts with the parent, not the school.

A principal may suspend a student "from one or more class periods or courses" (s.36(3)(b)). "A suspension may not exceed 5 school days", except

with a recommendation for expulsion (s.36(5)), and the principal must report all the circumstances to the parent in writing (s.36(4)(b)).

A board must "make all reasonable efforts" to ensure a student attends (s.7(3)), and must publish its school days (s.60).

The Minister may, by order, exempt a board from having to offer in-person learning to each student (In-person Learning Regulation s.2(3)). See 8.8 for the 2025 order.

The 2026 framework, which is guidance, says that for students needing medical supports "Reasonable limitations may be considered related to the student profile and capacity, including attendance, stamina, readiness to learn, and continuity of programming" (s.5.3.1.1(3.1)).

Source: Education Act ss.7(3) and (4), 36(3) to (5), 60, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026 (law). In-person Learning Regulation, Alta Reg 13/2025, s.2(3), read 9 October 2026 (regulation). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.5.3.1.1 (guidance). What was searched is recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"Which section of the Education Act are you relying on for a shortened day? I'd like that in writing, with the hours, the start date and the date it ends."

Ask for this in writing

The legal basis for the reduced attendance, the hours your child will attend, the start date, the review date, the plan for returning to full days, and what instruction your child gets for the missed time.

If you don't get it

If you're told it's a suspension, the 5-day limit and written report apply (see 8.9). If you didn't agree to it, say so in writing. A decision that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed (chapter 12). See also 2.10.

Write this down

Date · hours attended · who asked you to pick up · the reason given · the legal basis named, or that none was named.

2.10 Is this discrimination? The Human Rights Act

You might be hearing

— "We're accommodating them as much as we can."

— "It would be an undue hardship."

— "We have to think about the other students."

— "That's not discrimination, it's a resource issue."

What's going on

The Alberta Human Rights Act sits above the Education Act. It bars discrimination in services customarily available to the public because of physical or mental disability, and the Alberta Human Rights Commission treats education as one of those services. The duty to accommodate means making changes to rules, practices or environments so a disability doesn't shut your child out. It runs until the change would be an undue hardship, which the Commission describes as "substantial in nature".

The Commission is a separate route from the school appeal process. It has a strict one-year deadline.

What the rules say

No person shall deny, or discriminate with respect to, "any goods, services, accommodation or facilities that are customarily available to the public" because of physical or mental disability (s.4). "Mental disability" includes "any mental disorder, developmental disorder or learning disorder, regardless of the cause or duration" (s.44(1)(h)).

A contravention is deemed not to have occurred if the person shows it "was reasonable and justifiable in the circumstances" (s.11). Every other Alberta law is "inoperative to the extent that it authorizes or requires the doing of anything prohibited by this Act" (s.1(1)).

A complaint must "be made within one year after the alleged contravention of the Act occurs" (s.20(2)(b)).

The Commission lists education as a service and says undue hardship factors include size and resources, and health and safety. It also says the person needing accommodation "must let the provider know their needs" and "cooperate with the service provider and participate in accommodation efforts".

Source: Alberta Human Rights Act, RSA 2000 c.A-25.5, ss.1(1), 4, 11, 20(2)(b), 44(1)(h), current as of 1 April 2023 (law). Alberta Human Rights Commission, Duty to accommodate in goods and services, read 23 October 2026 (Commission information).

Say this

"I'm asking for an accommodation for my child's disability. If the answer is no, can you tell me in writing what hardship it would cause?"

Ask for this in writing

The accommodation you asked for and the date, the school's decision, and if refused, the reasons and what hardship the school says it would cause.

If you don't get it

Note the date of each refusal; the one-year clock runs from it. The Commission's director may dismiss a complaint better dealt with in another forum (s.21(1)(a)(iv)), so think about timing if you're also appealing (chapter 12).

Write this down

Date of request · what you asked for · date of refusal · reason given · one-year deadline date.

2.11 They compare your child to other kids with special needs

You might be hearing

- "Other kids with special needs get the same as your child."
- "We have to be fair to all our coded students."
- "Special education is an extra."
- "Everyone in the program gets the same level of support."

What's going on

When a school says your child gets the same as other children with disabilities, it's making a comparison. The Supreme Court of Canada looked at that comparison in Moore v. British Columbia (Education), 2012, a case

about a student with a severe learning disability. It was decided under British Columbia's human rights law, not Alberta's. Its reasoning is still worth knowing, because it answers this exact sentence.

The Court said the service is education, the same education every child gets, and special education is how some children reach it.

What the rules say

From the judgment:

- "Adequate special education, therefore, is not a dispensable luxury" (para. 5).
- For students with learning disabilities, special education "is not the service, it is the means by which those students get meaningful access" to "the general education services available to all of British Columbia's students" (para. 28).
- "the 'service' is education generally" (para. 29).
- Para. 30, in our words (not a quote): if a student is compared only with other special needs students, a district could cut every special needs program and still face no discrimination claim. In the Court's own words, that comparison "risks descending into the kind of 'separate but equal' approach".

On the school district's budget defence, the Court said: "In order to decide that it had no other choice, it had at least to consider what those other choices were" (para. 52).

The test the Court set out: a complainant shows they have a protected characteristic, "experienced an adverse impact with respect to the service", and that "the protected characteristic was a factor in the adverse impact" (para. 33).

Source: Moore v. British Columbia (Education), 2012 SCC 61, [2012] 3 S.C.R. 360, judgment 9 November 2012, paras. 5, 28 to 30, 33, 52, read live on the Supreme Court of Canada's site 23 October 2026. Supreme Court of Canada decision under British Columbia law.

Say this

"I'm not comparing my child to other students with special needs. I'm asking whether they can get to the same education every child gets."

Ask for this in writing

What your child needs to access the general curriculum or IPP goals, what is being provided, and the gap between them, as at [date].

If you don't get it

For the Alberta human rights route, see 2.10. For school appeals, see chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · who made the comparison · their exact words · what your child needed · what was provided.

2.12 Your child is turned away from the school or program you chose

You might be hearing

— "There's no room in that program."

— "French immersion isn't a good fit for kids with IPPs."

— "That school doesn't have the supports."

— "You'll need to go to your designated school."

What's going on

A division can tell your child which of its schools to attend. You can ask for a different school, and the board must enrol your child there if, in its opinion, it has enough resources and facilities. That's a real limit. But it's a judgment the board makes about your child's case, not a blanket rule. Programs of choice, like French immersion, sit inside the same rules.

No provincial rule found for this edition says a child with a disability can or can't be refused a program of choice because of that disability. The human rights rules in 2.10 still apply.

What the rules say

"A board shall enrol a resident student of the board in the school operated by the board that is requested by the parent of the student if, in the opinion of the board asked to enrol the student, there are sufficient resources and facilities available to accommodate the student" (s.10(2)). Students living in

a school's attendance area get priority (s.10(3)). A board "may authorize the use of French or any other language as a language of instruction" (s.17(2)).

The 2026 framework says that where a board has decided a specialized setting may be most appropriate, "this may affect the board's determination of whether there are sufficient resources and facilities to accommodate the student at school requested by the parent(s)" (s.5.3.2(1.3)). It is guidance.

Source: Education Act ss.10(1) to (4), 17(2), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law; not amended by the 2026 amending Act). Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.5.3.2 (guidance). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"Is this a decision that the school doesn't have sufficient resources under section 10(2)? Can I have it in writing, with what supports would be needed?"

Ask for this in writing

The board's decision on your enrolment request, its date, the reason, and what resources or facilities it says are not available.

If you don't get it

An enrolment decision that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed (chapter 12). If disability was a factor, see 2.10. For changing schools, see chapter 14.

Write this down

Date of request · school or program asked for · date of answer · reason given · who decided.

Chapter 3: The paperwork

Every document you'll meet at school, who holds it, what it legally is, and what to do when two of them disagree.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/3

Turn here when you're hearing

- "The IPP is just a planning document." → 3.1
- "That's what's in the system." → 3.1
- "We already have that on file." → 3.2
- "There's nothing in the file you haven't seen." → 3.3
- "That's not part of the student record." → 3.4
- "Those are just the teacher's notes." → 3.4
- "We can't change what's in the record." → 3.5
- "The portal is up to date." → 3.6
- "That's what PowerSchool shows." → 3.6
- "That's on PASI." → 3.7
- "The report card shows they're doing fine." → 3.8
- "That's an old version." → 3.9
- "We're using the updated one." → 3.9
- "The behaviour plan is still in place." → 3.10
- "We'll place an alert on the file." → 3.11
- "The psychologist's report is with the division." → 3.12
- "No concerns to note today." → 3.13
- "We have those recorded at school." → 3.13
- "What exactly are you looking for?" → 3.14

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
3.1	Two documents say different things. Which one counts?

Entry	Title
3.2	The registration form
3.3	Nobody will tell you what's in the student record
3.4	They say those notes aren't part of the record
3.5	Something in the record is wrong
3.6	The portal says one thing and the IPP says another
3.7	PASI, the Alberta Student Number and MyPass
3.8	The report card and the IPP don't tell the same story
3.9	There are two different versions of the same plan
3.10	The behaviour plan describes a classroom your child isn't in any more
3.11	You were promised a health plan and got "an alert on the file"
3.12	You never got a copy of the assessment
3.13	The daily note says "a good day" and the school's own log doesn't
3.14	Asking for the whole file

3.1 Two documents say different things. Which one counts?

You might be hearing

- "The IPP is just a planning document."
- "That's what's in the system."
- "Go by the email, that's more current."
- "Don't worry about the paperwork, we know what they need."

What's going on

Your child generates many documents: the registration form, the IPP (Individualized Program Plan), report cards, a behaviour plan, a health

plan, assessment reports, daily notes, emails, incident reports. They are written by different people at different times, so they will sometimes disagree.

No Alberta rule says which school document wins when two disagree. That means you ask, in writing, which one staff are following, and you ask them to correct the other. A few anchors help. The IPP is the plan you're asked to consent to, it must list the accommodations your child needs, and it must be placed in the student record. A portal screen, a daily note or a hallway conversation is none of those things.

What the rules say

Boards must "ensure IPPs are placed in student records" and obtain "written informed parental consent on IPPs to indicate agreement with the IPP". The IPP must include "required classroom accommodations".

The Student Record Regulation goes further: the IPP "and any amendments to the plan must be placed on the student record" (s.2(4)).

The 2006 IPP resource states: "Required accommodations must be listed on the IPP."

No provincial rule was found that ranks other school documents against each other.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f), pp.10 to 11 (standard, under MO 015/2004). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(4), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1, p.12 (guidance). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"These two documents don't match. Which one are staff following today? Can you correct the other one so they agree?"

Ask for this in writing

Which document staff are following on [the point], its date and version, and the date the other document will be corrected.

If you don't get it

If the IPP is missing something another document says your child needs, that's a 4.2 problem. Keep both documents and a one-line comparison (chapter 11).

Write this down

Date · document A says · document B says · which one staff said they follow · date of correction.

3.2 The registration form

You might be hearing

— "We already have that on file."

— "Just fill in what's changed."

— "The IPP pulls from your registration form."

— "Medical information goes on the registration form."

What's going on

The registration form is what you fill in when your child enrols, and often again every year. It's the one document in the school's file that you wrote. Some divisions' software copies parts of it, like medical information, into other documents such as the IPP. So what you put on it, and what you leave off, travels.

Keep a copy of every registration form you submit, every year. Write every diagnosis and medical instruction on it each time, even if you're told the school already has it.

What the rules say

Boards must "request information from parents that is relevant to students' education when students enter the education system" (Standard 2(c)).

For anaphylaxis (a severe, possibly fatal allergic reaction), each board's policy must require that "upon enrollment, parents and students are asked to supply information on life-threatening allergies, if any". Parents and students are responsible for keeping the school's allergy file current.

Registration forms in public and separate divisions must also include two required questions about French-language education rights.

How a division's software copies registration information into other documents is not set by Alberta (see 4.7).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 2(c), p.6 (standard). Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act, SA 2019 c.P-30.6, ss.2(2)(d)(ii), 6(2), current as of 1 September 2025 (law). Guide to Education ECS to Grade 12, 2025-26, Francophone education section (provincial policy).

Say this

"I'd like a copy of the registration form you have on file for my child this year, so I can check it against what I sent."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the registration form on file for [school year], and the name of the person who carries mid-year medical updates into the IPP.

If you don't get it

If the IPP's medical section doesn't match the form, see 4.7. For medical plans, see 3.11 and chapter 9.

Write this down

Date submitted · how (online, paper, email) · what medical information you listed · whether you kept a copy.

3.3 Nobody will tell you what's in the student record

You might be hearing

— "There's nothing in the file you haven't seen."

— "The cum file is at the office."

— "You'd have to book a time with the principal."

— "That's confidential."

What's going on

The student record (sometimes called the cumulative file or "cum file") is the official file the board must keep on your child. The Education Act gives you, as a parent, the right to review it and to get a copy. The Student Record

Regulation sets out what goes in it, and the test is wide: anything that affects decisions about your child's education, however it's stored.

The board must tell you that you can review it. Each division must also name one employee responsible for its student record rules. Ask who that is.

"Confidential" means the record is protected from other people. It doesn't mean it's protected from you.

What the rules say

A board "shall establish and maintain in accordance with the regulations a student record" for each student. The student, and "the student's parent, except where the student is an independent student", may review it. A person entitled to review it "may submit a request for a copy of the student record, along with any associated fee", and the board "shall provide a copy of the student record to the person" (s.56(1), (3), (4)).

The record "must contain all information affecting the decisions made about the education of the student". That includes assessments, the IPP and its amendments, and summaries of past years' IPPs (Student Record Regulation s.2(1), (4)). The board must ensure people entitled to review the record "are informed that they are entitled to review" it (s.6). It must keep the record for 7 years after your child stops attending its schools, unless it has been transferred (s.4). And it must designate an employee responsible for making its student record policies comply with the regulation (s.10).

Boards must also "provide parents with access to information contained in the student record, including results of specialized assessments and student progress reports" (Standard 5). When parents refuse consent to a specialized assessment, the reasons go in the record (Standard 1(b)).

At 18 your child becomes an "independent student" and the parent's right to review ends (s.56(3)(b)). See 14.12.

Source: Education Act ss.1(1)(n), 56, consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law; not amended by the 2026 amending Act). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, ss.2(1), 2(4), 4, 6, 10, current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 1(b), 5, pp.6, 8 (standard).

Say this

"Under section 56 of the Education Act I can review my child's student record and get a copy. I'd like to request a copy, please."

Ask for this in writing

A complete copy of your child's student record under Education Act s.56(4), as at [date], with any fee stated in advance, and the name of the employee designated under s.10 of the Student Record Regulation.

If you don't get it

A decision about access to the student record can be appealed to the board (s.42(4)) and then reviewed by the Minister (s.43(4)). For records kept outside the student record, see 3.4.

Write this down

Date requested · who to · fee quoted · date received · number of pages.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on student records that lists what goes in the file and how long it's kept. Ask for it by name.

3.4 They say those notes aren't part of the record

You might be hearing

- "That's not part of the student record."
- "Those are just the teacher's notes."
- "That's an internal log."
- "Counselling notes are kept separately."

What's going on

Not everything a school writes about your child goes into the student record. The Student Record Regulation leaves out staff notes, but only notes that meet two conditions: they were written for that staff member's own use, and they were not used in decisions about your child's program placement. Notes shared with other staff, or used in deciding your child's

placement, may not fit that exception. Some sensitive counselling records and child intervention reports are also kept out.

Being outside the student record doesn't mean being out of reach. You can ask the board for your child's personal information wherever it's kept, including logs, emails and notes, through an access to information request.

What the rules say

The record must not include "notes and observations prepared by and for the exclusive use of a teacher, teacher's assistant, counsellor or principal, and that are not used in program placement decisions" (Student Record Regulation s.3(1)(a)(i)). Both parts must be true for notes to be left out.

The Access to Information Act replaced FOIP on 11 June 2025. The province says local public bodies, including school boards, "administer their own records under the guidance of the ATIA". "If you are requesting access to your own personal information, no fee is required." Whether a request for your child's information is treated the same way is for the division to confirm, so ask before you send. "Public bodies will have 30 business days to respond to an access request." That may be extended in some cases. You "submit your request directly to the public body that has the records".

Source: Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.3(1), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Alberta.ca, Access to information requests, published 23 September 2025, read 23 October 2026 (provincial information). Guide to Education ECS to Grade 12, 2025-26, Student Record Regulation note (provincial policy).

Say this

"Were these notes used in deciding my child's program placement? If so, the regulation says they belong in the record. Either way, who handles access to information requests?"

Ask for this in writing

An access to information request to the division for all records containing your child's personal information held at [school] and the division office from [date] to [date], including incident logs, notes, emails and messages.

If you don't get it

Note the date your request was received; 30 business days runs from there unless extended in writing. For a review by the Information and Privacy Commissioner and how to word a request, see chapter 11.

Write this down

Date request sent · to whom · date received by them · 30-business-day date · date answered.

3.5 Something in the record is wrong

You might be hearing

— "We can't change what's in the record."

— "That's the teacher's professional judgment."

— "You can add a note if you like."

— "It's historical, it doesn't matter now."

What's going on

Records follow your child from school to school. A wrong diagnosis, a behaviour your child doesn't show, or a missing medical condition will be read by the next teacher, and sometimes by paramedics. The Education Act gives you a way to ask for a correction, and a way to appeal if the board says no.

A professional's opinion isn't usually "corrected", because it's an opinion. But you can ask that a mistake of fact be fixed, and that your disagreement with an opinion be recorded next to it.

What the rules say

If a person entitled to review a student record "is of the opinion that the student record contains inaccurate or incomplete information, that person may request that the board ... rectify the matter" (s.56(6)).

A board employee's decision "respecting access to or the accuracy or completeness of the student record" may be appealed to the board (s.42(4)). The board's decision may then be reviewed by the Minister on a written request (s.43(4)).

Each year your child is enrolled, the board must make sure the information in the record is recorded or updated (Student Record Regulation s.2(6)). You can also ask that health information you choose be placed on the record (s.2(1)(p)).

From 18, the right to review and correct is your child's, not yours (s.56(3)(b)). See 14.12.

Source: Education Act ss.42(4), 43(4), 56(6), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 16 October 2026; s.56(3)(b), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1)(p), 2(6), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation).

Say this

"This part of the record is inaccurate. Under section 56(6) I'm asking you to correct it. If you won't, I'd like that decision in writing."

Ask for this in writing

Correction of [the exact wording] on [document, date] to [the correct wording], with the supporting document attached, and the board's written decision by [date].

If you don't get it

A refusal, or no answer, can be appealed to the board under s.42(4) (see 1.2 on no decision). Then the Minister can review it under s.43(4). See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · document and page · what it says · what it should say · your evidence · date of their decision.

3.6 The portal says one thing and the IPP says another

You might be hearing

— "The portal is up to date."

— "That's what PowerSchool shows."

— "The system auto-populates that."

— "Just check the parent portal."

What's going on

A parent portal is a website or app where you see some of what the division's student information system holds: attendance, marks, contact details, sometimes documents. It shows what the division chooses to show. It's a window, not the whole file.

The student record in the Education Act is defined by the Student Record Regulation, not by what a portal displays. No provincial rule was found that says what a portal must show, or that a portal screen is the student record. So when the portal and the IPP disagree, the portal isn't automatically right.

What the rules say

The board must keep a student record "in accordance with the regulations" (s.56(1)). The record covers the listed information "regardless of the manner in which the student record is maintained or stored" (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)), so it can be partly electronic. Boards must place IPPs in student records (Standard 11(f)).

How a division's software fills or displays any field is an arrangement between the division and its vendor. It is not set by Alberta (see 4.7).

No provincial rule about what a parent portal must show was found.

Source: Education Act s.56(1), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), p.11 (standard). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"The portal and the IPP don't match on this. Which one is correct, and who will fix the other?"

Ask for this in writing

Which is correct on [the point], the date the other will be corrected, and whether the portal entry is part of the student record or a separate system.

If you don't get it

Ask for the student record itself (3.3). Take screenshots of the portal with the date showing before anything changes (chapter 11).

Write this down

Date · portal shows · IPP shows · screenshot saved (yes/no) · who you asked.

3.7 PASI, the Alberta Student Number and MyPass

You might be hearing

— "That's on PASI."

— "The code is in the provincial system."

— "Check MyPass."

— "Alberta Education has their record."

What's going on

PASI (the Provincial Approach to Student Information) is the province's student information system. Schools, divisions and the ministry use it to share student information as children move between schools. Every student has an Alberta Student Number (ASN), a 9-digit number assigned by the province.

Your child's special education code (a number the school uses to report a type of need to the province) is entered in PASI by school staff. MyPass is a provincial website mostly for high school records: transcripts, diploma exam marks, achievement test results. Parents can use it in some cases, with limits.

What the rules say

PASI "allows schools, school authorities and the ministry to share student information in real-time." Alberta "assigns every student a unique 9-digit Alberta Student Number (ASN)".

"It is the responsibility of school authority staff to assign a special education code to a child's/student's registration in the Provincial Approach to Student Information (PASI)." Schools "must have the documentation to support the assignment of a special education code before the special education code is assigned in PASI."

Parents or guardians can use MyPass if the child attended an accredited Alberta school and the school entered their details. "Parents or guardians can access this information until the child turns 18 years of age or becomes independent." Official transcripts cost $20.00 a copy.

Source: Guide to Education ECS to Grade 12, 2025-26, PASI and ASN sections (provincial policy). Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, Education and Childcare, 11 June 2026, Introduction (provincial criteria). Alberta.ca, Student information and high school transcripts, published 14 October 2026 (provincial information).

Say this

"What special education code does my child have in PASI this year? Has it changed since last year, and what documentation supports it?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's special education code(s) in PASI as at [date], the date each was assigned or changed, and the documents relied on.

If you don't get it

For what codes mean and what they change, see chapter 6. For transcripts and high school records, see chapter 14.

Write this down

Date · code(s) given · date assigned · documents named · any change from last year.

3.8 The report card and the IPP don't tell the same story

You might be hearing

— "The report card shows they're doing fine."

— "They're meeting expectations with support."

— "The IPP is reported separately."

— "Report cards use the grade-level outcomes."

What's going on

A report card reports progress against the curriculum. An IPP review reports progress against your child's own goals. They measure different things, so they can look different. But they shouldn't contradict each other. A report card saying "meeting expectations" next to an IPP saying your child is several grades behind needs an explanation.

Ask which outcomes the report card is measuring: grade-level, adapted, or modified. Adapted programming keeps the grade-level outcomes with changes to how they're taught. Modified programming changes the outcomes themselves.

What the rules say

A teacher must "regularly assess students and periodically report the results of the assessment to the students, the students' parents and the board" (s.196(1)(e)).

Boards must "ensure that students' IPPs include information about students' current level of performance and academic achievement relative to identified learner outcomes included in the provincial curriculum" and "inform parents of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods, throughout the year" (Standard 13). The Standards define adapted and modified programming (Definitions).

Source: Education Act s.196(1)(e), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions pp.3 to 4 and Standard 13, p.12 (standard).

Say this

"The report card and the IPP seem to say different things. Is the report card grade-level, adapted or modified for each subject?"

Ask for this in writing

For each subject on the report card dated [date], whether it reports against grade-level, adapted or modified outcomes, and your child's current level of performance as recorded in the IPP for that subject.

If you don't get it

If you're told the IPP replaces the report card, see 4.9. If the IPP shows no current level of performance, see 4.2.

Write this down

Date of report card · subject · mark or comment · IPP level for that subject · explanation given.

3.9 There are two different versions of the same plan

You might be hearing

— "That's an old version."

— "We're using the updated one."

— "It's a living document."

— "The changes are minor."

What's going on

IPPs and behaviour plans often exist in several versions in one year. Software can save a new version each time someone edits it. That's normal. The problem comes when you signed one version and staff are following another, or when goals, supports or team members drop out between versions without anyone telling you.

Comparing versions side by side is one of the most useful things you can do. It shows what changed, when, and sometimes who typed it.

What the rules say

Teachers must "make changes to the IPP, as required", "document, in the IPP, the formal review of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods", and "obtain written informed parental consent on IPPs to indicate agreement with the IPP" (Standard 11(f)).

Informed consent means the parent "has been provided with all information relevant to the activity for which consent is sought" and "understands that the granting of consent is voluntary and may be withdrawn at any time" (Definitions).

The IPP "and any amendments to the plan must be placed on the student record" (Student Record Regulation s.2(4)). So changes to the plan belong in the record.

No provincial rule was found requiring a school to tell parents each time an IPP is edited, or to keep a software version history. That means you ask.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f), pp.10 to 11 (standard). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(4), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"I have two versions of this plan. Which one is in force today, and what changed between them, and when?"

Ask for this in writing

Every version of the IPP (or behaviour plan) for this school year, each with its date, the version in force today, and the change history if the software keeps one.

If you don't get it

If a goal changed without you being told, see 4.8. If the version in force isn't the one you signed, see 4.6.

Write this down

Date · version dates you hold · version in force · what changed · whether you were told.

3.10 The behaviour plan describes a classroom your child isn't in any more

You might be hearing

- "The behaviour plan is still in place."
- "We'll update it when we have time."
- "Staff know what to do."
- "We haven't needed it lately."

What's going on

A behaviour plan (also called a behaviour support plan, PBSP or safety plan) says what staff do to prevent and respond to hard moments. It names rooms, routines, people and steps. When your child changes class, school, EA or timetable, a plan that still names the old ones isn't guiding anyone.

No provincial rule found sets a review date for a general behaviour plan. But where a plan includes seclusion or physical restraint, there are binding rules about it, including review after an incident.

What the rules say

Under the seclusion and restraint standards, if seclusion or restraint is agreed "as a safety, emergency or crisis measure by parents/guardians, this agreement is to be noted in a safety or crisis management plan", which "is to be noted and attached to the child's/student's Instructional Support Plan (ISP)". Ask your school which of its documents that is. Where a child has a history of crisis-level behaviour, or their behaviour can reasonably be predicted to pose a danger, parents must be involved in developing the plan, and the school must seek "written informed consent from parents or guardians on the emergency or safety measures to be implemented".

After each incident of seclusion or restraint, "a review of the individual behaviour plan, where one has been previously created, occurs and the plan is updated to prevent and reduce recurrence."

For IPPs generally, teachers must "make changes to the IPP, as required" (Standard 11(f)).

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools, appendix to Ministerial Order 042/2019, pp.14 to 16, in effect 1 November 2019 (standard). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), p.11 (standard).

Say this

"This plan still names the old classroom and staff. Which plan are staff following right now, and when will it be updated with me?"

Ask for this in writing

The behaviour or safety plan in force today with its date, who wrote it, the date it will be revised, and an invitation for you to take part in the revision.

If you don't get it

For seclusion, restraint and safety plans, see chapter 8. For plans after a school change, see chapter 14.

Write this down

Date · plan date · what's out of date (room, staff, steps) · who you asked · revision date given.

3.11 You were promised a health plan and got "an alert on the file"

You might be hearing

— "We'll place an alert on the file."

— "Can you get us something from the doctor?"

— "Staff are aware."

— "It's in the system."

What's going on

An alert is a flag in the student information system. A health or emergency care plan is a document that says who does what: who watches for symptoms, who acts, who is trained, where medication is kept, and what goes with your child in an ambulance. An alert tells staff something exists. A plan tells them what to do.

For anaphylaxis, Alberta law requires a file and an emergency procedure for each student. For other conditions, no law, regulation or ministerial order found for this edition requires a plan for one student. Provincial guidance for Type 1 diabetes says each student who needs support should have one. Boards must still have written procedures for medical information.

What the rules say

For anaphylaxis, each board's policy must ensure every school keeps "a file for every student who has an anaphylactic allergy including any current treatments, copies of any prescriptions, any instructions from health professionals and a current emergency contact list". Each school's risk reduction plan must include "a readily accessible emergency procedure for each student".

For all students, boards must "have written procedures for accessing, recording, and sharing medical information and for storing and/or administering medications" (Standard 6(e)). The IPP must include relevant medical information. You can ask that health information be placed on the student record: it must contain "any health information that the parent ... wishes to be placed on the student record" (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(p)).

For Type 1 diabetes, Alberta Education's 2019 guidelines say staff "should initiate the development of an ICP" (individual care plan) when the school learns of a medical need, and that students needing diabetes support "are to have an emergency plan as part of their ICP". These are guidelines, not law.

The 2026 School Critical Emergency Standards (MO 029/2026) require a school-wide emergency plan, not a plan for one student. No other province-wide instrument was found requiring an individual health plan.

Source: Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act, SA 2019 c.P-30.6, ss.2(2)(d)(iii), 3(c), current as of 1 September 2025 (law). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1)(p), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 6(e), p.8 (standard). Ministerial Order 029/2026, School Critical Emergency Standards, ss.2, 3 (standard). Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, February 2019, pp.7 and 11 (guidance). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"An alert isn't a plan. Who will act if this happens at school, what will they do, and where is that written down?"

Ask for this in writing

An individual health or emergency care plan for your child stating who acts, what they do, who is trained, where it's kept, and what is given to paramedics, plus the division's written procedure for medical information under Standard 6(e).

If you don't get it

For medical needs at school, see chapter 9. For medical information missing from the IPP, see 4.7.

Write this down

Date doctor's letter sent · how sent · date receipt confirmed · what the school produced · date of plan.

3.12 You never got a copy of the assessment

You might be hearing

— "The psychologist's report is with the division."

— "We'll go over the results at the meeting."

— "You'll get a summary."

— "The full report is for professionals."

What's going on

An assessment report is a written report by a qualified professional, such as a psychologist (a psychoeducational or "psych-ed" assessment), a speech-language pathologist (SLP) or an occupational therapist (OT). It describes how your child learns and recommends supports. It's often the most important document in the file, and the one parents most often don't hold.

You're entitled to the results, and the school is expected to use them to plan. An IPP is meant to list each assessment with its date and source, so you can check which ones were used.

What the rules say

Boards must "report results of assessments to parents, teachers and others involved with students' programming" and "use results of assessments to make decisions, develop Individualized Program Plans (IPPs)" (Standard 3). They must "use qualified professionals to conduct specialized assessments, interpret results, and provide program recommendations to parents, teachers and others" (Standard 4(d)). Specialized assessments should be done "within a reasonable time (recommended guideline is within eight weeks unless there are extenuating circumstances) from the date of written referral including completion of a written report" (Standard 4(f)).

Parents get access to "results of specialized assessments" in the student record (Standard 5).

The student record must hold, for each formal intellectual, behavioural or emotional assessment the board gives your child individually, its name, date, who gave it, a summary of results, "any interpretive report", and "any action taken as program planning as a result" (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(n)). The same applies to a private assessment you asked for, once the

school holds it (s.2(1)(o)). The test itself (the "test instrument") needn't be in the record, but if there's an appeal about the assessment, you can review it as if it were (s.3(2)).

"Each assessment report should be listed within the IPP and should include the date and source (including the name of the assessment tool and the person who did the assessment)."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 3, 4(d), 4(f), 5, pp.7 to 8 (standard). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, ss.2(1)(n), (o), 3(2), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1, p.5 (guidance).

Say this

"I'd like a copy of the full written assessment report, not just a summary. When can I have it?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the full written report of the [type] assessment dated [date], the program planning action recorded as a result of it, and where in the IPP each of its recommendations is addressed.

If you don't get it

Request it as part of the student record (3.3). For getting assessments done and turning recommendations into goals, see chapter 5.

Write this down

Date of assessment · assessor's profession · date report finished · date you received it · recommendations listed.

3.13 The daily note says "a good day" and the school's own log doesn't

You might be hearing

— "No concerns to note today."

— "Please see email."

— "We have those recorded at school."

— "If you'd like incidents reported daily, just let us know."

What's going on

Many children have a daily note, communication book or app that goes home. It's often the only school record you see day to day. Schools may also keep separate records: incident reports, behaviour logs, tracking sheets. These can say different things. A home note that says "good day" on a day the log records a serious incident leaves you without the information you'd need.

No provincial rule was found setting what a daily home note must contain. That makes it worth agreeing in writing, at the start of the year, what you'll be told and when. Where seclusion or restraint is used, the rules are firm.

What the rules say

After any use of seclusion or physical restraint, "the principal is required to notify the child's/student's parents/guardians as soon as possible after the incident and on the same school day". Details must be documented, and "can be captured in an incident report" covering what was tried first, the behaviour, the duration, injuries, staff involved, and "efforts, including methods used, to notify parents/guardians, including dates and times."

For IPPs, teachers must "throughout the year, provide feedback during informal reviews to parents" (Standard 11(f)).

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools, appendix to Ministerial Order 042/2019, pp.15 to 16 (standard). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), p.11 (standard). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"I'd like the daily note to include one line: incident today, yes or no. If yes, a report to follow. Can we agree that in writing?"

Ask for this in writing

Agreement on which kinds of incident you'll be told about the same day, by whom and how, and copies of any incident reports or behaviour logs about your child from [date] to [date].

If you don't get it

Keep every original note. Compare them date by date with any log you receive (chapter 11). For incidents and safety, see chapter 8. To get logs, see 3.4.

Write this down

Date · what the note said · what you later learned happened · source of that information.

3.14 Asking for the whole file

You might be hearing

— "What exactly are you looking for?"

— "That's a lot of records."

— "You've already got everything."

— "We don't take minutes at those meetings."

What's going on

At some point you may want everything: before a big meeting, before an appeal, or when changing schools. "Everything" is spread across several places and two legal routes. The student record (3.3) comes through Education Act s.56. Everything else with your child's personal information in it, like emails, logs, notes and attendance details, comes through an access to information request (3.4).

No provincial rule was found requiring schools to take minutes at parent meetings. If there are none, your own dated summary, emailed the same day, becomes the record (chapter 10).

What the rules say

You may review the student record and request a copy; the board "shall provide a copy" (s.56(3) and (4)). The record must contain "all information affecting the decisions made about the education of the student", including private assessments you gave the school (Student Record Regulation s.2(1), (o)). From 18 the right to review is your child's (s.56(3)(b)); see 14.12.

For records outside it, the province says a request for your own personal information has no fee (confirm fees for a request about your child), and public bodies have 30 business days to respond, which may be extended.

A checklist for the request:

— the student record, including all IPPs and plans

— every version of the IPP and behaviour plan this year (3.9)

— assessment reports, including private ones you shared, and the action taken on each (3.12)

— incident reports and behaviour logs (3.13)

— emails and messages about your child, between staff and with the division

— attendance records, including any early dismissals

— consent records, including any verbal consents logged

— health and medication records (3.11)

Source: Education Act s.56(3) and (4), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025 (law). Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1), current as of 1 September 2025 (regulation). Alberta.ca, Access to information requests, read 23 October 2026 (provincial information). Negative search recorded in the ledger.

Say this

"I'm asking for a copy of my child's student record, and separately for all other records with my child's information in them. Who do I send each request to?"

Ask for this in writing

Two requests, both dated. One to the principal or division for a copy of the student record under s.56(4), copied to the employee designated for student records (Student Record Regulation s.10). One to the division's access to information office for all records containing your child's personal information from [date] to [date].

If you don't get it

Diarize both deadlines. Refusals about the student record can be appealed (3.5). For access request reviews and organizing what you get, see chapter 11.

Write this down

Date of each request · sent to · received date · deadline date · date answered · pages received.

Chapter 4: The IPP

The document that decides what your child is taught, and the one most parents sign without being told what it commits anyone to.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/4

Turn here when you're hearing

— "Your child will have an IPP this year." → 4.1

— "We call it an ISP here." → 4.1

— "That isn't something we'd put in the IPP." → 4.2

— "We use our own format." → 4.2

— "We'll go through the goals when we meet." → 4.3

— "It's ongoing." → 4.4

— "We assess on an ongoing basis." → 4.4

— "The IPP is a living document, it changes as we go." → 4.5

— "We'll get you to sign it later." → 4.6

— "It's only to confirm you were at the meeting." → 4.6

— "That part is auto-populated." → 4.7

— "We adjusted that goal, it wasn't appropriate any more." → 4.8

— "The IPP is the report card." → 4.9

— "We've drafted it for you to review." → 4.10

— "You'll get a copy once it's finalized." → 4.11

— "It'll transfer with him." → 4.12

— "We have to try the lower tiers first." → 4.13

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
4.1	What an IPP is, and who gets one
4.2	What the IPP has to contain
4.3	You haven't seen the goals before the meeting
4.4	They won't give you a date for when

Entry	Title
	progress is measured
4.5	"It's a living document"
4.6	The IPP has no parent signature on it
4.7	The medical information is wrong or missing
4.8	A goal changed or vanished and nobody told you
4.9	"The IPP is the report card"
4.10	You weren't part of writing it
4.11	Getting your own copy, and keeping it
4.12	What happens to it when your child changes school
4.13	They want to try everything else first

4.1 What an IPP is, and who gets one

You might be hearing

— "Your child will have an IPP this year."

— "We call it an ISP here."

— "He's on a plan."

— "She doesn't need an IPP, she's doing fine with classroom supports."

What's going on

An IPP (Individualized Program Plan) is the written plan for a student the school has identified as needing specialized supports and services: help beyond what every student gets, because of a learning, behavioural, communication, intellectual or physical need. Some divisions call it an ISP (instructional support plan). The name changes. The duties don't.

The trigger is the school's own decision. Under the Education Act, a board decides whether a student needs specialized supports and services. Once it has decided that, the student is entitled to access them, and the provincial Standards say every student identified as having special education needs gets an IPP. There is no such thing as being identified "a little".

Gifted students are covered too. Under the provincial definition, special education includes students who are gifted and talented.

What the rules say

The Education Act says a board "may determine that the student is in need of specialized supports and services" (s.11(3)), and a student so determined "is entitled to have access to those supports and services" (s.11(4), subject to s.40). Before providing them, the board "shall consult with the parent" (s.11(5)).

The Standards for Special Education require boards to "ensure that IPPs are developed, implemented, monitored and evaluated for all students identified as having special education needs" (Standard 11(a)). Alberta's 2006 IPP resource puts it in one line: "Each student identified as having special education needs must have an IPP."

Alberta's Guide to Education uses both names: when students require specialized supports and services, "an instructional support plan (ISP) or individualized program plan (IPP) is collaboratively developed."

Which schools: the 2004 Standards cover Grades 1 to 12 in public and separate boards, including francophone authorities, and do not cover charter schools. The Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026, guidance, not law) covers public, separate and francophone authorities and public charter school operators. Preschool and kindergarten have their own standards (see chapter 14).

Source: Education Act s.11(3) to (5), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, law. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword and Standard 11(a), applied under Ministerial Order 015/2004. Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.3, guidance. Guide to Education, "Supports and services for students", last updated 26 August 2025, provincial policy.

Say this

"Has the school decided my child needs specialized supports and services? If yes, I'd like the IPP. If no, I'd like that decision in writing."

Ask for this in writing

Whether the school has determined that [child] needs specialized supports and services, the date of that decision, and, if there is no IPP, the reason.

If you don't get it

A "no" in writing is a decision you can challenge. No answer at all is too: under the Education Act a failure to make a decision counts as a decision you can appeal (see chapter 12). If your child has needs but no one has assessed them, start at chapter 5.

Write this down

Date · who you asked · whether they said your child is identified · what the plan is called at this school.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on inclusive education or IPPs that names who coordinates the plan at each school. Ask for it.

4.2 What the IPP has to contain

You might be hearing

— "That isn't something we'd put in the IPP."

— "The IPP is just a planning document."

— "We use our own format."

— "That's not required."

What's going on

Alberta does not tell divisions what the IPP form must look like, so every division's IPP looks different. Staff sometimes describe a missing item as a quirk of their format. It isn't. The province sets a list of information every IPP must carry. A division can put it anywhere on its own form. It cannot leave it out.

What the rules say

The 2004 Standards define an IPP as including ten pieces of "essential information". Standard 11(f) adds two duties for teachers: document the formal review of progress in the IPP at regularly scheduled reporting periods, and obtain written informed parental consent. Alberta's 2006 IPP resource puts all twelve in one list:

— assessment data: the diagnostic assessment used to decide programming and services

— current level of performance and achievement

— identification of strengths and areas of need

— measurable goals and objectives

— procedures for evaluating student progress

— identification of coordinated support services

— relevant medical information

— required classroom accommodations

— transition plans

— formal review of progress at regularly scheduled reporting periods

— year-end summary

— parent signature to indicate informed consent

The same page says: "Alberta Education does not mandate a specific format." So the form is theirs. The contents are not.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f), under Ministerial Order 015/2004. Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.4, guidance restating the Standards.

Say this

"Alberta sets a list of things every IPP has to contain. I can't find [the item] anywhere on this one. Where is it?"

Ask for this in writing

A complete copy of the IPP, and written confirmation of where each required element appears in it, or that it is absent and why.

If you don't get it

A missing element is a programming problem, not a paperwork one, and the gap is usually the thing you were worried about. Put the missing element to the principal in writing with a date by which you'd like it added. Still missing after that date — chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · which element is missing · who you asked · what they said it was.

4.3 You haven't seen the goals before the meeting

You might be hearing

— "We'll go through the goals when we meet."

— "We'll have it ready for the meeting."

— "It's easier to explain it in person."

— "There's not much new, it's mostly the same as last year."

What's going on

If the first time you see the goals is when they are read to you across a table, you are reacting, not planning. Asking for the draft a few days ahead is ordinary. Alberta's own resource suggests schools give parents an agenda in advance so they can think about it and bring what they know.

"Mostly the same as last year" is worth checking. Most of an IPP is meant to change every year: the assessment data, current level, goals and objectives, transition plans and year-end summary.

What the rules say

Teachers must "involve parents ... in the development, implementation, monitoring and evaluation of students' IPPs" (Standard 11(f)). Boards must "ensure parents have information needed to make informed decisions" (Standard 8(b)).

The 2006 resource suggests schools "Provide parents with an agenda a day or two in advance. This allows them time to think about the items to be discussed and to collect relevant information to bring to the meeting." It also says many components "will change from one school year to the next, including assessment data, current level of performance, goals and objectives, transition plans, and year-end summaries."

No Alberta rule sets a number of days by which a draft must reach you. That makes it a reasonable request, not an entitlement with a deadline.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 8(b) and 11(f). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.4 and Chapter 2 p.7, guidance.

Say this

"Could you send me the draft goals before we meet? I'll come with questions, and we'll get through it faster."

Ask for this in writing

The draft IPP, or at least the draft goals and objectives, by [date three school days before the meeting], and the names and roles of everyone who will attend.

If you don't get it

Go, listen, and don't sign at the table (see 4.6). Ask for the document to take home and say when you'll return it. Then send your questions in writing (see chapter 10 on meeting follow-up).

Write this down

Date asked for the draft · date it arrived, or that it didn't · meeting date.

4.4 They won't give you a date for when progress is measured

You might be hearing

- "It's ongoing."
- "We assess on an ongoing basis."
- "Progress is triangulated through conversations, observations and products."
- "We test when the classroom teacher feels a student is approaching the goal."
- "We'll have a better sense by the end of the year."

What's going on

"Ongoing" sounds like more measurement, which is why it slides past. But you asked when. An interval is a date or a frequency: every six weeks, the first week of each reporting period, 22 November. "When the teacher feels he's close" is a trigger, not a date, so nobody can later say whether it happened.

This matters more than it sounds. If reading is measured twice a year, nobody can tell during the year whether what's being done is working. By the time the second number arrives, the year is spent.

What the rules say

An IPP must contain measurable goals and objectives, procedures for evaluating progress, and a formal review of progress at regularly scheduled reporting periods, documented in the IPP (Standards, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f)).

Alberta's own resource is blunt about "ongoing": "Typically, IPP reviews align with the school's regular reporting periods. These are generally scheduled three to four times per year. ... A comment regarding the student's progress should appear on the IPP along with the date of the review. Checkmarks or vague terms such as 'ongoing' do not adequately describe what a student has achieved."

On objectives: "Each objective should include a target date for achieving that particular objective. ... Most often target dates are set in four- to 12-week periods, but this will vary for different objectives." And: "Student progress should be evaluated several times throughout the school year."

SMART goals are a format some divisions use, not a provincial requirement: the resource says "a number of school jurisdictions use a version of the SMART acronym." Measurability is required whatever the format.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 pp.11 and 14, Chapter 7 pp.1 and 7, guidance.

Say this

"Ongoing tells me how, not when. What's the date of the next measurement?"

Ask for this in writing

The date of the next formal review of each goal, how often it will be re-measured, and the target date recorded against each short-term objective.

If you don't get it

Either a date comes back and you have something to hold them to, or no date comes back, and the plain reading is that nobody has planned to measure before the year ends. Put it to the principal in writing. An IPP with no dated review and no target dates is also a 4.2 problem.

Write this down

Date you asked · who · their exact words · the date they gave, or that they gave none. Record the words as said: "ongoing", three times across a year, is the evidence.

4.5 "It's a living document"

You might be hearing

- "The IPP is a living document, it changes as we go."
- "It's a working document."
- "We don't lock things in."
- "We'll update it as needed."

What's going on

"Living document" is true and it is also used to explain why nothing on the page can be relied on. A plan that can change is fine. A plan that changes without a date, a reason, or you, is not a plan you can check.

The province's own guidance pairs change with schedule. Goals can be added to or modified during the year, and each change is meant to be documented when an objective reaches its target date. Flexible is not the same as unscheduled.

What the rules say

Teachers must "make changes to the IPP, as required" and must involve parents in its "development, implementation, monitoring and evaluation" (Standard 11(f)).

The 2006 resource calls the IPP "a working document and a record of student progress", says annual goals "may be added to or modified throughout the school year", and says that at an objective's target date

"revisions should be documented and, if necessary, a new objective and target date set."

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says "IPPs are reviewed on set schedules with parents to monitor progress and adjust supports" (s.7, 1.3).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.3, Chapter 7 pp.1 and 7, guidance. Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026, s.7, guidance.

Say this

"Living is fine. I just need to know when it changes. Can every change carry a date and a reason, and can I hear about it before it happens?"

Ask for this in writing

The review schedule for this IPP for this school year, and agreement that any change to goals, supports or accommodations will be dated, explained in the IPP, and sent to you.

If you don't get it

Compare each new version against the last one you were given, line by line. Anything changed without notice goes to 4.8. Keep every version (see 4.11).

Write this down

Date of each version you receive · what changed · whether you were told before.

4.6 The IPP has no parent signature on it

You might be hearing

— "We'll get you to sign it later."

— "Just sign to show you've seen it."

— "It's only to confirm you were at the meeting."

— "We'll finalize it and send a copy home."

What's going on

The signature line on an IPP is not a receipt. It is informed consent: your agreement with the plan. Being told it only shows you attended is a common way a parent ends up signing a document they haven't read.

Four things follow, and most parents are told none of them:

— You are meant to be invited to sign at the start of the year once goals are written, and again at each reporting period.

— Informed consent means you have the information first. Asking to read it before signing is the process working.

— Consent is voluntary and can be withdrawn at any time.

— Not signing is not a dead end. If you decline, the school has to write down why and what it did to resolve the difference. Declining creates a record. It does not stop the school teaching your child: the resource says instruction then has to be based on reasonable practice and the child's best interests.

What the rules say

Teachers must "obtain written informed parental consent on IPPs to indicate agreement with the IPP" and, where parents refuse, "document the reasons for refusal and/or actions undertaken by the school to obtain consent and/or resolve concerns" (Standard 11(f)). Informed consent means the person has all relevant information, agrees in writing, and "understands that the granting of consent is voluntary and may be withdrawn at any time" (Standards, Definitions p.4).

The 2006 resource: "Schools are required to obtain informed written consent from parents to indicate agreement with the IPP. Typically, parents will be invited to sign the IPP at the beginning of the school year when goals and objectives have been developed, and at each reporting period throughout the school year." Its parent tips page adds: "If you do not agree with the IPP and do not wish to sign, the school has an obligation to document the reasons for your decision and what actions are taken to resolve the issue."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.16 and Appendix 2-E (Chapter 2 p.20), guidance.

Say this

"My signature is consent to the plan, not a receipt for it. I'd like to read it properly first. Can I take it home and bring it back Monday?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the IPP to review before signing, and the dates this school year when you will be invited to sign at each reporting period.

If you don't get it

If you decide not to sign, say so in writing and give your reason. That triggers their duty to record it. Then ask for a copy of what was recorded. An IPP with neither a signature nor a documented explanation is missing a required element: back to 4.2.

Write this down

Date · what you were asked to sign · whether you had read it first · what you did · next reporting period date.

4.7 The medical information is wrong or missing

You might be hearing

— "That part is auto-populated."

— "It pulls straight from your registration form."

— "That's a field we can't change."

— "It must be an IT issue, we'll look into it."

What's going on

Relevant medical information is a required part of an IPP. Divisions often explain this section by saying it fills itself from the registration form. That may be true, and it is checkable.

Keep your registration form, every year. It is the only copy you control of what you told them. Then compare the two line by line. There are three possible outcomes:

— The IPP matches your form. Nothing to do.

— Something on your form is missing from the IPP. Either the field didn't fill, or it was removed. Ask which.

— The IPP says something that was never on your form. Then it did not come from your form. Either a person typed it, or the system reads other records. Ask which.

None of this needs an accusation. You are asking which of the three it is.

Why it matters past the paperwork: in an emergency, what staff can tell paramedics comes from what the school has on file. A condition missing from the school's records may be missing from what goes with your child (see chapter 9).

What the rules say

The IPP must contain "relevant medical information" (Standards, Definitions p.4). Alberta's sample IPP checklist breaks it into "Medical diagnosis • Medications • Other conditions that impact schooling", or a note that there is none. The resource adds that the IPP should say if there are no known medical issues, and that families' wishes about sharing a diagnosis should be respected.

The Student Record Regulation, which is law, says the student record must include "any health information that the parent of the student or child or the student or child wishes to be placed on the student record" (s.2(1)(p)). So you can put the correct information on the record in writing yourself.

How a division's software fills that field is not set by Alberta. It is an arrangement between the division and its vendor. That makes "it's auto-populated" a description of their system, not a rule.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4. Student Record Regulation, Alta Reg 97/2019, s.2(1)(p), current as of 1 September 2025, regulation (law). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.12 and Appendix 1-B (Chapter 1 p.35), guidance.

Say this

"I have my registration form here. This doesn't match what I wrote. Can you tell me how this field gets filled, and fix it today?"

Ask for this in writing

How the medical information field is populated, whether staff can edit it and who, the date it will be corrected to match the registration form, and

what information staff give paramedics in an emergency. Attach the correct health information and ask that it be placed on the student record.

If you don't get it

"It must be an IT issue" is somewhere to set the question down, not an answer. Ask again in writing with a date. If the error could matter in an emergency, say so plainly. Still not fixed: ask for the record and its change history (see chapter 11), and use the record-correction route (see chapter 3).

Write this down

Date · the IPP's exact wording · your form's exact wording · who you asked · what they said · date corrected.

4.8 A goal changed or vanished and nobody told you

You might be hearing

— "We adjusted that goal, it wasn't appropriate any more."

— "He met that one."

— "We streamlined the plan."

— "That support was from last year."

— "Those are covered in class now."

What's going on

Goals, supports and accommodations can change mid-year. That is allowed. What should not happen is that you find out by comparing versions. A goal that was met should show the date and the evidence. A goal that was dropped should show the reason. A support that was written into the plan and is no longer happening is a change to the plan, even if no one edited the page.

Compare every version you receive with the last one. Put a line through anything that moved, and ask about each one.

What the rules say

Teachers must involve parents in the "monitoring and evaluation" of the IPP and "make changes to the IPP, as required" (Standard 11(f)). The 2006

resource says that when an objective reaches its target date, "revisions should be documented and, if necessary, a new objective and target date set," and its checklist expects new objectives to be "added/revised as planned ones are reviewed and/or achieved."

The Student Record Regulation, which is law, says that when an IPP is devised for a school year, "the plan and any amendments to the plan must be placed on the student record" (s.2(4)). So every amended version should exist on the record, and you can ask for each one.

Consent: parents are typically invited to sign at each reporting period, and consent "may be withdrawn at any time" (resource Chapter 1 p.16; Standards Definitions p.4).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says "Parents receive written explanations of adjustments, curricular adjustments, and/or specialized setting, credentialing, or programming implications" (s.7, 3.1).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 11(f). Student Record Regulation, Alta Reg 97/2019, s.2(4), current as of 1 September 2025, regulation (law). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.16, Chapter 7 p.7, Appendix 1-B, guidance. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.7, guidance.

Say this

"This goal was in the last version and it isn't in this one. When did it change, who decided, and what's the evidence it was met or the reason it was dropped?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of every amended version of the IPP on the student record this school year. For each goal, support or accommodation that changed: the date of the change, who decided, the data it was based on, and why you were not told beforehand.

If you don't get it

Say in writing that you do not consent to the change until it is explained (see 4.6 on withdrawing consent). If a support was removed that you believe your child still needs, ask for the decision in writing. A decision that

significantly affects a student's education can be appealed to the board (Education Act s.42; see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date you noticed · version dates compared · what changed · who you asked · their answer.

4.9 "The IPP is the report card"

You might be hearing

— "This program doesn't issue report cards."

— "The IPP is the report card."

— "Progress is in the IPP update."

— "We don't give grade levels for kids on modified programs."

What's going on

Some divisions report progress for students on IPPs through the IPP itself. That can work, if the IPP update tells you what a report card would: where your child is now, against what, and how that compares with last time. A progress update that says "progressing" or "ongoing" without a level, a measure or a date tells you nothing you can compare.

Ask what the update will say in numbers or levels before the reporting period arrives, not after.

What the rules say

Boards must "inform parents of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods, throughout the year" (Standard 13(b)) and must ensure IPPs include "current level of performance and academic achievement relative to identified learner outcomes included in the provincial curriculum" (Standard 13(a)).

Alberta's Guide to Education says "Teachers shall ensure that information is effectively communicated to parents about" their child's learning against curriculum outcomes, "how well their child is doing in each subject", and "the grade level(s) the child has achieved" in English language arts and literature (or language arts) and mathematics.

The 2006 resource: "Levels of performance for academic areas that are not identified as areas of need on the IPP will be reported on the report card as well," and "Checkmarks or vague terms such as 'ongoing' do not adequately describe what a student has achieved."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 13. Guide to Education, "Assessment as the basis for communicating individual student achievement", alberta.ca, read 23 October 2026, provincial policy. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 pp.7 and 14, guidance.

Say this

"If the IPP is the report card, I need it to tell me what a report card would. What grade level is my child working at in reading and math right now?"

Ask for this in writing

The dates of this year's reporting periods, and, at each one, your child's level in English language arts and mathematics and the measure used, plus progress on each IPP goal with the date it was reviewed.

If you don't get it

Point to the Guide to Education provision by name and ask which part of it the update meets. Then the principal, in writing. A reporting period with no dated review in the IPP is also a 4.4 problem.

Write this down

Reporting period date · what you received · the level given, or that none was given.

4.10 You weren't part of writing it

You might be hearing

- "We've drafted it for you to review."
- "The team put it together."
- "You can add comments at the bottom."
- "We used your input from last year."

What's going on

Being shown a finished plan is not the same as helping write it. Alberta's rules expect parents in the room while the plan is made: for strengths and needs, goals, and how progress will be checked. "Parent input" at the bottom of a finished page is a comment box, not involvement.

You know things no one at school knows: what your child does at home, what worked before, what a bad day looks like. That information is meant to shape the goals.

What the rules say

Before providing specialized supports and services, a board "shall consult with the parent of the student" (Education Act s.11(5)). The Standards define consultation as giving parents "the opportunity to assist in making decisions about all aspects of programming and placement" (Definitions p.3). Boards must "invite meaningful involvement of parents in planning, problem-solving and decision-making" (Standard 8(c)), and teachers must involve parents in "development, implementation, monitoring and evaluation" of the IPP (Standard 11(f)).

The 2006 resource says strengths and needs "should involve input from parents", and its checklist expects goals "Based on input from teachers, parents and student (where appropriate)". The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says IPPs "are developed collaboratively with students (where appropriate), parents, teachers, school-based teams, and relevant qualified professionals" (s.7, 1.2).

Source: Education Act s.11(5), law. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions and Standards 8(c), 11(f). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.9 and Appendix 1-B, guidance. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.7, guidance.

Say this

"I'd like to help write the goals, not just review them. Can we set a time to build them together before this is finalized?"

Ask for this in writing

A planning meeting before the IPP is finalized, and a note in the IPP recording what parent input was given and where it appears in the goals.

If you don't get it

Send your input in writing: three or four things you want worked on this year, and what you see at home. Ask that it be attached to the IPP. Decline to sign until it's considered (see 4.6).

Write this down

Date · whether you were invited to plan or only to review · what input you gave · where it shows up.

4.11 Getting your own copy, and keeping it

You might be hearing

— "You'll get a copy once it's finalized."

— "It's in the system, you can see it on the portal."

— "We don't send IPPs home."

— "You'd have to make a formal request."

What's going on

You should have your own copy of every version of your child's IPP, signed or not. The parent portal is not a copy: what it shows can change, and it may not show everything. A paper or PDF copy dated when you received it is the only version you control.

Your child's IPP is part of the student record, and the Education Act gives you the right to see that record and get a copy. Asking under the Education Act is enough. You do not have to start with a request under the Access to Information Act.

What the rules say

Teachers must "ensure IPPs are placed in student records" (Standard 11(f)). A parent "may review the student record" (Education Act s.56(3)(b)) and "may submit a request for a copy of the student record, along with any associated fee", and the board "shall provide a copy of the student record to the person" (s.56(4)). Boards must provide parents access to the student record "including results of specialized assessments and student progress reports" (Standard 5).

The Student Record Regulation, which is law, says that when an IPP is devised for a school year, "the plan and any amendments to the plan must be placed on the student record of that student or child in addition to summaries of all individualized program plans for previous school years" (s.2(4)). The board "must ensure" that parents entitled to review the record "are informed that they are entitled to review the student record" (s.6).

The 2006 resource's tips for parents: "Ask for a copy of the IPP to refer to at home."

Source: Education Act s.56(3) and (4), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, law. Student Record Regulation, Alta Reg 97/2019, ss.2(4) and 6, current as of 1 September 2025, regulation (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 5 and 11(f). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Appendix 2-E (Chapter 2 p.20), guidance.

Say this

"Please email me a PDF of the IPP as it stands today, and every new version when it changes."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the current IPP and of every amendment this school year, each with its date, and the summaries of past years' IPPs held on the record.

If you don't get it

Ask for the student record under section 56 of the Education Act (see chapter 3). A refusal about access to the record can be appealed to the board and then reviewed by the Minister (Education Act s.42(4) and s.43(4); see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date each version arrived · date printed on it · signed or not.

4.12 What happens to it when your child changes school

You might be hearing

— "It'll transfer with him."

— "The new school will do their own plan."

— "They'll get to know her first."

— "The file is on its way."

What's going on

The student record, including the IPP, is meant to move to the new school in a timely way. But a file arriving is not the same as supports being ready on the first day. The new school may wait weeks to "get to know" your child, and the old plan can sit unread.

Transition planning is one of the required parts of the IPP. A move to a new school, or from elementary to junior high, is the biggest transition there is. It should be planned in the spring, not discovered in September.

What the rules say

Where a board is required to transfer a student record, it "shall do so in a timely manner" (Education Act s.56(7)). The IPP must include transition plans (Standards, Definitions p.4); transition planning is defined to include "between grades/levels of schooling" and to involve "receiving school staff" (Definitions p.5).

The 2006 resource suggests the sending school "Communicate with the receiving teachers about the student's strengths and areas of need. If the student already has an IPP, discuss its contents and the accommodations required in the upcoming year," and "Ensure that specific supports that need to be in place at the beginning of the year are included in the transition component of the IPP." Its checklist lists what should move: "registration form – current and preceding IPPs – current assessment results – medical information – classroom assessment results – listing of supports in place."

Source: Education Act s.56(7), law. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions pp.4 and 5. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 8 pp.6 and 7, Appendix 8-A (Chapter 8 p.15), guidance.

Say this

"What supports will be in place on day one at the new school, and who at the new school has read the IPP?"

Ask for this in writing

The date the record was sent, the name of the person at the new school who received the IPP, the supports in place from the first day, and the date of the first IPP meeting at the new school.

If you don't get it

Bring your own copy of the IPP to the new school (see 4.11). Ask the new principal for a meeting in the first two weeks. If supports aren't in place, see chapter 14 on transitions and chapter 12 on decisions you can appeal.

Write this down

Date of the move · date the record was sent · who received it · supports on day one.

4.13 They want to try everything else first

You might be hearing

— "We have to try the lower tiers first."

— "Let's see how the classroom supports go."

— "We need more data before we go to an IPP."

— "She has to go through the pyramid."

What's going on

Many schools use a "pyramid" or "tiers" of support: help for everyone, then small-group help, then individual help. That model is fine as a way to organize support. It becomes a problem when it is used as a waiting line that a child must finish before getting what an assessment already says they need.

Alberta's new guidance says that is not how it is meant to work.

What the rules say

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance, 22 October 2026) says: "Access to individualized supports and services does not depend on completing a prescribed sequence of universal or targeted supports and services" (s.5.3, 7). It is guidance: its own release says it "does not create new legislative requirements." Quote it as what the province expects.

The Standards require boards to "use results of assessments to make decisions, develop Individualized Program Plans (IPPs), assign support services and/or determine adapted or modified programming" (Standard 3(c)).

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026, s.5.3, guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 3(c).

Say this

"The province says individual support doesn't depend on finishing the lower tiers first. What does the assessment say my child needs, and when does it start?"

Ask for this in writing

The supports currently in place, the date each started, the data being collected and the date it will be reviewed, and the date the school will decide on individualized supports.

If you don't get it

A delay with no decision date is a failure to decide, which you can appeal (see chapter 12). If there is no assessment yet, see chapter 5.

Write this down

Date · what tier they say your child is in · what's in place · the review date they gave.

Chapter 5: Assessment: getting your child identified and tested

How to ask for an assessment, what you are consenting to, how long it should take, what happens to the report, and what the new Kindergarten to Grade 3 screening does and does not do.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/5

Turn here when you're hearing

— "Let's wait and see." → 5.1

— "The teacher has to make the referral." → 5.1

— "Just sign here so the psych can see him." → 5.2

— "We need to do six weeks of intervention before we can refer." → 5.3

— "There's a long waitlist for the psychologist." → 5.4

— "Maybe next year." → 5.4

— "Our OT only consults." → 5.5

— "That's something you'd go through your doctor for." → 5.5

— "We'll take it under advisement." → 5.6

— "Those are recommendations, not requirements." → 5.6

— "Those are just recommendations." → 5.8

— "The psych will send a summary." → 5.7

— "We'll fold it into the next IPP." → 5.8

— "It's just a screener, it's not a diagnosis." → 5.9

— "We can't do anything until there's a diagnosis." → 5.10

— "If you don't consent, our hands are tied." → 5.11

— "That assessment is out of date." → 5.12

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
5.1	You think your child needs to be assessed

Entry	Title
5.2	They want you to sign a consent form
5.3	They want to try the lower tiers before they'll refer
5.4	"There's a long waitlist"
5.5	Who does which assessment
5.6	Paying for a private assessment, and whether the school will use it
5.7	Getting the report, and having it explained
5.8	The assessment never made it into the IPP
5.9	The new reading and math screening, Kindergarten to Grade 3
5.10	"We can't do anything until there's a diagnosis"
5.11	You said no to an assessment, or want to limit it
5.12	"That assessment is out of date"

5.1 You think your child needs to be assessed

You might be hearing

— "Let's wait and see."

— "They're young, they'll catch up."

— "The teacher has to make the referral."

— "We don't really do assessments for that."

What's going on

A specialized assessment is testing done one-on-one by a trained professional (for example a psychologist or a speech-language pathologist) to find out how your child learns and what they need. A referral is the step that arranges it.

Every board (the public, separate or francophone school division) must have written procedures for spotting students who need help, referring them and assessing them. Parents are meant to be part of that process.

What you see at home counts: parent information is one of the listed reasons to refer.

"Wait and see" is not a decision. Asking in writing turns it into one.

What the rules say

School boards must "develop and implement written procedures for early identification, referral and assessment" and "involve parents ... in the screening, identification and referral process" (Standard 2(a) and (b)). They must "have written procedures for referral of students requiring specialized assessment" and "base referrals on a variety of indicators such as: screening procedures; teacher assessment and observation; parent information; previous assessments" (Standard 4(a) and (b)).

The Standards define a referral as "arranging for students to receive specialized assessment and/or intervention" (Definitions p.5).

The Coding Criteria say "The need for additional supports may be determined at any time during the school year."

We found no Alberta rule saying only a teacher can start a referral. The Standards list parent information as a reason to refer, and nothing in them limits who can raise it.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.5 and Standards 2 and 4, applied under Ministerial Order 015/2004, read 16 October 2026. Standard. Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27 (11 June 2026), Introduction p.1. Provincial coding document.

Say this

"I'm asking for my child to be referred for a specialized assessment. Can you send me the division's referral procedure, and tell me who decides and by when?"

Ask for this in writing

The division's written procedure for referral and specialized assessment (Standard 4(a)), the date your request was received, the name and role of the person who will decide, and the date they will decide by.

If you don't get it

A refusal is a decision. Ask for it in writing with the reasons. If the reason is "try the classroom supports first", see 5.3. If no decision comes at all, see chapter 12.

Write this down

Date you asked · who you asked · what you asked for · the date they said they would decide.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on referral and specialized assessment. Standard 4(a) says it has to exist in writing.

5.2 They want you to sign a consent form

You might be hearing

- "Just sign here so the psych can see him."
- "It's a standard form."
- "It's just so the team can observe."
- "This covers everyone on the team."

What's going on

No specialized assessment or referral should happen without your written, informed consent. Informed means you know what you are agreeing to before you sign: which professional, which kind of assessment, why, and who will see the results.

A general form that "covers everyone" can be hard to read that way. You are allowed to ask what it covers. Consent is voluntary, and you can withdraw it later.

What the rules say

School boards must "obtain parents' informed written consent for specialized assessments or referral" (Standard 1(a)), and again "obtain parents' written informed consent for specialized assessment or referral" (Standard 4(c)).

Informed consent means the person "has been provided with all information relevant to the activity for which consent is sought", "understands and agrees, in writing" and "understands that the granting of consent is voluntary and may be withdrawn at any time" (Definitions p.4).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance, not law) says consent is "Required for sharing of personal and health information and for external referrals", and that "Consent processes must be transparent, documented" and aligned with privacy laws including the Protection of Privacy Act and the Health Information Act (s.7, 2.1 and 2.2).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standards 1(a), 4(c), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026, s.7. Guidance.

Say this

"Before I sign, can you tell me who will assess my child, what kind of assessment it is, and who gets the report? And I'd like a copy of what I sign."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the signed consent, the name and profession of each person who will assess your child, the type of assessment, the expected date, and who will receive the report.

If you don't get it

Don't sign until you know what it covers. You can ask for the scope to be written on the form before you sign. If you want to withdraw consent you already gave, say so in writing and keep a copy. If you decide not to consent at all, see 5.11.

Write this down

Date signed · what assessment · who will do it · whether you got a copy.

5.3 They want to try the lower tiers before they'll refer

You might be hearing

— "We need to do six weeks of intervention before we can refer."

— "She has to go through the pyramid first."

— "We need more data."

— "The team hasn't met about him yet."

What's going on

Many schools organize help in tiers: support for everyone, then small-group support, then individual support. Classroom and small-group help can run alongside a referral. It doesn't have to come first and finish before anyone looks closer.

This entry is about the referral. If the school is holding back individual supports the same way, see 4.13.

What the rules say

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance, 22 October 2026) says: "Access to individualized supports and services does not depend on completing a prescribed sequence of universal or targeted supports and services" (s.5.3, 7). It also says supports and services "are provided at any point when school-based teams identify a student need" (s.5, 3.2). Its own release says it "does not create new legislative requirements", so quote it as what the province expects.

The Standards list the reasons to refer as "screening procedures; teacher assessment and observation; parent information; previous assessments" (Standard 4(b)). A completed sequence of interventions is not on the list.

No Alberta law or standard we found sets a number of weeks of intervention before a referral. A wait of that kind is a school or division practice.

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026, ss.5 and 5.3. Guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 4(b), read 16 October 2026. Standard.

Say this

"The province says individual support doesn't depend on finishing a sequence first. Can the referral start now, alongside the classroom supports?"

Ask for this in writing

The intervention being tried, its start date, the data being collected, the date it will be reviewed, and the date the referral decision will be made.

If you don't get it

Ask for the division procedure that sets the waiting period (see 5.1). If there is no written rule and no decision date, a failure to decide is something you can take further (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · what intervention · start date · review date · referral decision date.

5.4 "There's a long waitlist"

You might be hearing

- "There's a long waitlist for the psychologist."
- "The psych only comes in a few times a year."
- "We only get so many assessments per school."
- "Maybe next year."

What's going on

Alberta has a recommended time limit for specialized assessments: eight weeks from the date of the written referral, including the written report. It is a guideline, not a hard deadline, and it allows for "extenuating circumstances". But it is written into a standard that boards must follow, and it gives you a benchmark to ask against.

The clock starts at the written referral. So the first thing to find out is whether a written referral exists, and its date.

What the rules say

School boards must "complete, when required, specialized assessments within a reasonable time (recommended guideline is within eight weeks unless there are extenuating circumstances) from the date of written referral including completion of a written report" (Standard 4(f)).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says school authorities should "Provide equitable access to qualified professional

support" (s.6, 6.2), "evaluate timely access to a responsive continuum of supports and services" (s.8, 1.2), and "track limitations in staffing and constraints related to educational supports" (s.8, 1.5).

No other Alberta time limit for school assessments was found.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 4(f), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.6 and 8. Guidance.

Say this

"The provincial guideline is eight weeks from the written referral, including the report. What date was the referral written, and when will the report be done?"

Ask for this in writing

The date of the written referral, the expected date of the assessment and of the written report, and, if it will take longer than eight weeks, the extenuating circumstances relied on.

If you don't get it

Take the dates to the principal, then the division. Meanwhile, ask what the school will do for your child while you wait (see 5.10). If a severe behaviour or a preschool language code is in question, ask about the Alternative Documentation route (see 6.10).

Write this down

Date of written referral · date they said the report would be done · date it arrived.

5.5 Who does which assessment

You might be hearing

- "That's not something the school does."
- "That's something you'd go through your doctor for."
- "Our OT only consults."
- "The speech pathologist will do a quick screen."

What's going on

Different professionals assess different things. A psychologist usually assesses thinking, learning and behaviour (often called a psychoeducational assessment). A speech-language pathologist (SLP) assesses language and speech. An occupational therapist (OT) looks at things like fine motor skills, sensory needs and daily living skills. An audiologist assesses hearing.

Some of these come through the school or division. Some come through the health system. Two words matter. A screen is a quick check, not an assessment. "Consultation" can mean the specialist talked to staff and never saw your child. Ask which.

What the rules say

Boards must "use qualified professionals to conduct specialized assessments, interpret results, and provide program recommendations" (Standard 4(d)).

The Coding Criteria define a qualified professional as someone "who has expertise and training in conducting specialized assessments, providing a diagnosis and providing interpretive reports", in good standing with their professional association, and name "Psychologists, psychiatrists, audiologists, occupational therapists and speech-language pathologists" as examples. They add: "Results from screening tools or screening instruments are not sufficient to diagnose" a disability or delay.

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) lists services such as "speech and language pathology, occupational therapy, physical therapy, behaviour therapy, psychology, hearing/vision services" (s.5.3, 8.4). It says health services that include "clinical or therapeutic services, diagnosis or rehabilitation" are the primary responsibility of the health system (s.6, 7.2.2).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 4(d), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, Assessment, pp.1 and 2. Provincial coding document. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.5.3 and 6. Guidance.

Say this

"Which professional will see my child in person, how many times, and will there be a written report I get a copy of?"

Ask for this in writing

The name and profession of each specialist involved, whether they will assess your child directly or consult with staff, how many sessions, and the date of the written report.

If you don't get it

If the school says an assessment belongs to the health system, ask in writing who is responsible for making the referral, and ask your doctor at the same time. For outside supports, see chapter 16.

Write this down

Date · specialist and profession · direct or consult · number of sessions · report date.

5.6 Paying for a private assessment, and whether the school will use it

You might be hearing

- "We'll take it under advisement."
- "Our psych will need to do their own."
- "Those are recommendations, not requirements."
- "Private reports don't always fit a school setting."

What's going on

You can pay a private registered psychologist or other qualified professional to assess your child. The cost is yours. Alberta publishes no fee for this, and we found no provincial program that pays it back.

A private report can count. The province's Coding Criteria ask for a diagnosis by a qualified professional in good standing. They do not say that person has to work for the school. And once you hand it in, the Student Record Regulation says an assessment you asked for, done by an independent professional, goes on your child's student record, along with any program planning action taken because of it.

Whether the school must follow every recommendation is another matter: no rule says recommendations bind the school. What the rules do

say is that the school must use assessment results to make its decisions. So the useful ask is a written answer to each recommendation.

It can help to ask the assessor to mark which recommendations are essential at school.

What the rules say

Boards must base referrals on indicators including "parent information; previous assessments" (Standard 4(b)), "use a number of assessment strategies and data to determine eligibility" (Standard 3(a)), and "use results of assessments to make decisions, develop Individualized Program Plans (IPPs), assign support services and/or determine adapted or modified programming" (Standard 3(c)).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) describes a student profile that includes "relevant information from specialists or service providers" and may include "formal assessments, specialized reports" (Glossary), and says "Parental consent is required in order to share clinical reports with the school-based teams" (s.5.3.1.1, 2.1).

The student record must contain, for "any formal intellectual, behavioural or emotional assessment or evaluation requested by the student's or child's parent and administered to the student or child by an independent party", its name, a summary of the results, the date, who did it, "any interpretive report relating to the assessment or evaluation", and "any action taken as program planning as a result of the assessment, evaluation or interpretive report" (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(o)).

No Alberta rule we found requires a school to adopt a private report's recommendations, and none bars it from considering them.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 3 and 4(b), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, Introduction and Assessment, p.1. Provincial coding document. Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1)(o), current as of 1 September 2025, read 23 October 2026. Regulation. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, Glossary and s.5.3.1.1. Guidance.

Say this

"I'm giving you this report for my child's file. Can you answer each recommendation in writing: yes, no, or not yet, and why?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation of the date the report was received and that it is in the student record (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(o)), a written response to each recommendation with a date, and confirmation it will be listed in the IPP's assessment data (see 5.8).

If you don't get it

Send the request again to the principal with a date. A recommendation left unanswered is also a 5.8 problem. A refusal to provide a support the report calls for is a decision you can take further (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date report handed in · who received it · date of written response · which recommendations were accepted.

Your division may also have

A procedure on how outside reports are received and reviewed. Ask for it.

5.7 Getting the report, and having it explained

You might be hearing

— "The psych will send a summary."

— "We'll go over the highlights at the meeting."

— "You don't need the full report."

— "It's very technical."

What's going on

A specialized assessment usually ends in a written report that explains the results and makes recommendations. You are entitled to the results, and to have them explained by the person who can explain them. A summary is a start, not a substitute.

Ask for the full report before the meeting where it will be discussed, so you can read it first and bring questions.

What the rules say

Boards must "report results of assessments to parents, teachers and others involved with students' programming" (Standard 3(b)) and use qualified professionals to "interpret results, and provide program recommendations to parents" (Standard 4(d)). They must give parents access to the student record, "including results of specialized assessments" (Standard 5(a)).

The Coding Criteria say "Specialized assessment typically results in a written, interpretative report."

A parent may review the student record and "may submit a request for a copy of the student record, along with any associated fee", and the board "shall provide a copy" (Education Act s.56(3)(b) and (4)).

For an assessment the school arranged, the student record must contain its name, a summary of the results, the date, who did it, "any interpretive report relating to the assessment or evaluation", and "any action taken as program planning as a result" (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(n)). The test booklet itself (the "test instrument") does not have to be kept in the record, but if there is an appeal about the assessment, a parent may review it "as if it were part of the student record" (s.3(2)).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 3(b), 4(d), 5(a), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, p.1. Provincial coding document. Education Act s.56(3) and (4), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, ss.2(1)(n) and 3(2), current as of 1 September 2025, read 23 October 2026. Regulation.

Say this

"I'd like the full written report, not a summary, before the meeting. And I'd like the person who did the assessment there to explain it."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the full written report including recommendations, by [date a few days before the meeting], and a meeting with the professional who did the assessment.

If you don't get it

Ask for a copy of the student record under section 56 of the Education Act. The interpretive report has to be in it (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(n)). See chapter 3 and chapter 11.

Write this down

Date of assessment · date you asked for the report · date it arrived · who explained it.

5.8 The assessment never made it into the IPP

You might be hearing

— "We're already doing most of that."

— "Those are just recommendations."

— "We'll fold it into the next IPP."

— "The IPP is a concise plan, it can't hold everything."

What's going on

Assessment data is one of the required parts of an IPP (Individualized Program Plan, the written plan for a student who needs specialized supports). The report is meant to drive the goals. Two common gaps: the IPP was written before the assessment and never reopened, or the recommendations sit in a file and never become goals.

A side-by-side table helps: each recommendation on the left, and on the right the IPP goal or support that carries it, or the written reason it doesn't.

What the rules say

Boards must "use results of assessments to make decisions, develop Individualized Program Plans (IPPs), assign support services" (Standard 3(c)). Assessment data is the first item in the IPP's essential information (Definitions p.4). The student record must show "any action taken as program planning as a result of the assessment" (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(n) and (o)).

Alberta's 2006 IPP resource says: "Current data is generally considered to be data that has been collected within the last two or three years. Each assessment report should be listed within the IPP and should include the

date and source (including the name of the assessment tool and the person who did the assessment)." On IQ results: "Do not include numerical scores or percentiles for IQ scores; include the range only (e.g., low average, below average)." Its sample checklist expects a "Summary of report findings."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 3(c), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1)(n) and (o), current as of 1 September 2025, read 23 October 2026. Regulation. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 pp.5 and 6, and Appendix 1-B (Chapter 1 p.35), read 23 October 2026. Guidance.

Say this

"This report came in on [date]. Where does each recommendation show up in the IPP, and when will the IPP be updated?"

Ask for this in writing

The IPP's assessment data section listing this report with its date, tool and author; a written list of each recommendation with the goal or support that carries it, or the reason it was not adopted; and the date the IPP will be revised.

If you don't get it

An IPP without current assessment data is missing a required element (see 4.2). A goal that should have changed and didn't is a 4.8 problem. Then the principal in writing, then chapter 12.

Write this down

Date of report · date of IPP · which recommendations appear · which don't.

5.9 The new reading and math screening, Kindergarten to Grade 3

You might be hearing

— "It's just a screener, it's not a diagnosis."

— "Every child in K to 3 does it."

— "The results show she needs some intervention."

— "We can't use the screener to get him an IPP."

— "You can ask for an exemption."

What's going on

Since 1 September 2026, every board must make sure children in Kindergarten to Grade 3 are screened in literacy (reading and writing) and numeracy (math), unless a child is exempted. A screener is a short check, not an assessment. Results must be reported to you.

If the province determines the results show your child is having difficulty, the board must provide intervention. After a third screening in one school year, intervention is allowed but no longer required.

One rule cuts both ways. A board cannot use screening results to decide your child needs specialized supports. So a poor screen does not replace a proper assessment, and a fine screen does not rule one out (see 5.1).

What the rules say

A board "must ensure that literacy and numeracy screening assessments ... are conducted" and "may exempt a child or student" (Education Act s.30.3(1) and (2)). Results "are reported to the parent" (s.30.4(1)). Where the Minister determines results show difficulties, a board "must ensure that literacy and numeracy intervention supports ... are provided" (s.30.51(1)); after a third screening in a single school year, they are "permitted but not required" (s.30.51(2)). "A board shall not use the results of a literacy and numeracy screening assessment to make a determination under section 11(3) that a student is in need of specialized supports and services" (s.30.51(3)).

Dates for 2026-27: Grades 1 to 3, 14 September to 2 October 2026 and 18 January to 5 February 2027; Kindergarten, 18 January to 5 February 2027; a spring screen from 10 to 28 May 2027 for Grade 1 to 3 students whose results showed difficulties (AR 44/2026, ss.3 and 4 and Schedule). The regulation sets no rules on exemptions.

The province's bulletin goes further than the law: it says "All children and students in kindergarten to grade 5 must be screened in literacy and numeracy." The Act and the regulation cover Kindergarten to Grade 3. The Grade 4 and 5 screening is the province's requirement set in its bulletin, not in the Act (see 13.4).

The province's 2026-27 bulletin says a superintendent decides exemptions on the principal's recommendation, made "in consultation with the parent/guardian and the teacher". Both conditions must be met: your child cannot access the screener in its original form because of their characteristics, and "participation would be harmful to the child or the student". A parent asks in writing to the principal. The bulletin also says "Reports should be provided to the parent within six weeks of the screener administration."

Source: Education Act ss.30.3, 30.4, 30.51, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Literacy and Numeracy Screening Assessments Regulation, AR 44/2026, current as of 2 March 2026. Regulation. 2026-2027 Literacy and Numeracy Screenings General Information Bulletin, Alberta Education and Childcare, pp.5, 9, 15, read live 23 October 2026. Provincial policy.

Say this

"Can I have my child's screening report? If it shows difficulty, what intervention starts, who gives it, how often, and when is it checked again?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's parent report for each screening, and, if intervention is provided, what it is, its start date, how often, who delivers it, and the date of the next screening.

If you don't get it

The intervention duty sits with the board: put it to the principal in writing. If you think more is going on than reading or math, ask for a referral for specialized assessment at the same time (see 5.1).

Write this down

Screening date · date report received · result · intervention, frequency and person · next screening date.

5.10 "We can't do anything until there's a diagnosis"

You might be hearing

— "We can't do anything until there's a diagnosis."

— "Without a diagnosis we can't code him."

— "There's no funding without a code."

— "Come back when you have paperwork from the doctor."

What's going on

Three different things are being treated as one.

— The decision that your child needs specialized supports belongs to the board under the Education Act. That section talks about your child's characteristics affecting their learning. It does not mention a diagnosis.

— A special education code (a reporting number, see 6.1) usually needs a diagnosis. For two codes there is a route while you wait (see 6.10).

— Funding in public schools is not set by coding (see 6.6).

So "no diagnosis yet" doesn't mean "no support yet".

What the rules say

"If a student's behavioural, intellectual, learning, communication or physical characteristics, or a combination of any of them, impair the student's ability and opportunity to learn, a board may determine that the student is in need of specialized supports and services" (Education Act s.11(3)). A student so determined "is entitled to have access to those supports and services" (s.11(4), subject to s.40).

The Coding Criteria say schools must have documentation, including "a diagnosis of a disability or disorder by a qualified professional", before assigning a code. The Standards describe the IPP as "based on diagnostic information" and define assessment as using "a number of formal and informal methods". They do not say a medical diagnosis must come first.

Alberta Education and Childcare's inclusive education page: "Funding is not determined through coding."

Source: Education Act s.11(3) and (4), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, Introduction p.1. Provincial coding document. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions pp.3 and 4. Standard. Inclusive education, alberta.ca, read 23 October 2026. Provincial guidance.

Say this

"Deciding my child needs specialized supports is the board's decision, and the Act doesn't require a diagnosis for it. What does my child need now, while we wait?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether the school has determined under section 11(3) that your child needs specialized supports and services, the supports in place now and their start dates, and whether the Alternative Documentation route has been considered (see 6.10).

If you don't get it

See 4.1 on asking for the decision in writing. A refusal, or no decision, can be taken further (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · what they said they need first · what support is in place now.

5.11 You said no to an assessment, or want to limit it

You might be hearing

- "If you don't consent, our hands are tied."
- "Without the assessment we can't offer anything else."
- "So you're refusing services."
- "We'll have to note that you declined."

What's going on

You can say no, or "not this one", or "yes, but only this part". Consent is yours to give and to withdraw. Saying no has consequences the school is allowed to point out: some supports need an assessment or your consent, and the school can only plan with what it is allowed to know.

When you decline, the school must record your reasons. Write them yourself, so the record says what you meant.

What the rules say

When parents refuse consent, boards must "document and place in the student record the reasons for refusal and/or actions undertaken by the school board to obtain consent" (Standard 1(b)). Consent "may be withdrawn at any time" (Definitions p.4).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says parents "have the right to information and informed consent", and "In circumstances where a parent withholds consent, the decision will influence what the applicable school authority can consider as reasonable alternatives and what individualized supports and services can be reasonably accessed" (s.5.3.1, 2.1 and 2.2). It also says "What student supports can be provided will be influenced by parental consent" (s.6, 2.3).

None of these sources says a refusal ends the school's other duties to your child.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standard 1(b), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.5.3.1 and 6. Guidance.

Say this

"I'm not consenting to this one right now. Please record my reasons as I've written them, and tell me what you'll provide in the meantime."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of what was placed in the student record under Standard 1(b), the supports that will continue, and any alternatives the school considered.

If you don't get it

You can consent later, or to a narrower scope, at any time. If supports are withdrawn because you declined, ask for that decision in writing (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · what you declined · your reasons · what the school said would continue.

5.12 "That assessment is out of date"

You might be hearing

— "That assessment is out of date."

— "We need a new one before we can change anything."

— "He was assessed in Grade 2, that's enough."

— "Reassessment isn't due yet."

What's going on

Alberta's guidance says specialized assessments are generally redone every two to five years, and treats data from the last two or three years as current. Neither is a hard rule. An older report doesn't stop being true overnight, but if the school says it is too old to use, the next step is a new referral with a date, not a pause.

What the rules say

Alberta's 2006 IPP resource says specialized assessment is "generally completed every two to five years" and "Current data is generally considered to be data that has been collected within the last two or three years."

Boards must determine placement "based on current assessment data" (Standard 10(b)).

For deafness (Code 45), the Coding Criteria say "New requests for approvals for the Program Unit Funding Grant or Severe Disabilities Grant require an audiogram within the past three years."

We found no Alberta rule that makes an older report invalid.

Source: Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.5, read 23 October 2026. Guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 10(b). Standard. Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, Code 45, p.10. Provincial coding document.

Say this

"When was my child last assessed, and when is the next assessment planned? If this one is too old to use, when will the new referral go in?"

Ask for this in writing

The date of each specialized assessment on file, the date of the next planned assessment, and, if the school says the current one is out of date, the date of the new written referral.

If you don't get it

Ask for the referral in writing (see 5.1) and track the eight-week guideline from its date (see 5.4).

Write this down

Date of last assessment · who did it · date of next planned assessment · referral date.

Chapter 6: Codes and money

What a special education code is, how to find out your child's, what it does and does not decide, and where the money for support comes from.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/6

Turn here when you're hearing

- "He's coded." → 6.1
- "She's a 54." → 6.1
- "ADHD doesn't qualify." → 6.2
- "That's not severe enough for a 44." → 6.2
- "We don't share codes." → 6.3
- "The code was updated." → 6.4
- "His code doesn't qualify him for that." → 6.5
- "That's only for severe codes." → 6.5
- "There's no funding for an aide." → 6.6
- "The money doesn't follow the child." → 6.6
- "That came out of complexity funding." → 6.7
- "Registration for PUF has closed." → 6.8
- "He needs three levels of support to qualify." → 6.9
- "We can't code her until the psych assessment is done." → 6.10
- "We don't test for giftedness until later." → 6.11

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
6.1	What a special education code is
6.2	What each code needs
6.3	You don't know your child's code
6.4	The code is wrong, missing, or changed without telling you
6.5	"His code doesn't qualify him for that"
6.6	"There's no funding for an aide"

Entry	Title
6.7	Where the money for support comes from
6.8	Preschool and kindergarten: Program Unit Funding
6.9	Charter and private schools: severe disabilities funding
6.10	Coding while you wait for a diagnosis
6.11	Gifted and talented (Code 80)

6.1 What a special education code is

You might be hearing

— "He's coded."

— "She's a 54."

— "We're waiting on the code."

— "The code is just for the government."

What's going on

A special education code is a two-digit number attached to your child's registration in PASI (the Provincial Approach to Student Information, the province's student database). School or division staff enter it. Its stated purpose is reporting to Alberta Education and Childcare.

The codes fall into groups:

— 41 to 48: severe (47 and 48 are for preschool and kindergarten only)

— 51 to 59: mild or moderate, Grades 1 to 12

— 30: mild or moderate, preschool and kindergarten

— 80: gifted and talented

A child can have two codes only if one of them is 80.

What the rules say

"Each category is given a code for the purpose of reporting special education data to Alberta Education and Childcare." "It is the responsibility of school authority staff to assign a special education code to a

child's/student's registration in the Provincial Approach to Student Information (PASI). If a second special education code is being assigned, one of the codes must be Code 80 (Gifted and Talented)." School authorities "should work with their PASI administrator to ensure codes are reported accurately in PASI."

The categories: 41 Intellectual Disability (Severe); 42 Severe Emotional/Behavioural; 43 Severe Multiple; 44 Severe Physical or Medical; 45 Deafness; 46 Blindness; 47 Severe Language Delay (ECS only); 48 Moderate Language Delay (ECS only); 51 and 52 Intellectual Disability (Mild, Moderate); 53 Emotional/Behavioural; 54 Learning Disability; 55 Hearing; 56 Visual; 57 Communication; 58 Physical or Medical; 59 Multiple; 30 for ECS mild/moderate; 80 Gifted and Talented. (ECS means Early Childhood Services: preschool programs and kindergarten.)

Source: Special Education Coding Criteria, ECS to Grade 12, 2026/27, Alberta Education and Childcare, 11 June 2026, Introduction p.1 and Contents. Provincial coding document.

Say this

"What special education code is my child registered with in PASI right now, and when was it assigned?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's current special education code or codes, the category name, the date assigned, and the documents relied on to assign it.

If you don't get it

See 6.3.

Write this down

Date asked · code · category · date assigned.

6.2 What each code needs

You might be hearing

— "ADHD doesn't qualify."

— "That's not severe enough for a 44."

— "Autism is a 44."

— "The doctor's letter isn't enough on its own."

What's going on

Every code needs two things in the school's file before it is entered: a diagnosis by a qualified professional, and a clear description of how the condition affects your child's learning and participation at school. A diagnosis alone is not enough. The school's own documentation is half of it.

Some codes have specific requirements and exclusions that catch families out. The main ones are below.

What the rules say

General: "Schools must have the documentation to support the assignment of a special education code before the special education code is assigned in PASI. This includes a diagnosis of a disability or disorder by a qualified professional. In addition to this diagnosis, it is essential to have a clear indication of how the disability/disorder impacts" the child's "participation and learning in an educational environment" (p.1). Test ranges: "the mild range is the 7th to 9th percentile; the moderate range is the 3rd to 6th percentile; and the severe range is the 2nd percentile and below" (p.1).

— Code 42: "A clinical diagnosis of a severe emotional/behavioural disorder by a psychiatrist, registered psychologist, or a developmental pediatrician is required", plus "extensive documentation by school authorities". A primary diagnosis of ADHD is "not included in this category"; FASD "should be reported under Code 44" (pp.7 and 8).

— Code 44: requires "extensive adult assistance and modifications"; "diagnoses could include autism spectrum disorder, FASD/alcohol-related neurodevelopmental disorder (ARND), Tourette syndrome, cerebral palsy, brain injury, cancer, selective mutism, social (pragmatic) communication disorder" (p.9).

— Code 43: Down syndrome with extensive support goes here; ADHD, emotional/behavioural disabilities, learning disability and speech and language disabilities "cannot be used in combination" to reach it (p.9).

— Code 54: interventions "at a minimum" include "specific skill instruction; accommodations; compensatory strategies; and self-advocacy skills" (pp.4 and 5).

Source: Special Education Coding Criteria, ECS to Grade 12, 2026/27, 11 June 2026, pp.1, 4, 5, 7, 8, 9. Provincial coding document.

Say this

"Which criteria in the 2026/27 Coding Criteria is my child's code based on, and which documents in the file meet each one?"

Ask for this in writing

The code, the criteria it is based on, and a list of the documents in your child's file that meet each criterion, with their dates.

If you don't get it

If you think the code is wrong, see 6.4. If a diagnosis is still pending, see 6.10 and 5.10.

Write this down

Date · code · criteria named · documents listed.

6.3 You don't know your child's code

You might be hearing

— "We don't share codes."

— "Codes are internal."

— "It's just for funding."

— "You don't need to worry about the code."

What's going on

Many parents don't know their child's code, or that there is one. You can ask. We found no Alberta rule that stops a school from telling you, and none that requires it to tell you without being asked.

You have a legal right to see your child's student record. The regulation that lists what the record must contain does not mention special education codes. So whether the code sits in that record, or only in PASI, is not settled

by the rules we read. If the school won't tell you, ask in writing which rule prevents it. An access request is the backstop.

What the rules say

A parent "may review the student record" and "may submit a request for a copy of the student record", and the board "shall provide a copy" (Education Act s.56(3)(b) and (4)). Boards must give parents access to information in the student record (Standard 5(a)). If the record "contains inaccurate or incomplete information", a parent "may request that the board ... rectify the matter" (s.56(6)).

The province's myPass system lets a parent connected to a student's Education Account see some PASI information, but the page we read does not say whether codes are shown.

The Student Record Regulation says the record "must contain all information affecting the decisions made about the education of the student", and lists items such as the IPP and its amendments, and assessments with their interpretive reports (s.2(1), (4)). It does not name special education codes anywhere.

Source: Education Act s.56, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2, current as of 1 September 2025, read 23 October 2026. Regulation. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 5(a). Standard. PASI, "Access to the Student Information", extranet.education.alberta.ca, read 23 October 2026. Provincial system documentation.

Say this

"I'd like my child's special education code as reported to the province. If you can't give it to me, please tell me in writing which rule prevents it."

Ask for this in writing

The code, its category, the date assigned and who assigned it; or a written refusal naming the rule relied on.

If you don't get it

Ask to review the student record under section 56 (see chapter 3). If that doesn't show it, make an access request under the Access to Information Act (see chapter 11).

Write this down

Date asked · who · answer · rule cited, if any.

6.4 The code is wrong, missing, or changed without telling you

You might be hearing

— "The code was updated."

— "We re-coded based on the new report."

— "The system changed it."

— "It doesn't matter which code it is."

What's going on

Codes can change during the year, and sometimes nobody tells the parent. A change can come from a new report, from staff reading a document differently, or from an error. Ask every fall what code your child holds and whether it changed since last year.

Before a code is entered, the school is supposed to have the documents that support it. That gives you a fair question: which document supports this code?

What the rules say

"Schools must have the documentation to support the assignment of a special education code before the special education code is assigned in PASI." School authorities "should work with their PASI administrator to ensure codes are reported accurately in PASI." "The need for additional supports may be determined at any time during the school year" (Coding Criteria, Introduction p.1).

A parent who thinks the student record "contains inaccurate or incomplete information" may ask the board to "rectify the matter" (Education Act s.56(6)).

We found no Alberta rule requiring a school to tell a parent when a code is assigned or changed.

Source: Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, 11 June 2026, Introduction p.1. Provincial coding document. Education Act s.56(6), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"My child's code changed. Who changed it, on what date, and which document met the criteria for the new code?"

Ask for this in writing

The previous code, the new code, the date of the change, who made it, and the documents relied on, with the page of the Coding Criteria each one meets.

If you don't get it

Put your correction request in writing under section 56(6) and attach the coding criteria page you rely on. If the change came with a change in your child's support, that change in support is a decision you can take further (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date noticed · old code · new code · who changed it · document relied on.

6.5 "His code doesn't qualify him for that"

You might be hearing

- "His code doesn't qualify him for that."
- "That's only for severe codes."
- "Mild and moderate kids don't get one-to-one."
- "Without a 40-series code we can't."

What's going on

In public, separate and francophone schools, the code does not unlock any particular support. The province says so in plain words. What decides support is your child's assessed need. The legal entitlement comes from the board deciding your child needs specialized supports, not from the number.

The code matters for money in a few places: preschool and kindergarten (see 6.8), and charter and private schools on severe disabilities funding (see 6.9).

What the rules say

Alberta Education and Childcare: "Funding is not determined through coding."

The Specialized Learning Supports grant goes "for the entire school jurisdiction", and "School jurisdictions are responsible for ensuring their SLS funding is disbursed based on child/student needs related to supports required for learning" (Funding Manual C2.1, p.54).

A student the board has determined needs specialized supports "is entitled to have access to those supports and services" (Education Act s.11(4), subject to s.40).

We found no Alberta rule that ties any specific support, such as an educational assistant, to a specific code in public, separate or francophone schools.

Source: Inclusive education, alberta.ca, read 23 October 2026. Provincial guidance. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, section C2.1, p.54. Provincial funding rules. Education Act s.11(4), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"Where is the rule that ties that support to a code? If there isn't one, what does my child's assessed need call for?"

Ask for this in writing

The rule or division procedure that links the support to a code; or, if there is none, the school's decision about that support for your child, with its reasons and the evidence used.

If you don't get it

A refusal of a support your child needs is a decision you can take further (see chapter 12). If disability is part of the reason, see chapter 2 on the duty to accommodate.

Write this down

Date · support asked for · reason given · rule cited, if any.

6.6 "There's no funding for an aide"

You might be hearing

— "There's no funding for an aide."

— "The money doesn't follow the child."

— "We didn't get funding for him this year."

— "Our staffing was set in the spring."

What's going on

Part of this is true. Alberta's funding goes to the school division as a whole, not to your child. No dollar amount is attached to your child, so a school can say, accurately, that there is no money "for him".

The other part doesn't follow. The board's duty to your child doesn't depend on a dollar figure arriving with them. Once the board has decided your child needs specialized supports, your child is entitled to access them. How the board spreads its money is the board's decision. So the useful question is not "is there funding?" but "what has the school decided my child needs, and how will it be met?"

What the rules say

"The funding model does not allocate funding for specific students or schools. Rather, AEM enrolment (wherever applicable) is used to allocate funding for the Early Childhood Services (ECS) to Grade 12 children/students educational activities of the entire school jurisdiction" (Funding Manual, section I1.1, p.173).

A student the board has determined needs specialized supports "is entitled to have access to those supports and services" (Education Act s.11(4), subject to s.40). A board has the responsibility to "provide a continuum of supports and services to students that is consistent with the principles of inclusive education" (s.33(1)(e)).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says authorities may "need to consider operational feasibility within the local context" and "should also consider other legal obligations beyond the Education Act", such as the Alberta Human Rights Act (s.2.1). It also says they should "track limitations in staffing" (s.8, 1.5).

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, section I1.1, p.173. Provincial funding rules. Education Act ss.11(4) and 33(1)(e), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.2.1 and 8. Guidance.

Say this

"I understand the money isn't tied to my child. The duty is. What has the school decided my child needs, and how will that be met?"

Ask for this in writing

The supports the school has decided your child needs, which of them are in place and since when, and any that are not being provided because of funding or staffing, with the name of the person who made that decision.

If you don't get it

A support withheld for budget reasons is still a decision about your child, and you can take it further (see chapter 12). On the duty to accommodate a disability, see chapter 2. On educational assistants, see chapter 7.

Write this down

Date · what they said about funding · what they said your child needs · what is in place.

6.7 Where the money for support comes from

You might be hearing

— "That came out of complexity funding."

— "We have a complexity team this year."

— "The division decides the allocations."

— "You'd have to ask the board."

What's going on

Public, separate and francophone divisions get several grants that pay for support. None is tied to your child, but knowing their names helps you ask where support is coming from and how it is decided.

— Specialized Learning Supports (SLS): a block grant to the division for "a continuum of supports and services", including money to build capacity for specialized assessment.

— Classroom Complexity Grant: for more classroom support staff, such as EAs (educational assistants), more EA hours, training, and specialists. The division must report how it was spent.

— Alberta Complexity Teams: one teacher and two EAs added to schools the province picks, based on how complex their Kindergarten to Grade 6 classrooms are. The manual marks this section "Under Review", so check whether it still runs.

What the rules say

SLS "provides additional funding for the entire school jurisdiction", made of three allocations, one to "build capacity and support for specialized assessment" (C2.1, p.54). Division amounts are posted on a ministry file site (p.55), not a public page.

The Classroom Complexity Grant adds "more classroom support staff, such as educational assistants or to increase their hours", training, and "specialists such as counsellors, psychologists, interpreters and more teachers"; at least 80 per cent goes to front-line support and 20 per cent to training (C2.9, p.67). A final report on spending, including "number of additional hours, specified by position type", is due 30 September 2027 (p.68).

"An Alberta Complexity Team is comprised of one teacher FTE and two educational assistants FTE at the school level in addition to current classroom staffing" (H7, p.170). Teams "must be assigned to the schools identified by Alberta Education and Childcare or as amended through agreement", with a focus on Kindergarten to Grade 6 classrooms, and the manual says "Alberta Education and Childcare is allocating $300,000 per Alberta Complexity Team" (p.170). The section, H7 "Class Size and Complexity", is marked "Under Review" in its heading (p.169).

Divisions must report results on "Access to a Continuum of Supports and Services" using "related local measures" in their annual results report (p.220).

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, sections C2.1, C2.9, H7 and the required local component, pp.54, 55, 67, 68, 169, 170, 220. Provincial funding rules.

Say this

"Does our school have Classroom Complexity Grant staff or an Alberta Complexity Team this year, and how is it decided which students they work with?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether your child's school has complexity-funded staff or a Complexity Team, how students are chosen for their time, and the division's most recent annual results report section on access to a continuum of supports and services.

If you don't get it

Annual results reports and audited financial statements are public documents. Ask the division office or your school board trustee where they are posted.

Write this down

Date · what funded staff the school has · how students are chosen · where the report is posted.

6.8 Preschool and kindergarten: Program Unit Funding

You might be hearing

- "He's too young, let's see in kindergarten."
- "PUF is only for the severe kids."
- "Registration for PUF has closed."
- "He'll just do regular kindergarten."

What's going on

Program Unit Funding (PUF) is extra provincial money paid to the school authority, not to you, for a preschool or kindergarten child with a severe disability or severe language delay. It runs for up to three years, and the kindergarten year counts as one of them. So the age your child starts matters: start later and there are fewer years left.

The school authority decides eligibility and holds the file. Two things are needed: an assessment by a qualified professional, and documentation

showing how severely the condition affects your child's learning in the program. There is a separate, smaller grant for moderate language delay (Code 48).

What the rules say

PUF "is provided to school authorities for children with a severe disability or severe language delay who require additional supports beyond that offered in a regular ECS program" (C2.7.1, p.61). It is for "a maximum of three years including the kindergarten year"; the child must be at least "2 years 8 months (32 months) of age as of August 31 and less than 6 years (72 months) of age as of September 1" (p.62).

Eligibility needs both "Assessment by a qualified professional of a severe disability or severe language delay" and "Documentation that demonstrates the severity of the impact" (p.62). "School jurisdictions are responsible for determining the PUF eligibility" (p.62).

Timing for 2026-27, from the PUF section itself: a child "Registered by November 30, 2026, with proof of assessment" is counted for full funding. A child registered "from December 1, 2026 up to and including February 1, 2027" brings the school authority 50 per cent of the per-child funding, and "Registration for the late count date is considered to use 1 year of PUF eligibility" (C2.7.1, criterion 3, p.62).

"An Alberta certificated teacher takes the lead role in the program planning process" to meet IPP goals, and a jurisdiction "may only claim the teacher directed instruction hours for a child that they have made available to that child" (pp.62 and 63).

We found no appeal route specific to a PUF refusal in the funding manual.

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, section C2.7.1, pp.61 to 63. Provincial funding rules.

Say this

"Is my child eligible for Program Unit Funding this year? Has the registration and documentation gone in by 30 November?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether the school authority has found your child eligible for PUF, the date of registration, the documents relied on, the hours of programming made available to your child, and a copy of the IPP.

If you don't get it

Ask for a refusal in writing with reasons. The general dispute routes apply (see chapter 12). For starting school, see chapter 14.

Write this down

Date registered · eligibility decision · hours offered · IPP date.

6.9 Charter and private schools: severe disabilities funding

You might be hearing

— "We don't have the funding for that here."

— "He needs three levels of support to qualify."

— "Severe funding wasn't approved."

— "We're funded differently from the public board."

What's going on

Charter schools and accredited funded independent (private) schools are funded differently. Private schools, and charter schools that chose it, get per-student severe disabilities funding, which needs the province's approval for each student. For that, the school's file must show your child receives at least three "levels of support" from a fixed list.

Charter schools choose between this and the block grant public boards get. Once a charter school chooses the block grant, it can't go back.

What the rules say

Charter schools may continue on severe disabilities funding; "Once a charter school opts to be funded based on the Specialized Learning Support grant, they are no longer eligible to choose the severe disabilities funding" (C2.1, p.55). Funding "will be based on approval of the student's eligibility by Alberta Education and Childcare" (p.55).

For accredited funded independent schools, the student's file must contain "assessment and diagnosis by qualified personnel", current functioning documentation, the supports provided, which must be "three or more levels of support", and "a current Individualized Program Plan (IPP) or Instructional Support Plan (ISP)" (D2.3, pp.120 and 121). Students "enrolled in an online program or home education and shared responsibility program are not eligible" (p.120).

The five levels of support: "specialized equipment or assistive technology"; "assistance with basic care"; "a minimum 0.5 FTE one-to-one instruction/intervention/support"; "frequent documented monitoring of medical and/or behaviour status"; and "direct specialized services" (Glossary, p.258).

The 2004 Standards do not cover charter schools. The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) covers public charter school operators and only encourages independent schools to use it.

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, sections C2.1 and D2.3, and Glossary, pp.55, 120, 121, 258. Provincial funding rules. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.1 and 3. Guidance.

Say this

"Is this school funded for my child under severe disabilities funding? If so, which three levels of support is my child receiving?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether an application was made for your child, its date and result, and the levels of support listed in your child's file.

If you don't get it

Ask the school for its own appeal or dispute procedure. For choosing between schools, see chapter 15.

Write this down

Date · funding status · levels of support listed · what you see happening.

6.10 Coding while you wait for a diagnosis

You might be hearing

— "We can't code her until the psych assessment is done."

— "The pediatrician waitlist is over a year."

— "No diagnosis, no code."

— "We'll code him once the report comes in."

What's going on

For two codes, the province lets schools code a child while a formal diagnosis is still pending. This is called Alternative Documentation. It applies to Code 42 (severe emotional or behavioural disability) and Code 48 (moderate language delay, preschool and kindergarten only). It does not apply to any other code.

The province's stated reason is that schools have had trouble getting qualified professionals to do assessments. All the listed documents must be from the current school year.

What the rules say

"The Alternative Documentation route enables the use of alternative assessments or documentation to determine eligibility for coding and eligibility for Code 42 ... while awaiting an assessment. The intention of this change is to reduce barriers to funding for supports and services" (p.8).

For Code 42, all four are needed: a statement of impact by a trained professional (teacher, behaviour therapist or consultant, social worker or similar) that includes "the plan for follow-up with a formal diagnosis"; "An ongoing behaviour plan, crisis or safety management plan, developed in consultation with the school-based learning team, including the parents/guardians"; "A behaviour tracking summary"; and an IPP or ISP describing the behaviour and interventions (p.8).

For Code 48: a document from a speech-language pathologist (or from both an SLP and an occupational therapist) whose "clinical opinion indicates areas of need are significant", with a follow-up plan for formal diagnosis, and "A detailed IPP/ISP" (p.12).

Source: Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, 11 June 2026, pp.8 and 12. Provincial coding document.

Say this

"The Coding Criteria have an Alternative Documentation route for Code 42 [or 48] while we wait. Has the school considered it, and which of the required documents are in place?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether Alternative Documentation has been considered for your child, which required documents exist and their dates, and the plan and date for the formal diagnosis.

If you don't get it

Support does not have to wait for a code (see 5.10). Track the assessment wait (see 5.4).

Write this down

Date · code considered · documents in place · date of planned diagnosis.

6.11 Gifted and talented (Code 80)

You might be hearing

- "We don't test for giftedness until later."
- "She's bright, but she doesn't need anything."
- "We don't have a gifted program."
- "Gifted kids don't get IPPs here."

What's going on

Giftedness has its own code, 80, from preschool to Grade 12. There is no provincial test for it. Each school authority sets its own process, so a child identified in one division may not be in another. A child can be gifted and have a disability too: that is the only case where a child can carry two codes.

What the rules say

"Giftedness is exceptional potential and/or performance across a wide range of abilities in one or more of the following areas: general intellect; specific academia; creative thinking; social; music; art; and kinesthesia."

"Each school authority establishes its own assessment process for identifying giftedness and ensuring appropriate educational programming for students who are identified" (p.6). Screening tools alone are not sufficient "to determine giftedness" (p.2). A second code must be Code 80 (p.1).

For preschool and kindergarten, the Guide to Education says "all children who require specialized supports and services, including children who are gifted and talented, require IPPs/ISPs." For Grades 1 to 12, see 4.1.

Source: Special Education Coding Criteria 2026/27, 11 June 2026, pp.1, 2, 6. Provincial coding document. Guide to Education 2025-26, "Supports and services for children", last updated 26 August 2025. Provincial policy.

Say this

"What is the division's process for identifying giftedness, and has my child been through it?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the division's process for identifying giftedness, whether your child has been assessed under it and the result, and, if identified, whether an IPP will be written.

If you don't get it

Ask whether the school has determined your child needs specialized supports (see 4.1). A refusal can be taken further (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · process described · result · IPP yes or no.

Your division may also have

A written gifted identification procedure. It is the division's own, so ask for it by name.

Chapter 7: Support in the classroom

Educational assistants, personal care, accommodations and modifications, assistive technology, specialized classes, French immersion, getting to school, and accommodations on provincial tests.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/7

Turn here when you're hearing

— "The EA will take care of that." → 7.1

— "There are several adults circulating in the room." → 7.2

— "She has support when needed." → 7.2

— "He doesn't need an EA, he needs independence." → 7.3

— "That support was only ever meant to be temporary." → 7.4

— "We've had to move some staff around." → 7.4

— "His EA was needed in another room today." → 7.5

— "We didn't have coverage, so can you pick her up?" → 7.5

— "He's on a modified program." → 7.6

— "The accommodations are in place." → 7.7

— "We don't really use the laptop in class." → 7.8

— "We think a specialized class would suit him better." → 7.9

— "This placement isn't the right fit." → 7.10

— "Have you thought about the English program?" → 7.11

— "He's not eligible for the bus." → 7.12

— "He's been suspended from the bus." → 7.13

— "The van comes at 2:15." → 7.13

— "He can't have a reader on the PAT unless he uses one in class." → 7.14

— "We don't have staff for toileting." → 7.15

— "Can you come in and change her?" → 7.15

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
7.1	What an EA is, and who directs them
7.2	Who is with your child, and for how long
7.3	"He doesn't need an EA, he needs independence"
7.4	The EA was removed or cut mid-year
7.5	Your child's EA is pulled to cover, or is away
7.6	Accommodations or modifications: which program is your child on
7.7	Accommodations on the IPP aren't happening
7.8	Assistive technology
7.9	They want to move your child to a specialized class
7.10	"This placement isn't the right fit"
7.11	French immersion and support
7.12	Getting a bus that works for your child
7.13	Trouble on the bus, or the bus cuts the school day
7.14	Accommodations on provincial tests and diploma exams
7.15	Toileting and personal care at school

7.1 What an EA is, and who directs them

You might be hearing

— "The EA will take care of that."

— "Her EA does the IPP goals with her."

— "The EA knows him best."

— "You'd have to talk to the teacher about that."

What's going on

An EA (educational assistant, sometimes called an aide or teacher assistant) is a school employee who works with students under a teacher's direction. The teacher stays responsible for what your child is taught and how progress is measured. The EA helps deliver it.

That matters when you ask questions. Questions about goals, teaching and progress go to the teacher. Questions about how the day goes are often best answered by the EA, with the teacher's knowledge.

We found no Alberta rule that sets qualifications for EAs or a ratio of EAs to students.

What the rules say

Boards must "ensure teacher assistants work under the direction of a certificated teacher to realize students' goals, as outlined in their IPPs" (Standard 11(g)).

Alberta's Guide to Education defines instruction as "the process in which Alberta certificated teachers take responsibility for ensuring that learning activities for students are directed toward achieving the outcomes of approved programs of study/curriculum and/or individualized program plans/instructional support plans."

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) lists educational assistants as members of the school-based team (Glossary and s.6, 4.1).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(g), applied under Ministerial Order 015/2004, read 16 October 2026. Standard. Guide to Education 2025-26, "Definition of instruction", last updated 26 August 2025. Provincial policy. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026. Guidance.

Say this

"Which teacher directs my child's EA, and how does the EA know what to work on each day?"

Ask for this in writing

The name of the teacher who directs the EA's work with your child, and where the EA's daily tasks for your child are written down (the IPP or another plan).

If you don't get it

If the EA appears nowhere in the plan, ask that the EA's role and tasks be written into the IPP's support section (see 4.2, coordinated support services).

Write this down

Date · EA's name and role · directing teacher · where the tasks are written.

7.2 Who is with your child, and for how long

You might be hearing

— "There are several adults circulating in the room."

— "She has support when needed."

— "The EA is shared between a few students."

— "We use a classroom model, not one-to-one."

What's going on

One-to-one means an adult assigned to your child. Shared means one adult across several students. "Circulating" or "when needed" can mean no one is assigned to your child at all. That may be fine for some children. For a child who can't yet ask for help, "when needed" depends on someone noticing.

You are entitled to know what support your child gets, how much, and from whom. Alberta's IPP guidance expects the IPP to list services with dates, types and providers, and how much time is offered.

What the rules say

The IPP must include "identification of coordinated support services (including health-related), if required" (Standards, Definitions p.4). The 2006 IPP resource says "The IPP should include an ongoing list of what services the student [receives], with dates, types of service and names of service providers." Its sample checklist adds "Amount of time services offered."

No Alberta law or standard we found requires one-to-one support, sets how many students may share an EA, or forbids one-to-one support. These are decisions about your child's needs.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4. Standard. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.11 and Appendix 1-B (Chapter 1 p.35), read 23 October 2026. Guidance.

Say this

"Who is assigned to my child, for which parts of the day, and how many other students does that person support at the same time?"

Ask for this in writing

For each support adult: their role, the times of day they work with your child, how many students they support at once, and where this is written in the IPP.

If you don't get it

Ask that the IPP list the support with the amount of time (see 4.2). If the school tells you one-to-one support is against its rules, ask for the written policy.

Write this down

Date · who supports your child · times · how many students share them.

7.3 "He doesn't need an EA, he needs independence"

You might be hearing

- "He doesn't need an EA, he needs independence."
- "We want to see what she can do on her own."
- "Too much support creates dependence."
- "He's showing more maturity."

What's going on

Independence is a fair goal. Alberta's own guidance names it. The problem is when the goal is used as a reason to remove support before your child can do the thing alone.

A goal needs a starting point, a target and a date. If "independence" is the goal, ask how it will be built, how it will be measured, and what support stays until it is met. If the IPP says your child is "independent" at

something, ask whether that means without help, or with supports in place. Ask that the supports be written right next to the word.

What the rules say

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says decisions "are guided by evidence to support students to develop the knowledge, skills, and competencies required for engaged learning, independence, and success" (s.4, 2).

IPP goals and objectives must be measurable (Standards, Definitions p.4). The 2006 resource: "Without measurability, progress cannot be monitored." Each objective "should include a target date".

Before providing specialized supports a board "shall consult with the parent" (Education Act s.11(5)).

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.4. Guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4. Standard. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.10 and Chapter 7 p.7. Guidance. Education Act s.11(5), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"Independence is a good goal. What's the plan to build it, how will you measure it, and what support stays in place until it's met?"

Ask for this in writing

The independence goal as written in the IPP, with its starting point, target and date; the support that continues meanwhile; and the data that would show the support can be reduced.

If you don't get it

A support reduced with no measured goal behind it is a change to the plan (see 4.8 and 7.4).

Write this down

Date · words used · goal and date given · support that continues.

7.4 The EA was removed or cut mid-year

You might be hearing

— "That support was only ever meant to be temporary."

— "We've had to move some staff around."

— "It was a transition measure."

— "We're trying a different model this term."

What's going on

Support that was working and then disappears, with no notice and no written reason, is one of the most common things parents describe. A change in support is a change to your child's program. You are meant to be part of it.

When support is first given, ask in writing how long it lasts and what review would end it. That one line protects you later.

What the rules say

Teachers must involve parents in "development, implementation, monitoring and evaluation" of the IPP and "make changes to the IPP, as required" (Standard 11(f)). Before providing specialized supports a board "shall consult with the parent" (Education Act s.11(5)).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says "Parents receive written explanations of adjustments, curricular adjustments, and/or specialized setting, credentialing, or programming implications" (s.7, 3.1) and encourages authorities to "Transparently document plans, interventions, outcomes, and rationale for decisions" (s.3, 2.3).

No Alberta rule we found sets a notice period before support is reduced.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f). Standard. Education Act s.11(5), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.3 and 7. Guidance.

Say this

"My child's support changed. Who decided, on what date, and what information was it based on?"

Ask for this in writing

The date the decision was made, who made it, the information it was based on (with dates), whether an assessment was considered, and when the change will be reviewed.

If you don't get it

Say in writing that you do not agree with the change (see 4.6 and 4.8). A decision that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date support ended · date you were told · who decided · reason given.

7.5 Your child's EA is pulled to cover, or is away

You might be hearing

— "His EA was needed in another room today."

— "We didn't have coverage, so can you pick her up?"

— "The sub didn't know him."

— "We used her EA to cover a gap."

What's going on

EAs get sick, and schools reassign staff to cover gaps. What matters is whether there is a plan for your child on those days: who steps in, what they are told, and whether your child stays at school. Ask for that plan before the day it is needed.

Being asked to pick your child up because there is no coverage raises a separate question about being sent home. See chapter 8.

What the rules say

We found no Alberta law or standard that sets how a school covers an absent EA, or that stops a school reassigning an EA for the day.

The IPP must list coordinated support services (Standards, Definitions p.4), and the 2006 resource expects the amount of time services are offered to be recorded (Appendix 1-B). A support listed in the IPP and not delivered is a gap between the plan and the day.

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) expects school-based teams to keep supports "coherent and timely" (s.6, 4.2).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4. Standard. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Appendix 1-B (Chapter 1 p.35). Guidance. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.6. Guidance.

Say this

"What's the written plan for my child on days their EA is away or moved, and who briefs the person covering?"

Ask for this in writing

The coverage plan for your child: who covers, what document they are given, whether your child stays at school, and how and when you are told.

If you don't get it

Keep a dated log of each day support was missing. If your child is sent home or kept home because of staffing, see chapter 8.

Write this down

Date · EA absent or moved · who covered · whether you were told · whether your child was sent home.

7.6 Accommodations or modifications: which program is your child on

You might be hearing

- "He's on a modified program."
- "She's working on adapted outcomes."
- "We've adjusted his expectations."
- "Don't worry about the grade level for now."

What's going on

Two words with very different effects.

— Adapted programming (accommodations): your child works on the same grade-level outcomes as everyone else, with changes to how they are taught or tested. Extra time, a reader, a quiet room.

— Modified programming: the learning outcomes themselves are different from the grade-level curriculum.

Modified programming can change what your child is working toward, including later in high school. Ask which one your child is on, subject by subject, and ask for the effect in writing.

What the rules say

"Adapted programming" means programming that "retains the learning outcomes of the Program of Studies and where adjustments to the instructional process are provided". "Modified programming" means programming "in which the learning outcomes are significantly different from the provincial curriculum and are specifically selected to meet students' special education needs" (Standards, Definitions pp.3 and 4).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) uses "Adjustments" for changes that "do not alter the curricular expectations" and "Curricular adjustments" where "the learning outcomes differ from the grade-level curriculum", documented in an IPP (Glossary). It says "Parents receive written explanations of adjustments, curricular adjustments, and/or specialized setting, credentialing, or programming implications" (s.7, 3.1).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, Glossary and s.7. Guidance.

Say this

"For each subject, is my child on grade-level outcomes with accommodations, or on modified outcomes? And what does that mean for what they can graduate with?"

Ask for this in writing

Subject by subject: adapted or modified, the date that was decided, who decided it, and a written explanation of the effect on future programming and credentials.

If you don't get it

A move to modified programming is a decision that significantly affects education (see chapter 12). For high school credentials, see chapter 14.

Write this down

Date · subject · adapted or modified · who decided · explanation received.

7.7 Accommodations on the IPP aren't happening

You might be hearing

- "The accommodations are in place."
- "He doesn't want to use them."
- "We offer them when he needs them."
- "The sub didn't know about it."

What's going on

An accommodation is a change to how your child is taught, tested or set up so they can show what they know. Required accommodations must be listed on the IPP. Listing them is not the same as using them.

There is a second reason to check. On provincial tests, an accommodation usually counts only if your child uses it in class during the year (see 7.14). One that exists only on paper can be lost when it matters most.

What the rules say

The IPP must include "required classroom accommodations (e.g., any changes to instructional strategies, assessment procedures, materials, resources, facilities or equipment)" (Standards, Definitions p.4). Boards must ensure IPPs are "developed, implemented, monitored and evaluated" (Standard 11(a)), and principals are "accountable for the delivery and implementation of school-based special education programming and services" (Standard 11(b)).

The 2006 resource: "Required accommodations must be listed on the IPP."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standards 11(a) and (b). Standard. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.12, read 23 October 2026. Guidance.

Say this

"These accommodations are on the IPP. Which ones did my child use this week, in which classes, and how do you track that?"

Ask for this in writing

For each accommodation on the IPP: the classes where it is used, how often, who makes sure it happens, and how it is recorded.

If you don't get it

The principal is accountable for implementation (Standard 11(b)). Put it to the principal in writing. If an accommodation has been dropped, that is a 4.8 problem.

Write this down

Date · accommodation · class · used or not · who you asked.

7.8 Assistive technology

You might be hearing

- "We don't really use the laptop in class."
- "It's too distracting for the others."
- "He needs to learn to write by hand first."
- "The device stays at school."

What's going on

Assistive technology is any tool that helps your child communicate, access learning, regulate, or show what they know: text-to-speech, speech-to-text, a communication device, a slant board, noise-cancelling headphones.

If your child needs it, it belongs in the IPP as an accommodation, with when and where it is used. Use in class also matters for provincial tests (see 7.14).

What the rules say

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says planning for a student who needs specialized supports should consider "Assistive technology and specialized tools that support communication, access, regulation, or demonstration of learning" (s.5.3, 8.3).

The Standards include "equipment" among the required classroom accommodations in an IPP (Definitions p.4).

On provincial achievement tests, text-to-speech, speech-to-text, scribe and reader are among the regular accommodations (PAT bulletin 2026-27, pp.27 to 29), and "Students must use the accommodation during regular classroom instruction and assessment" (p.26).

We found no Alberta rule on who pays for a device or whether it may go home. Ask your division.

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, s.5.3. Guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4. Standard. General Information Bulletin 2026-2027, Grades 6 and 9 Provincial Achievement Testing, pp.26 to 29, read 23 October 2026. Provincial policy.

Say this

"Can the IPP say which technology my child uses, in which classes, and who makes sure it's charged and working?"

Ask for this in writing

The assistive technology listed in the IPP, where and when it is used, who supports it, and whether it can go home.

If you don't get it

Ask for any division procedure on assistive technology. If the device is refused, ask for the decision and reasons in writing (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · tool · where it's used · who supports it.

Your division may also have

An assistive technology procedure or loan program. Ask for it by name.

7.9 They want to move your child to a specialized class

You might be hearing

— "We think a specialized class would suit him better."

— "There's a spot opening in the program at another school."

— "She'd get more support there."

— "It's a smaller class with more adults."

What's going on

A specialized setting (sometimes called a congregated class, a special program, or a district program) is a class or program set up for students with high needs, often at a different school. For some children it is the right place. But Alberta's starting point is the regular classroom in your neighbourhood school, and moving out of it is meant to be decided with you, on evidence, with written reasons.

You can ask to visit, ask what the goals are, and ask how and when it will be reviewed.

What the rules say

"Educating students with special education needs in inclusive settings in neighbourhood or local schools shall be the first placement option considered by school boards, in consultation with parents" (Standard 10(a)). Boards must "determine the most enabling placement ... in consultation with parents, and based on current assessment data" (Standard 10(b)).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says planning should include "Consideration of specialized settings only when essential to support access to learning, based on documented rationale, parent consultation, and review of available supports" and "Regular review of placement suitability" (s.5.3, 8.6 and 8.7). When access to a specialized setting is being decided, the things that "must be considered" include consultation with parents where curricular adjustments are required, that school-based teams "should provide written information to parents about implications for future programming considerations, including credentialing and post-secondary pathways", and that "Regular review and

transition planning are mandatory" (s.5.3.2, 2). The framework is still guidance, not law.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 10. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.5.3 and 5.3.2. Guidance.

Say this

"Before I decide, can I have the reasons in writing, the assessment it's based on, and what this means for my child's credentials later?"

Ask for this in writing

The documented rationale, the supports already tried in the current class, the current assessment data relied on, the review date for the placement, and written information on future programming and credential effects.

If you don't get it

A placement decision significantly affects your child's education and can be appealed (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date proposed · who proposed it · reasons given · review date.

7.10 "This placement isn't the right fit"

You might be hearing

- "This placement isn't the right fit."
- "We can't meet his needs here."
- "Have you looked at other schools?"
- "Some families find home education works better."

What's going on

This sentence often comes before a suggestion that your child go somewhere else: another school, a program, or home education. The board can direct which of its schools a student attends, and it can say a school lacks the resources for a requested enrolment. But the board must still make sure each of its resident students is provided with an education

program. And once your child is identified as needing specialized supports, the board running their school owes them access to those supports.

The Education Act has a specific route for a board that decides it cannot meet a student's needs: it refers the matter to a Complex Education Needs Tribunal. No instrument setting up such a tribunal had been found as of 13 October 2026, and a search on 23 October 2026 found nothing new.

Home education is your choice to make, not the school's (see chapter 15).

What the rules say

"Subject to subsection (2), a board shall direct a resident student of the board to enrol in and attend a particular school operated by the board" (Education Act s.10(1)). The board must enrol the student in the school the parent asks for "if, in the opinion of the board asked to enrol the student, there are sufficient resources and facilities available to accommodate the student" (s.10(2)). The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) adds that where a board has decided a specialized setting may be most appropriate, "this may affect the board's determination" of whether there are sufficient resources at the school the parent asked for (s.5.3.2, 1.3).

"A board shall ensure that each of its resident students is provided with an education program" (s.11(1)). "A board may determine that a student requires specialized supports and services that cannot be met in an education program that may be provided by the board under any other provision of this Act" (s.40(1)). If it does, "the board shall refer the matter to a Complex Education Needs Tribunal" (s.40(2)). "The Minister may establish one or more Complex Education Needs Tribunals" (s.40(7)). That word is "may": the Act does not require one to exist.

Placement must be decided "in consultation with parents, and based on current assessment data" (Standard 10(b)). Home education is something "A parent of a student may provide" (s.20(1)).

Source: Education Act ss.10, 11(1), 20(1), 40, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 10(b). Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026. Guidance.

Say this

"Is the board saying it can't meet my child's needs? If so, I'd like that in writing, with the assessment it's based on."

Ask for this in writing

Whether the board has determined it cannot meet your child's needs, the date and who decided, the assessment data relied on, and the steps the board will take under the Education Act.

If you don't get it

A placement or enrolment decision can be appealed (see chapter 12). For other schooling options, see chapter 15.

Write this down

Date · exact words used · who said them · what was suggested.

7.11 French immersion and support

You might be hearing

- "Have you thought about the English program?"
- "Immersion might be too much for her."
- "We can't assess in French."
- "Support is easier to get in the English stream."

What's going on

French immersion is an "alternative program" under the Education Act. A board can decline to offer it to a student if it decides the program isn't appropriate for that student's needs. But a student in immersion is still a student of that board, and the board's duty to provide specialized supports to an identified student doesn't switch off because the program is in French.

Alberta's own handbook for immersion administrators says students with learning difficulties can do as well in immersion as in English if they get the same help, and tells divisions to set up support services for them.

What the rules say

An "alternative program" is one that "emphasizes a particular language, culture, religion or subject-matter" (Education Act s.19(1)). A board "may offer an alternative program to a student whose parent requests it where, in the opinion of the board", it has the resources and "the alternative program is appropriate to meet the student's education needs" (s.19(2)).

A student determined to need specialized supports "is entitled to have access to those supports and services" (s.11(4)). Section 11 applies to "each student enrolled in a school operated by the board" (s.11(2)) and does not exclude alternative programs.

Alberta's Handbook for French Immersion Administrators (2010, guidance) says early immersion students with difficulties do as well "as they would in a regular English program provided they receive the same assistance" (p.5), lists "access to appropriate testing and diagnostic services for French immersion students experiencing learning difficulties" (p.25), and tells senior administrators to "Establish the necessary support services for French immersion students with special needs" and to transfer a student out only "after considering all other options" (p.38).

Source: Education Act ss.11 and 19, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Handbook for French Immersion Administrators, Alberta Education, 2010, pp.5, 25, 38, read 23 October 2026. Guidance.

Say this

"Is the suggestion to leave immersion a decision about my child's needs, or about support available in French? What would my child get if they stay?"

Ask for this in writing

The reason for the suggestion, the supports your child would receive in immersion, and, if the board has decided immersion is not appropriate, that decision with its reasons.

If you don't get it

A decision to move your child out of a program can be appealed (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · who suggested a move · reason · supports offered in each program.

7.12 Getting a bus that works for your child

You might be hearing

— "He's not eligible for the bus."

— "We don't run door-to-door."

— "Special transportation is only for severe codes."

— "You could drive her yourself and we'd pay mileage."

What's going on

Boards must provide transportation in some cases, set by the Education Act and the School Transportation Regulation. The regulation has one rule specific to disability: if your child is entitled to specialized supports and the school that provides them is outside your attendance area, your home board must transport your child there.

The regulation says nothing about bus aides, specialized vehicles or how long a ride can be. Specialized transportation (a separate bus, van or taxi for students who can't use the regular bus because of a disability) is set out in your division's own procedure; several divisions publish one. The province funds it for students with a severe disability who can't use regular transportation.

If a board offers to pay you to drive, that is an agreement, and the province has funding rules about it.

What the rules say

"Subject to the regulations, a board must provide for the transportation of a student to and from the site of the school in which the board has enrolled the student" if the student lives in the school's attendance area and in the division, and any criteria in the regulations are met (Education Act s.59(1)). A board may instead agree with a parent to convey the student and "receive payment, as determined by the board" (s.59.1(1)).

Provincial special transportation funding is for students "with a severe disability/delay ... who cannot, because of the severity of their disability/delay, use regular transportation services", and "Program or school location shall not be considered when determining eligibility for this funding" (Funding Manual C3.2.5, p.86). For parent-provided transport, agreements must be signed and on file by 31 October; reimbursement "must

take into consideration the transportation funding the jurisdiction receives for the student along with the cost of providing comparable service", and agreements cannot let the board withhold reimbursement to offset other amounts owed (p.87).

The School Transportation Regulation (AR 96/2019) sets the distance criteria: a student in Grade 6 or lower qualifies if they live at least 1.6 km from the school, and Grade 7 or higher at least 2 km (s.2). Under section 5, where a student entitled to specialized supports under section 11(4) "does not reside in the attendance area for any school that provides specialized supports and services that are suitable for the student", the student's home board "must provide for the transportation of the student to and from the school that provides the specialized supports and services in which the board enrols the student." Each board "must establish, maintain and implement policies respecting the transportation of students", and those policies must include "processes designed to enable the resolution of disputes and concerns between parents and the board" (s.8). Boards publish their transportation policies before each school year (s.10). The regulation has no section on bus aides, specialized vehicles or ride length.

Source: Education Act ss.59 and 59.1, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. School Transportation Regulation, AR 96/2019, ss.2, 5, 8, 10, current as of 1 September 2025, read 23 October 2026. Regulation. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, section C3.2.5, pp.86 and 87. Provincial funding rules.

Say this

"My child can't use the regular bus because of their disability. What is the division's procedure for specialized transportation, and who decides?"

Ask for this in writing

The division's specialized transportation procedure, the decision on your child with reasons, and, if you are offered a parent-transport agreement, the rate and how it was calculated.

If you don't get it

Use the board's transportation dispute process first: section 8 of the regulation says its policy must have one. Then the general routes (see

chapter 12). Transportation needs can also be written into the IPP's transition and support sections.

Write this down

Date · what you asked for · decision · who decided · rate offered.

Your division may also have

A special needs transportation procedure. Most divisions have one; ask for it by name.

7.13 Trouble on the bus, or the bus cuts the school day

You might be hearing

- "He's been suspended from the bus."
- "The driver can't manage her."
- "The van comes at 2:15."
- "He can wait in the office until his ride comes."

What's going on

Two things go wrong. First, behaviour on the bus can lead to a suspension from transportation, which can mean your child can't get to school. Second, specialized transport is sometimes scheduled so that your child leaves class early or arrives late every day, and nobody mentions the lost time.

Ask for the pickup and drop-off times next to the bell schedule, and ask what is missed. If the end-of-day wait is a hard time for your child, ask for it to be planned in the IPP or behaviour plan.

What the rules say

A principal may suspend a student "from transportation provided under section 59" (Education Act s.36(3)(c)). When that happens the principal "shall ... immediately inform the student's parent", "report in writing to the student's parent all the circumstances", and "provide an opportunity to meet" (s.36(4)). "A suspension may not exceed 5 school days", except with a recommendation for expulsion (s.36(5)).

On time in class, the Guide to Education says "schools must provide Grade 1 to Grade 9 students with a minimum of 950 hours of instruction per

year in each grade" (with alternatives allowed for individual Grade 1 students), and the high school minimum is 1000 hours.

The School Transportation Regulation sets no limit on ride length. It does require each board's transportation policy to include "processes designed to enable the resolution of disputes and concerns between parents and the board" (s.8).

We found no Alberta rule on how a school must report bus incidents to parents beyond the suspension rules above.

Source: Education Act s.36, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. School Transportation Regulation, AR 96/2019, s.8, current as of 1 September 2025, read 23 October 2026. Regulation. Guide to Education 2025-26, "Minimum hours of instruction", last updated 26 August 2025. Provincial policy.

Say this

"What time does my child leave class for the van, what do they miss, and can the pickup time be changed so they get the full day?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's daily pickup and drop-off times beside the bell schedule, the classes missed, and, for any bus suspension, the written report of the circumstances required by section 36(4).

If you don't get it

Ask for the meeting section 36(4) offers. If transport is cutting your child's day, put it to the principal and the division transportation office in writing, and use the board's transportation dispute process (see 7.12). For suspensions and being sent home, see chapter 8.

Write this down

Date · pickup time · bell time · minutes missed · any incident and who told you.

7.14 Accommodations on provincial tests and diploma exams

You might be hearing

— "He can't have a reader on the PAT unless he uses one in class."

— "That accommodation needs approval from the province."

— "She'll be excused from the PAT."

— "It's too late to apply."

What's going on

Provincial Achievement Tests (PATs, written in Grades 6 and 9) and diploma exams (in high school) allow accommodations such as a reader, scribe, text-to-speech, large print or braille. For the common ones there is no application: the school decides. But your child must already use the accommodation in class. Less common ones (called unique accommodations) need an application to the province with a deadline. Every student may have up to twice the official time on a PAT if they need it.

Only a superintendent can excuse a student from writing a PAT, and only when two set conditions are both met.

What the rules say

PATs 2026-27: "Students are eligible for regular accommodations and provisions without an application process." "Students must use the accommodation during regular classroom instruction and assessment." "Decisions rendered by school personnel are official and must be communicated to the parent/guardian," and "Parents/guardians must contact the school authority should they wish to dispute the decision rendered" (p.26). Unique accommodations need an application from school staff with supporting documentation, which can include an IPP (p.30); deadlines are 27 November 2026 (January writing) and 5 March 2027 (June writing) (p.41); "The original decision may be reconsidered once only" (p.30), and the bulletin sets out a further appeal with a deadline (p.30). "All students are permitted twice the official time limit to write a PAT if they require it" (p.30). Only a superintendent may excuse a student, and both conditions must be met: the student cannot access the test, even with

accommodations, because of their characteristics, and "participation would be harmful to the student" (p.7).

Diploma exams 2026-27: the condition for using an accommodation is that students "regularly use the accommodation for classroom assignments and/or assessments"; "There is no application process required by Alberta Education and Childcare" for regular accommodations; "The decision rendered by school personnel is official" (p.50). Unique accommodations are decided by the province's Special Cases and Accommodations Team, and the bulletin sets out a reconsideration and appeal process with deadlines. Read pages 50 to 52 of the bulletin for the steps.

Boards must ensure "special provisions for testing, including school-based and provincial tests, are available to students with special education needs throughout the course of the year" (Standard 15(a)).

Source: General Information Bulletin 2026-2027, Grades 6 and 9 Provincial Achievement Testing, pp.7, 26, 30, 41, and General Information Bulletin 2026-2027, Diploma Examinations Program, pp.50 to 52 (printed page footers), Alberta Education and Childcare, read 23 October 2026. Provincial policy under the Provincial Assessment Directive. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 15(a). Standard.

Say this

"Which accommodations will my child have on the PAT, and is each one being used in class now so they qualify?"

Ask for this in writing

The accommodations your child will have on each provincial test, confirmation each is used in regular classroom instruction and assessment now, and, for any unique accommodation, the date the application was sent.

If you don't get it

Disputes about regular accommodations go to the school authority. Ask for its dispute process in writing. For a unique accommodation decision, both bulletins set out a reconsideration and appeal process with deadlines: ask the school for the pages and the dates before the deadline passes.

Write this down

Test · accommodation · used in class since · school decision date · application date if unique.

7.15 Toileting and personal care at school

You might be hearing

— "We don't have staff for toileting."

— "Can you come in and change her?"

— "He needs to be toilet trained to attend full days."

— "That's not in the EA's job description."

— "We'll call you if there's an accident."

What's going on

Personal care means help with toileting, changing, feeding, dressing or grooming. Some children need it every day at school. Alberta has no provincial rule that names who at school must do it. That gap is why parents get called in.

What does exist: the school's broader duties to your child, the rule that staff who give health-related support get trained (and parents can be among the trainers), and human rights law on disability. Personal care should be written down: in the IPP, a health or care plan, or both. Ask who does it, where, with what privacy, and what happens on days that person is away. A plan that depends on you answering the phone is not a school plan.

What the rules say

We found no Alberta law, regulation, ministerial order or provincial standard that assigns toileting or personal care at school to a named role, sets a privacy procedure for it, or allows a school to require a parent to come in to provide it.

Boards must have "written procedures for accessing, recording, and sharing medical information" and, "when required to administer health-related support services to students in schools, provide staff with training by qualified professionals or other individuals with expertise, including parents" (Standards 6(e) and (f)). EAs "work under the direction of a certificated teacher to realize students' goals, as outlined in their IPPs"

(Standard 11(g)). The IPP must identify "coordinated support services (including health-related), if required" (Definitions p.4).

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says planning should consider "increased in-class support" and "Environmental adjustments to ensure safety, regulation, accessibility, and participation" (s.5.3, 8.2 and 8.5), and that school-based teams "adjust educational programming appropriately" with health providers and parents when specialized medical procedures are required (s.5.3.1.1, 3). It also says "Reasonable limitations may be considered" related to the student profile (s.5.3.1.1, 3.1). Principals "allocate staffing, resources, and time" (s.6, 5.4).

The Alberta Human Rights Act says no person shall "deny to any person or class of persons any goods, services, accommodation or facilities that are customarily available to the public", or discriminate in them, because of physical or mental disability (s.4), unless shown to be "reasonable and justifiable in the circumstances" (s.11). How this applies to schools is in chapter 2.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4 and Standards 6(e), 6(f), 11(g), read 16 October 2026. Standard. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, ss.5.3, 5.3.1.1, 6. Guidance. Alberta Human Rights Act, RSA 2000 c.A-25.5, ss.4 and 11, current as of 1 April 2023. Law.

Say this

"Who at school does my child's personal care, where, and how is their privacy protected? And what's the plan on days that person is away?"

Ask for this in writing

The name or role of each staff member who provides personal care, the training they have had and from whom, where it happens and the privacy procedure, the backup plan for absences, and where this is written in the IPP or care plan.

If you don't get it

If you are asked to come in or take your child home because no one will do it, ask for that request in writing with the reason (see chapter 8 on being sent home, and chapter 9 on health care plans). A refusal to provide care your child needs because of a disability can be raised under the board's

dispute process (see chapter 12) and as a human rights matter (see chapter 2).

Write this down

Date · what care was needed · who did it, or that you were called · how long your child was without it.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on personal care or health care plans. Ask for it by name.

Chapter 8: Behaviour, safety, and being sent home

What the rules say about behaviour plans, restraint and seclusion, time-out, early pick-ups, short days, suspension, expulsion, police at school, injuries and bullying.

Last verified: October 2026

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Turn here when you're hearing

— "We're going to put a behaviour plan in place." → 8.1

— "It's just a safety plan." → 8.1

— "We're still using last year's plan." → 8.2

— "We took the plan off, things have been going well." → 8.2

— "We had to hold him for his safety." → 8.3

— "She was in the quiet room." → 8.3

— "It was handled." → 8.4

— "We have those recorded at school." → 8.4

— "We need you to sign the safety plan." → 8.5

— "He just had some time out of class." → 8.6

— "It's a sensory break, not a time-out." → 8.6

— "Can you come and pick him up?" → 8.7

— "It's not a suspension, just a reset at home." → 8.7

— "We're going to try half days for now." → 8.8

— "It's just until we get staffing." → 8.8

— "He's suspended for the rest of the week." → 8.9

— "It's zero tolerance." → 8.9

— "I'm recommending expulsion to the board." → 8.10

— "We don't have an EA for the trip." → 8.11

— "You're welcome to come along as his support." → 8.11

— "We had to call the police." → 8.12

— "It's a threat assessment, it's protocol." → 8.12

— "That mark was already there this morning." → 8.13

— "Kids will be kids." → 8.14

— "It's a conflict, not bullying." → 8.14

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
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8.3	What the rules on restraint and seclusion allow
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8.12	Police or emergency services came to the school
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8.14	Your child is being bullied

8.1 They want to put a behaviour plan in place

You might be hearing

— "We're going to put a behaviour plan in place."

— "It's just a safety plan."

— "The behaviour consultant will write it."

— "It's an internal document."

What's going on

A behaviour support plan (often called a BSP, IBSP or safety plan) is a written plan for helping a child whose behaviour gets in the way of learning or safety. A good one is mostly about prevention: what sets the behaviour off, the early warning signs, what staff do before things build, and what skills are being taught instead. The crisis or safety part says what staff do if things become dangerous. They are often stapled together. Ask for both parts.

A functional behavioural assessment (FBA) is the process of working out what conditions lead to a behaviour and keep it going. A plan built on an FBA is aimed at the cause. A plan built on nothing is aimed at the behaviour.

What the rules say

No Alberta law or standard sets a form for a behaviour plan or names who must write it. That means its quality depends on your division, and on you asking what it is based on.

Alberta's time-out guidelines (guidance) say a behaviour support plan "is essential for a child/student with complex behavioural needs that may result in or have resulted in the need for crisis or safety management procedures in school," and that its focus "is mostly on preventive and proactive strategies."

A LearnAlberta resource (guidance) lists what a plan "should include": triggers, "warning signs that the student is experiencing difficulty," "plans for diffusing the behaviour," and "positive supports." It says the plan "should be a collaborative effort between parents and school staff."

Where restraint or seclusion could come into it, the seclusion standards attached to Ministerial Order 042/2019 say more is required: an FBA "with the assistance of an appropriately trained professional," positive supports in the child's plan, a safety or crisis management plan, and your involvement (see 8.5).

Source: Guidelines for Time-out in Alberta Schools, Alberta Education, November 2019, p.7, guidance. Using Individual Behaviour Support Plans,

LearnAlberta Inclusive Education Library, undated, guidance. Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools (Appendix to Ministerial Order 042/2019), p.15, standards attached to a ministerial order.

Say this

"Before I agree, can I see the draft? What is it based on, who wrote it, and what will staff do before things get to a crisis?"

Ask for this in writing

A dated copy of the behaviour support plan and any safety or crisis plan; the name and role of the person who wrote it; whether an FBA was done, on what date and by whom; and the plan's review date.

If you don't get it

If the school describes your child's behaviour as dangerous but no FBA or safety plan exists, ask in writing why the steps in 8.5 have not happened. If the plan arrives finished, write back that you were not part of writing it and ask for a meeting (see chapter 10).

Write this down

Date · plan name and version date · who wrote it · what it is based on · review date.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on behaviour supports, or on seclusion and restraint. Ask for it by name.

8.2 The behaviour plan is out of date, or it vanished

You might be hearing

- "We're still using last year's plan."
- "That's the plan from the old school."
- "We took the plan off, things have been going well."
- "Things are calmer now, so we don't need it."
- "Just reply to this email if you're okay with it."

What's going on

A behaviour plan is written for one child in one place: named adults, a particular room, a particular calm-down space, a particular routine. When your child changes classroom or school, or the adults change, the plan can still name people and spaces your child no longer has. Nobody notices until the day it is needed.

The opposite also happens. A plan is removed because things seem calmer. Calm may be the plan working. Ask what information supports removing it, the same way you would ask what supports creating it.

What the rules say

No Alberta rule says a behaviour plan expires when a child changes class or school. That means nobody is automatically prompted to rewrite it. You have to ask.

The seclusion standards say: "After each incident where there is use of seclusion and/or physical restraint, it is required that" (among other things) "a review of the individual behaviour plan, where one has been previously created, occurs and the plan is updated to prevent and reduce recurrence."

A LearnAlberta resource (guidance) says a plan should be developed "at the beginning of the school year or as soon as possible after a student has been identified as needing a support plan," and that if the crisis plan is used, "the team needs to revisit the behaviour support plan as soon as possible."

Alberta's IPP resource (guidance) says to "Ensure documentation is in place prior to the move" when a child changes school, including a "listing of supports in place."

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools (Appendix to MO 042/2019), p.16, standards attached to a ministerial order. Using Individual Behaviour Support Plans, LearnAlberta, undated, guidance. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Appendix 8-A, guidance.

Say this

"This plan names a room and staff my child doesn't have any more. Which version is in force today, and when will it be rewritten for where they are now?"

Ask for this in writing

The version date of the behaviour plan in force today; who is revising it and by what date; that you be included in the revision. If a plan was removed: the date, who decided, and the information the decision was based on.

If you don't get it

Say in writing that you do not agree to removing the plan until you have the reasons. Removing a support can be a decision that significantly affects your child's education, and the Education Act treats a failure to decide as a decision too. Both can be appealed (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · plan version in force · what in it is out of date · who is revising it · date promised.

8.3 What the rules on restraint and seclusion allow

You might be hearing

- "We had to hold him for his safety."
- "She was in the quiet room."
- "The door wasn't locked, so it's not seclusion."
- "It was a physical escort, not a restraint."
- "We only use it as a last resort."

What's going on

Physical restraint means holding a child so they cannot move freely. Seclusion means keeping a child alone in a room or space they cannot freely leave, whether the door is locked or held shut. Both are allowed in Alberta schools, but only in narrow circumstances set by provincial standards. Time-out is a different thing with different rules (see 8.6).

Staff sometimes describe the same event in softer words. Ask what happened in plain terms, then match it to the definitions below.

What the rules say

Seclusion "is the involuntary confinement or isolation of a person, alone in a room or area from which the person cannot freely exit or is physically prevented from leaving." It "generally occurs in a room with a door that has a lock. The lock may be engaged, or if not engaged, the door is otherwise blocked or held shut." So a door held shut counts, locked or not. "Seclusion and time-out are not the same or synonymous with each other."

Physical restraint is "any method of using physical contact for restricting or immobilizing another person's freedom of movement." A brief escort holding a hand or arm, moving a child away from danger, or breaking up a fight is not restraint. Mechanical and chemical restraints "are not to be used in school settings."

Either may "only be used as a last resort when a child's/student's behaviour poses significant imminent danger of serious physical harm to themselves or others," and use "is to be immediately discontinued" when the behaviour "no longer poses such danger." They are "to never be used to punish or discipline," and "Only staff who have received specific training on the particular procedure are to attempt physical restraint or seclusion." They are also not used to stop property damage unless safety is at risk, "as substitutes for appropriate educational support," or when a known condition would make them dangerous. Seclusion "is not used when a child/student is engaging in severe self-injurious behaviours." There must be "continual visual and aural monitoring." A child who cannot communicate fully through speech must have staff present who can communicate with them if seclusion is used.

How hard these bind: the standards are attached to Ministerial Order 042/2019 as its Appendix. Their own wording is that if seclusion or restraint is to be used, "the following is required." Alberta's web page describes them as "a basis for school authorities to develop policies, procedures and practices." Division policies are to be "developed in consultation with and shared with parents/guardians."

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools, Appendix to Ministerial Order 042/2019, in effect 1 November 2019, pp.9 to 12, standards attached to a ministerial order. alberta.ca/seclusion-standards, read 23 October 2026.

Say this

"I want to understand what happened. Was my child held, or kept somewhere they couldn't leave? What was the danger, and what was tried first?"

Ask for this in writing

The division's written policy or procedure on seclusion and physical restraint; whether my child's school has a seclusion room; and whether my child has been restrained or secluded this school year, with the dates.

If you don't get it

The standards say division policies are to be shared with parents. If the school does not provide it, ask the superintendent's office in writing. For a specific incident, go to 8.4. The standards also require complaint and appeal processes to be "clearly communicated to parents/guardians" (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · what you were told happened · the exact word they used (held, escorted, quiet room) · who told you.

Your division may also have

Its own seclusion and restraint procedure, which may be stricter than the provincial one. The provincial one is the floor.

8.4 Your child was restrained or secluded: what you should get afterwards

You might be hearing

— "It was handled."

— "We didn't want to bother you at work."

— "We have those recorded at school."

— "If you'd like incidents reported daily, just let us know."

What's going on

Every use of restraint or seclusion triggers three things for you: notice the same school day, a detailed written record, and a chance to talk it through. You do not have to ask in advance to be told. If you learn about an incident days later, or from your child, the same-day step was missed.

What the rules say

Notice: "the principal is required to notify the child's/student's parents/guardians as soon as possible after the incident and on the same school day during which the incident occurred." Efforts to reach you "are required to be made and documented before the end of the school day."

Record: after each use, "detailed information regarding the use is to be documented." It includes what was tried first, attempts to de-escalate, the behaviour that led to it, how long it lasted, the techniques used, injuries, names of staff involved, and "efforts, including methods used, to notify parents/guardians, including dates and times." It goes to central administration within the division.

Debrief: staff debrief is to "occur and be documented within three days." "An opportunity to de-brief with parents/guardians and the child/student, where appropriate, is provided as soon as possible." Any existing behaviour plan is reviewed and updated.

Reporting outside the division: the Order's opening words say divisions "will be required to submit regular reports" on the use of seclusion rooms, to be reviewed by Alberta Education. No section of the standards sets out that duty, and no published provincial incident count was found.

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools (Appendix to MO 042/2019), pp.14 to 16, standards attached to a ministerial order; Ministerial Order 042/2019, opening recitals.

Say this

"I understand my child was held or put in a room today. I'd like the incident report, and a time this week to debrief with you."

Ask for this in writing

The incident report for [date], with each element the standards list; the record of efforts to reach me, with times; the date of the staff debrief; a date for my debrief; and the date the behaviour plan was reviewed.

If you don't get it

Ask for the report as part of your child's student record, or through an access request (see chapter 11). If incidents were logged but not reported to you, write to the principal listing the dates, then to the superintendent (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date and time you were told · by whom · how · what they said happened · report asked for on · debrief date.

8.5 They want your consent to a plan that includes restraint or seclusion

You might be hearing

— "We need you to sign the safety plan."

— "It's standard for all students in this program."

— "If you don't sign, we can't keep everyone safe."

— "It's just in case."

What's going on

A pre-planned plan is one where the school decides in advance that restraint or seclusion may be used with your child. That needs you involved in writing it and needs your informed consent. Informed consent means you have the information first, you agree in writing, and you can withdraw it.

Your consent covers planned use. The standards still allow restraint or seclusion in an unplanned emergency without it. Saying no to a seclusion room does not end the conversation. It starts the search for an equally safe alternative.

What the rules say

For pre-planned use, "it is required that parents/guardians are involved in the development of these plans and provide their informed consent."

Where a child has a history of crisis-level behaviour, or danger "can be reasonably predicted," the school is required to do an FBA with a trained professional, put positive supports in the child's plan, involve you, and seek

"written informed consent from parents or guardians." "If parents/guardians do not support the use of seclusion, involve them in determining if alternative options that are equally protective of the child/student and staff safety are reasonable."

"Recurrent use of seclusion and/or physical restraint is not to be a regular part of a child's/student's educational program." Any agreement is noted in a safety plan attached to the child's support plan (the standards call it an Instructional Support Plan, or ISP; Alberta's Guide to Education uses ISP and IPP as names for the same kind of plan, see 4.1).

Alberta's special education standards define informed consent as having all relevant information, agreeing in writing, and understanding that consent "may be withdrawn at any time."

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools (Appendix to MO 042/2019), pp.10, 14, 15, standards attached to a ministerial order. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4.

Say this

"I'm not signing today. I'd like the behaviour assessment this is based on, and to talk about alternatives that keep everyone safe."

Ask for this in writing

The draft plan; the FBA it is based on (date and who did it); the name of the trained professional consulted; the alternatives considered; and whether the plan is attached to the IPP.

If you don't get it

If you do not support seclusion, say so in writing and ask for the alternatives meeting the standards require. If a planned procedure is used without your consent, write to the principal and superintendent the same week (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · what you were asked to sign · whether you had the FBA · what you decided · alternatives discussed.

8.6 Time-out, the hallway, the office, the "calm room"

You might be hearing

— "He just had some time out of class."

— "She spent the afternoon in the office."

— "It's a sensory break, not a time-out."

— "It's our calm-down room."

What's going on

Time-out is a behaviour strategy: briefly cutting a child off from what they enjoy to reduce a behaviour. It comes in two kinds. Non-exclusion time-out happens inside the classroom. Exclusion time-out moves the child to a separate supervised space, like the office or library. A sensory break your child asks for is not time-out, and time-out is not seclusion. Different rules apply to each, so it matters which one it was.

Frequent time out of class is also lost teaching time. Ask what work goes with your child.

What the rules say

Alberta's time-out guidelines are guidance, not a standard. The document says it "provides guidance for school authorities," and its main list of conditions is introduced as what "is expected."

Before exclusion time-out is used for ongoing or recurrent behaviour, the guidelines expect parents to be involved and "informed written parental/guardian consent is obtained and documented in the child's/student's individual behaviour support plan (IBSP)." The space should be "unlocked and does not have a passive locking mechanism," and the child "visible and supervised at all times." "Seclusion rooms are not to be used for exclusion time-out."

Expected records: strategies tried first, the behaviour, "duration of time-out," "frequency of time-outs," and what was observed. Divisions are to have written time-out policies "clearly communicated to parents/guardians."

Source: Guidelines for Time-out in Alberta Schools, Alberta Education, November 2019, pp.9 to 15, guidance.

Say this

"When my child is taken out of class, where do they go, who's with them, is the door ever closed, and for how long?"

Ask for this in writing

The division's time-out policy; and for [date range], each date my child spent time out of class, how long, where, who was with them, and what work they did.

If you don't get it

If the space is locked, or your child cannot leave, ask in writing whether it is seclusion (see 8.3). If time out of class is frequent, ask for the behaviour plan to be reviewed (8.2) and for how missed teaching will be made up.

Write this down

Date · where · how long · who was with your child · what work was sent.

8.7 They keep calling you to come and get your child

You might be hearing

- "Can you come and pick him up?"
- "She's had a rough day, it's best she goes home."
- "We don't have the staff to keep him safe today."
- "It's not a suspension, just a reset at home."
- "His EA is away today."

What's going on

A pick-up call feels like an order. The Education Act lists when a student who must attend school is excused: sickness or another unavoidable cause, a religious holiday, a suspension, an expulsion, or a board excusal after the parent shows sufficient cause. "Go home for the rest of the day" is not on that list. So the useful question is: which one is this? If it is a suspension, the principal owes you written reasons (8.9). If it is not, ask what it is.

If your child is unwell, that is different: sickness is a listed reason to be away. Keep a log of every call. A run of early pick-ups adds up to a shortened day (8.8).

What the rules say

A student is excused from school only for sickness or another unavoidable cause, a religious holiday, a suspension, an expulsion, or where the board decides "the parent of the student has shown sufficient cause" and excuses the student. A board "shall make all reasonable efforts to ensure" a student attends. We found no provision allowing a school to send a well, unsuspended child home.

FSCD (Family Supports for Children with Disabilities, run by Assisted Living and Social Services) states that "Respite services are not intended to address care needs related to the ability of the school division to provide an appropriate program for a child." It allows respite only short-term, "pending the coordination of an education program."

Source: Education Act ss.7(1), 7(3), 7(4), 36, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. FSCD Policy Manual 7.5 and 8.2, read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026, provincial policy.

Say this

"Before I come, is this a suspension? If it is, I'll need the written report. If it isn't, what is it, and what's the plan for tomorrow?"

Ask for this in writing

For each early pick-up: the date, time of the call, who called, the reason, whether it was recorded as a suspension or an absence, and what work was sent. And the written plan to keep my child at school for the full day.

If you don't get it

If the calls keep coming, ask for a meeting and a written plan (see chapter 10). If pick-ups were recorded as absences, ask in writing for the attendance record to be corrected (see chapter 11). Then escalate (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · time of call · who called · reason given · suspension yes or no · time you picked up.

8.8 Your child is on a shortened or partial day

You might be hearing

— "We're going to try half days for now."

— "It's a modified schedule."

— "He can come in from nine to eleven."

— "It's just until we get staffing."

— "It's what's best for her right now."

What's going on

We read the whole Education Act, the In-person Learning Regulation and the 2004 Standards for Special Education looking for a power that lets a school set a shorter day for one child. We didn't find one. What we did find are three narrow ways a child can lawfully be out for part of a day, and each comes with limits:

— **Suspension from class periods.** A principal can suspend a student from one or more class periods. It can't run more than 5 school days unless expulsion is being recommended, and the principal has to report the circumstances to you in writing and offer a meeting. A "modified schedule" that runs for weeks doesn't fit inside that.

— **An excusal you ask for.** The board can excuse a student when the parent has shown sufficient cause. That route starts with you, not the school.

— **A ministerial exemption order.** Under the In-person Learning Regulation, the Minister can exempt a board, by order, from having to offer in-person learning to every student. In 2025 one division got an order during a labour strike that told it to try part-day attendance before moving some students with complex needs to full-time learning at home. That order and the one that replaced it were made for that strike only. Ask whether any order applies to your division now, and ask for its number.

If the school names something else, ask for the section number. That's the whole point: a short day should rest on a rule someone can point to.

Some parents agree to a short day as a stepping stone back. If you do, put the hours, the review date and the plan for full days in writing, so it stays a stepping stone.

What the rules say

A principal may suspend a student "from one or more class periods or courses" (s.36(3)(b)). The principal shall "report in writing to the student's parent all the circumstances respecting the suspension" and provide an opportunity to meet (s.36(4)). "A suspension may not exceed 5 school days, except in accordance with a recommendation for expulsion made by the principal under section 37" (s.36(5)).

The excusal applies where the board "determines that the parent of the student has shown sufficient cause as to why the student should not be required to attend school" and excuses the student "for a prescribed period of time" (s.7(4)(e) and (5)). A board "shall determine and make publicly available for each school year the days, dates and number of days of school operation" (s.60).

A board offering in-person learning may offer at-home learning "only if the board provides or continues to provide an option for in-person learning for each student at the student's regularly attended school" (In-person Learning Regulation s.2(1)). "The Minister may, by order, exempt a board" from that (s.2(3)). The regulation expires on May 31, 2027 (s.10).

The 2025 order said that before exempting a student, the board "shall make reasonable efforts to continue in-person learning for the student, including but not limited to, for part of a school day or school week" (MO 002/2025, Appendix clause 6). It was revoked by MO 012/2025. Both orders were made for one labour strike and ran until it ended or the Minister revoked them.

What we searched for and did not find: any provision in those three documents that sets up a shortened day for one child at the school's choice, caps one, requires your consent to one, or requires a plan to end one.

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says that where a student needs specialized medical procedures or life-saving medical care, "Reasonable limitations may be considered related to the student profile

and capacity, including attendance, stamina, readiness to learn, and continuity of programming." It does not say who decides or how (see 9.12).

Source: Education Act ss.7(4)(e), 7(5), 36(3) to (5), 60, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, read 23 October 2026. Law. In-person Learning Regulation, Alta Reg 13/2025, ss.2 and 10, current as of 1 September 2025, read 9 October 2026. Regulation. Ministerial Orders 002/2025 and 012/2025, read 28 September 2026. Ministerial orders, each limited to one strike. Standards for Special Education (2004), searched 23 October 2026. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, 5.3.1.1, guidance.

Say this

"Which section is the school relying on for a shortened day? If it's a suspension, I'd like the written report. If not, what's the written plan and date for full days?"

Ask for this in writing

The provision relied on; the start date and hours; who decided; the plan and dates for adding time back; what teaching covers the missed hours; and how the time is recorded on attendance.

If you don't get it

Ask for the decision in writing. A decision that significantly affects a student's education can be appealed to the board, and the Act treats a failure to decide as a decision too. A human rights complaint has a one-year limit. Both are in chapter 12. If it's a suspension, see 8.9.

Write this down

Date it started · hours · who decided · the provision they named · date promised for full days.

8.9 Your child has been suspended

You might be hearing

— "He's suspended for the rest of the week."

— "It's zero tolerance."

— "The code of conduct is the code of conduct."

— "Don't bring her back until we've met."

What's going on

A suspension is a formal step with rules. A teacher can suspend from one class. Only a principal can suspend from school, from classes, from the bus or from an activity. The principal must tell you right away, put all the circumstances in writing, and offer to meet. A suspension cannot go past 5 school days unless the principal recommends expulsion (8.10).

Every division's code of conduct must say its consequences take account of a child's age, maturity and individual circumstances. Ask how your child's disability was taken into account.

What the rules say

A principal who suspends "shall (a) immediately inform the student's parent of the suspension, (b) report in writing to the student's parent all the circumstances respecting the suspension, and (c) provide an opportunity to meet with the student's parent." "A suspension may not exceed 5 school days, except in accordance with a recommendation for expulsion." The Act does not say your child's return depends on a meeting.

The code of conduct's consequences "must take account of the student's age, maturity and individual circumstances," and must ensure support for students affected by the behaviour and for the student who engaged in it.

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says: "When behaviour is connected to a disability or protected characteristic, decisions must be reasonable, rights-aligned, and focused on access to education."

Source: Education Act ss.36(1) to (5), 33(3)(d)(iv), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, 5.3.1.2, guidance.

Say this

"Can I have the written report of everything about this suspension, and a time to meet? And what's the end date?"

Ask for this in writing

The written report of all the circumstances; the start and end dates; which ground in section 36(1) and which part of the code of conduct; how my

child's age, maturity and individual circumstances, including their disability, were taken into account; and what work will be sent.

If you don't get it

If a suspension runs past 5 school days with no expulsion recommendation, point to section 36(5) in writing. A suspension that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed to the board after you use the school's dispute process. A pattern of suspensions linked to disability can also go to the Human Rights Commission. See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · who suspended · from what (school, class, bus, activity) · number of days · reason given · date written report received.

8.10 The principal is recommending expulsion

You might be hearing

— "I'm recommending expulsion to the board."

— "He'll stay suspended until the board decides."

— "We can't meet his needs here."

— "Expelled means no school."

What's going on

Only the board (the trustees) can expel, and only if the principal recommends it. Your child stays suspended until the board decides, and the board has 10 school days from the first day of the suspension. You and your child can make your case to the board. Expulsion does not end schooling: an expelled child still gets a supervised education program and supports.

The grounds listed in section 37 are about the student's conduct. "We can't meet his needs" is not among them. If that is the school's view, the Act has a different process (see 9.12).

What the rules say

The grounds are wilful, blatant and repeated refusal to follow student responsibilities or the code of conduct, conduct "injurious to the physical or mental well-being of others," or distributing an intimate image. The

principal must report to the board in writing. "The student and the student's parent may make representations to the board." The board decides "within 10 school days after the initial date of the suspension."

If expelled, the board must tell you in writing of any conditions and "of the right to request a review under section 43," and must ensure "a supervised education program" and supports. A request for the Minister's review must be made "within 60 days." The Minister asks whether the board's decision "was reasonable in the circumstances."

Source: Education Act ss.37, 43, 44, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"I want to make representations to the board. When does it meet, and can I have the principal's written report to the board?"

Ask for this in writing

The principal's written report to the board; the date and format of the board's hearing; the date by which the board must decide; and, if expelled, the written conditions and the program and supports my child will receive, from what date.

If you don't get it

If the board expels, you can ask the Minister to review it within 60 days of being told. Put the request in writing. See chapter 12.

Write this down

First day of suspension · date of recommendation · 10-school-day deadline · date of board decision · program offered.

8.11 Your child was left out of a field trip or activity

You might be hearing

— "It's not safe for him to come on this one."

— "We don't have an EA for the trip."

— "You're welcome to come along as his support."

— "She can stay back and help in the library."

— "The start-of-year form covers outings."

What's going on

Two different things get called "he can't come." One is a consequence for behaviour. The Act calls that a suspension from a school-related activity, and the suspension duties apply (8.9). The other is a gap in support. That is a question of accommodation, and disability is a protected ground under Alberta's human rights law.

Supervision on school field trips is not FSCD's job. Its manual excludes it.

What the rules say

A principal may suspend a student "from any school-related activity." The principal must then inform you, put the circumstances in writing and offer to meet.

No person shall deny or discriminate in "services ... customarily available to the public" because of physical or mental disability. "Mental disability" includes "any mental disorder, developmental disorder or learning disorder."

We found no Alberta rule that makes a parent's attendance a condition of a child going on a trip.

FSCD community support cannot be provided "for the purposes of support and supervision in educational activities that take place during regular school hours (for example, school field trips, lunch time, recess)."

Source: Education Act s.36(3)(d), (4), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Alberta Human Rights Act ss.4, 44, current as of 1 April 2023. Law. FSCD Policy Manual 8.7B, provincial policy.

Say this

"Is this a suspension from the trip, or is it about support? If it's support, what would it take for my child to go, and who's arranging it?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether this is a suspension under section 36(3)(d); if not, the reason; what support was considered; what my child will do instead that day; and a trip-specific consent form for each trip, stating the activity, timing, supervision and transport.

If you don't get it

Appeal to the board, and consider a human rights complaint, which must be made within one year (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date of trip · reason given · who decided · what was offered instead · trip consent form received yes or no.

8.12 Police or emergency services came to the school

You might be hearing

— "We had to call the police."

— "We called 911 for everyone's safety."

— "It's a threat assessment, it's protocol."

— "We can't tell you who else was involved."

What's going on

Schools can call police or emergency services. Some divisions also belong to a community threat assessment protocol, often called a VTRA (violence threat risk assessment), shared with police, health services and other agencies. These are local agreements, and each one reads differently. Ask for your division's.

If your child was held or put in a room before help arrived, the restraint and seclusion rules apply as well (8.4).

What the rules say

We found no Alberta law, regulation or standard on when a school calls police about a student, or how parents are told. That means your division's procedure and any local protocol are what govern it.

The seclusion standards say restraint or seclusion may be used "as a last resort emergency or crisis procedure to maintain safety before contacting emergency responders, if necessary."

One regional protocol we read, signed by school divisions, police and health partners (2022), states: "In the case of children/youth, parents/guardians, or caregivers must be notified pending any unique circumstances." Yours may differ.

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools (Appendix to MO 042/2019), p.11, standards attached to a ministerial order. A regional community violence threat risk assessment protocol, 2022, published by an Alberta school division, local protocol.

Say this

"Who called, at what time, and why? When was I called? Was my child held before they arrived, and who was with my child the whole time?"

Ask for this in writing

The time of the call and who made it; the reason; the time I was called; whether restraint or seclusion was used; whether a threat assessment was opened and under which protocol; and a copy of that protocol.

If you don't get it

Ask for the school's records through an access request (see chapter 11). If you were not told, or told late, write to the superintendent (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · time of call · who called · who came · time you were told · what your child said.

Your division may also have

A threat assessment protocol and a procedure on police in schools. Ask for both.

8.13 Your child came home hurt

You might be hearing

— "That mark was already there this morning."

— "We didn't see it happen."

— "Staff blocked him, nobody grabbed him."

— "There's no report because it wasn't an incident."

What's going on

An unexplained injury is the moment records matter most, and the first day is when they are easiest to make. The same day: take dated photos, have your child's doctor see and record the injury, and ask the school in writing what happened. Write down what your child says, word for word, as a lead for your questions.

Ask whether any physical contact was a restraint (8.3). If it was, the full incident record is required.

What the rules say

Where restraint or seclusion is used, the incident record must include "injuries to self or others," and you must be told the same school day.

We found no Alberta law or standard requiring a school to write an injury report for every student injury, or to give one to parents. That means it depends on your division's procedure.

You may review your child's student record and ask for a copy, and ask the board to fix information you believe is "inaccurate or incomplete."

Source: Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools (Appendix to MO 042/2019), pp.15 to 16, standards attached to a ministerial order. Education Act s.56(3), (4), (6), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"My child came home with a mark on their arm. What happened, who was there, and is there a report or video? Please keep any video."

Ask for this in writing

What happened, when and where, and which staff were present; whether any restraint was used; a copy of any incident or injury report; whether video exists, that it be kept, and when it was reviewed.

If you don't get it

Ask for the records through an access request (see chapter 11). Then write to the superintendent with your photos and the doctor's note listed (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · time you saw the mark · photos taken · doctor seen on · who you asked · their account.

8.14 Your child is being bullied

You might be hearing

- "Kids will be kids."
- "It's a conflict, not bullying."
- "We can't discuss the other student."
- "They were both involved."

What's going on

Bullying has a definition in Alberta law, and every school board has to have a code of conduct that deals with it. Children with disabilities can be targeted, and can also be blamed when they react. The code has to cover both: support for the child who was hurt, and support for the child who did it.

The Act's wording changed on 1 September 2026. Codes now must also deal with a duty to refrain from violence. Ask for this year's version.

What the rules say

Bullying "means repeated and hostile or demeaning behaviour by an individual in the school community where the behaviour is intended to cause harm, fear or distress," including psychological harm.

A board must have a code of conduct "that addresses bullying behaviour." It must be public, "reviewed every year," given to parents, address the grounds in the Alberta Human Rights Act (which include disability), and ensure "support is provided for students who are impacted by inappropriate behaviour." Students must "refrain from, report and not tolerate bullying."

The 2026 amendments replaced "welcoming, caring, respectful and safe learning environment" with "safe and caring environment that fosters and maintains respectful and responsible behaviours," and added a student responsibility to "refrain from engaging in violence of any kind at school."

Source: Education Act s.1(1)(d), consolidation current as of 11 December 2025, not amended in 2026; ss.31(e), 31(e.1), 33(2), 33(3), consolidation current as of 1 September 2026, as amended by SA 2026 c13 (Bill 25), in force 1 September 2026. Law.

Say this

"This has happened four times since September. Under your code of conduct, what support is my child getting, and what's the plan to stop it?"

Ask for this in writing

This year's code of conduct and the date it was last reviewed; the school's written plan to stop the behaviour toward my child; the support my child is getting; and the dates of incidents the school has recorded.

If you don't get it

Write to the principal, then the superintendent (see chapter 12). If the bullying is about your child's disability, a human rights complaint is also possible, within one year.

Write this down

Date · what happened · who saw it · who you told · what they said they would do.

Chapter 9: Health and medical needs at school

Who is responsible for your child's medical safety at school, what the few binding rules require, and what to ask for where there are no rules.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/9

Turn here when you're hearing

— "Medical needs are the parent's responsibility." → 9.1

— "We're not medical professionals." → 9.1

— "We've put an alert on the file." → 9.2

— "Can you get us a letter from the doctor?" → 9.2

— "Only the office can give medication." → 9.3

— "We missed the lunchtime dose, but he seemed fine." → 9.3

— "The EpiPen is in the office." → 9.4

— "We follow the provincial diabetes guidelines." → 9.5

— "Staff don't do insulin." → 9.5

— "We don't have a seizure policy." → 9.6

— "None of our staff are trained for that." → 9.7

— "Staff could be sued." → 9.8

— "We'll call 911 and then call you." → 9.9

— "Whatever's in the system goes with him." → 9.9

— "We updated the plan." → 9.10

— "FSCD should cover that." → 9.11

— "That's a nursing task." → 9.11

— "She can't be here until the nurse is in place." → 9.12

— "The emergency plan is for the whole school." → 9.13

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
9.1	Who is responsible for your child's

Entry	Title
	medical safety at school
9.2	There's "an alert on the file" but no plan
9.3	Medication at school
9.4	Life-threatening allergies
9.5	Type 1 diabetes
9.6	Seizures
9.7	"None of our staff are trained for that"
9.8	"Staff could be liable"
9.9	When 911 is called: what goes with your child
9.10	Something in the health plan changed and nobody told you
9.11	Nursing-level care: whose job is it at school?
9.12	Kept home because medical needs "can't be met"
9.13	The school's emergency plan doesn't mention your child

9.1 Who is responsible for your child's medical safety at school

You might be hearing

— "Medical needs are the parent's responsibility."

— "We're not medical professionals."

— "We'll do our best."

— "That's between you and the doctor."

What's going on

Alberta's starting point is that parents are mainly responsible for their child's medical needs. That is true, and it is not the whole picture. School boards also have written duties: procedures for medical information and medication, and training for staff when health supports are needed. One condition, life-threatening allergy, has its own law (9.4).

Beyond that, most day-to-day medical tasks at school are set by your division, not the province. So the first job is finding your division's written procedure.

What the rules say

Alberta's page for families says: "Parents and guardians are primarily responsible for the medical needs of their children."

School boards "must" have "written procedures for accessing, recording, and sharing medical information and for storing and/or administering medications." When boards are "required to administer health-related support services to students in schools," they must "provide staff with training by qualified professionals or other individuals with expertise, including parents." An IPP must include "relevant medical information" and "coordinated support services (including health-related), if required" (see 4.2).

These Standards apply to public, separate and francophone boards, not charter schools.

We found no province-wide rule naming who carries out routine medical tasks at school. That means the answer is in your division's procedure.

Source: Students with medical needs, alberta.ca, published 19 May 2026. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 6(e), 6(f) and Definitions p.4, ministerial order standard (MO 015/2004).

Say this

"I know the medical side starts with me. From the school I need the written procedure for medication and medical information, and who here is trained for my child's needs."

Ask for this in writing

The division's written procedure for medical information and medication (Standard 6(e)), with its date; and the names or roles of staff trained for my child's needs, who trained them, and when (Standard 6(f)).

If you don't get it

The Standards say boards "must." Ask the superintendent's office in writing for the procedure. See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · procedure name and date · who is trained · training date · who you asked.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on medication and medical treatment. Ask for it by name.

9.2 There's "an alert on the file" but no plan

You might be hearing

- "We've put an alert on the file."
- "Can you get us a letter from the doctor?"
- "It's in the system."
- "Not every child needs a care plan."

What's going on

An alert tells staff a condition exists. A plan tells them what to do, who does it, and what happens in an emergency. Alberta's diabetes guidelines are the only provincial document that describes such a plan in detail. They call it an individual care plan (ICP), with two parts: daily care and an emergency plan. Divisions use the same idea for other conditions under different names: health care plan, emergency response plan.

When you send a doctor's letter, ask for written confirmation it was received. Medical letters can sit unread in an inbox.

What the rules say

The diabetes guidelines (guidance) say a care plan's purpose is to set out "what needs to be done to support a child's/student's medical needs, when it must be done, by whom, and what to do during an emergency." "The ICP should have two components: a daily management plan and an emergency plan." It should name staff roles, emergency contacts, where emergency kits are, and "when the ICP is to be reviewed." "ICPs can form part of a child's or student's individualized program plan (IPP)." The principal should keep a copy in the student record. The guidelines also say "Not all children/students may require an ICP."

For anaphylaxis, the law requires "a readily accessible emergency procedure for each student" (9.4).

The Student Record Regulation, which is law, says the student record must include "any health information that the parent of the student or child or the student or child wishes to be placed on the student record." So you can ask in writing for your doctor's letter to be placed on the record.

Source: Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, Alberta Education, February 2019, pp.7 to 9 and 14, guidance. Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act s.3(c), current as of 1 September 2025. Law. Student Record Regulation, Alta Reg 97/2019, s.2(1)(p), current as of 1 September 2025. Regulation (law).

Say this

"An alert isn't a plan. Can we write a health care plan together that says what staff do, who does it, and what happens in an emergency? When can we meet?"

Ask for this in writing

Written confirmation that my doctor's letter dated [date] was received and placed on the student record; and a written care plan with a daily part and an emergency part, the named roles, who is trained, where it is kept, and its review date, with a copy to me.

If you don't get it

Ask that the care plan be added to the IPP as a coordinated health-related support (see 4.2). Then write to the superintendent (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date letter delivered · how · receipt confirmed by · plan meeting date · plan received on.

9.3 Medication at school

You might be hearing

— "Staff can't give medication without the form."

— "Only the office can give medication."

— "It has to be in the original pharmacy bottle."

— "We missed the lunchtime dose, but he seemed fine."

What's going on

Medication at school runs on your division's written procedure. Alberta requires each board to have one, but does not set what it says: who gives medication, where it is kept, how doses are recorded, or whether staff may decline. Ask for yours and read it before the first dose.

What the rules say

School boards "must" have "written procedures for ... storing and/or administering medications."

We found no province-wide rule on who gives routine medication at school, or on telling parents about a missed or late dose. That means the answer depends on your division's procedure, and on what you ask for in writing.

So ask for your own division's medication procedure. The 2004 Standards require every board to have written procedures for storing and administering medications, so there will be one to ask for.

For diabetes, the guidelines expect parents to supply medication and supplies, "appropriately labelled, maintained and/or replaced before their expiration date."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 6(e), ministerial order standard. Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, February 2019, p.13, guidance.

Say this

"Can I have the division's medication procedure? And please tell me the same day if a dose is missed, late or refused."

Ask for this in writing

The medication procedure; who gives my child's medication and who covers when they are away; where it is stored; how each dose is recorded; same-day notice of any missed, late, refused or extra dose; and a copy of the dose record for [dates].

If you don't get it

Standard 6(e) is a "must." Ask the superintendent's office for the procedure in writing (see chapter 12). If a dose was missed and you were not told, ask for the dose record (see chapter 11).

Write this down

Date · form submitted · who gives it · where it's kept · any missed dose and when you were told.

9.4 Life-threatening allergies

You might be hearing

— "We're nut-aware, not nut-free."

— "The EpiPen is in the office."

— "Only trained staff can give it."

— "The substitute didn't know."

What's going on

This is the one medical condition with its own Alberta law for schools. The board must have a policy, train all its regular staff, keep a file on your child, have an emergency procedure for your child, and keep at least one spare auto-injector (an EpiPen or similar) in every school. In a reaction, any regular employee may give epinephrine even without prior sign-off.

Your side: tell the school on enrolment and keep the file current. A file that is out of date removes the pre-authorized route.

What the rules say

Every board "shall establish and maintain an anaphylaxis policy." It must include "mandatory regular training on dealing with life-threatening allergies for all employees," and a file for every student with "current treatments, copies of any prescriptions, any instructions from health professionals and a current emergency contact list." Each school's risk reduction plan must include "a readily accessible emergency procedure for each student." A board "shall ensure that a minimum of one epinephrine auto-injector is maintained" in each school.

"Even if not preauthorized to do so ... an employee may administer an epinephrine auto-injector" if they believe a reaction is happening. "Employee" means a board employee "who regularly works at the school." Good-faith responses are protected unless there is gross negligence. "Parents and students are responsible for ensuring that the information ... remains current."

The Act covers public, separate, francophone, charter and independent schools.

Source: Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act, SA 2019 c.P-30.6, ss.1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, current as of 1 September 2025. Law.

Say this

"Can I see my child's file and the risk reduction plan? Where is my child's emergency procedure kept, and where are the auto-injectors?"

Ask for this in writing

The board's anaphylaxis policy; my child's entry in the school's risk reduction plan and emergency procedure; the date staff were last trained; and where the stock and my child's own auto-injectors are kept, including on trips.

If you don't get it

These are "shall" duties in a statute. Write to the superintendent quoting the section (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · policy received · last training date · where auto-injectors are kept · date you updated the file.

9.5 Type 1 diabetes

You might be hearing

— "We follow the provincial diabetes guidelines."

— "Staff don't do insulin."

— "She's old enough to manage it herself."

— "We need you to come in at lunch."

What's going on

Alberta's diabetes guidelines (2019) are guidance, not law. They set out roles and a care plan, and expect children to manage their own care where they can. They do not say who gives insulin or treats a low when a child cannot do it alone. The word glucagon (an emergency medicine for a severe low) does not appear in them.

The guidelines also tell schools to be aware of "Schedule 7.1 of the Government Organization Act," which used to hold Alberta's list of restricted health activities. Since 31 March 2023, that list sits in Part 0.1 of the Health Professions Act. Treat that line as out of date.

What the rules say

Children should, "wherever possible and appropriate, take primary responsibility for the management of their medical needs." School authorities should "ensure that appropriate personnel and alternatives are assigned the responsibility to support the needs" of students with diabetes, and "make available the appropriate training."

Principals should co-create the care plan, "ensure that an emergency plan for responding to medical emergencies is included," make sure staff, "bus drivers and volunteers participate in necessary training," tell off-site activity providers, and debrief after emergencies. Schools should provide "a private and sanitary place to test blood and inject insulin" and allow "meals and snacks when needed." "All children/students that require support with Type 1 diabetes in schools are to have an emergency plan as part of their ICP."

Source: Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, Alberta Education, February 2019, pp.8, 10 to 15, guidance.

Say this

"The guidelines say the division assigns people and alternatives to support my child. Who is assigned, what are they trained to do, and who covers when they're away?"

Ask for this in writing

My child's care plan with its emergency plan; the named roles and backup; training dates; the private place for testing; and arrangements for the bus and field trips.

If you don't get it

Ask for the plan to be added to the IPP (see 4.2). If your child's access to school depends on you coming in, see 9.12. Escalate in writing (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · who is assigned · backup · training date · plan review date.

9.6 Seizures

You might be hearing

— "We don't have a seizure policy."

— "Staff can't give rescue medication."

— "We'll call 911 and you."

— "We'd need a doctor's form first."

What's going on

Alberta has no provincial document on seizures at school that we could find. Plans are made locally, school by school. That makes the care plan (9.2) and the training question (9.7) the whole of your protection.

Your child's doctor or neurologist writes the medical instructions. The school's part is to put them into a plan: what a seizure looks like for your child, when to time it, when to call 911, any rescue medication, who is trained to give it, and what goes on the bus and on trips.

What the rules say

We found no Alberta law, standard or guidance on seizure care in schools. Alberta's page on students with medical needs does not mention seizures.

The general Standards still apply: written procedures for medical information and medication, and staff training "by qualified professionals or other individuals with expertise, including parents" when health-related supports are needed.

Alberta's human rights law names epilepsy in its definition of physical disability.

Source: Students with medical needs, alberta.ca, published 19 May 2026. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 6(e), 6(f),

ministerial order standard. Alberta Human Rights Act s.44, current as of 1 April 2023. Law.

Say this

"I have a seizure plan from my child's doctor. Who here will be trained on it, including the rescue medication, and who covers when they're away?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation the seizure plan was received and is attached to the care plan and IPP; names or roles of trained staff and the training date; where rescue medication is kept; and what goes with my child on the bus and on trips.

If you don't get it

Point to Standard 6(f) in writing. If your child is kept from school or activities because of seizures, see 9.12 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date plan delivered · receipt confirmed by · trained staff · training date.

9.7 "None of our staff are trained for that"

You might be hearing

- "None of our staff are trained for that."
- "We'd need training first."
- "It's not in the EA's job description."
- "Training is booked for later in the year."

What's going on

Training is the board's job when the school has to deliver health-related support. Parents can be part of it: the Standards name parents as people with expertise. What no rule sets is a deadline. So the questions are who, by when, and what happens until then.

What the rules say

When boards are "required to administer health-related support services to students in schools," they must "provide staff with training by qualified professionals or other individuals with expertise, including parents."

For anaphylaxis, training is "mandatory regular training ... for all employees."

For diabetes, school authorities should "make available the appropriate training."

We found no Alberta rule setting how soon training must happen. That means you ask for a date.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 6(f), ministerial order standard. Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act s.2(2)(c), current as of 1 September 2025. Law. Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, February 2019, p.13, guidance.

Say this

"Who will train staff, by what date, and what's the plan for my child until then? I'm happy to help with the training."

Ask for this in writing

The name or role of the trainer; the date; which staff will be trained; and the written interim plan until training is done.

If you don't get it

Write to the principal and superintendent quoting Standard 6(f) (see chapter 12). If your child is kept home until training happens, see 9.12.

Write this down

Date · who will train · date promised · staff to be trained · interim plan.

9.8 "Staff could be liable"

You might be hearing

— "Staff could be sued."

— "We can't take that risk."

— "Our insurance doesn't allow it."

— "Good Samaritan doesn't cover us for that."

What's going on

Alberta's Good Samaritan law, the Emergency Medical Aid Act, protects a person who voluntarily gives emergency first aid at the scene, unless they are grossly negligent. Its protection is tied to an accident or other emergency, at the immediate scene. The Act does not mention planned daily care, like a scheduled dose or procedure. We found no Alberta law giving staff protection for planned care at school. That gap may be the reason behind a refusal.

Insurance and liability rules are your division's. Ask for the exact rule behind the answer.

What the rules say

A person other than a doctor, nurse or listed health professional who "voluntarily renders emergency first aid assistance" that "is rendered at the immediate scene of the accident or emergency" is "not liable for damages ... unless it is established that the injuries or death were caused by gross negligence."

For anaphylaxis, "No action lies" for anything done "in good faith in response to an anaphylactic reaction" under that Act, unless caused by gross negligence.

Source: Emergency Medical Aid Act, RSA 2000 c.E-7, s.2, current as of 16 December 2009. Law. Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act s.8, current as of 1 September 2025. Law.

Say this

"If liability is the reason, can I have that in writing, with the policy or insurance term it comes from? Then we can work out who can do it."

Ask for this in writing

The reason staff will not do the task; the procedure, policy or insurance term it is based on; and the alternative arrangement for my child.

If you don't get it

Ask the superintendent's office (see chapter 12). If the task needs a nurse, see 9.11.

Write this down

Date · task refused · reason given · rule named · alternative offered.

9.9 When 911 is called: what goes with your child

You might be hearing

- "We'll call 911 and then call you."
- "The office will print his information for the paramedics."
- "Whatever's in the system goes with him."
- "Someone will go with her if we have coverage."

What's going on

No provincial rule says what a school hands paramedics or who rides with your child. Staff can only pass on what the school has on file. If the medical information in the school's record is wrong or out of date, what goes with your child may be wrong too (see 4.7). Check that page now, while nothing is happening.

What the rules say

We found no Alberta law, standard or guidance on what a school gives paramedics, who accompanies a child, or the order of calls.

For anaphylaxis, the law requires an emergency procedure for each student, "including emergency contact information."

For diabetes, the emergency plan in the care plan "is to be followed," emergency responders "should be contacted as necessary and parents/guardians are to be notified of emergencies involving their child as early as possible."

Source: Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act s.3(c), current as of 1 September 2025. Law. Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, February 2019, p.11, guidance.

Say this

"If my child needs an ambulance, what exactly do you hand the paramedics, who goes with my child, and how fast am I called? Can I see that page today?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of exactly what would be given to paramedics today; who would go with my child; the order of calls; and correction of anything that doesn't match my registration form and the care plan, by [date].

If you don't get it

Use 4.7 to get the medical information corrected. If the school cannot say what goes with your child, ask for it to be written into the care plan (9.2), then escalate (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · what's on the emergency page · errors found · date corrected.

9.10 Something in the health plan changed and nobody told you

You might be hearing

- "We updated the plan."
- "That's no longer our practice."
- "We took that equipment out of the classroom."
- "We'll need a new doctor's letter for that."

What's going on

A care plan, or the health part of an IPP, can be changed. But removing a medical instruction changes what staff will do in an emergency. You should hear about it before it happens, not find it by comparing versions. Keep every version you are given.

What the rules say

We found no Alberta rule requiring a school to tell parents before it changes a health care plan. That means you set the expectation in writing.

The diabetes guidelines (guidance) describe the plan as built together: "Partners, including parents/guardian and child/student, where appropriate, determine roles and responsibilities." The plan includes parent consent, and is reviewed "annually, when care needs change or based on a review cycle specified in the ICP." Parents are to notify the school of changes "in writing."

Health information you want on the student record must be placed there (Student Record Regulation s.2(1)(p)). Send each medical instruction in writing and ask that it be placed on the record.

Where the health plan is part of the IPP, teachers must involve parents and get "written informed parental consent on IPPs" (see 4.6 and 4.8).

Source: Guidelines for Supporting Students with Type 1 Diabetes in Schools, February 2019, pp.8, 9, 12, guidance. Student Record Regulation, Alta Reg 97/2019, s.2(1)(p), current as of 1 September 2025. Regulation (law). Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), ministerial order standard.

Say this

"This instruction was in the plan and now it isn't. Who removed it, when, and on whose medical advice? Until we've talked, please follow the plan I agreed to."

Ask for this in writing

The date of the change; who made it; the health professional's advice it was based on; copies of both versions; and that no medical instruction be changed in future without notice to me first.

If you don't get it

Say in writing that you do not consent to the change. If equipment or a routine was stopped, ask who decided and on what basis. Then escalate (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date you noticed · what changed · versions compared · who you asked · their answer.

9.11 Nursing-level care: whose job is it at school?

You might be hearing

— "FSCD should cover that."

— "That's a nursing task."

— "The school nurse only does immunizations."

— "Our EAs can't do medical procedures."

What's going on

Three systems each point at another. FSCD (run by Assisted Living and Social Services) says nursing-level care comes from the health system, and FSCD does not fund support during school hours. Alberta's new student support framework says medical treatment is mainly the health system's job. The one school health program listing we read describes public health nursing, immunizations and health promotion, not individual care. No document we found says who does nursing-level care for a child during the school day.

So ask both sides, in writing, and get the answers on paper.

What the rules say

FSCD: "Nursing level of care (Registered Nurse or Licensed Practical Nurse) is provided by the health authority. The FSCD program cannot provide nursing level of care."

Student Support Policy Framework (guidance): medical supports include "interventions, monitoring, or treatment that are the primary responsibility of Primary and Preventative Health Services, through Primary Care Alberta, and Hospital and Surgical Health Services, through Alberta Health Services."

An Alberta Health Services listing for a School Health Program in the Calgary area describes "public health nursing to support all schools in Calgary and surrounding areas" and immunizations. It does not mention care for individual students. Programs in other areas may differ.

We found no Alberta instrument naming who performs nursing-level care at school.

Source: FSCD Policy Manual 7.5, read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026, provincial policy. Student Support Policy Framework,

Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026, s.6, 7.2.1, guidance. Alberta Health Services, School Health Program listing, read 23 October 2026.

Say this

"FSCD says nursing-level care comes from the health system. Has the school asked the health service to be part of my child's plan? Who's making that call, and by when?"

Ask for this in writing

From the school: who contacted which health service, when, and the answer; and who does each task in the meantime. From the health service: whether it will provide or train for the task at school.

If you don't get it

Ask your local home care or public health nursing service whether it can provide or train for the task. Health Link at 811 offers help finding your way in the health system and lists home care among common requests. For FSCD, see chapter 16. If your child is kept home meanwhile, see 9.12 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · task needed · who the school contacted · health service's answer · interim plan.

9.12 Kept home because medical needs "can't be met"

You might be hearing

- "She can't be here until the nurse is in place."
- "Until staff are trained, he'll need to stay home."
- "You'll have to come in to do the procedure."
- "It's a reasonable limitation."

What's going on

Being kept home for medical reasons is a shortened or missed day by another name, and the same Education Act logic applies (8.8). The Act lets a

child be away for sickness. Its list of reasons to be excused does not include "the school isn't ready."

If the board's position is that it cannot meet your child's needs at all, the Act has a separate process for that. Ask whether the board has used it.

What the rules say

We found no published Alberta document addressing a child being kept from school because medical needs cannot be met. Nothing found permits it either.

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says that where specialized medical procedures or life-saving medical care are needed, "Reasonable limitations may be considered related to the student profile and capacity, including attendance, stamina, readiness to learn, and continuity of programming." It does not say who decides, for how long, or how parents are involved.

If a board decides a student needs supports "that cannot be met in an education program" it can provide, it "shall refer the matter to a Complex Education Needs Tribunal." We could not confirm that any such tribunal has ever been set up.

Under human rights law, a contravention is treated as not having happened only if the person responsible shows it "was reasonable and justifiable in the circumstances."

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, 22 October 2026, 5.3.1.1, guidance. Education Act ss.7(4), 40(1), (2), (7), 43, consolidation current as of 1 September 2026. Law. Alberta Human Rights Act s.11, current as of 1 April 2023. Law.

Say this

"Which section of the Education Act allows my child to be kept home? What's the written plan, with dates, to have them back full-time?"

Ask for this in writing

The provision relied on; who decided; the dates; what teaching my child gets meanwhile; the plan and date for return; and whether the board has made a determination under section 40.

If you don't get it

Appeal to the board, and ask the Minister to review a decision about specialized supports within 60 days. A human rights complaint must be made within one year. See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date kept home from · reason given · who decided · provision named · return date promised.

9.13 The school's emergency plan doesn't mention your child

You might be hearing

- "The emergency plan is for the whole school."
- "Everyone follows the same lockdown procedure."
- "Her EA will handle it."
- "We'll deal with it if it happens."

What's going on

A new provincial order requires every school to have a written plan for critical emergencies: evacuation, shelter-in-place, lockdown and similar events. The order does not mention disability, medication or individual student plans. So the question is how your child's care plan fits inside the school's: who stays with your child, where their medication and kit go, and how a child who uses a wheelchair or cannot follow spoken instructions gets out.

What the rules say

School authorities must set up a critical emergency framework "no later than January 4, 2027," and each school must develop its plan "no later than April 5, 2027." Both must be communicated "to staff members, students, and parents annually" and reviewed annually. The school authority's framework must include evacuation, shelter-in-place, lockdown, "hold and secure" and "all clear" protocols, "communication protocols with health and emergency services," and reunification with families.

The order's text does not mention disability, medication or individual plans.

Source: Ministerial Order 029/2026, School Critical Emergency Standards, Education and Childcare, dated 24 September 2026, Appendix ss.2 to 7, ministerial order standard.

Say this

"In a lockdown or evacuation, who is responsible for my child, and where do their medication and plan go? Can we write that into their care plan?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's critical emergency plan once it is in place; and a written addition to my child's care plan or IPP covering evacuation, shelter-in-place and lockdown, naming the responsible adult and where medication goes.

If you don't get it

Ask again after 5 April 2027, when every school's plan must exist. Then escalate (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · plan received · who is responsible for your child · where medication goes · date added to care plan.

Chapter 10: Meetings

How to get ready for a school meeting, what to do in the room, how to record it, and how to make what was agreed stick afterwards.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/10

Turn here when you're hearing

- "We just want to touch base." → 10.1
- "We'll send everything after the meeting." → 10.1
- "It'll just be a few of us from the team." → 10.2
- "This is a meeting for parents and staff only." → 10.3
- "Your child can translate for you." → 10.4
- "We'll go over it all at the meeting." → 10.5
- "That's not on the agenda today." → 10.6
- "Let's park that for another time." → 10.6
- "We all met beforehand to get on the same page." → 10.7
- "Their teacher couldn't make it, but I can speak for them." → 10.7
- "The division team has a few recommendations." → 10.8
- "We're doing everything we can." → 10.9
- "I'll have to check on that." → 10.9
- "You seem upset. Should we take a break?" → 10.10
- "Can you just sign here before you go?" → 10.11
- "Are you recording this?" → 10.12
- "We don't allow recording in our meetings." → 10.12
- "We'll send a summary." → 10.13
- "We don't take minutes at these meetings." → 10.14
- "Those are just my own notes." → 10.14

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
10.1	You've been called to a meeting and

Entry	Title
	don't know what it's about
10.2	You don't know who'll be in the room, or who can decide anything
10.3	You want to bring someone with you
10.4	You need an interpreter, or someone to explain the words
10.5	"We'll go over it at the meeting"
10.6	"That's not on the agenda today"
10.7	You're outnumbered, and some of them have never met your child
10.8	A case conference with division staff
10.9	You keep getting answers that aren't answers
10.10	Keeping your own notes, and keeping your footing
10.11	They want you to sign something at the table
10.12	Recording the meeting
10.13	After the meeting: the follow-up email
10.14	Asking for the minutes or notes

10.1 You've been called to a meeting and don't know what it's about

You might be hearing

— "We just want to touch base."

— "Nothing formal, just a chat."

— "We'll send everything after the meeting."

— "Can you come in tomorrow at 3?"

What's going on

You can't prepare for a meeting if you don't know what it's for. Ask for three things before you go: the agenda (the list of topics, in order), any draft documents that will be discussed (a draft IPP, a behaviour plan, an assessment report), and what decision, if any, they expect to make.

A meeting that is "just a chat" can still end with a decision about your child's day. Knowing that in advance is the difference between taking part in the decision and hearing about it.

What the rules say

No Alberta law or standard says a school must send an agenda before a meeting with a parent. That means you have to ask for one.

Alberta's own IPP guidance tells schools to: "Provide parents with an agenda a day or two in advance. This allows them time to think about the items to be discussed and to collect relevant information to bring to the meeting." That is guidance ("should"), not a rule.

What does bind school boards is the Standards for Special Education. Boards must "ensure parents have the opportunity for participation in decisions that affect students' education" and "ensure parents have information needed to make informed decisions." Getting the agenda and drafts first is how you get that information.

Source: Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 2, p.7 (guidance); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 8(a) and (b), p.9 (standard, applies under Ministerial Order 015/2004).

Say this

"Before I come in, can you send me the agenda and any drafts you'll be going over? And is a decision being made at this meeting?"

Ask for this in writing

The agenda for the meeting on [date], copies of every document to be discussed, the names and roles of everyone attending, and whether any decision about my child's program or supports is expected at that meeting.

If you don't get it

Ask once more in writing and say you'd like to move the meeting if the drafts can't come first. If a decision is made anyway, ask for it in writing the same day (10.13) and for the reasons behind it. If a decision significantly affects your child's education, it can be appealed (see 12.6).

Write this down

Date asked · what you asked for · date the agenda and drafts arrived, or that they didn't · date of the meeting.

Your division may also have

A meeting or IPP procedure that sets its own notice times. Ask the school for it.

10.2 You don't know who'll be in the room, or who can decide anything

You might be hearing

— "It'll just be a few of us from the team."

— "Some division people may join."

— "I'll have to take that back to my director."

— "That's above my pay grade."

What's going on

Two different questions: who is coming, and which of them can decide. A meeting can have six staff and nobody who can say yes to the thing you came for. Then every answer is "I'll have to check", and you leave with nothing settled.

Ask both questions before the meeting. If the person who can decide won't be there, you can ask for them to come, or ask that no final decision be made until they're involved.

What the rules say

Alberta's standards describe the "learning team" as "a team that consults and shares information relevant to the individual student's education and plans special education programming and services as required. The team may consist of the classroom teacher, parents, students (where appropriate), other school and jurisdiction staff aware of the students' needs, and others as required." You are named as part of it.

Boards must "identify principals as accountable for the delivery and implementation of school-based special education programming and services." So at school level, the principal is the person accountable.

No Alberta rule we found requires a school to tell you in advance who will attend. That means asking is the only way to know.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions, pp.3-5, and Standard 11(b), pp.10-11 (standard, under Ministerial Order 015/2004). Searched Education Act, Standards, Student Support Policy Framework (22 Oct 2026) and Guide to Education 2025-26 for an attendance notice rule: none found.

Say this

"Who will be at the meeting, and what's each person's role? Which of them can make a decision for the school, or for the division, on the day?"

Ask for this in writing

The name and role of each person attending the meeting on [date], and the name of the person who has authority to decide [the issue] for the school or division.

If you don't get it

Open the meeting by asking it out loud: "Who here can make decisions today?" Write down the answer. If nobody can, ask that the meeting's outcome be treated as a draft until the decision-maker has reviewed it, and follow up in writing (10.13).

Write this down

Date · who attended and their roles · who said they could decide · what they decided, or who they said would.

10.3 You want to bring someone with you

You might be hearing

— "This is a meeting for parents and staff only."

— "We'd prefer to keep it small."

— "We'll need to know who they are in advance."

— "There's no need for an advocate. We're all on the same side."

What's going on

A support person is someone you bring for you: a partner, friend, relative, or an advocate from a disability organization. They can take notes, keep track of questions, and later confirm what was said. That last part matters. A second set of ears is a record.

Telling the school ahead of time who you're bringing, and why, usually goes smoothly. It also gives them the chance to raise any privacy concern before the day rather than at the door.

What the rules say

No Alberta law, regulation or standard we found gives a parent a right to bring a support person to a school meeting, and none forbids it. That means it is up to you to ask, and up to the school or division how it responds.

The standards' own definition of the learning team includes "others as required", so the team is not a closed list.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions, pp.3-5 (standard). Searched Education Act (to 11 Dec 2025, plus 1 Sept 2026 changes), Standards, Student Support Policy Framework (22 Oct 2026), IPP resource (2006) and Guide to Education 2025-26 for "support person" and "advocate": none found.

Say this

"I'll be bringing [name], who's supporting me. They'll help me keep track and take notes. Please let me know before the day if that's a problem."

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation that [name] may attend the meeting on [date] as my support person, or, if not, the written policy or procedure that prevents it.

If you don't get it

If you are told no, ask for the policy that says so. If there isn't one, say in writing that you'd like the refusal reconsidered and why. Either way, you can still take your own notes (10.10) and send a follow-up email (10.13).

Write this down

Date · who you told · their answer · the policy they named, or that they named none.

Your division may also have

A procedure on advocates or support persons. Ask the school office whether one exists.

10.4 You need an interpreter, or someone to explain the words

You might be hearing

— "Your child can translate for you."

— "We don't have anyone who speaks that language today."

— "It's pretty straightforward, you'll be fine."

— "Don't worry about the technical parts."

What's going on

You can't agree to something you can't follow. That's true if English isn't your first language, if you are Deaf or hard of hearing, and if the meeting is full of acronyms nobody explains.

Your child should not be your interpreter. They would be translating decisions about themselves, sometimes about behaviour or diagnosis, in front of the adults who made them.

What the rules say

No Alberta law or standard we found requires a school to provide an interpreter for a parent at a meeting. That means you have to ask, early, and in writing.

What does exist: boards must "ensure parents have information needed to make informed decisions." And informed consent, as the Standards define it, means the person "has been provided with all information relevant to the activity" and "understands and agrees, in writing." If you can't understand what's being said, neither of those can happen.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions, pp.3-5, and Standard 8(b), p.9 (standard). Searched Education Act, Standards, Student Support Policy Framework (22 Oct 2026), Guide to Education 2025-26 for "interpreter": none found.

Say this

"I need an interpreter in [language] for this meeting, not my child. Please let me know who will be interpreting, or we'll need to change the date."

Ask for this in writing

An interpreter in [language or ASL] for the meeting on [date], the interpreter's name, and copies of the documents for that meeting in advance so I can have them explained.

If you don't get it

Ask the school to move the meeting until one is arranged, and say you won't sign anything until you've had it interpreted (see 4.6 and 10.11). For jargon, use the question in 10.9: "What does that mean for my child on a school day?"

Write this down

Date asked · language · who you asked · whether an interpreter was there · what you signed, if anything.

Your division may also have

An interpretation or newcomer family service. Ask the division office.

10.5 "We'll go over it at the meeting"

You might be hearing

- "We'll go over it all at the meeting."
- "It's easier to explain in person."
- "The draft isn't ready yet."
- "We'll walk you through the goals when we meet."

What's going on

This is the most common way a parent first sees a plan at the same moment they're being asked to agree to it. Going over something together is useful. Reading it for the first time across a table, with the clock running, is not.

You're not asking them to skip the meeting. You're asking for the paper first, so the meeting can be about questions instead of reading.

What the rules say

Alberta's IPP guidance tells schools to send an agenda "a day or two in advance" so parents have time "to collect relevant information to bring to the meeting" (guidance).

Boards must "invite meaningful involvement of parents in planning, problem-solving and decision-making relating to students' special education programming" (standard).

The province's 2026 framework says IPPs "are developed collaboratively with students (where appropriate), parents, teachers, school-based teams, and relevant qualified professionals" (guidance). A draft you see for the first time at the table hasn't been developed with you.

Source: Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 2, p.7; Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 8(c), p.9 (standard); Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 Oct 2026, section 7, item 1.2 (guidance, "does not create new legislative requirements").

Say this

"I'd like to read the draft before we meet so I can come with questions. Can you send it by [day]?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the draft [IPP / plan / report] to be discussed on [date], sent to me by [date two days before].

If you don't get it

Go, listen, and don't sign on the day (see 4.6 and 10.11). Ask to take the document home. In the follow-up email (10.13), record that you first saw it at the meeting. For the IPP itself, see 4.3.

Write this down

Date asked · what you asked for · date you received it · whether it came before or at the meeting.

10.6 "That's not on the agenda today"

You might be hearing

— "That's not on the agenda today."

— "Let's park that for another time."

— "We're running short on time."

— "That's a separate conversation."

What's going on

Sometimes this is fair. A meeting can't cover everything. But if the thing you most need to talk about is always for "another time", it never gets talked about.

The fix is simple: get your item onto the agenda before the meeting, in writing. If it is still moved off, get a date for when it will be discussed, and who will be there.

What the rules say

No Alberta rule sets who controls a school meeting's agenda. That means a parent's item gets on it by being asked for in writing, ahead of time.

Boards must "ensure parents have the opportunity for participation in decisions that affect students' education." An item that is never scheduled is a decision you can't take part in.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 8(a), p.9 (standard). Searched Education Act, Standards, Student Support Policy Framework (22 Oct 2026), Guide to Education 2025-26 for "agenda": no rule found.

Say this

"I sent this in before the meeting. If we can't cover it today, can we set the date now for when we will, and who'll be there?"

Ask for this in writing

The date, time and attendees for the meeting at which [your item] will be discussed, confirmed by [date].

If you don't get it

Put the item to the principal in writing as a question that needs an answer, not a topic for discussion (see 10.9). If it's a decision being put off with no date, that can itself be appealed (see 12.5).

Write this down

Date you asked to add it · date it was moved off · the reason given · the new date offered, or that none was.

10.7 You're outnumbered, and some of them have never met your child

You might be hearing

— "We all met beforehand to get on the same page."

— "Their teacher couldn't make it, but I can speak for them."

— "I've read the file."

— "From what I've seen, they're doing really well."

What's going on

Walking into a room of six staff who've already talked it through is hard. It can feel like the answers were agreed before you arrived. Two things help: knowing in advance who is coming (10.2), and asking each person what they know first-hand.

Someone who has read the file knows what the file says. The teacher and EA (educational assistant, the adult who works with your child under a teacher's direction) know your child's day. If they aren't there, say so, and ask that nothing about the daily plan be final until they've been asked.

What the rules say

The standards say boards must make sure teachers "involve parents and, when appropriate, students and other professionals in the development, implementation, monitoring and evaluation of students' IPPs."

The 2026 framework describes the school-based team as bringing "together teachers, educational assistants, principal, and qualified professionals (as required) to review student strengths and needs" (guidance).

No Alberta rule we found sets a limit on how many staff attend, or requires staff to meet parents before meeting each other.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), pp.10-11 (standard); Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 Oct 2026, section 6, item 4.1 (guidance). Searched Education Act, Standards, Framework: no rule on numbers or pre-meetings found.

Say this

"Before we start, could everyone say their name, their role, and how often they see my child? The teacher and EA aren't here, so I'd like nothing about the daily plan finalized today."

Ask for this in writing

The names and roles of everyone at the meeting on [date], how often each works with my child, and a date for a follow-up with the classroom teacher and EA before any change to the IPP takes effect.

If you don't get it

Say it again in your follow-up email (10.13) so it's on record. If the plan changes without the teacher and EA being consulted, ask who decided it and on what information. See 4.8 for goals that change without notice.

Write this down

Date · who attended · who had met your child · who was missing · what was decided without them.

10.8 A case conference with division staff

You might be hearing

— "The division team has a few recommendations."

— "We've brought in our specialists."

— "This is a consultation meeting."

— "We'll be making recommendations to the school."

What's going on

A case conference is a meeting that brings in people from beyond the school: division consultants, psychologists, behaviour specialists, sometimes outside agencies. The province's 2026 framework calls this "case coordination". It can be where the biggest decisions get shaped.

Two things to find out first: who will attend, and whether the people who carry out the plan every day (teacher and EA) will be there. Then ask whether their recommendations bind the school or are suggestions.

What the rules say

The 2026 framework defines case coordination as "the collaborative process that involves the school-based team, including qualified professionals, that the applicable school authority engages, with parent(s), to plan, implement, and monitor supports for a student," and says other terms include "case conferencing and wrap-around meetings" (guidance).

The Standards define consultation as a process that gives parents "the opportunity to assist in making decisions about all aspects of programming and placement," and say it "includes conferencing and meeting with school staff" (standard).

Source: Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 Oct 2026, section 1.2, Glossary, "Case coordination" (guidance); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions, pp.3-5 (standard).

Say this

"Who here can decide for the division today? Are these recommendations the school must follow, or suggestions? Who's responsible for each one, and by when?"

Ask for this in writing

A written list of every recommendation from the case conference on [date], whether each is required or optional, the person responsible, and the date it will be in place.

If you don't get it

Send your own list in the follow-up email (10.13) and ask them to correct it within a week. If a recommendation is not carried out, that is a question for the principal and then the dispute process in 12.3.

Write this down

Date · who attended and their roles · each recommendation · who owns it · the date promised.

10.9 You keep getting answers that aren't answers

You might be hearing

— "We're doing everything we can."

— "I'll have to check on that."

— "It's ongoing."

— "Just trust us, we know what we're doing."

— "We'll see how it goes."

What's going on

Most non-answers come from questions that can be answered with a feeling. "How's it going?" invites "fine". A question that names a number, a date, a person or a document can only be answered with one of those, or with "I don't know", which is also useful.

Short questions work better than long ones. One topic per question. Write the answer down before moving on.

Questions that get answers	Questions that don't
"What's the date of the next measurement?"	"How is reading going?"
"Who works with my child on this, and how often?"	"Is my child getting support?"
"Which document says that? Can I have a copy?"	"Is that the policy?"
"Who decided this, and on what date?"	"Why did this change?"
"What's the number now, and what's the target?"	"Is my child improving?"
"Can you confirm that in writing before I leave?"	"Can you keep me posted?"

What the rules say

Teachers must "regularly assess students and periodically report the results of the assessment to the students, the students' parents and the board." Boards must "inform parents of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods, throughout the year."

Alberta's IPP guidance says "Checkmarks or vague terms such as "ongoing" do not adequately describe what a student has achieved" (guidance).

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.196(1)(e) (law); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 13(b), p.12 (standard); Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1, p.14 (guidance).

Say this

"Can you give me that as a date, a number or a name? If you don't know today, when will you?"

Ask for this in writing

The answer to each question below, by [date]: [list each question on its own numbered line].

If you don't get it

Send your questions as a short numbered list by email, one topic each, and ask for answers by a date. A non-answer in writing is still a record. For progress dates in the IPP, see 4.4.

Write this down

Date · the question, word for word · the answer, word for word · whether it was a date, number, name or none.

10.10 Keeping your own notes, and keeping your footing

You might be hearing

— "You seem upset. Should we take a break?"

— "Let's keep this productive."

— "I don't think that tone is helpful."

— "We hear you."

What's going on

These meetings are about your child, so of course they're hard. The trouble is that when voices rise, the meeting can turn into a conversation about how you're speaking instead of what you're saying.

Two things help. First, write your main points down before the meeting, read them out, and hand over a copy. Then it's on paper in your words, whatever happens next. Second, keep notes as you go, or have your support person do it (10.3): who said what, and any date, number or promise.

What the rules say

No rule stops a parent from taking notes in a meeting about their child. A parent's own notes are your record, and nobody else controls them.

Parents have duties too. Since 1 September 2026, the Education Act says a parent must "ensure that the parent's conduct safeguards and contributes to a safe and caring environment that fosters and maintains respectful and responsible behaviours" and "co-operate and collaborate with school staff to support the delivery of supports and services to the child." A written statement read calmly fits those duties and keeps your point intact.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.32(d) and (e), consolidation current 1 Sept 2026 (law). Searched Education Act, Standards, Student Support Policy Framework (22 Oct 2026) for any rule on parent note-taking: none found.

Say this

"I've written down what I need to say so I get it right. I'll read it, and here's a copy for each of you."

Ask for this in writing

That my written statement of [date] be placed on my child's file, and confirmation that it has been.

If you don't get it

Attach your statement to your follow-up email (10.13). Then it's on record with the date, whether or not it was filed.

Write this down

Date · your statement (keep the copy) · who received it · any comment made about your tone, word for word.

10.11 They want you to sign something at the table

You might be hearing

— "Can you just sign here before you go?"

— "It's only to show you were at the meeting."

— "We need it signed today to get things started."

— "Just email us back that you're OK with it."

What's going on

An attendance sheet is a receipt. An IPP signature, a consent for an assessment, or a consent to share information is agreement. They can look the same on the table. Ask which one it is.

You can take any document home to read before you sign. And an email reply saying you've read something is not the same as signing it. If you agree with part and not the rest, say which part in writing.

What the rules say

Boards must "obtain parents' informed written consent for specialized assessments or referral" and must make sure teachers "obtain written informed parental consent on IPPs to indicate agreement with the IPP."

Informed consent means the person "has been provided with all information relevant to the activity", "understands and agrees, in writing", and "understands that the granting of consent is voluntary and may be withdrawn at any time."

If you refuse, boards must make sure teachers "document the reasons for refusal and/or actions undertaken by the school to obtain consent and/or resolve concerns."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions, pp.3-5, and Standards 1(a) and 11(f), pp.6 and 10-11 (standard). See 4.6.

Say this

"What exactly am I signing: that I was here, or that I agree? If it's agreement, I'll read it at home and get back to you by [day]."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the document I was asked to sign on [date], what my signature would mean, and the date by which you need my answer.

If you don't get it

Don't sign. Write back with what you agree with, what you don't, and why. That triggers the school's duty to record your reasons. For the IPP signature, see 4.6.

Write this down

Date · what you were asked to sign · what they said it meant · whether you signed · what you wrote back.

10.12 Recording the meeting

You might be hearing

— "Are you recording this?"

— "We don't allow recording in our meetings."

— "If you record, we'll have to end the meeting."

— "Recording makes staff uncomfortable."

What's going on

Two different sets of rules apply, and people mix them up.

The first is criminal law, which is federal. It says it is not an offence to record a conversation you are part of. That's called "one-party consent": the consent of one person in the conversation, you, is enough.

The second is the school's own rules. A school division, or a school, may have its own rules about recording on its premises or in its meetings, even though recording isn't a crime. Breaking a division rule is not a crime, but it can still mean the meeting is stopped or moved. So ask for the policy in writing, and say at the start that you're recording.

What the rules say

The Criminal Code makes it an offence to knowingly intercept "a private communication", but says that does not apply to "a person who has the consent to intercept, express or implied, of the originator of the private communication or of the person intended by the originator thereof to receive it." This is federal law, and it applies in Alberta.

Division rules vary. Among the Alberta division procedures we read, the ones on recording dealt with video cameras on school property, not with parents recording meetings. We found no Alberta division procedure we could read that sets a rule for parents recording a school meeting. Yours may have one: ask for it in writing.

Source: Criminal Code, RSC 1985 c.C-46, s.184(1) and (2)(a), current to 30 Sept 2026 (federal law); Alberta division administrative procedures read 23 Oct 2026 (division policy).

Say this

"I'm recording today so I have an accurate record. I'm happy to share a copy. Is there a division policy on recording I should know about?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of any division policy or administrative procedure on recording meetings with parents, and a copy of any recording the school or division makes of the meeting on [date].

If you don't get it

If you're told you can't record and no policy is produced, ask for the refusal in writing. Take careful notes instead (10.10), bring a support person (10.3), and send your follow-up email (10.13) the same day. If the school records, ask for its copy (see 11.6).

Write this down

Date · whether you said you were recording · what they said · the policy they named, or that none was named · whether they recorded too.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on recording or on use of electronic devices. Ask the division office for it by name.

10.13 After the meeting: the follow-up email

You might be hearing

— "We'll send a summary."

— "No need to follow up, we're all clear."

— "Let's just see how things go."

— "Written messages get misread. Let's keep talking face to face."

What's going on

Within a day of any meeting, send one short email to everyone who was there: what was agreed, who will do it, and by what date. End by asking them to tell you by a set date if anything is wrong. If nobody corrects it, it stands as the record.

This is the single most useful habit in this book. A promise made out loud can later be remembered differently. A promise in an email, sent the same day and not corrected, is much harder to dispute.

What the rules say

No Alberta rule requires a school to send a written summary after a meeting with a parent. That means you write it.

What the rules do say: boards must make sure teachers document the formal review of a student's progress in the IPP "at regularly scheduled reporting periods", and boards must have "written procedures for timely, fair and open dispute resolution and appeals." If a dispute comes later, written records are what each of those processes will look at.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 11(f) and 16(a), pp.10-11 and 14 (standard). Searched Education Act, Standards, Student Support Policy Framework (22 Oct 2026) for a meeting-summary rule: none found.

Say this

"I'll send a short email tonight with what we agreed, who's doing it and by when. Please let me know by Friday if I've got anything wrong."

Ask for this in writing

Send this, under 150 words: "Thank you for meeting on [date]. My understanding is: 1. [action], [person], by [date]. 2. ... Next meeting: [date]. Please tell me by [date] if any of this is wrong."

If you don't get it

If no one corrects it, file it: it's your record. If someone disagrees, ask them to put their version in writing so both are on file. When dates pass, forward the email and ask what happened (see 12.2).

Write this down

Date of meeting · date your summary was sent · who it went to · any corrections received.

10.14 Asking for the minutes or notes

You might be hearing

— "We don't take minutes at these meetings."

— "Those are just my own notes."

— "The notes are internal."

— "There's nothing formal written down."

What's going on

Minutes are a formal written record of a meeting. Most school meetings with parents don't have them. But staff often take notes, and some meetings are typed up afterwards.

Whether those notes go on your child's student record depends on what they were for and how they were used. Notes kept only for a staff member's own use, and never used in a placement decision, are left out. Notes used to decide your child's program placement are not.

What the rules say

No Alberta rule we found requires minutes of a school meeting with a parent.

The Student Record Regulation says the student record "must contain all information affecting the decisions made about the education of the

student." It leaves out "notes and observations prepared by and for the exclusive use of a teacher, teacher's assistant, counsellor or principal, and that are not used in program placement decisions." Both conditions must be true for notes to be left out: they were for that staff member's use only, and they were not used in program placement decisions.

Separately, the Access to Information Act gives a right of access to "any record in the custody or under the control of a public body", and "record" includes information in any "written, graphic, electronic, digital, photographic, audio or other medium". School boards are covered.

Source: Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, ss.2(1) and 3(1)(a)(i), consolidated to 159/2025 (regulation); Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, ss.1(u) and 6(1) (law; in force 11 June 2025); alberta.ca, "Access to information requests" (school boards listed). See chapter 3 and 11.5 to 11.7.

Say this

"Were notes taken at our meeting? Were they used for any decision about my child's program? If so, I'd like a copy."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of any notes, minutes, summaries or recordings made by staff at or after the meeting on [date], and confirmation of whether any of them were used in a decision about my child's program or placement.

If you don't get it

Ask for your child's student record (11.5). If notes are withheld, make an access request under the Access to Information Act (11.7). Keep your own follow-up email (10.13) as the record either way.

Write this down

Date asked · who you asked · what they said exists · what you received · date received.

Chapter 11: Records and evidence

What to keep, how to keep it, how to get the school's records about your child, and how to fix them when they're wrong.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/11

Turn here when you're hearing

- "You don't need to keep all that." → 11.1
- "Let's not go back over old history." → 11.2
- "It pulls from your registration form." → 11.3
- "No concerns to note today." → 11.4
- "Please see email." → 11.4
- "You can't just look at the file." → 11.5
- "There's a fee for copies." → 11.5
- "We can't release the video." → 11.6
- "You'll have to put in a FOIP." → 11.7
- "That request is still being processed." → 11.8
- "That's the professional's opinion. We can't change it." → 11.9
- "It was a mistake, it went to the wrong parent." → 11.10
- "The system doesn't track who changed it." → 11.11
- "That's not how I remember it." → 11.12
- "We have no record of that." → 11.13
- "Can you get us something from the doctor?" → 11.14

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
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11.2	The chronology: date, what happened, source
11.3	Keep the registration form, every year
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11.5	Getting your child's student record

Entry	Title
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11.7	Making an access request to the school board
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11.11	Who changed it, and when: audit trails
11.12	Written at the time, or remembered later
11.13	Their documents don't agree with each other
11.14	Records made outside the school

11.1 What to keep, and how to keep it

You might be hearing

— "You don't need to keep all that."

— "We have it all on file."

— "It's in the system."

— "You can always ask us for a copy."

What's going on

The school keeps its records. You keep yours. They will not always match, and when they don't, your copy is the only one you control.

Keep: every IPP version (not just the latest), every report card, every assessment report, every registration form, every letter, every email, and every daily note that comes home. Save emails as PDFs with the date in the file name, because email accounts get closed and threads get lost. Keep one notebook, in date order, for phone calls and meetings.

Number your documents as you file them (1, 2, 3 ...). In a meeting you can then say "document 32" instead of hunting for it.

What the rules say

The school board must keep a student record for your child, and "If an individualized program plan is specifically devised for a student or child for a school year, the plan and any amendments to the plan must be placed on the student record." Boards must keep the record "for 7 years after the student or child ceases to attend a school operated by the board", or until it has been sent on to a new school.

No rule tells parents what to keep. That means it's up to you, and there is no time limit on your own copies.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.56(1) (law); Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, ss.2(4) and 4(1), consolidated to 159/2025 (regulation).

Say this

"Could you email me a copy of that, please? I keep my own file of everything."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of every IPP version and every amendment for my child for [school year], with the date each version was created.

If you don't get it

Ask for your child's student record (11.5). IPPs and their amendments are meant to be in it.

Write this down

Date · document received · who sent it · your document number for it.

11.2 The chronology: date, what happened, source

You might be hearing

— "Let's not go back over old history."

— "That was a long time ago."

— "Let's focus on going forward."

— "I don't remember it that way."

What's going on

A chronology is a list of events in date order. Each line has three parts: the date, what happened, and where it's written down (the source). No adjectives. Not "the principal was dismissive", but "Principal said support would be reviewed in January. Source: my email to principal, 4 Oct."

Plain lines are what make a chronology useful. Anyone can check them. Anyone can see the pattern. Nobody can say it's just how you feel.

Keep a second, short table for the thing that matters most to you (support hours, an EA, a goal). Put what was promised next to what happened.

What the rules say

No Alberta rule tells a parent how to keep a chronology. That means the format is yours.

The province's own IPP guidance uses the same idea for the school's assessment records: each report "should include the date and source (including the name of the assessment tool and the person who did the assessment)" (guidance). Date and source is how the system records things too.

Source: Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1, p.5 (guidance).

Say this

"I keep a dated list so I don't get things mixed up. On [date], my notes say [event]. Is that how you have it too?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation of the date and content of [event], or the school's own record of it, by [date].

If you don't get it

Your chronology stands on its sources. Where a line has no document behind it, ask the school for theirs. Where the school has a different date, see 11.13.

Write this down

Date · what happened (no adjectives) · source document and its number.

11.3 Keep the registration form, every year

You might be hearing

— "It pulls from your registration form."

— "We already have that on file."

— "You don't need to write it again."

— "Just update anything that's changed."

What's going on

The registration form is often where the school's records about your child's health start. If a diagnosis, medication or emergency instruction isn't on it, it may not reach the IPP, or the record that goes with your child in an emergency.

Write every diagnosis and every medical instruction on the form every year, even if they "already have it". Keep a copy (a photo is fine) before you hand it in. Then you can check it against the IPP. See 4.7.

If medical documents arrive mid-year, ask in writing how they get into the IPP. Don't assume they will.

What the rules say

Boards must "request information from parents that is relevant to students' education when students enter the education system."

The student record must contain "any health information that the parent of the student or child or the student or child wishes to be placed on the student record."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 2(c), p.6 (standard); Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1)(p), consolidated to 159/2025 (regulation).

Say this

"I've written everything on this year's form again, including the medical instructions. Please put the health information on my child's record. I've kept a copy."

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation that the health information on my registration form dated [date] has been placed on my child's student record, and how health documents sent during the year reach the IPP.

If you don't get it

Compare the IPP's medical section line by line with your copy of the form (4.7). If anything is missing, ask for it to be fixed in writing (11.9).

Write this down

Date submitted · what you wrote on it · date the IPP was checked against it · what was missing.

11.4 Daily notes and the home-school book

You might be hearing

— "No concerns to note today."

— "Please see email."

— "Good day!"

— "We've updated the daily sheet."

What's going on

A daily note or communication book can be the best record you'll ever have, because it was written on the day by the people who were there. Keep every one. Don't throw them out at the end of the year.

Three things make a daily note useful: it says what happened, it says whether there was an incident, and it gives you room to write back. If the format changes, ask who changed it and why. If it stops coming home, email the same day.

A line worth asking for: "Incident today: yes / no. If yes, report to follow." It turns silence into a checkable answer.

What the rules say

No Alberta rule requires a school to send daily notes home. That means what a note includes is up to the school, unless it's written into your child's IPP or behaviour plan. Ask for it there.

Boards must make sure teachers "throughout the year, provide feedback during informal reviews to parents." The 2026 framework says school-based teams should be "maintaining communication with parent(s)" (guidance).

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), pp.10-11 (standard); Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 Oct 2026, section 6, item 4.2 (guidance). Searched Education Act, Standards, Framework for a daily-note requirement: none found.

Say this

"Could the daily note have a line for 'incident today, yes or no' and space for me to write back? Can we put that in the IPP?"

Ask for this in writing

That my child's IPP state how often home notes are sent, what they include (including whether an incident happened that day), and how I can reply.

If you don't get it

Keep the originals anyway and compare them, date by date, with anything else you later receive. For incidents not reported to you, see chapter 8.

Write this down

Date · what the note said · anything you learned later about that day · source of that later information.

11.5 Getting your child's student record

You might be hearing

- "You can't just look at the file."
- "There's a fee for copies."
- "That's internal."
- "We'll need to know why you want it."

What's going on

The student record is the school board's official file on your child. It's meant to hold "all information affecting the decisions" about your child's education: achievement, assessments, IPPs and their amendments, and health information you asked to have included. Chapter 3 explains what's in it and who holds it.

You have a right to review it and to get a copy. The Act doesn't ask you to give a reason. The Education Act route is the simplest one, so start there.

What the rules say

The student's parent may review the student record, "except where the student is an independent student" (a student who is 18 or older, or 16 or older and in certain situations, such as living on their own).

A parent "may submit a request for a copy of the student record, along with any associated fee," and the board "shall provide a copy of the student record."

Boards must make sure parents "are informed that they are entitled to review the student record," and must give parents "access to information contained in the student record, including results of specialized assessments and student progress reports."

The Act and regulation do not set a fee amount or a time limit for providing the copy. That means you should ask the division what fee and timeline it uses.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.1(1)(n), 6 and 56(3)(b) and (4) (law); Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, ss.2(1) and 6, consolidated to 159/2025 (regulation); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 5(a), p.8 (standard).

Say this

"I'd like to review my child's student record and get a full copy, under section 56 of the Education Act. What's the fee, and when can I have it?"

Ask for this in writing

A complete copy of my child's student record under s.56(4) of the Education Act, including all IPPs and amendments, assessment reports and progress reports, with the fee (if any) and the date it will be provided.

If you don't get it

A decision about access to the record can be appealed to the board (12.6), and then to the Minister (12.7). You can also make an access request under the Access to Information Act (11.7).

Write this down

Date asked · who you asked · fee quoted · date promised · date received · what was missing.

Your division may also have

A student records procedure. Some offer a staff member to explain test results when you review the file.

11.6 Video and recordings the school holds

You might be hearing

- "We can't release the video."
- "The footage has been deleted."
- "There are other students in it."
- "You can view it here with the principal."

What's going on

Many schools have cameras on buses and in halls. Some school meetings are recorded by staff. If something happened to your child where a camera might have caught it, ask the same day. Video is often kept for a short time and then deleted unless someone asks for it.

Because other children may appear, you may be offered a viewing at school rather than a copy. Take a support person and take notes of what you see, with times.

What the rules say

A "record" under the Access to Information Act includes information "in any written, graphic, electronic, digital, photographic, audio or other medium." So video and audio held by a school board are records you can ask for.

Division rules on keeping video vary. One Alberta division procedure we read says recordings "not used as evidence are not to be retained for more than sixty (60) days," and that a parent's viewing "must be done in the presence of an administrator," with a right to request an advocate. Others we read set different periods or none. No provincial rule we found sets how long schools keep video.

Source: Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, s.1(u) (law); Alberta division administrative procedures on video monitoring, read 23 Oct 2026 (division policy).

Say this

"Please keep any video of [place] on [date] between [times]. Don't delete it. I'm asking for access to it."

Ask for this in writing

That all video and audio recordings of [place] on [date] between [times] be preserved, and access to them, under the Access to Information Act and the division's video procedure.

If you don't get it

Make a formal access request (11.7). If you're refused or told it's gone, ask for the date it was deleted and the procedure that allowed it, then see 11.8.

Write this down

Date and time of incident · date and time you asked · who you asked · whether it was kept · what you saw, with times.

Your division may also have

A video monitoring procedure that sets how long footage is kept. Ask for it by name.

11.7 Making an access request to the school board

You might be hearing

— "You'll have to put in a FOIP."

— "Just tell us what you need and we'll see."

— "That would take a lot of staff time."

— "Emails aren't part of the record."

What's going on

An access request is a formal written request for records held by a public body, here the school board. It reaches things the student record may not: emails between staff, internal notes used for decisions, logs, and recordings. FOIP, the old law, was replaced in June 2025 by the Access to Information Act (ATIA). Staff may still call it "a FOIP".

Send it to the division's access or privacy coordinator, not the school. Be specific: name the kind of record, the people, and the date range. The board has a duty to help you with your request.

Independent (private) schools are covered by a different law, the Personal Information Protection Act.

What the rules say

A request must "be in writing" and give "enough detail to enable the public body to locate and identify the record within a reasonable time with reasonable effort." School boards are covered.

The board must "make every reasonable effort to assist applicants and to respond to each applicant openly, accurately and completely."

The board must make every reasonable effort to respond "not later than 30 business days" after your request is complete. It may extend that by up to 30 business days if you agree, if there are many records, or if it needs to consult others. Failing to respond in time "is to be treated as a decision to refuse access to the record."

A parent can use these rights for a child who is a minor only where the board's head thinks doing so "would not constitute an unreasonable invasion of the personal privacy of the minor."

Fees: the Act makes access "subject to the payment of any fee required under this Act." The province's page says "If you are requesting access to your own personal information, no fee is required," and "an initial application fee of $25 is required" for other records. Ask the coordinator how they treat a request for your child's information.

Source: Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, ss.1(e), 6(3), 7(2), 12(1), 13, 16 and 86(1)(e), current as of 18 Dec 2025 (law, in force 11 June 2025); alberta.ca, "Access to information requests", page dated 23 Sept

2025; Guide to Education 2025-26, "Protecting student privacy" (independent schools under PIPA).

Say this

"I'd like to make an access request under the Access to Information Act for records about my child. Who's your access coordinator?"

Ask for this in writing

Under the Access to Information Act: all records about [child's initials or student number] from [date] to [date], including emails, notes, logs, incident reports and recordings, held by [school] and [division office], in electronic form.

If you don't get it

If 30 business days (or any extended deadline) pass with no answer, that counts as a refusal and you can ask the Information and Privacy Commissioner to review it (11.8).

Write this down

Date sent · who to · how sent · date 30 business days later · any extension notice and its reason · date answered.

Your division may also have

An access request form. Some division forms still say FOIP. They still work.

11.8 They haven't answered, or they held things back

You might be hearing

- "That request is still being processed."
- "Some records were withheld under the Act."
- "We needed more time."
- "There's nothing else."

What's going on

If the board doesn't answer in time, holds back records, charges a fee you think is wrong, or takes a time extension you disagree with, you can ask the

Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner (OIPC) to review it. The OIPC is independent of the school board and the government. It deals with access and privacy only, not with education decisions.

The OIPC suggests calling the board first to try to sort it out. If you think more records exist, you must raise that with the board first.

What the rules say

You may ask for a review if you "disagree with the response", "a time extension", or "a fee estimated or charged", or if the board "disregarded or abandoned your access request."

The request for review must be made "within 60 business days after the person asking for the review is notified of the decision, act or failure to act." The Commissioner may allow up to 30 more business days.

"There is no charge to request a review." Send the form and all documents "in one submission". Submissions "should not exceed 15 pages" including the form and attachments. If your only concern is that more records exist, the OIPC says you "will be required to submit the concern directly to the entity first" and to allow it "at least 30 business days to respond." A review can take up to 180 business days, and may be extended.

Source: Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, s.59(2)(a), current as of 18 Dec 2025 (law); OIPC, "Information Access Review", page dated June 2025.

Say this

"I haven't had a response within 30 business days, so I'm treating it as a refusal. I'll be asking the Information and Privacy Commissioner for a review unless I hear by [date]."

Ask for this in writing

A complete response to my access request dated [date], including the section of the Act relied on for each record withheld.

If you don't get it

File the OIPC's ATIA Request for Review form within 60 business days. Keep it under 15 pages and send everything at once. See 12.10 for what the OIPC can and can't do.

Write this down

Date of request · date response was due · what came back · date you asked for review · OIPC file number.

11.9 Something in the record is wrong

You might be hearing

— "That's the professional's opinion. We can't change it."

— "It's auto-populated."

— "We'll add a note."

— "That's how it was reported at the time."

What's going on

There are two routes to fix a wrong record, and they work differently. Pick the one that fits.

The Education Act route is for the student record: you ask the board to "rectify" (fix) information that is inaccurate or incomplete. If it refuses, you can appeal to the board and then ask the Minister to review.

The privacy route, under the Protection of Privacy Act (POPA), is for personal information a public body holds. It can't change an opinion, but if a correction is refused, the body adds your requested correction to the record or links it.

What the rules say

A parent who thinks "the student record contains inaccurate or incomplete information" may "request that the board ... rectify the matter." A decision on "access to or the accuracy or completeness of the student record" can be appealed to the board within a reasonable time, and then to the Minister in writing. The Act's 60-day limit is written for supports and expulsion decisions, but the department's page applies 60 days to every review request. Use 60 days to be safe.

On asking to correct an opinion, "including a professional opinion," the OIPC says "Alberta's privacy laws do not permit this." If a correction is refused, "the entity will either annotate or link the requested correction." A review of a refused correction "must be submitted within 60 business days."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.56(6), 42(4), 43(2) and (4) (law); alberta.ca, "Review by the Minister of Education", page dated 21 Feb 2025; OIPC, "Privacy Complaint or Correction Request", page dated June 2025.

Say this

"This part of the record is wrong. My copy of [document] says [X]. Please correct it under section 56 of the Education Act and confirm in writing."

Ask for this in writing

Correction of [exact wording] in [document, date] to read [correct wording], under s.56(6) of the Education Act, and a written decision by [date], with the reason if refused.

If you don't get it

Ask for the refusal in writing. Then appeal it to the board (12.6) and, after that, ask the Minister to review it, within 60 days to be safe (12.7). Or use the privacy route through the OIPC (12.10). Note which route you chose.

Write this down

Date asked · exact wrong wording · exact correct wording and its source · decision · date.

11.10 Your child's information went somewhere it shouldn't

You might be hearing

— "It was a mistake, it went to the wrong parent."

— "It was only shared internally."

— "We've asked them to delete it."

— "It's not a big deal."

What's going on

A privacy breach is when personal information is lost, or seen or shared without authority. Examples: your child's IPP emailed to the wrong family,

a report left in a shared space, details shared with someone who had no reason to see them.

Public school boards must follow the Protection of Privacy Act (POPA). If there's a real risk of significant harm, they must tell you. The province's page says the notice is in writing. Independent schools follow a different law (PIPA).

What the rules say

POPA says that where there is "the loss of, unauthorized access to or unauthorized disclosure of personal information" and "a reasonable person would consider that there exists a real risk of significant harm to an individual", the public body "must give notice, without unreasonable delay" to that individual, the Information and Privacy Commissioner, and the Minister.

To complain, the OIPC says to "make the complaint FIRST to the public body" and to allow "at least 30 business days for the entity to respond." Then you can complain to the OIPC "within 60 business days after you have received a response from the public body." "There is no charge to request a review or file a complaint."

Source: Protection of Privacy Act, SA 2024 c.P-28.5, s.10(2), current as of 11 Dec 2025 (law, in force 11 June 2025); alberta.ca, "Report a privacy incident (public bodies)", page dated 17 Aug 2026; OIPC, "Privacy Complaint or Correction Request", page dated June 2025.

Say this

"My child's information was sent to someone who shouldn't have it. What happened, who has it now, and have you assessed whether this needs to be reported?"

Ask for this in writing

A written account of the privacy incident on [date]: what information, who received it, what was done to recover it, and whether the board assessed it under POPA and notified the Commissioner.

If you don't get it

Make a written privacy complaint to the board's privacy officer. If 30 business days pass, or you're not satisfied with the answer, complain to the OIPC (12.10). Keep this separate from any education dispute.

Write this down

Date of breach · how you found out · what was shared and with whom · date you complained · response date.

11.11 Who changed it, and when: audit trails

You might be hearing

— "The system doesn't track who changed it."

— "It's a new process, some staff forgot to initial."

— "It must be an IT issue."

— "That field updates automatically."

What's going on

Many records are kept in software. Some software keeps a history: who edited a field, when, and what it said before. That's called an audit trail or amendment history. Where one exists, it can answer questions nobody remembers: when a goal changed, who removed a name from a team list, when a medical note dropped out.

Whether your division's system keeps one is a question only the division can answer. Ask it plainly, in writing.

A simpler step: ask that every IPP entry carry the writer's initials and the date. Then each version shows its own history.

What the rules say

An IPP "and any amendments to the plan" must be placed on the student record. A "record" under the Access to Information Act includes "any electronic record," and, subject to the Act's exceptions, a board must provide a record if doing so "can be done using the public body's normal computer hardware and software and technical expertise," would not unreasonably interfere with its operations, and would be reasonable and practical. So an amendment history that exists is a record you can ask for.

No Alberta rule we found requires a division's software to keep an audit trail. That means one may or may not exist.

Source: Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(4), consolidated to 159/2025 (regulation); Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, ss.1(u) and 12(2) (law). Searched Education Act, Student Record Regulation, Standards and Student Support Policy Framework for "audit": none found.

Say this

"Does your system keep a history of changes to the IPP? If it does, I'd like the history for [section] since [date]."

Ask for this in writing

Under the Access to Information Act: any amendment history, audit log or version history for [section] of my child's IPP from [date] to [date], showing each change, its date and the user who made it.

If you don't get it

If the answer is that no history exists, ask for that in writing too. Then compare every IPP version you hold, side by side (11.13). See 4.7 for the medical section and 4.8 for changed goals.

Write this down

Date asked · what you asked for · whether a history exists · what it showed.

11.12 Written at the time, or remembered later

You might be hearing

— "That's not how I remember it."

— "I don't recall saying that."

— "You must have misunderstood."

— "That was a long time ago."

What's going on

A record made at the time something happened (a "contemporaneous" record) is usually more reliable than memory, for everyone, including you. That's why the same-day email (10.13) matters so much.

Strongest: documents the school or division wrote itself, dated and signed. Then: your same-day email that nobody corrected. Then: your notebook entry written that day. Weakest: anyone's memory months later, including yours.

When it's your memory against theirs, find the document. If there isn't one, write down now what you remember, say when you're writing it, and stop arguing about it.

What the rules say

No Alberta education rule says how much weight each kind of record gets. Each body decides on what's in front of it. What the rules show is that every route runs on documents. Before asking for the Minister's review, you "must have a written decision letter from the board", and the request form asks you to explain "how the decision is not reasonable and/or fair". The OIPC wants "a completed form and all supporting documents in one submission."

Source: Education and Childcare, "Review by the Minister: Parent information", September 2019; OIPC, "Information Access Review", page dated June 2025.

Say this

"I wrote it down that day. Here's my email from [date]. If your record says something different, can you send it to me?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's own record of [event or conversation] on [date], including any notes, emails or log entries.

If you don't get it

Keep your record and file it with its date. If the question matters to a decision, put both versions to the decision-maker in one short letter (11.13).

Write this down

Date of event · date you wrote it down · what you wrote · what record the school has, if any.

11.13 Their documents don't agree with each other

You might be hearing

— "We have no record of that."

— "That's a different document."

— "Both are correct, in context."

— "That was an earlier version."

What's going on

Sometimes the school's own papers contradict each other. The IPP says one thing and the behaviour plan says another. The daily note says a calm day and the incident log says otherwise. One email says something was recorded, and a later one says there's no record.

You don't need to say anyone is wrong. Put the two side by side and ask which is correct. When two documents from the same body conflict, that body is the one who has to resolve it.

What the rules say

A parent who finds "inaccurate or incomplete information" in the student record may ask the board to "rectify the matter."

Boards must make sure teachers "document, in the IPP, the formal review of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods." That means the IPP is meant to be a record of what was reviewed and when.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.56(6) (law); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(f), pp.10-11 (standard).

Say this

"These two documents say different things. [Document A, date] says [X]. [Document B, date] says [Y]. Which one is correct?"

Ask for this in writing

Send one short letter: quote both passages exactly, with each document's title and date, and ask which is correct, and for the correction of the other, by [date].

If you don't get it

The two documents, side by side, are the record. Add them to your chronology (11.2). If the conflict affects your child's program, raise it under the dispute process (12.3). If it's about accuracy of the student record, see 11.9.

Write this down

Date · document A and what it says · document B and what it says · who you asked · their answer.

11.14 Records made outside the school

You might be hearing

— "Can you get us something from the doctor?"

— "We'll put it on file."

— "We'll place an alert on the file."

— "We didn't see that at school."

What's going on

Records made by people outside the school are hard to dispute: a doctor's note, a clinic's dated report, a photo with a date on it, an outside assessment. They often turn out to matter most.

Same day, if something happens: take dated photos, see the doctor and ask them to record what they saw, and write to the school asking what happened. When you hand in an outside document, ask for written confirmation that it was received and placed on the record.

What the rules say

The student record must include, "in relation to any formal intellectual, behavioural or emotional assessment or evaluation requested by the student's or child's parent and administered to the student or child by an independent party," its name, date, who gave it, a summary of the results and any interpretive report. It must also include "any health information that the parent ... wishes to be placed on the student record."

Source: Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019, s.2(1)(o) and (p), consolidated to 159/2025 (regulation).

Say this

"Here's the doctor's letter. Please put it on my child's record and confirm in writing that you've received it and where it's been filed."

Ask for this in writing

Written confirmation that [document, date, author] was received on [date] and placed on my child's student record, and who will act on it.

If you don't get it

Hand-deliver a second copy and ask for a signed, dated receipt. Ask for the student record later to check it's there (11.5). For medical instructions, an alert on file is not a plan: see chapter 9.

Write this down

Date · document · who made it · date given to school · confirmation received, or not.

Chapter 12: When it goes wrong: the ladder

Where to take a problem, in what order, what each office can and can't do, and the deadlines that apply.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/12

Turn here when you're hearing

- "Who should I even complain to?" → 12.1
- "You need to start with the teacher." → 12.2
- "Have you spoken to the principal?" → 12.2
- "You haven't gone through our process yet." → 12.3
- "That's best handled at the school level." → 12.3
- "I can't direct the school on staffing." → 12.4
- "We're still looking into it." → 12.5
- "No decision has been made yet." → 12.5
- "That isn't something that can be appealed." → 12.6
- "The board's decision is final." → 12.7
- "Trustees don't get involved in individual cases." → 12.8
- "You can file a complaint against the teacher." → 12.9
- "That's a privacy matter." → 12.10
- "That isn't discrimination, it's a resourcing issue." → 12.11
- "Try the Ombudsman." → 12.12
- "Have you called your MLA?" → 12.13
- "You'd have to take us to court." → 12.14
- "There's no deadline, take your time." → 12.15

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
12.1	Which door? Keeping each problem in its own lane

Entry	Title
12.2	Start with the teacher, then the principal
12.3	The school's dispute resolution policy
12.4	The superintendent and the division office
12.5	Nobody will make a decision
12.6	Appealing to the school board
12.7	Asking the Minister to review the board's decision
12.8	Trustees and public board meetings
12.9	A complaint about a teacher's or principal's conduct
12.10	Privacy and access: the Information and Privacy Commissioner
12.11	Disability discrimination: the Alberta Human Rights Commission
12.12	The Ombudsman and the Child and Youth Advocate
12.13	Your MLA
12.14	The courts, and the Complex Education Needs Tribunal
12.15	The deadlines, in one table

12.1 Which door? Keeping each problem in its own lane

You might be hearing

— "Who should I even complain to?"

— "That's not something we deal with."

— "You'll need to take that up with someone else."

— "You've already raised that elsewhere."

What's going on

Each office deals with one kind of problem. Sending a problem to the wrong one wastes months and can end with it being closed without anyone looking at what happened to your child.

Your problem is about	Where it goes	Entry
Your child's program, supports, placement, IPP, a decision by staff	Teacher, principal, dispute policy, board appeal, Minister	12.2 to 12.7
A teacher's or principal's professional conduct or competence	Alberta Teaching Profession Commission	12.9
Getting records, or how your child's information was handled	Board's access or privacy office, then the Information and Privacy Commissioner	12.10
Being treated worse because of disability	Alberta Human Rights Commission	12.11

One problem can have more than one part. Split it, and send each part to its own door.

What the rules say

Boards must "have written procedures for timely, fair and open dispute resolution and appeals," must "advise parents of their right to make a formal appeal of decisions regarding the special education needs of their children, and inform them of the appeal procedures of the board," and must "advise parents of their right to request that the Minister ... review the board's decision."

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 16(a), (d) and (e), p.14 (standard, under Ministerial Order 015/2004). The Standard names the "Minister of Learning", the title at the time; the Minister responsible is now the Minister of Education.

Say this

"Can you send me your dispute resolution and appeal procedures, and tell me which step I'm at now?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the board's school dispute resolution policy, its appeal procedure under s.42 of the Education Act, and written information on the right to ask the Minister to review a board decision.

If you don't get it

The Act requires every board to set an appeal procedure by resolution (s.42(5)), so ask for it. Ask the superintendent's office (12.4) or look on the division website under board policies.

Write this down

Date · what the problem is · which lane · which step you're on · date of next step.

12.2 Start with the teacher, then the principal

You might be hearing

— "You need to start with the teacher."

— "Have you spoken to the principal?"

— "Let's keep this informal for now."

— "We'll look into it and get back to you."

What's going on

The division concerns process we read starts with the teacher, then the principal. It isn't just a hoop. Many problems end here, and when they don't, this step creates the record the next step will look at.

Put each conversation in a short email the same day (10.13). If the teacher can't fix it (because it's about staffing, money or a school decision), go to the principal. The principal is the person accountable for special education at the school.

What the rules say

Teachers must "provide instruction competently" and "regularly assess students and periodically report the results of the assessment to the students, the students' parents and the board."

Principals must "provide instructional leadership in the school," "evaluate or provide for the evaluation of programs offered in the school," and "ensure that students in the school have the opportunity to meet the standards of education set by the Minister." Boards must "identify principals as accountable for the delivery and implementation of school-based special education programming and services."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.196(1)(a) and (e) and 197(a), (c) and (d) (law); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(b), pp.10-11 (standard).

Say this

"I raised this with [teacher] on [date] and it isn't resolved. I'm asking you, as principal, to decide it. When can I have your answer in writing?"

Ask for this in writing

The principal's decision on [issue], with reasons, by [date], and the next step in the division's dispute process if I don't agree.

If you don't get it

Move to the school dispute resolution policy (12.3). If no decision comes, see 12.5.

Write this down

Date raised with teacher · their answer · date raised with principal · their answer, word for word · date of written decision.

12.3 The school's dispute resolution policy

You might be hearing

- "You haven't gone through our process yet."
- "That's best handled at the school level."
- "Please fill in the concerns form."
- "The process has steps, you can't skip ahead."

What's going on

Every school board must have a written policy for settling disputes between parents and school staff. It's sometimes called a concerns and complaints process. It sets the steps, who decides at each one, and sometimes the time limits.

You have to follow it before you can appeal to the board. So get a copy early, follow it in writing, and keep proof of each step. In the division process we read, the last step was a superintendent's review.

What the rules say

"A board shall establish a policy respecting the resolution of disputes or concerns at the school level between parents and school staff."

Before appealing to the board, a parent "must have followed the school dispute resolution policy established by the board under section 41."

Boards must "make every reasonable effort at the school and jurisdiction level to resolve concerns collaboratively with parents."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.41 and 42(3) (law); Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 16(c), p.14 (standard).

Say this

"Please send me the board's dispute resolution policy. I want to follow every step so this can go to the board if it needs to."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the policy under s.41 of the Education Act, the form (if any), the name of the person who decides at each step, and any time limits.

If you don't get it

The policy has to exist. Ask the superintendent's office (12.4). If you're sent back to the school after you've already been through it, say in writing which steps you've completed and when.

Write this down

Date · step · who decided · their decision · date of written decision.

Your division may also have

A concerns form and a page explaining each step. Check the board policies section of its website.

12.4 The superintendent and the division office

You might be hearing

— "I can't direct the school on staffing."

— "I'll pass that on to the principal."

— "That's a school-based decision."

— "Let's set up a meeting with the school."

What's going on

The superintendent runs the school division for the board. A letter to the superintendent is often where things start moving, especially when it's short and structured: what you raised, what changed, what didn't, and numbered requests with dates.

If the person given your file was part of the earlier decisions, you can ask for someone who wasn't. Give your reasons as effects ("the assessment findings were not acted on"), not as motives.

Ask any contact you're given what they can decide. Some can pass messages and arrange meetings but can't change staffing.

What the rules say

"The superintendent is the chief executive officer of the board and the chief education officer of the school division." The superintendent "shall supervise the operation of schools and the provision of education programs in the school division," including "ensuring that students have the opportunity in the school division to meet the standards of education set by the Minister."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.222(3) and (5)(b) (law).

Say this

"I'm writing to you because this hasn't been resolved at school level. Who in the division can decide this, and by what date?"

Ask for this in writing

A written response to my letter of [date], naming the person with authority to decide each of my numbered requests, and the date each will be answered.

If you don't get it

If the reply sends you back to the school after you've completed the school steps, say so in writing and ask for a decision. A failure to decide can be appealed (12.5). Then go to the board (12.6).

Write this down

Date of letter · who it went to · date of reply · who was assigned · what they said they could and couldn't decide.

12.5 Nobody will make a decision

You might be hearing

— "We're still looking into it."

— "No decision has been made yet."

— "Let's revisit it next term."

— "It would be premature to say."

What's going on

A problem that's never decided can never be appealed, or so it seems. Alberta's Education Act closes that gap. If a person fails to make a decision, the law treats that failure as a decision you can appeal to the board.

Before you rely on that, put a date on it. Ask in writing for a decision by a fair date. If the date passes with nothing, you have a failure to decide, on paper.

What the rules say

"The failure of a person to make a decision is deemed to be a decision that may be appealed under this section."

The appeal still has to be about a decision that "significantly affects the education of a student," and you still have to follow the school dispute policy first.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.42(1), (2) and (3) (law).

Say this

"I asked for a decision on [date]. If I don't have one by [date], I'll treat that as a decision and appeal it to the board."

Ask for this in writing

A decision on [issue], with reasons, by [date]. If none is given, I will treat that as a decision under s.42(1) of the Education Act.

If you don't get it

Appeal to the board (12.6), and include your request and the date that passed.

Write this down

Date asked · date you set · what happened by that date · date you appealed.

12.6 Appealing to the school board

You might be hearing

— "That isn't something that can be appealed."

— "You'd need to go through the process first."

— "The board doesn't hear individual cases."

— "The board will review it at a future meeting."

What's going on

A board appeal is a formal review by the elected board (or a committee of it) of a decision made by a staff member. It's for decisions that significantly affect your child's education, such as supports, placement, or programming. It's also the route for decisions about access to or accuracy of the student record.

There's no fixed number of days in the Act, only "a reasonable time." Don't wait. The board's own procedure may set a time limit.

What the rules say

A decision "that significantly affects the education of a student" made by a board employee may be appealed by a parent (or by a student 16 or older) "within a reasonable time from the date that the parent or student was informed of the decision." The school dispute policy must be followed first.

The board "shall establish an appeal procedure by resolution," "may make any decision that it considers appropriate," and "shall make a decision ... forthwith after receiving a notice of an application for an appeal and shall report that decision, in writing, to the person making the appeal forthwith." "Forthwith" means promptly, without delay.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.42(2) to (8) (law).

Say this

"I'm appealing this decision to the board under section 42. It significantly affects my child's education. Please send me the board's appeal procedure."

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the board's appeal procedure, the date of the hearing, the materials the board will see, and the board's decision in writing as required by s.42(8).

If you don't get it

Ask the board chair's office in writing for the procedure. Once you have the board's written decision, and if it's about specialized supports, expulsion, which board is responsible, or the student record, you can ask the Minister to review it. Do it within 60 days to be safe (12.7).

Write this down

Date informed of decision · date appealed · hearing date · date of written board decision · date 60 days later.

12.7 Asking the Minister to review the board's decision

You might be hearing

— "The board's decision is final."

— "The Minister doesn't get involved in local decisions."

— "There's nothing more you can do."

— "That's not one of the things the Minister reviews."

What's going on

For some board decisions, you can ask Alberta's Minister of Education (Education and Childcare) to review them. Only four kinds: specialized supports and services for your child, expulsion, which board is responsible for your child, and access to or accuracy of the student record.

Send your request within 60 days of being told of the board's decision. You'll need the board's written decision. The Minister's review asks whether the board's decision was reasonable. The Minister's decision is final.

What the rules say

A parent "may request in writing that the Minister review the decision." For supports and expulsion decisions, the request "must be made within 60 days of the date on which the parent or the student ... is informed of the decision." The Act sets no time limit for the other two kinds, but the department's page says to request the review "within 60 days" without carving them out, so use 60 days for all four. The Minister "may review" the matter, to decide "whether the decision of the board was reasonable in the circumstances", and "that decision is final."

The department says it may consider: "Did the board's policy and procedures comply with the requirements of the Education Act?"; "Did the board follow its policy and procedures when making the decision?"; and "Was there a lack of fairness sufficiently serious to call into question the reasonableness of the decision of the board?" It says the Minister "has discretion to determine if the decision will be reviewed." Its parent sheet says you "must have a written decision letter from the board."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.43(1) to (4) and 44(1) and (2) (law); alberta.ca, "Review by the Minister of Education", page dated 21 Feb 2025; Education and Childcare, "Review by the Minister: Parent information", September 2019.

Say this

"I'm asking the Minister to review the board's decision of [date] on my child's specialized supports. Here's the board's letter and why I think it wasn't reasonable."

Ask for this in writing

Send the Parents' Request Form with: the board's written decision letter with its reasons, communication related only to the matter in the appeal, and a short explanation of how the decision is not reasonable or fair. Ask for written confirmation of receipt.

If you don't get it

The Minister decides whether to review. If the matter isn't one of the four types, it can't go here. Discrimination can go to the Human Rights Commission (12.11).

Write this down

Date of board decision · date you were told · date sent to Minister · date 60 days ends · reply date.

12.8 Trustees and public board meetings

You might be hearing

— "Trustees don't get involved in individual cases."

— "You can email your trustee."

— "Delegations have to be booked in advance."

— "That will need to be discussed in camera."

What's going on

Trustees are the people elected to the school board. The board appoints the superintendent and hears appeals. A trustee can listen and ask questions, but decisions are made by the board at its meetings.

Board meetings are public. Many boards let members of the public present as a "delegation" (a short presentation to the board). Each board sets its own rules. Among Alberta boards we read, requests were due between nine business days and two weeks ahead, with 10 to 15 minutes to speak. At one, the chair decided whether the topic fits.

Speak about the issue, not your child by name. A public meeting is public.

What the rules say

"The meetings of a board must be held in public and no person may be excluded from them except for improper conduct." The board can go private for a matter by resolution, but a private meeting can't pass "a bylaw or resolution ... except the resolution necessary to revert to an open meeting."

An elector of the division may inspect "the agenda of any public meeting or board meeting" and "the minutes of any public meeting or board meeting."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.64(1), (3) and (4) and 65(1)(a) and (b) (law); Alberta board delegation procedures read 23 Oct 2026 (division policy).

Say this

"I'd like to present to the board as a delegation on [topic] at the [date] meeting. What do you need from me, and by when?"

Ask for this in writing

The board's delegation procedure, the deadline to request a spot at the [date] meeting, and how the board will respond to the delegation.

If you don't get it

You can still attend and listen; board meetings are public. For your child's own case, use the appeal route (12.6).

Write this down

Date requested · meeting date · what you said · what the board did with it.

Your division may also have

A delegations policy, and a rule on recording at board meetings. Ask for both.

12.9 A complaint about a teacher's or principal's conduct

You might be hearing

- "You can file a complaint against the teacher."
- "That's an HR matter."
- "That was dismissed."
- "That's not something the Commission looks at."

What's going on

The Alberta Teaching Profession Commission (ATPC) is an independent regulator. It deals with complaints that a certificated teacher or teacher leader (principal or superintendent) broke the Code of Professional Conduct, or isn't meeting the Professional Practice Standards. That's all it deals with.

The Commission looks at an individual teacher's or leader's professional conduct or competence, not at whether a child's program or IPP is adequate. Programming disputes go through the division and the board

appeal (12.2 to 12.7). A complaint that's really about a division decision can end with "no further action", which closes the complaint without looking at your child's program.

You can't complain anonymously. Your name and the nature of your complaint are shared with the teacher, and you're expected to take part until the end.

What the rules say

A complaint can be about unprofessional conduct (a teacher or teacher leader "has violated the Code of Professional Conduct for Teachers and Teacher Leaders") or professional incompetence ("not meeting Professional Practice Standards"). In the Act, a "teacher leader" includes "a principal or superintendent". Incompetence complaints "can be filed up to 2 years after" it occurred; conduct complaints "can be filed at any time." If you're comfortable and it's appropriate, you're "encouraged to first address your concern with the school or school division, or both." The page says: "Your name and the nature of your complaint will be shared with the teacher."

The Commissioner may "take no further action" if a complaint is "frivolous, vexatious or without merit." You can appeal that within 15 days of being served, with a fee.

Source: alberta.ca, "Alberta Teaching Profession Commission: making a complaint", published 6 July 2026, read 23 Oct 2026; Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.225.1(u), 225.91(1), 225.93, 225.94(2)(a) and 225.95(2) (law).

Say this

"My concern is about this person's professional conduct, not about the division's decision on my child's program. I'm raising that part separately."

Ask for this in writing

From the Commission: written confirmation that your complaint was received on [date], and the date it was referred to the Commissioner.

If you don't get it

If the Commissioner decides "no further action", you'll be told why and how to appeal. Diarize the 15 days. Keep the program dispute moving in its own lane at the same time.

Write this down

Date of conduct · which Code or Standard · date filed · date of decision · date 15 days ends.

12.10 Privacy and access: the Information and Privacy Commissioner

You might be hearing

— "That's a privacy matter."

— "Put in a request through our access office."

— "The Commissioner can't change the IPP."

— "We've applied an exception under the Act."

What's going on

The Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner (OIPC) is independent. For a public school board, it deals with two things only: getting access to records (the Access to Information Act) and how personal information is handled (the Protection of Privacy Act). It can't decide anything about your child's education.

Use it when a board won't give you records, holds part back, charges a fee you dispute, misses the deadline, refuses a correction, or mishandles your child's information. See 11.7 to 11.10.

What the rules say

A request for review of an access decision must be made "within 60 business days after the person asking for the review is notified of the decision, act or failure to act."

For a privacy complaint, the OIPC says to "make the complaint FIRST to the public body," allow "at least 30 business days for the entity to respond," then complain "within 60 business days after you have received a response from the public body." Correction reviews "must be submitted within 60 business days."

"There is no charge to request a review or file a complaint." Send everything in one submission of no more than about 15 pages.

Source: Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, s.59(2)(a), current as of 18 Dec 2025 (law); OIPC, "Information Access Review" and "Privacy Complaint or Correction Request", pages dated June 2025.

Say this

"This part is about access to my child's records, so I'm taking it to the Information and Privacy Commissioner. The education issue is going through the board."

Ask for this in writing

The board's written decision on my access request, correction request or privacy complaint, with the sections of the Act relied on.

If you don't get it

If 30 business days (or any extended deadline) pass on an access request, that counts as a refusal (11.7). File the review form within 60 business days.

Write this down

Date of request or complaint · date of board's response · date you went to the OIPC · file number.

12.11 Disability discrimination: the Alberta Human Rights Commission

You might be hearing

- "That isn't discrimination, it's a resourcing issue."
- "We treat all students the same."
- "That's an education matter, not a human rights one."
- "You should finish the appeal first."

What's going on

Alberta's human rights law says nobody may deny, or discriminate in, a service customarily available to the public because of physical or mental disability. The Commission lists schools as one of those services. "Mental disability" includes learning and developmental disorders.

The deadline is strict: one year from the last event. It doesn't wait for the board appeal to finish, so keep an eye on it while you're using the other routes.

The Commission can decline a complaint that is being, or should be, dealt with somewhere else. If you're running an appeal and a human rights complaint at once, say so on the form.

What the rules say

No person shall "deny to any person ... any goods, services, accommodation or facilities that are customarily available to the public" or "discriminate" in them because of "physical disability" or "mental disability." "Mental disability" means "any mental disorder, developmental disorder or learning disorder, regardless of the cause or duration of the disorder."

"The Commission can only accept complaints that are received within one year of the last event of discrimination," and the limit "cannot be extended for any reason." The director may dismiss a complaint that "should be more appropriately dealt with in another forum or under another Act."

Source: Alberta Human Rights Act, RSA 2000 c.A-25.5, ss.4, 20(2)(b), 21(1)(a)(iv) and 44(1)(h) (law, consolidation current 1 April 2023); Alberta Human Rights Commission, "Human Rights Complaint Guide", Sections C, D and G, read 23 Oct 2026.

Say this

"I'm concerned this is about my child's disability. What accommodation was considered, and why was it refused?"

Ask for this in writing

The decision, the accommodations considered, and the reasons each was refused, with the date of the decision.

If you don't get it

Do the Commission's self-assessment and complaint form before one year from the last event. List other action you've taken, and its status, in Section G of the form.

Write this down

Date of each event · what happened · date one year after the last one.

12.12 The Ombudsman and the Child and Youth Advocate

You might be hearing

— "Try the Ombudsman."

— "The Child Advocate can help."

— "Call the Advocate's office."

— "The Ombudsman investigates government."

What's going on

The Alberta Ombudsman cannot investigate complaints about schools or school divisions. Its own site says so. Don't build a file for it for a school complaint.

The Office of the Child and Youth Advocate (OCYA) helps young people who are receiving "designated services": child intervention (under the Child, Youth and Family Enhancement Act), services under the Protection of Sexually Exploited Children Act, and youth justice. Its advocates focus on those services. Education is one of the outcomes it names. If your child gets one of those services and school is part of the problem, call and ask whether it's in scope. If your child doesn't, the OCYA may refer you elsewhere.

What the rules say

The Ombudsman: "The Alberta Ombudsman does not have jurisdiction to investigate complaints about schools and universities." It says to contact "your school, school district office ... directly to ask about complaints and appeal options."

The OCYA: designated services are "A service under the Child, Youth and Family Enhancement Act (CYFEA), other than adoption," "A service under the Protection of Sexually Exploited Children Act," and "A service provided to young people in the youth justice system." "The focus of individual advocacy is the designated service, not the young person's family." Education is named as an outcome advocacy can help secure.

Source: Alberta Ombudsman, "Universities & Schools", read 23 Oct 2026; Office of the Child and Youth Advocate, Individual Advocacy Services Policy Manual, v1.0, 1 Oct 2024, ss.1.4, 2.1 and 3.4.

Say this

"My child receives [child intervention / youth justice] services, and school is part of the problem. Is that something an advocate can help with?"

Ask for this in writing

From the OCYA: whether your child's issue is within its scope, and if not, the referral it suggests.

If you don't get it

OCYA: 1-800-661-3446. For school decisions, use 12.2 to 12.7.

Write this down

Date called · who you spoke to · whether it's in scope · referral given.

12.13 Your MLA

You might be hearing

- "Have you called your MLA?"
- "Write to the Minister."
- "Politicians can't get involved in school decisions."
- "Copy your MLA on it."

What's going on

Your MLA (Member of the Legislative Assembly) is the person elected to represent the area where you live in the Alberta Legislature. You can write to their constituency office and ask what they can do.

An MLA can't overturn a school or board decision. In the Education Act, appeals go to the board and reviews go to the Minister. Copying your MLA can be useful for problems that go beyond your child, such as a gap in provincial rules.

What the rules say

The Education Act gives the decision on an appeal to the board, and the review of a board decision to the Minister. No role is given to an MLA in either step.

To find your MLA, the Legislative Assembly says: "Please visit the Elections Alberta web site to determine your MLA using your full address."

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.42(7) and 44(1) and (2) (law); Legislative Assembly of Alberta, "Find your MLA", read 23 Oct 2026.

Say this

"I live in your constituency. I've used the school and board processes. I'm writing about a gap in provincial rules that affects children like mine."

Ask for this in writing

A reply from the constituency office saying what the MLA will do with your letter, and copies of any letters sent on your behalf.

If you don't get it

Keep your own case moving through 12.2 to 12.7. MLA letters run alongside the process, not instead of it.

Write this down

Date · MLA's office · what you sent · reply date · what they did.

12.14 The courts, and the Complex Education Needs Tribunal

You might be hearing

— "You'd have to take us to court."

— "That's a legal matter."

— "There's a tribunal for complex cases."

— "The board can refer it to a tribunal."

What's going on

Courts: a court can review whether a public body made a decision lawfully. That's called judicial review. It can be expensive and slow, and it has strict

time limits. If you're thinking about it, get legal advice quickly. This book can't advise you on it.

The Complex Education Needs Tribunal: the Education Act lets a board refer a student whose needs it says it can't meet to a tribunal, which would confirm that or tell the board it can. The Minister "may" set up such a tribunal. We could find no record that one has ever been established.

What the rules say

"A board may determine that a student requires specialized supports and services that cannot be met in an education program that may be provided by the board." The board "shall refer the matter to a Complex Education Needs Tribunal." "The Minister may establish one or more Complex Education Needs Tribunals." A parent may ask the Minister in writing to review a tribunal's confirmation or plan.

Source: Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, s.40(1), (2), (7) and (9) (law, read in the consolidation current 1 Sept 2026); searches for an establishing order, 13 and 23 Oct 2026: none found.

Say this

"Has the board made a determination under section 40 about my child? If so, I'd like it in writing."

Ask for this in writing

Whether the board has made any determination under s.40 of the Education Act about my child, and if so, the determination and its date.

If you don't get it

For a court, speak to a lawyer. For everything else, use 12.2 to 12.7.

Write this down

Date · what was said about court or a tribunal · who said it.

12.15 The deadlines, in one table

You might be hearing

— "There's no deadline, take your time."

— "Let's wait until the end of term."

— "You can always appeal later."

— "We'll deal with it after the review."

What's going on

Some routes have a firm deadline. Some have "a reasonable time". Some run in business days, which skip weekends and holidays. Several can run at once. The human rights deadline in particular does not wait for any other process to finish.

Put each date in your calendar the day the clock starts.

Route	Deadline	Clock starts	Entry
Appeal to the board	"Within a reasonable time." Check the board's own procedure	When you're told of the decision	12.6
Board's decision on appeal	"Forthwith", in writing	When the board gets your appeal	12.6
Minister's review	60 days (set in the Act for supports and expulsion; the department applies it to all four kinds)	When you're told of the board's decision	12.7
ATPC, incompetence	2 years	When it occurred	12.9
ATPC, conduct	Any time		12.9
ATPC, appeal of "no further action"	15 days, plus a fee	When you're served with the decision	12.9
Board's answer to an access request	30 business days (may be extended up to 30 more)	When your request is complete	11.7
OIPC review of an access decision	60 business days (up to 30 more business days if the Commissioner allows)	When you're told of the decision, or the deadline passes	12.10
Privacy complaint	First to the board; wait 30 business days; then 60 business days to go	When the board responds	12.10

Route	Deadline	Clock starts	Entry
	to OIPC		
OIPC review of a refused correction	60 business days	When you're told of the decision	11.9
Human Rights Commission	1 year, cannot be extended	The last event of discrimination	12.11
Courts	Strict; get legal advice	Varies	12.14

What the rules say

Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3, ss.42(2) and (8), 43(2), 225.93 and 225.95(2) (law); alberta.ca, "Review by the Minister of Education"; Access to Information Act, SA 2024 c.A-1.4, ss.13, 16 and 60(2)(a) (law); OIPC pages dated June 2025; Alberta Human Rights Act, s.20(2)(b), and Alberta Human Rights Commission, "Human Rights Complaint Guide".

No Alberta law sets a fixed number of days for a board appeal. That means the board's own procedure, and "a reasonable time", decide it. Don't wait.

Source: as listed above, read or carried forward October 2026.

Say this

"What's the deadline for the next step, and when does the clock start? Please confirm it in writing."

Ask for this in writing

The deadline for [next step] under the board's procedure, and the date the board considers the clock to have started.

If you don't get it

Use the earliest date that could apply, and act before it.

Write this down

Route · date clock started · deadline date · date you acted.

Chapter 13: The school year, month by month

What happens when in an Alberta school year, which dates are set by the province and which by your division, and what to ask for before each one passes.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/13

How to read this chapter: the dates below are for the 2026-27 school year. Where a date is set by Alberta, it is given with its source. Where your division sets it, the entry says so and tells you what to ask for. A date this chapter can't source is not printed.

Turn here when you're hearing

— "We'll sort out supports once we get to know them." → 13.1

— "The calendar's on the website somewhere." → 13.1

— "We write the IPPs in October." → 13.2

— "Their code carries over automatically." → 13.3

— "It's just a screener, don't worry about it." → 13.4

— "Reports go home at the end of the term." → 13.5

— "It's too late to register for this year's funding." → 13.6

— "Accommodations for the test are decided by the school." → 13.7

— "The winter screening is for everyone." → 13.8

— "Registration for next year opens in the new year." → 13.9

— "We'll talk about next year in June." → 13.10

— "Only kids who need it do the spring screening." → 13.11

— "You'll get the final IPP in the fall." → 13.12

— "Nothing happens over the summer." → 13.13

— "There's no deadline on that." → 13.14

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
13.1	Before school starts: August

Entry	Title
13.2	September: the new IPP
13.3	September: count day and your child's code
13.4	Late September and October: the fall screening
13.5	October and November: the first reporting period
13.6	November: the preschool funding deadline
13.7	November and December: test accommodations for January
13.8	January: the winter screening and the second semester
13.9	February and March: registration and the June test deadline
13.10	April: planning next year starts now
13.11	May: the spring screening and the end-of-year meeting
13.12	June: tests, the year-end summary and the last copies
13.13	Summer: what keeps running
13.14	The clocks that don't follow the school calendar

13.1 Before school starts: August

You might be hearing

— "We'll sort out supports once we get to know them."

— "The calendar's on the website somewhere."

— "Just fill in the registration form like last year."

— "We'll be in touch once school starts."

What's going on

The first weeks set the pattern for the year. If supports aren't in place on day one, they can take weeks to arrive. August is when you lock down three

things: the school calendar, your copy of everything you hand in, and who is responsible for your child on the first day.

Fill in the registration form in full every year, even if the school "already has it": every diagnosis, every medication, every emergency instruction. Keep a copy. Some divisions say the medical part of the IPP (Individualized Program Plan, the written plan for a student with special education needs) is filled in from that form (see 4.7).

What the rules say

Your board must "determine and make publicly available for each school year the days, dates and number of days of school operation" (Education Act s.60). That's law. The calendar is public, so you can ask for it.

Alberta's IPP guidance says "Planning for transition begins each September" and the IPP must contain information about upcoming transitions. For a child changing schools or levels, it suggests a meeting at the end of the school year "and a follow-up progress meeting for early fall". That is guidance ("should"), not law.

Source: Education Act s.60, consolidated to 1 September 2026, law. Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.13 and Chapter 8 pp.6-7, guidance.

Say this

"Before the first day, can you tell me who will be with my child, which supports start on day one, and when we'll meet about the IPP?"

Ask for this in writing

The 2026-27 school calendar with reporting period dates, the name of the staff member responsible for your child's IPP this year, the supports in place from the first day, and the date of the first IPP meeting.

If you don't get it

Bring your own copy of last year's IPP and registration form to the first day and ask for a meeting in the first two weeks (see 4.11). If supports from last year's IPP are missing, see 13.2 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · who you asked · supports promised for day one · date of the first IPP meeting · copy of registration form kept (yes/no).

Your division may also have

A division calendar with board-set reporting periods and parent-teacher interview dates. Ask for both in August.

13.2 September: the new IPP

You might be hearing

— "We write the IPPs in October."

— "We need a few weeks to get to know them first."

— "Last year's IPP still applies until the new one's done."

— "We'll send it home for you to sign."

What's going on

Most IPPs are rewritten at the start of each school year. Until the new one is written, ask in writing which plan is in force, because a gap between plans is a gap in supports. A support that worked last year can quietly drop off at the start of a new year if nobody carries it over.

Signing is consent, not a receipt (see 4.6). You can read the plan first.

What the rules say

Alberta's IPP guidance says "Typically, IPPs are developed at the beginning of each school year" and parents "will be invited to sign the IPP at the beginning of the school year when goals and objectives have been developed, and at each reporting period throughout the school year."

No Alberta law or standard sets a date by which the IPP must be written. That means the date is your division's to set, and yours to ask for.

Source: Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 pp.4 and 16, guidance restating the Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004 (Ministerial Order 015/2004).

Say this

"Which IPP is in force today, last year's or a new one? What date will the new one be ready for me to read?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation of which IPP is in force as of [date], the date the 2026-27 IPP draft will be sent to you, and a list of any support from last year's IPP that is not continuing, with the reason and who decided.

If you don't get it

If a support has stopped with no written reason, ask who decided and on what date. A decision that significantly affects your child's education can be appealed to the board (Education Act s.42). See chapter 12. For goals you haven't seen before the meeting, see 4.3.

Write this down

Date · which IPP is in force · date the new draft was promised · any support dropped and the reason given.

13.3 September: count day and your child's code

You might be hearing

- "Their code carries over automatically."
- "Coding is just for funding, it doesn't change anything."
- "We don't share codes with parents."
- "The code's under review."

What's going on

Alberta counts enrolment on one day each fall: the September count date. A code is the special education category your child is recorded under (for example a learning disability, or a severe physical or medical disability). In public schools, Grade 1 to 12 funding for supports comes as a block grant to the division, not a cheque per child. But codes still matter: they are reported to the province, some funding still depends on them (for example PUF for young children, see 13.6), and a code can change without anyone telling you.

Ask every fall what code your child holds and whether it changed since last year.

What the rules say

The September count date for 2026-27 is 29 September 2026. Funding is calculated from enrolment on that date. The provincial coding criteria are published each year in the Special Education Coding Criteria, which says each category "is given a code for the purpose of reporting special education data to Alberta Education and Childcare" and that school authority staff assign the code. For Grades 1 to 12 in public, separate and francophone divisions, the Specialized Learning Supports grant goes to the whole division, which is "responsible for ensuring their SLS funding is disbursed based on child/student needs".

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27 (Education and Childcare), Sections C1 and C2.1, provincial funding policy. Special Education Coding Criteria ECS to Grade 12, 2026/2027, Introduction, provincial policy.

Say this

"What special education code is my child recorded under this year? Has it changed since last year? If it has, what was it based on?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's special education code as recorded at the 29 September 2026 count date, whether it changed from 2025-26, and if it changed, the date, who decided and the documents used.

If you don't get it

As a parent you can review your child's student record and ask for a copy (Education Act s.56(3) and (4)). Ask for a copy of the student record. If the code changed on a reading of a report you sent in, check it against the published coding criteria and challenge it in writing. See chapter 6 and chapter 11.

Write this down

Date · code this year · code last year · who told you · what it was based on.

13.4 Late September and October: the fall screening

You might be hearing

— "It's just a screener, don't worry about it."

— "Everyone in the grade does it."

— "The results don't mean anything on their own."

— "If they need help, we'll let you know."

What's going on

Since 1 September 2026, Alberta law requires literacy and numeracy screening from kindergarten to Grade 3. A screener is a short check, not a diagnosis. In the fall it covers Grades 1 to 3 under the law. Alberta Education also requires a fall screening in Grades 4 and 5 from this year, but that comes from provincial policy, not from the Act or the regulation. You are owed the results.

Two rules in the Act matter for kindergarten to Grade 3. First, where the results show difficulty, intervention support must follow. Second, a board can't use the screening result to decide that your child needs specialized supports and services. That decision has its own process (see chapter 5), so a screening result, good or bad, is not a substitute for an assessment.

What the rules say

The fall window for Grades 1 to 3 in 2026-27 is 14 September to 2 October 2026 (AR 44/2026, Schedule). The Act's screening rules cover "kindergarten to grade 3" (s.30.1(b)), and so does AR 44/2026. Alberta's screening bulletin says "Grades 4 and 5 screenings are required through policy" and gives the same fall window for them.

A board "must ensure that results of the literacy and numeracy screening assessment are reported to the parent" (Education Act s.30.4(1)). The bulletin says "Reports should be provided to the parent within six weeks of the screener administration." Where the Minister determines the results show difficulty, the board "must ensure that literacy and numeracy intervention supports" are provided (s.30.51(1)). A board "shall not use the results of a literacy and numeracy screening assessment to make a determination under section 11(3) that a student is in need of specialized supports and services" (s.30.51(3)).

A board may exempt a child (s.30.3(2)). The bulletin says the principal recommends an exemption to the superintendent after consulting the parent and teacher, and a parent asks the principal in writing.

Source: Education Act ss.30.1, 30.3, 30.4, 30.51, in force 1 September 2026, law. Literacy and Numeracy Screening Assessments Regulation, AR 44/2026, Schedule, regulation. Literacy and Numeracy Screenings General Information Bulletin 2026-2027, pp.6, 10, 11, 16, provincial policy (Grades 4 and 5) and guidance. alberta.ca, Literacy and numeracy screening.

Say this

"When will I get my child's screening results? If they show difficulty, what intervention will they get, how often, and from whom?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's fall 2026 screening results, the date they were sent, and if difficulty was found, the named intervention, its frequency, the person delivering it and its start date.

If you don't get it

Ask again in writing once six weeks have passed since 2 October. If difficulty was found and no intervention has started, put s.30.51(1) to the principal in writing. If you were told the screening shows your child doesn't need an assessment, point out that under s.30.51(3) the screening isn't the tool for deciding specialized supports, and ask for your assessment request to be handled on its own (see chapter 5).

Write this down

Date screened · date results received · result · intervention named · start date.

13.5 October and November: the first reporting period

You might be hearing

- "Reports go home at the end of the term."
- "We'll update the IPP at the end of the year."
- "Progress is ongoing."
- "The report card covers it."

What's going on

A reporting period is the stretch of the year that ends with a report card or progress report. Your division sets the dates. Alberta's guidance ties IPP reviews to those same dates, so the first reporting period is the first point at which the IPP should show written progress on each goal, with a date.

"Ongoing" is not a review (see 4.4).

What the rules say

The 2004 Standards require teachers to "document, in the IPP, the formal review of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods" and boards to "inform parents of students' progress, at regularly scheduled reporting periods, throughout the year". Alberta's IPP guidance adds: "Typically, IPP reviews align with the school's regular reporting periods. These are generally scheduled three to four times per year," and "Checkmarks or vague terms such as 'ongoing' do not adequately describe what a student has achieved."

No provincial rule sets the reporting dates. Your board does.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standards 11(f) and 13(b), under Ministerial Order 015/2004. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.14, guidance.

Say this

"When is the first reporting period this year? On that date, can I see a written comment on each IPP goal?"

Ask for this in writing

The reporting period dates for 2026-27, and a dated written progress comment on each IPP goal at the first reporting period.

If you don't get it

If the IPP has no dated review after the reporting period, it is missing a required element (see 4.2). Ask the principal in writing for the review by a set date. Then chapter 12.

Write this down

Date of the reporting period · date you got the IPP review · goals with a written comment · goals without one.

13.6 November: the preschool funding deadline

You might be hearing

— "It's too late to register for this year's funding."

— "We'll do the paperwork after the assessment comes back."

— "PUF is the school's business, not yours."

— "There's always next year."

What's going on

PUF (Program Unit Funding) is provincial money paid to a school authority, not to you, for a preschool or kindergarten child with a severe disability or severe language delay. It is time-limited: three years at most, and the kindergarten year counts as one. Registration after the November deadline gets half the money and still uses up a whole year.

If your child is in pre-kindergarten or kindergarten and may qualify, November is the month to push.

What the rules say

Children "Registered by November 30, 2026, with proof of assessment and the reporting of hours completed" are eligible for up to three years of funding including kindergarten. Children registered from 1 December 2026 to 1 February 2027 get "50 per cent of the per child total funding rate", and "Registration for the late count date is considered to use 1 year of PUF eligibility." Eligibility needs both an assessment by a qualified professional and documentation of the impact on the child's learning. "School jurisdictions are responsible for determining the PUF eligibility." For a moderate language delay (code 48), assessments "must be completed by November 30, 2026".

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, Section C2.7.1 criteria 1 to 6 and C2.7.2 criterion 3, provincial funding policy.

Say this

"Has my child been registered for PUF for this year? Is the assessment and the paperwork in by November 30?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation of whether your child was registered for PUF by 30 November 2026, the date the eligibility documentation was completed, and if not registered, the reason and who decided.

If you don't get it

The decision is made and the file is kept by the school authority. Ask for a copy of the eligibility documentation. No published appeal route specific to PUF was found. If the program is run by a school board, a board decision about specialized supports for a child in an early childhood services program can go to the Minister for review, asked for in writing within 60 days (Education Act s.43). See 14.2 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date asked · registered by 30 November (yes/no) · assessment date · who decided.

13.7 November and December: test accommodations for January

You might be hearing

— "Accommodations for the test are decided by the school."

— "They can only have what they use in class."

— "Your child doesn't have to write it."

— "There's nothing extra you can apply for."

What's going on

PATs (Provincial Achievement Tests) are written in Grades 6 and 9. Diploma exams are written in some Grade 12 courses. Most accommodations, like extra time or a reader, are decided by the school, with no application to the province. A few unusual ones need an application to Alberta's Special Cases and Accommodations Team, with a deadline.

Some Grade 9 PATs and a diploma exam sitting run in January, so the deadline falls in November.

What the rules say

For 2026-27 PATs: "Students are eligible for regular accommodations and provisions without an application process," students "must use the accommodation during regular classroom instruction and assessment," and decisions by school personnel are official and must be told to the parent. The deadline to apply for unique accommodations is 27 November 2026 for the January 2027 tests. Grade 9 PATs run 18 to 27 January 2027 for some courses. "Only a superintendent, on an individual basis, may excuse a student from writing a PAT."

Diploma exams are given in November 2026 and January, April, June and August 2027. Regular diploma accommodations need no provincial application and must be used regularly in class.

The 2004 Standards require boards to make special provisions for testing available "throughout the course of the year, as required".

Source: Provincial Achievement Tests General Information Bulletin 2026-27, pp.7, 14, 26, 42. Diploma Examinations Program General Information Bulletin 2026-27, pp.11-15, 50. Both provincial policy. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 15(a).

Say this

"Which accommodations will my child have on the provincial test? Are they ones they use in class now? Does any need an application, and by what date?"

Ask for this in writing

The list of accommodations your child will have for each 2026-27 PAT or diploma exam, confirmation that each is used in class now, and whether any unique accommodation application was sent, with the date sent.

If you don't get it

If you disagree with a school's accommodation decision, the bulletin says to contact the school authority. Put it to the principal in writing, then see chapter 12. If an accommodation isn't used in class now, ask for it to start now and be written in the IPP (see 4.2).

Write this down

Date · test and date · accommodations agreed · unique application sent (date) · who decided.

13.8 January: the winter screening and the second semester

You might be hearing

— "The winter screening is for everyone."

— "New semester, new teachers, they'll catch up."

— "Kindergarten doesn't have testing."

— "The IPP is in the system, they can look it up."

What's going on

January brings the second literacy and numeracy screening for Grades 1 to 3 and the only one for kindergarten. For Grades 4 and 5, Alberta's bulletin says a winter screening is not required but is recommended. In junior and senior high, many schools start a new semester, which can mean new teachers who have not read the IPP. A plan nobody has read isn't in force in that classroom.

What the rules say

The winter window for kindergarten and Grades 1 to 3 is 18 January to 5 February 2027 (AR 44/2026, Schedule). Results must be reported to the parent (Education Act s.30.4).

The 2004 Standards require that principals "identify teachers whose responsibility it is to coordinate, develop, implement, monitor and evaluate student IPPs". "Required accommodations must be listed on the IPP" (IPP guidance).

Semester dates are set by your board, not the province.

Source: AR 44/2026, Schedule, regulation. Education Act s.30.4, law. Literacy and Numeracy Screenings General Information Bulletin 2026-2027, p.11, provincial policy. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(d). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.12, guidance.

Say this

"My child has new teachers this semester. Has each one read the IPP? Who is the person responsible for it now?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation that each teacher in the new semester has the IPP, the name of the teacher now responsible for coordinating it, and your child's winter screening results with the date sent.

If you don't get it

Send the IPP accommodations list to each teacher yourself and copy the principal. If accommodations aren't being given, see chapter 7. For junior and senior high transitions, see 14.7.

Write this down

Date · new teachers' names · who confirmed they read the IPP · winter screening result received (date).

13.9 February and March: registration and the June test deadline

You might be hearing

- "Registration for next year opens in the new year."
- "We'll see if there's space."
- "Kindergarten registration is first come, first served."
- "Talk to the new school in the fall."

What's going on

Many divisions open registration for the next school year in late winter. The dates are set locally. If you're asking for a particular school or a specialized program, this is when the answer gets decided, not in August.

March is also when the province's deadline falls for unusual accommodations on the June provincial tests.

What the rules say

A board must enrol your child in the school you ask for "if, in the opinion of the board asked to enrol the student, there are sufficient resources and facilities available to accommodate the student" (Education Act s.10(2)). Students living in a school's attendance area get priority (s.10(3)).

No province-wide registration date was found. Your division sets it.

The deadline to apply for unique accommodations for the June 2027 PATs is 5 March 2027. The late PUF registration window closes 1 February 2027 (see 13.6).

Source: Education Act s.10, law. Provincial Achievement Tests General Information Bulletin 2026-27, p.41, provincial policy. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, C2.7.1.

Say this

"When does registration for next year open and close? If I ask for a particular school or program, when and how will I hear the answer?"

Ask for this in writing

Your division's registration dates for 2027-28, the date you'll be told whether your requested school or program can take your child, and if not, the written reason.

If you don't get it

A refusal of the school you asked for is a decision you can ask the board to explain and, if it significantly affects your child's education, appeal (s.42). See 14.5 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date registered · school or program requested · date of answer · reason given.

Your division may also have

Program-of-choice or specialized-setting applications with earlier deadlines than general registration. Ask in January.

13.10 April: planning next year starts now

You might be hearing

— "We'll talk about next year in June."

— "Staffing isn't confirmed until the fall."

— "The new school will do their own plan."

— "Let's see how the rest of the year goes."

What's going on

A move to a new school, a new level (elementary to junior high, junior high to senior high) or a new program goes better when it's planned before the summer. Spring is when the sending school and the receiving school can still talk to each other. The IPP has a transition section for this reason. Leaving it blank until September is how supports go missing.

What the rules say

The IPP must contain "transition plans" (2004 Standards, definition of IPP). Transition planning is defined to include changes "between grades/levels of schooling" and to involve "receiving school staff".

Alberta's IPP guidance says to "Ensure documentation is in place prior to the move", listing the "registration form – current and preceding IPPs – current assessment results – medical information – classroom assessment results – listing of supports in place", and to "Host a team meeting with the receiving school". That is guidance.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions pp.4-5. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 8 pp.6-7 and Appendix 8-A (Chapter 8 p.15), guidance.

Say this

"My child is moving next year. Who is writing the transition plan, and when is the meeting with the new school?"

Ask for this in writing

The name of the person writing the transition section of the IPP, the date of a transition meeting with the receiving school before the end of June, and the list of documents that will go to the new school.

If you don't get it

Ask the principal in writing for the transition meeting by a set date in May. See 14.5 to 14.8 for each kind of move, and 4.12 on what happens to the IPP.

Write this down

Date asked · who is writing the transition plan · meeting date · documents to be sent.

13.11 May: the spring screening and the end-of-year meeting

You might be hearing

— "Only kids who need it do the spring screening."

— "After this, the extra help is optional."

— "We'll do the year-end meeting if there's time."

— "Goals for next year get set in September."

What's going on

In Grades 1 to 3, a third screening in spring is only for children whose fall or winter screening showed difficulty. If that third screening still shows difficulty, the law no longer requires intervention support in that year: it is allowed, not required. Ask now what happens next fall.

May is also when to book the end-of-year IPP meeting, before the June rush.

What the rules say

In Grades 1 to 3, where the fall or winter screening shows difficulty, "a third screening assessment of that student must be conducted and concluded within a 3-week period in spring" (AR 44/2026 s.4(1) and (2)). The 2026-27 spring window is 10 to 28 May 2027. Where a third screening in a single school year still shows difficulty, intervention supports are "permitted but not required" (Education Act s.30.51(2)).

Alberta's IPP guidance for students changing schools says "If possible, schedule a meeting at the end of the school year and a follow-up progress meeting for early fall."

Source: AR 44/2026 s.4(2) and Schedule, regulation. Education Act s.30.51(2), law. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 8 pp.6-7, guidance.

Say this

"If the spring screening still shows difficulty, what support will my child have next September? Can we book the year-end IPP meeting now?"

Ask for this in writing

Your child's spring screening results, the intervention planned for September 2027, and a date for the year-end IPP meeting before the last week of June.

If you don't get it

The screening is not the only route to help. Ask in writing for a referral for assessment (see chapter 5). If the year-end meeting isn't booked by June, see 13.12.

Write this down

Date · spring screening result · plan for September · year-end meeting date.

13.12 June: tests, the year-end summary and the last copies

You might be hearing

- "You'll get the final IPP in the fall."
- "The year-end summary is just for us."
- "They don't need to write the PAT."
- "Let's leave that decision for next year."

What's going on

June is crowded: provincial tests, the last report card, and the IPP's year-end summary. The year-end summary is what next year's teacher reads first. It is your best chance to make sure what worked this year carries over.

Any decision made in June, such as a placement, repeating a grade or a support ending, should be in writing before school closes, with who decided and when. A decision nobody wrote down is hard to appeal.

What the rules say

The IPP must include a "year-end summary" (2004 Standards, definition of IPP). Alberta's guidance says it "describes what goals, accommodations and strategies were most successful" and "should also include recommendations for new goals, accommodations that should be continued and programming considerations for the upcoming school year".

The 2026-27 Grade 6 and Grade 9 PATs run from 31 May to 22 June 2027. Only a superintendent may excuse a student from a PAT, on the principal's recommendation after consulting the parent and teacher. Grade 6 students will not write the Social Studies PAT this year.

Source: Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions p.4. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.15, guidance. Provincial Achievement Tests General Information Bulletin 2026-27, pp.7, 8, 14, 42, provincial policy.

Say this

"Before school ends, can I have a copy of the year-end summary and the final IPP? And any decision about next year, in writing, with who made it?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of the 2026-27 IPP with the year-end summary, dated, before the last day of school, and written confirmation of any decision about next year's placement, grade or supports, with the date and the name of the person who decided.

If you don't get it

Ask the principal again in writing before the last day. A decision that significantly affects your child's education, and a failure to make one, can be appealed to the board (Education Act s.42(1) and (2)). See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · year-end summary received (yes/no) · decisions about next year · who made each one.

13.13 Summer: what keeps running

You might be hearing

— "Nothing happens over the summer."

— "The office is closed until August."

— "We'll deal with it in the fall."

— "Your appeal can wait until school's back."

What's going on

Schools close. Legal deadlines don't. If a decision was made in June, the time to ask the Minister to review it, or to make a human rights complaint, keeps counting through July and August. FSCD agreements (Family Support for Children with Disabilities, a provincial program outside school) also keep their own dates.

Summer is also the time to put your records in order: every IPP version, the year-end summary, report cards, screening results, the registration form.

What the rules say

A request for the Minister to review a board decision about specialized supports and services, or an expulsion, "must be made within 60 days" of the date you were told of the decision (Education Act s.43(2)). A human rights complaint must "be made within one year after the alleged contravention" (Alberta Human Rights Act s.20(2)(b)). The Alberta Human Rights Commission says this limit "cannot be extended for any reason".

Diploma exams also run in August 2027.

Source: Education Act s.43, law. Alberta Human Rights Act s.20(2)(b), law. Alberta Human Rights Commission, Human Rights Complaint Guide. Diploma Examinations Program General Information Bulletin 2026-27, p.15.

Say this

"Who at the division is the contact over the summer for an appeal or a decision about my child's supports?"

Ask for this in writing

The name and contact details of the person at the division who handles appeals and special education decisions during July and August 2027.

If you don't get it

Write to the superintendent's office and keep proof of when you sent it. Count your deadlines from the date you were told of the decision, not from when school reopens. See 13.14 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date of the decision · date you were told · day 60 · date you sent your request.

13.14 The clocks that don't follow the school calendar

You might be hearing

— "There's no deadline on that."

— "Let's try the review first and see."

— "Your agreement will roll over."

— "Just wait for the letter."

What's going on

Some deadlines start from a decision or an expiry date, not from the school year. Missing one can close a door for good. This entry collects them in one place so you can put them in your calendar the day the decision arrives.

What the rules say

School decisions:

— Appeal to the board: "within a reasonable time" of being told, after following the board's school dispute resolution policy (Education Act s.42(2) and (3)). No fixed number of days is set in the Act. Your board's appeal procedure may set one.

— Request for Minister's review of a board decision on specialized supports and services, or an expulsion: within 60 days (s.43(2)).

— Human rights complaint: within one year (Alberta Human Rights Act s.20(2)(b)).

FSCD (Assisted Living and Social Services):

— Appeal: 45 days. The FSCD Act sets this (s.7(2)), counted from the date you were told of the decision. The manual says 45 calendar days from the written decision (10.4).

— Review of an FSCD program decision: 30 calendar days to request (manual 10.2). Asking for a review does not pause the appeal clock: "The 45 calendar day time limit for submission of a notice of appeal is not suspended when a parent or guardian requests a review of an FSCD program decision" (10.2).

— Agreement review starts "no less than 60 calendar days" before an agreement expires (manual 6.5).

The 45-day appeal limit is in the Act. The review and agreement timelines are policy-manual rules, which can be changed without the Legislature.

Source: Education Act ss.42, 43, law. Alberta Human Rights Act s.20, law. Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act s.7, law. FSCD Policy Manual 6.5, 10.2, 10.4 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy.

Say this

"What is the deadline for me to appeal this, and from what date does it count?"

Ask for this in writing

The decision itself in writing, the date it was made, the date you were told, and the appeal or review route with its deadline.

If you don't get it

Count from the date you were told and act before the shortest deadline. For FSCD, because a review doesn't pause the 45 days, you can file the notice of appeal first and then ask for the review (see 16.9). For school decisions, see chapter 12.

Write this down

Date of decision · date told · deadline · route · date filed.

Chapter 14: Transitions

Starting preschool, kindergarten and Grade 1, changing schools, moving to junior and senior high, staying in school past 18, and what changes at 16 and 18.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/14

Turn here when you're hearing

— "Preschool spots are limited." → 14.1

— "PUF is only for three years." → 14.2

— "Kindergarten isn't part of the school system." → 14.3

— "Grade 1 is a fresh start." → 14.4

— "The funding doesn't follow them to Grade 1." → 14.4

— "Supports will look the same wherever they're placed." → 14.5

— "That support was transitional." → 14.5

— "We'll wait for the file from the old division." → 14.6

— "In junior high, they need to learn to advocate for themselves." → 14.7

— "Not every teacher needs to see the IPP." → 14.7

— "They'll still graduate." → 14.8

— "The -4 courses are a better fit." → 14.9

— "Now they're 16, they can sign for themselves." → 14.10

— "They age out at 19." → 14.11

— "Once they're 18, we deal with them, not you." → 14.12

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
14.1	Starting preschool
14.2	"PUF is only for three years"
14.3	Starting kindergarten
14.4	Starting Grade 1
14.5	Changing schools in the same division
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Entry	Title
14.7	Junior high: many teachers, one plan
14.8	Senior high: diploma, certificate, or neither
14.9	A program change that closes a door later
14.10	Turning 16
14.11	Staying in school to 19 or 20
14.12	Turning 18

14.1 Starting preschool

You might be hearing

— "Preschool spots are limited."

— "Wait until they're older and see how they do."

— "You'll need a diagnosis first."

— "There's a fee for preschool."

What's going on

In Alberta, preschool and kindergarten are called ECS (Early Childhood Services). A child with a severe disability or a moderate or severe language delay can start pre-kindergarten earlier than other children. Starting early matters, because the extra funding for these children runs for three years at most (see 14.2).

ECS is run by school boards and by approved private operators. Your local board is the first call.

What the rules say

Alberta says children with a severe disability or a moderate or severe language delay "may start pre-Kindergarten at age 2 years 8 months as of August 31". Other children may begin at 3 years 8 months.

A board or approved operator may provide ECS to a child younger than 6 on 1 September "if the parent of the child requests it" (Education Act s.21(1)), and may charge the parent fees (s.21(6)).

Alberta's Standards for the Provision of Early Childhood Special Education (2006) say the ECS programs they cover must "ensure IPPs are developed, implemented, monitored and evaluated for all children identified with special education needs", with parents involved and parents signing "to indicate agreement with the IPP, or attempts to obtain the signature are documented". The document names no ministerial order and cites the repealed School Act; Alberta still lists it among its standards.

Source: alberta.ca, Early childhood education (published 30 July 2026). Education Act s.21, law. Standards for the Provision of Early Childhood Special Education (Alberta Education, September 2006), p.13 requirement 8, provincial standard.

Say this

"My child has a [disability or language delay]. Can they start pre-kindergarten at 2 years 8 months? What do you need from me to apply?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether your child can be offered a pre-kindergarten place for September [year], the documents the operator needs, any fee, and the date the IPP will be written.

If you don't get it

Ask another ECS operator in your area: boards and approved private operators both run programs. Write down each answer. Funding deadlines are in 13.6.

Write this down

Date · operator · place offered (yes/no) · documents asked for · fee.

14.2 "PUF is only for three years"

You might be hearing

— "PUF is only for three years."

— "It's too late to register for funding this year."

— "We decide who qualifies."

— "Kindergarten counts as one of the years."

What's going on

PUF (Program Unit Funding) is money Alberta pays to the school authority, not to you, for a preschool or kindergarten child with a severe disability or severe language delay. It pays for a program with more support than a regular ECS class. It lasts three years at most, and the kindergarten year is one of them. A child who starts later gets fewer years.

The school authority decides who qualifies and keeps the file. You can ask to see what it decided and why.

What the rules say

PUF is allocated "for a maximum of three years including the kindergarten year". A child must be at least 2 years 8 months on 31 August and under 6 on 1 September. Eligibility is "based on all of the following": an assessment by a qualified professional, and documentation of the severity of the impact on learning. "School jurisdictions are responsible for determining the PUF eligibility." Late registration (1 December 2026 to 1 February 2027) pays 50 per cent and "is considered to use 1 year of PUF eligibility". A program must give access to minimum hours (for example 475 hours for a half-day program for a child 4 years 8 months or older), and the school authority "may only claim the teacher directed instruction hours ... that they have made available to that child".

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27 (Education and Childcare), C2.7.1 criteria 1 to 8, provincial funding policy.

Say this

"Is my child registered for PUF? Which year of the three is this? How many hours a year is the program giving them?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether your child is registered for PUF for 2026-27, which of their three PUF years this is, the number of teacher-directed hours made available this year, and if PUF was refused, the reason and the documents used.

If you don't get it

Ask for a copy of the PUF eligibility documentation (the file is kept by the school authority). No PUF-specific appeal route was found in the funding manual. If a school board runs the program, a board decision about

specialized supports for a child in an ECS program can go to the Minister for review, asked for in writing within 60 days (Education Act s.43). See chapter 6 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · PUF year (1, 2 or 3) · hours offered · who decided · reason if refused.

14.3 Starting kindergarten

You might be hearing

— "Kindergarten isn't part of the school system."

— "It's not mandatory, so supports are limited."

— "We'll assess them in Grade 1."

— "They'll grow out of it."

What's going on

Kindergarten is part of ECS, not Grade 1. School attendance becomes compulsory for a child who is 6 by 1 September. That affects your child's legal position: under the Education Act, a child under 6 in ECS is not yet a "student", so some rights that come with being a student don't apply yet.

But some rights do apply. With any ECS operator, you can see your child's record. If the kindergarten is run by a school board, you can also appeal decisions to the board and ask the Minister to review a board decision about specialized supports. And the ECS special education standards require an IPP for every child identified with special education needs.

What the rules say

Alberta says children "may start Kindergarten at age 4 years 8 months as of August 31". The Act makes school attendance compulsory from 6 (s.7(1)). A "student" under the Act "does not include a child younger than 6 years of age who is enrolled in an early childhood services program" (s.1(1)(hh)), and attending ECS does not by itself give a child "any of the rights or benefits given to a student" (s.21(7)).

But: the parent of "a child enrolled in an early childhood services program" can review the child's record (s.56(3)(c)). Where the program is

"operated by the board", a parent can appeal decisions that significantly affect the child's education (s.42(2)), and can ask the Minister to review a board decision on specialized supports to the child (s.43(1)(a)).

The ECS Standards (2006) say parents must be involved in IPPs and transition planning, and that when a child moves to Grade 1, information needed for ongoing programming is passed on "in a timely manner".

Source: alberta.ca, Early childhood education. Education Act ss.1(1)(hh), 7, 21(7), 42, 43, 56, law. Standards for the Provision of Early Childhood Special Education (2006), pp.11, 13, 14, provincial standard.

Say this

"My child is in kindergarten with an identified need. Can I see the IPP, and when do we start planning the move to Grade 1?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of your child's ECS IPP, the date of the next IPP review, and the date the Grade 1 transition planning meeting will happen.

If you don't get it

Your right to see the record applies in ECS (s.56). If a school board runs the program, so does the right to appeal (s.42). See chapter 11 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · IPP received (yes/no) · next review date · Grade 1 transition meeting date.

14.4 Starting Grade 1

You might be hearing

— "Grade 1 is a fresh start."

— "The funding doesn't follow them to Grade 1."

— "We'll see how they settle before we put anything in place."

— "The kindergarten plan was a different program."

What's going on

At Grade 1 your child becomes a "student" under the Education Act. That is when the board's duties under section 11 apply in full. PUF ends. In public schools, support for Grades 1 to 12 is paid out of a block grant to the whole division rather than a sum per child. So "the funding doesn't follow them" may be true. The duty to your child still does.

A year in which a child with known needs "settles in" with no plan is a lost year. Ask for the plan to be ready on day one.

What the rules say

A board must give each student enrolled in its schools "an education program ... that will give the student the opportunity to meet the standards of education set by the Minister" (s.11(2)). If a board decides the student needs specialized supports and services, the student "is entitled to have access to those supports and services" (s.11(4), subject to s.40). The board must consult the parent first (s.11(5)).

The 2004 Standards require an IPP for every student identified with special education needs (Standard 11(a)), and define transition planning to include "school entry".

For Grades 1 to 12 in public divisions, the Specialized Learning Supports grant goes to the whole division.

Source: Education Act s.11, law. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(a) and Definitions, under Ministerial Order 015/2004. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, C2.1.

Say this

"My child had an IPP in kindergarten. What supports will they have on the first day of Grade 1, and when is the first IPP meeting?"

Ask for this in writing

The supports in place for your child from the first day of Grade 1, the name of the teacher responsible for the IPP, and the date of the first IPP meeting.

If you don't get it

Bring the kindergarten IPP and assessments yourself (see 4.11). If the school says it will wait to decide, ask who decides, by what date, and put it

in writing. A failure to decide is itself appealable (s.42(1)). See 13.2 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · kindergarten IPP passed on (yes/no) · supports on day one · first IPP meeting date.

14.5 Changing schools in the same division

You might be hearing

— "Supports will look the same wherever they're placed."

— "That support was transitional."

— "The new school will do its own plan."

— "They're settling in well."

What's going on

When your child moves to another school in the same division, the record and the IPP should move too (see 4.12). What often doesn't move is the support itself: an EA (educational assistant) arrangement, a behaviour plan, a room set up a certain way. Support granted at the old school can be called "temporary" or "transitional" at the new one.

When a support is granted, ask in writing how long it lasts and what review would end it. At the new school, ask which version of any behaviour plan is in force.

What the rules say

A board must enrol your child in the school you ask for if, in its opinion, "there are sufficient resources and facilities available" (Education Act s.10(2)). During a school year, you can't ask for another school "unless the board operating the other school consents" (s.10(7)).

The student record must hold the current IPP and any amendments, plus summaries of IPPs from previous years (Student Record Regulation s.2(4)), and the rules on passing it to a new school are in s.8 (see 14.6). The IPP must contain transition plans (2004 Standards).

If your child is entitled to specialized supports and services and you don't live in the attendance area of any school that provides suitable ones,

the School Transportation Regulation says your resident board "must provide for the transportation of the student to and from the school that provides the specialized supports and services in which the board enrols the student" (s.5). Alberta's IPP guidance says to "Ensure that specific supports that need to be in place at the beginning of the year are included in the transition component of the IPP." The Student Support Policy Framework (2026, guidance) says decisions about a specialized setting need "Regular review and transition planning".

Source: Education Act s.10, law. Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019 s.2(4), current as of 1 September 2025, regulation. School Transportation Regulation, AR 96/2019 s.5, current as of 1 September 2025, regulation. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Definitions. Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 8 pp.6-7, guidance. Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026), 5.3.2(2.3), guidance.

Say this

"Which supports from the old school continue here, and which don't? For any that don't, who decided and why?"

Ask for this in writing

A list of the supports in your child's IPP at the old school, marked continuing or not continuing at the new school, with the reason and decision-maker for each one that isn't, the version and date of any behaviour plan now in force, and the transportation arranged if the school is outside your attendance area.

If you don't get it

A support stopped with no written reason is a decision you can ask the board to explain and appeal (s.42). See chapter 7 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date of move · supports continued · supports dropped · who decided · behaviour plan version in force.

14.6 Moving to a different division

You might be hearing

— "We'll wait for the file from the old division."

— "We do things differently here."

— "We'll need our own assessment."

— "Your child's code doesn't transfer."

What's going on

A new division has its own procedures, its own IPP form and sometimes its own view of your child's needs. Files can take time to arrive. The safest plan is to arrive with your own copies and to ask, before the first day, what the new division will do with them.

What the rules say

A board must enrol a resident of another board in the school asked for, for that school year, if in its opinion there are sufficient resources and facilities (Education Act s.10(4)).

The Student Record Regulation says that when a child transfers between Alberta schools, the old board "may disclose" the record and the new board "may collect" it (s.8(1)). Those words allow the transfer; they don't require it. The one "must" is for a paper record: the old board must send the original "on receipt of a written request from the school to which the student or child transfers" (s.8(2)). Where a transfer is required, it must happen "in a timely manner" (Education Act s.56(7)). The record must hold the current IPP and its amendments, plus summaries of IPPs from previous years (s.2(4)). The old board keeps the record for 7 years after your child leaves, unless it has been sent on (s.4(1)).

Alberta's IPP guidance lists what should be in place "prior to the move": "registration form – current and preceding IPPs – current assessment results – medical information – classroom assessment results – listing of supports in place".

No Alberta rule found sets a number of days for a record transfer.

Source: Education Act ss.10(4), 56(7), law. Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019 ss.2(4), 4, 8, current as of 1 September 2025, regulation.

Individualized Program Planning (2006), Appendix 8-A (Chapter 8 p.15), guidance.

Say this

"I've brought copies of my child's IPPs and assessments. Who here will read them before the first day, and which supports start right away?"

Ask for this in writing

The date the new school requested the record from the old division, the date it arrived, the name of the person who read the IPP and assessments, and the supports in place from the first day.

If you don't get it

Ask the old division in writing for the date it sent the record. If the record is on paper, ask the new school to send the old board a written request (Student Record Regulation s.8(2)). Ask the new division for its IPP and special education procedure. See 4.11, 4.12 and chapter 11.

Write this down

Date of move · date record requested · date received · supports on day one.

Your division may also have

An administrative procedure on student records and transfers. Ask both divisions for theirs.

14.7 Junior high: many teachers, one plan

You might be hearing

- "In junior high, they need to learn to advocate for themselves."
- "Not every teacher needs to see the IPP."
- "We can't adapt every class."
- "They'll have a homeroom teacher who looks after that."

What's going on

In elementary school, one or two teachers carry the IPP. In junior high, your child may have six or more teachers a day, rotating rooms. An

accommodation that only one teacher knows about is given in one class out of six.

Learning to ask for help is a fair goal. It belongs in the IPP as a goal, with support, not as a reason to stop the support.

Knowledge and Employability (K&E) courses can start in Grade 8 (see 14.9).

What the rules say

"Required accommodations must be listed on the IPP" (IPP guidance). The 2004 Standards require that principals "identify teachers whose responsibility it is to coordinate, develop, implement, monitor and evaluate student IPPs" (Standard 11(d)). The definition of transition planning includes changes "between grades/levels of schooling" and involves "receiving school staff".

The IPP guidance suggests the sending school "Communicate with the receiving teachers about the student's strengths and areas of need. If the student already has an IPP, discuss its contents and the accommodations required in the upcoming year."

K&E courses "are designed for students in grades 8 to 12 who demonstrate reading, writing, mathematical and/or other levels of achievement 2 to 3 grade levels below their age-appropriate grade" (Guide to Education).

Source: Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.12 and Chapter 8 pp.6-7, guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(d) and Definitions. Guide to Education 2025-26, Knowledge and Employability courses.

Say this

"My child has [number] teachers. Has each of them got the IPP accommodations? Who is the one person coordinating it?"

Ask for this in writing

The name of the teacher coordinating your child's IPP, and confirmation that each teacher on your child's timetable has the list of accommodations, with the date they received it.

If you don't get it

Send the accommodations list to each teacher and the coordinator yourself, copying the principal. If an accommodation isn't given in a class, see chapter 7. At semester change, see 13.8.

Write this down

Date · teachers' names · who confirmed they have the IPP · coordinator's name.

14.8 Senior high: diploma, certificate, or neither

You might be hearing

— "They'll still graduate."

— "A certificate is just as good."

— "The diploma isn't realistic for them."

— "We'll look at that in Grade 12."

What's going on

Alberta has more than one way to finish high school, and they open different doors. The Alberta High School Diploma needs 100 credits. The Certificate of High School Achievement needs 80 credits and is for students in K&E courses. The Certificate of School Completion is for students with a significant cognitive disability who can't achieve either. None of them guarantees admission to college or university.

Course choices in Grade 10, or earlier, can decide which path your child is on. Ask about it early.

What the rules say

The diploma requires "100 credits". The Certificate of High School Achievement requires "80 credits" and that the student "successfully complete a minimum of one academic Knowledge and Employability course or be identified as a Knowledge and Employability student (710 code)". The Certificate of School Completion "may be awarded to students with a significant cognitive disability" who can't achieve the diploma or the Certificate of High School Achievement, have worked toward IPP goals,

have been a student for at least 12 years and are 17 or older by 1 March of that year, on nomination by the principal or assistant principal.

The Guide says: "Possession of an Alberta High School Diploma or Certificate of High School Achievement does not guarantee admission to a post-secondary institution," and students "should be advised, as early as Grade 10" to check admission requirements.

Source: Guide to Education 2025-26, High school completion requirements and Certificate of High School Achievement, provincial policy. alberta.ca, Guide to Education: Certificate of School Completion.

Say this

"Which credential is my child working toward right now: the diploma, the certificate of achievement, or the certificate of completion? What does that keep open after high school?"

Ask for this in writing

The credential your child's current course plan leads to, the credits earned to date, and what that credential does and does not allow after high school.

If you don't get it

Ask the school counsellor and the principal in writing. If a course change will move your child off the diploma path, see 14.9.

Write this down

Date · credential path · credits to date · who told you.

14.9 A program change that closes a door later

You might be hearing

- "The -4 courses are a better fit."
- "We're modifying the program so they can be successful."
- "It's only for this year."
- "They can always switch back."

What's going on

Modified programming means your child is taught different learning outcomes from the provincial curriculum. K&E courses (numbered with -4, like Math 10-4) lead to the Certificate of High School Achievement. These can be the right choice. But they have consequences for credentials and for what comes after school, and those consequences should be explained to you in writing before the decision, not discovered at graduation.

What the rules say

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance, 22 October 2026) says, where a specialized setting is being considered and curricular adjustments are needed: "School-based teams should provide written information to parents about implications for future programming considerations, including credentialing and post-secondary pathways" (5.3.2(2.2)). Section 7 adds: "Parents receive written explanations of adjustments, curricular adjustments, and/or specialized setting, credentialing, or programming implications" (section 7, item 3.1). The Framework is guidance. Its own release says it "does not create new legislative requirements."

The 2004 Standards require boards to "ensure parents have information needed to make informed decisions" (Standard 8(b)).

Students "may enrol in K&E courses and other junior–senior high school courses or transition in and out of K&E courses throughout grades 8 to 12" (Guide to Education).

Source: Student Support Policy Framework (Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026), 5.3.2 and section 7 item 3.1, guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 8(b). Guide to Education 2025-26, Knowledge and Employability courses.

Say this

"Before we agree to this change, can you put in writing what it means for the diploma and for college or university later?"

Ask for this in writing

A written explanation of the proposed change (adapted, modified, K&E, or a specialized setting), what credential it leads to, how your child could move back to diploma courses, and the date of the next review of the decision.

If you don't get it

Don't sign the IPP change until you have it (see 4.6). If the change goes ahead without your agreement, it is a decision you can appeal (Education Act s.42). See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · change proposed · credential it leads to · written explanation received (yes/no) · review date.

14.10 Turning 16

You might be hearing

— "Now they're 16, they can sign for themselves."

— "They can take courses online now."

— "FSCD will start talking about adulthood."

— "They can make that appeal on their own."

What's going on

At 16, some rights under the Education Act pass to your child as well as to you. They can appeal a decision to the board and ask the Minister for a review themselves. The Guide to Education's rule that a student under 16 needs the principal's approval to enrol in online learning no longer applies to them. If FSCD (Family Support for Children with Disabilities) supports your family, transition-to-adulthood planning is meant to start at 16.

At 16, rights are shared, not handed over. You still hold your rights as a parent unless your child is living independently (see 14.12).

What the rules say

In the case of a student 16 or older, "either a parent of the student or the student" may appeal to the board (Education Act s.42(2)(b)), and the student may ask the Minister for a review (s.43(1)). A student 16 or older who is living independently, as decided by the board, is an "independent student" (s.1(1)(n)).

The Guide to Education says students "under age 16 may only be enrolled in online learning programs with the approval of the principal."

The FSCD Policy Manual says "Transition to adulthood planning is the expectation for all youth starting at age 16" (9.1). That is provincial policy run by Assisted Living and Social Services.

Source: Education Act ss.1(1)(n), 42, 43, law. Guide to Education 2025-26, Online learning programs. FSCD Policy Manual 9.1 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy.

Say this

"My child is turning 16. What will change in how you deal with us, and when do we start planning for after high school?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's transition plan for after high school, the date it will be added to the IPP, and, if your family has FSCD, the date of the first Transition to Adulthood planning meeting.

If you don't get it

Ask for the transition section of the IPP to be completed by a date (see 4.2). For FSCD transition planning, see 16.10.

Write this down

Date · transition plan started (yes/no) · FSCD transition meeting date.

14.11 Staying in school to 19 or 20

You might be hearing

- "They age out at 19."
- "We can't fund them past Grade 12."
- "They'll have to go to an adult program."
- "There's no space for them next year."

What's going on

A child who is under 19 on 1 September has a right to school for that whole school year. If your child is 19 or older on 1 September, staying is up to the board. Some students with disabilities need more time. The board can say yes, but it is not required to.

Ask early, in writing, so the decision is made with time to plan and to appeal.

What the rules say

A person who on 1 September is "6 years of age or older and younger than 19 years of age" is "entitled to have access in that school year to an education program" (Education Act s.3(1)). A board "may permit" a person older than 18 on 1 September to have access (s.3(2)). That is a discretion, not a duty.

The funding manual counts students in Grades 10 to 12 "who are less than 20 years of age as of September 1" toward a high school grant, at the full rate for the first three years of high school, 50 per cent in the fourth year and 25 per cent after that. A board may direct a student asking for a senior high program "beyond a 3rd school year" to a school it chooses (s.10(5)).

The Guide says boards must "concentrate their educational programming on students who are six years of age or older and younger than 19 years of age, as of September 1."

Source: Education Act ss.3, 10(5), law. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, C1 high school allocation formula and criterion 2, provincial funding policy. Guide to Education 2025-26, Adult programming in the K-12 education system.

Say this

"My child will be 19 on September 1 next year. Will the board let them stay? When will you decide, and who decides?"

Ask for this in writing

The board's decision on whether your child may continue in school for [school year], the name of the decision-maker, the date, and the program and school offered.

If you don't get it

A refusal is a decision that significantly affects your child's education, which can be appealed to the board (s.42). If your child is 16 or older, they can appeal too. See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date asked · age on 1 September · decision · who decided · date.

14.12 Turning 18

You might be hearing

- "Once they're 18, we deal with them, not you."
- "We can't share their records with you now."
- "You'll need guardianship papers."
- "That's an adult services question."

What's going on

At 18, your child becomes an "independent student" under the Education Act. From then on, they hold the rights you held as a parent under the Act. You no longer do. That includes seeing their school record.

If your child needs help making decisions, that is a question for adult decision-making law, not school law. Adult guardianship, co-decision-making, AISH (Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped) and PDD (Persons with Developmental Disabilities) belong to The Alberta Disability System Breakdown's adult stream. Start there well before the birthday.

What the rules say

An "independent student" includes a student "18 years of age or older" (Education Act s.1(1)(n)). An independent student "is entitled to exercise all the rights and powers ... that the student's parent would be entitled to exercise", and "the student's parent shall not exercise those rights" (s.6(2)). A parent may review the student record "except where the student is an independent student" (s.56(3)(b)).

The FSCD Policy Manual (Assisted Living and Social Services) says the caseworker will assist with a guardianship or trusteeship application at 17 and with an AISH application at 17½, and that the FSCD file closes at 18 (9.1).

Source: Education Act ss.1(1)(n), 6(2), 56(3), law. FSCD Policy Manual 9.1 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy.

Say this

"My child turns 18 on [date]. What will you need, from them and from me, so I can keep taking part in meetings?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's written process for parent involvement after a student turns 18, and any consent form your adult child can sign to let you take part and see records.

If you don't get it

Ask your child, if they are able, to tell the school in writing that they want you involved. For guardianship, AISH and PDD, go to The Alberta Disability System Breakdown's adult materials. For FSCD's transition steps, see 16.10.

Write this down

Date of 18th birthday · consent signed by your child (yes/no, date) · adult supports applied for.

Chapter 15: Other paths

Home education, shared responsibility, online school, private and designated special education schools, and charter schools: what each one gives your child, and what you give up when you leave a public school board.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/15

Turn here when you're hearing

— "Have you thought about homeschooling?" → 15.1

— "Home might suit them better." → 15.1

— "Once you home educate, you're on your own." → 15.2

— "You get funding for home education." → 15.3

— "They won't get a diploma if you don't follow the curriculum." → 15.4

— "We could do part days here and part at home." → 15.5

— "Online would take the pressure off." → 15.6

— "A private school would be better equipped." → 15.7

— "There are special schools for kids like yours." → 15.8

— "Charter schools have smaller classes." → 15.9

— "You can always come back." → 15.10 and 15.11

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
15.1	"Have you thought about homeschooling?"
15.2	What a school board owes a home-educated child
15.3	The money in home education
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15.5	Part at school, part at home: shared responsibility
15.6	Online school
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Entry	Title
15.8	Designated special education private schools
15.9	Charter schools
15.10	What you keep and what you give up when you leave
15.11	Coming back to a public school

15.1 "Have you thought about homeschooling?"

You might be hearing

— "Have you thought about homeschooling?"

— "Home might suit them better."

— "Maybe school isn't the right place for them right now."

— "Lots of families find it works."

What's going on

In Alberta, home education is a legal choice. You don't need a diagnosis, and the Home Education Regulation sets no test based on your child's needs. You do have to give notice, and for the supervised kind an associate board or school must accept the program. It is a choice you make, not a placement the school makes for you. If a school suggests it, the question underneath is often whether the school can meet your child's needs. That is a separate question with its own answer (see chapter 2 and chapter 12).

There are two kinds. Supervised home education is overseen by a school board or an accredited private school (called the "associate" board or school) and comes with some funding. Unsupervised home education only requires notifying the Minister and comes with no funding.

What the rules say

"A parent of a student may provide, at home or elsewhere, a type of home education program for the student in accordance with the regulations" (Education Act s.20(1)).

Alberta says families who home educate without school authority supervision "are not eligible to receive any Alberta Education funding." For

the supervised kind, the parent "must have notified and been accepted by an associate board or associate private school regarding the home education program before September 30," and "Students are not eligible for funding if a home education program is accepted after September 29."

For the unsupervised kind, parents "notify the Minister of Education of their intent to home educate their child".

Section 20 (home education) does not apply to charter schools (Education Act s.27(1)(c)), and the funding manual says "Charter schools may not offer Home Education programs".

Source: Education Act ss.20, 27, law. Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019, current as of 1 September 2025, regulation. alberta.ca, Home education (published 6 August 2026). Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, C1.6.2 criterion 15.

Say this

"Is the school suggesting home education because it can't meet my child's needs here? If so, I'd like that in writing."

Ask for this in writing

If the suggestion came from the school: the reason, the supports the school says it can't provide, and the name of the person who made the suggestion, with the date.

If you don't get it

A school's suggestion is not a decision you have to accept. If the school says it can't meet your child's needs, that is a matter for the board (see chapter 12). If you choose home education, read 15.2 and 15.3 first.

Write this down

Date · who suggested it · reason given · your decision.

15.2 What a school board owes a home-educated child

You might be hearing

— "Once you home educate, you're on your own."

— "We can't offer assessments to home ed families."

— "The IPP doesn't apply anymore."

— "Your associate board will help with everything."

What's going on

When your child is enrolled in a public school, the board can decide that they need specialized supports and services, and once it does, your child is entitled to access them. Those rules are tied to being enrolled in the board's school. Home education changes it.

The board that supervises your home education still has duties to you. They are smaller and different. One matters a lot: it must tell you what services and resources it has that you can use.

What the rules say

A board must provide an education program "to each student enrolled in a school operated by the board" (Education Act s.11(2)), and the determination of need for specialized supports and services is made "In respect of a student referred to in subsection (2)" (s.11(3)).

The Home Education Regulation does not mention disability, special education or IPPs. An earlier full-text search of AR 89/2019 for "special", "disab", "specialized", "individualized program plan" and "coding" found none.

The associate board or school must "facilitate student learning by offering assistance and advice to parents", must "advise parents ... of the services and resources of the associate board or associate independent school that are available for use by the parents and students", and must keep student records and tell you that you may view them (AR 89/2019 s.5).

Alberta funds AISCA (the Association of Independent Schools and Colleges of Alberta) to run "a program that facilitates access to supports to home education families who request them".

Source: Education Act s.11, law. Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019 s.5, current as of 1 September 2025, regulation. alberta.ca, Home education.

Say this

"Under section 5 of the Home Education Regulation, can you tell me in writing which services and resources, including assessment, are available to my child?"

Ask for this in writing

A list from your associate board or school of the services and resources available to your child, including any assessment, speech-language, occupational therapy or psychology services, and how to request them.

If you don't get it

Ask again, quoting s.5(d). Ask the AISCA home education supports program what it offers. If the associate board won't answer, you can choose a different associate board.

Write this down

Date · associate board · services listed · what you asked for · response.

15.3 The money in home education

You might be hearing

— "You get funding for home education."

— "Half the money goes to you."

— "You can use it for whatever helps."

— "The disability funding comes with them."

What's going on

Supervised home education comes with a set amount per child, paid to the associate board or school. Half of it is offered back to you as reimbursement for learning materials, with receipts. There is no extra amount for a child with a disability. The funding streams that pay for supports in a public school don't follow your child home.

What the rules say

The 2026-27 Home Education rate is $1,856.06 per student in Grades 1 to 12. The associate board or school "must offer to the parents of a home education student 50 per cent of the Home Education funding for the purchase of instructional materials" and may not reimburse more than 50 per cent. "Parents who submit receipts for at least 75 per cent of eligible expenses will receive the full 50 per cent of the grant." You have up to two

school years to claim. (The regulation itself says "not less than 50%" (s.7(2)); the funding manual caps reimbursement at 50 per cent.)

Home education students are excluded from the enrolment count used for the Specialized Learning Supports grant and the Classroom Complexity grant. "Home education kindergarten children are not eligible for PUF." Home education and shared responsibility students in accredited funded private schools "are not eligible for severe disabilities funding."

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27 (Education and Childcare), C1.6.1, C1.6.2, C2.1, C2.9 and rate tables, provincial funding policy. Home Education Regulation s.7, regulation.

Say this

"What exactly can I claim with receipts, and by what date? Is there anything extra for my child's disability?"

Ask for this in writing

The parent portion available for your child this year, the list of eligible expenses, the deadline to submit receipts, and confirmation of whether any other funding or service is available because of your child's disability.

If you don't get it

Ask the associate board for the Standards for Home Education Reimbursement it applies. Compare with another associate board before you commit.

Write this down

Date · associate board · parent portion offered · receipts submitted (date, amount).

15.4 Following the curriculum, or not, and what it means for credits

You might be hearing

— "They won't get a diploma if you don't follow the curriculum."

— "You have to follow the programs of study."

— "Home ed kids can't get high school credits."

— "They'd have to start Grade 10 from scratch."

What's going on

A home education program doesn't have to follow the Alberta programs of study (the provincial curriculum). It can follow a much shorter list of learning outcomes in the Home Education Regulation instead. For a child who can't work at grade level, that can be a better fit.

But credits for high school come through the programs of study. If a diploma is a possibility later, plan for it now. One route back is a course challenge: a formal assessment that can award credit without taking the course.

What the rules say

"A home education program may follow the Alberta Programs of Study" (AR 89/2019 s.3(4)). If it doesn't, the parent certifies the activities will meet the outcomes, and the associate board or school must accept the program (s.3(5)). "On the recommendation of a school principal, a student receiving a home education program that follows the Alberta Programs of Study is eligible to receive high school credits" (s.6).

The Guide to Education: "The course challenge provision allows any student registered in senior high school to challenge the outcomes of a course by participating in a formal assessment process, rather than taking the course." In diploma exam courses, a challenge covers only the school-awarded mark, and credit comes only after the student writes the diploma exam.

Alberta's unsupervised home education notification form warns that the student "may not apply to a high school principal for high school credits" and "may not receive an Alberta High School Diploma".

Source: Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019 ss.3, 6, regulation. Guide to Education 2025-26, Course challenge, provincial policy. Alberta home education notification form (unsupervised), as archived 25 September 2026.

Say this

"If my child doesn't follow the programs of study now, what would they need to do later to earn high school credits? Do you offer course challenges?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether your associate board accepts a program that doesn't follow the programs of study, whether it arranges course challenges for senior high students, and any fee or waiting time.

If you don't get it

Ask another associate board the same questions before you choose. Credentials are in 14.8.

Write this down

Date · associate board · programs of study or Schedule · course challenge offered (yes/no).

15.5 Part at school, part at home: shared responsibility

You might be hearing

— "We could do part days here and part at home."

— "That would keep them connected to the school."

— "We don't offer that."

— "If they're here more than that, it's not home ed."

What's going on

In a shared responsibility program, a school teaches some of your child's program and you teach the rest at home. It can keep a link to the school, and sometimes to its staff, while reducing time in the building. But a board doesn't have to offer it, and the split has limits.

This is different from a shortened school day, which is a school limiting a child's attendance (see chapter 8).

What the rules say

The school authority must be responsible for "at least a minimum of 20% to a maximum of 80% of the student's program in Grades 1 to 12. Below this range, a student should be enrolled as a home education student, and above this range, a student should be enrolled as a regular or online student ..." "School boards or accredited-funded independent schools are not required

to offer shared responsibility programs." "Charter schools may not offer shared responsibility programs."

Shared responsibility students are excluded from the enrolment count for the Specialized Learning Supports and Classroom Complexity grants.

Source: Guide to Education 2025-26, Shared responsibility programs, provincial policy. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, C1.6.2 criterion 11, C2.1, C2.9.

Say this

"Do you offer shared responsibility? If so, what part would you teach, and which supports would my child still have at school?"

Ask for this in writing

Whether the school offers a shared responsibility program, the percentage of the program it would teach, the courses, and the supports your child would receive during school time.

If you don't get it

The board doesn't have to offer it. Ask other boards or accredited private schools that supervise home education. If the school is proposing a reduced day instead, see chapter 8.

Write this down

Date · school · offered (yes/no) · percentage at school · supports at school.

15.6 Online school

You might be hearing

— "Online would take the pressure off."

— "They can work at their own pace."

— "There are no supports online, but they won't need them."

— "Online counts as home ed."

What's going on

Online school is not home education. In an online program, a certificated teacher employed by a school authority plans, teaches and assesses your

child's courses over the internet. You may be at home with your child, but the school is responsible for the program.

Ask before you enrol how the online school delivers accommodations and specialized supports, because it varies.

What the rules say

In an online program "Alberta certificated teachers employed by a school authority are responsible for instruction." Online programs must provide at least 950 hours of instruction a year in elementary and junior high and 1,000 in senior high. Students "know, prior to enrolling in courses, how and when they will be able to access the instructional expertise of teachers." Online students "must be given the same opportunity and necessary supports to write provincial assessments as students in a classroom-based setting." "School authorities cannot enrol ECS children in online learning programs, and students under age 16 may only be enrolled in online learning programs with the approval of the principal."

The Education Act's duties under s.11 apply to students "enrolled in a school operated by the board" (s.11(2)). No provision found says in plain words how that applies to a student learning online with a board, so ask the online school in writing. In accredited funded private schools, students with severe disabilities in an online program "are not eligible for severe disabilities funding."

Source: Guide to Education 2025-26, Online learning programs, provincial policy. Education Act s.11, law. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, D2.3 criterion 7.

Say this

"Is my child enrolled in your school if they learn online with you? How will you provide the accommodations and supports in their IPP?"

Ask for this in writing

Confirmation of which school and authority your child is enrolled in, how the IPP will be written and reviewed, how each accommodation will be provided online, and when your child can reach a teacher.

If you don't get it

Don't withdraw from the current school until you have it. If the online school is run by a board, its decisions can be appealed like any other board's (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date · online school · enrolled with (authority) · IPP plan confirmed (yes/no).

15.7 Private (independent) schools

You might be hearing

— "A private school would be better equipped."

— "They have smaller classes."

— "Private schools don't have to take kids with IPPs."

— "You can appeal to the board if it doesn't work out."

What's going on

Alberta calls private schools "independent schools". Some are only registered. Some are accredited, and some of those get public funding. They charge tuition.

Most of the Education Act's protections for students with special needs are written for school boards. Many of them don't apply to independent schools. In particular, the board's s.11 duty and the board appeal and Minister review route (ss.41 to 44) aren't on the list of sections that apply. Your right to see the student record does apply.

What the rules say

An independent school operator "shall ensure students enrolled in the independent school are provided with an education program consistent with the requirements set out in the Act and the regulations" (Education Act s.28.1). An accredited independent school must have "the capacity ... to deliver an appropriate education program to its students" (s.29(2)(b)(ii)).

Section 30(1) lists the parts of the Act that apply to independent schools. Section 11(2) to (5) and sections 41, 43 and 44 are not on it. Section 42

applies only to certain appeals under s.58.2. Section 56 (student records) is on it.

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says independent schools "are not expressly required by the Education Act to provide a continuum of supports and services but are bound by other legal requirements" and are "encouraged to use this Framework".

Source: Education Act ss.28.1, 29, 30, law. Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026), section 3, guidance.

Say this

"How would you support my child's needs here? Who writes the plan, how often is it reviewed, and what happens if we disagree?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's written special education or student support policy, how it writes and reviews individual plans, its tuition and fees for [year], and its process for resolving disagreements with parents.

If you don't get it

Don't sign an enrolment contract until you have the school's dispute process in writing. A discrimination complaint can be made to the Alberta Human Rights Commission, within one year (see 13.14). Whether a particular school's services are covered is for the Commission to decide. Records requests are in chapter 11.

Write this down

Date · school · policy received (yes/no) · tuition · dispute process.

15.8 Designated special education private schools

You might be hearing

- "There are special schools for kids like yours."
- "You'll need the board's permission to go there."
- "Those schools are funded, so it's free."
- "There's a waitlist."

What's going on

A Designated Special Education Independent School (DSEIS) is an accredited, publicly funded private school whose only purpose is to teach students with disabilities. Alberta approves a short list each year. They charge tuition, which varies and is set by each school. Most of the approved schools are in Calgary and Edmonton.

You don't need your home board's permission to apply. But the board's duties under the Education Act don't follow your child there (see 15.7 and 15.10).

What the rules say

A DSEIS is a school given that status by the Minister "where the sole purpose of the school is to serve students who are identified with a mild, moderate or severe disability," with each student's program "specified in the Individualized Program Plan (IPP) or Instructional Support Plan (ISP)". "Parents are no longer required to consult with a school official or their resident board regarding their child's special education programming options." DSEIS "are not required to notify resident boards, in writing" of students registered with them.

For severe disabilities funding at an accredited funded private school, the file must include "a current Individualized Program Plan (IPP) or Instructional Support Plan (ISP)" and the student "must receive three or more levels of support".

Source: Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, D1.7 criteria 3 and 4, D2.3 criterion 8, and Glossary (DSEIS, with the approved list for 2026/27), provincial funding policy.

Say this

"What is your tuition for next year, what deposit is due and when, and how do you decide which students you accept?"

Ask for this in writing

The school's tuition, deposits and payment dates for [year], admission criteria, waitlist position, and how the IPP or ISP is written and reviewed.

If you don't get it

Ask the next school on the list. If a school tells you it needs your board's sign-off, you can point to D1.7 criterion 4 and ask whether that is the school's own admission rule.

Write this down

Date · school · tuition · deposit due · admission decision date.

15.9 Charter schools

You might be hearing

- "Charter schools have smaller classes."
- "We focus on one way of teaching."
- "We don't have the same special education rules."
- "We can't offer home ed or part-time."

What's going on

A charter school is a public school run under a charter from the Minister by an operator that is a society or a company registered under Part 9 of the Companies Act. Like a board, it can't charge tuition to Alberta resident students. Each one focuses on a particular approach or kind of program.

Charter schools sit between the two systems. Much of the Education Act applies to them, including the s.11 entitlement to specialized supports and the appeal route to the Minister. But the 2004 Standards for Special Education do not apply to charter schools. The new Student Support Policy Framework does.

What the rules say

A charter school is operated by a society or a company registered under Part 9 of the Companies Act (Education Act s.24(1)). A charter is issued for a program that focuses on a learning or teaching style or approach not already offered by local boards, or on vocation-based education (Education Act s.25(1)). Section 27(1) applies most of the Act to charter schools, but not s.11(1), s.20 (home education) or certain other sections. Section 11(2) to (5), s.13 (no tuition for resident students) and Part 3 (including appeals, ss.41 to 44) apply.

The 2004 Standards apply to public and separate boards "but excluding charter schools". The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) covers "an operator of a public charter school".

A charter school can be funded under Specialized Learning Supports or Severe Disabilities Funding; "Once a charter school opts to be funded based on the Specialized Learning Support grant, they are no longer eligible to choose the severe disabilities funding."

The 2026 Charter Schools Amendment Regulation (AR 183/2026) sets new renewal criteria. A word search of its text found no mention of disability, special education or accommodation.

Source: Education Act ss.13, 24, 25, 27, law. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Foreword. Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026), section 1 and Glossary ("Applicable school authority"), guidance. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, C2.1 criterion 2. AR 183/2026, regulation, in force 1 September 2026.

Say this

"How does this charter school decide whether a student needs specialized supports, and where is that written down?"

Ask for this in writing

The charter school's policy on specialized supports and IPPs, its school dispute resolution policy, and its appeal procedure.

If you don't get it

Section 42 appeals and the s.43 Minister review apply to charter schools (s.27(1)(d)). See chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · school · policies received · contact for appeals.

15.10 What you keep and what you give up when you leave

You might be hearing

— "You can always come back."

— "It's the same rules everywhere."

— "Your rights go with your child."

— "That's between you and the new school."

What's going on

Your child's protections depend on where they are enrolled. Before you move, check what you're leaving behind. This entry puts it side by side, from the Education Act. It doesn't tell you which choice is right.

What the rules say

From the Education Act:

— Public, separate or francophone board school: s.11 entitlement to specialized supports applies; appeal to board (s.42) and Minister review (s.43) apply; student record (s.56) applies.

— Charter school: s.11(2) to (5), ss.42 to 44 and s.56 apply (s.27). The 2004 Standards don't.

— Independent (private) school, including a DSEIS: s.11(2) to (5), s.41, s.43 and s.44 are not among the sections applied by s.30(1); s.56 is.

— Supervised home education: the associate board's duties are in AR 89/2019 s.5; the Regulation has no disability provisions; s.11's duties are tied to students enrolled in a board's school.

The Alberta Human Rights Act prohibits discrimination because of physical or mental disability in services "customarily available to the public" (s.4). A complaint must be made within one year (s.20(2)(b)).

Source: Education Act ss.11, 27, 30, 42, 43, 56, law. Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019 s.5. Alberta Human Rights Act ss.4, 20, law.

Say this

"If my child leaves, what can I still appeal, and to whom? If they come back, what happens to their IPP and supports?"

Ask for this in writing

From the school you're leaving: confirmation of what happens to the IPP and records, and what the process would be to come back. From the new setting: its written dispute and appeal process.

If you don't get it

Get your own copies of everything before you leave (see 4.11 and chapter 11). Coming back is in 15.11.

Write this down

Date · leaving from · going to · copies taken · appeal route in new setting.

15.11 Coming back to a public school

You might be hearing

- "You can always come back."
- "There's no space mid-year."
- "We'll need to reassess them."
- "They'll go into the grade we decide."
- "Their old IPP has expired."

What's going on

You can bring your child back to a public school. Your resident board has to direct them to a school it operates. It may not be the school you want, and mid-year moves can be harder. A child returning from home education or private school may be placed at a grade the school decides, and if your child is identified as having special education needs, the school will need to write an IPP of its own.

Bring your own records: the old IPP, assessments, and your home education records or private school reports.

What the rules say

"A board shall direct a resident student of the board to enrol in and attend a particular school operated by the board," and must enrol your child in the school you ask for if, in the board's opinion, there are sufficient resources and facilities (Education Act s.10(1) and (2)). A parent of a student enrolled in a board's school can't ask for another school mid-year unless the other school's board consents (s.10(7)).

Alberta's unsupervised home education notification form warns a returning student "may not necessarily be placed at the same grade level if the student registers in another school."

Home education parents must keep "dated samples of student work and a general record of the student's activities" (AR 89/2019 s.4(1)(b)).

Source: Education Act s.10, law. Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019 s.4, regulation. Alberta home education notification form (unsupervised), as archived 25 September 2026.

Say this

"My child is coming back to school. What do you need from me, and when will the IPP meeting be?"

Ask for this in writing

The school and grade your child will be placed in, the basis for the grade placement, the supports in place from the first day, and the date of the first IPP meeting.

If you don't get it

A grade placement or a refusal of the school you asked for is a decision you can appeal to the board if it significantly affects your child's education (s.42). See 14.5 and chapter 12.

Write this down

Date · school · grade placed · basis given · IPP meeting date.

Chapter 16: Outside school: FSCD and the rest of the support stack

What FSCD (Family Support for Children with Disabilities) is, how to apply, where it stops and school starts, how to get the two to work together, and the federal benefits beside them.

Last verified: October 2026

Live page: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/16

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown publishes separate FSCD quick answers in the Children and FSCD section of albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app. This chapter covers the parts that meet school.

Turn here when you're hearing

— "FSCD is through the school, right?" → 16.1

— "You need a diagnosis before you can apply." → 16.2

— "The waitlist is so long there's no point yet." → 16.2

— "Your file was closed." → 16.2

— "We're still waiting on your documents." → 16.3

— "FSCD can't help with school." → 16.4

— "The school should be covering that." → 16.4

— "The ISP and the IPP are basically the same thing." → 16.5

— "We can't talk to the school without consent." → 16.6

— "Can't you just be paid to do it yourself?" → 16.7

— "Your agreement expired." → 16.8

— "Request a review first." → 16.9

— "At 18 the file closes." → 16.10

— "Have you applied for the disability tax credit?" → 16.11

Entries in this chapter

Entry	Title
16.1	What FSCD is, and what it isn't
16.2	When to apply: before the diagnosis

Entry	Title
16.3	What you need to apply
16.4	"FSCD can't help with school"
16.5	Specialized services: the ISP and the IPP
16.6	Getting FSCD and the school to talk to each other
16.7	Paying for help: who can be paid, and at what rate
16.8	Your agreement is ending
16.9	When FSCD says no
16.10	From 16 to 18: FSCD's transition planning
16.11	The federal layer: the disability tax credit and the child disability benefit

16.1 What FSCD is, and what it isn't

You might be hearing

— "FSCD is through the school, right?"

— "Ask your FSCD worker about the classroom."

— "It's a disability program, so it covers everything."

— "You have to choose: FSCD or the school."

What's going on

FSCD is a provincial program for families raising a child with a disability. It is run by Assisted Living and Social Services, a different ministry from the one that runs schools (Education and Childcare). FSCD and school are separate systems with separate rules, separate workers and separate appeals.

FSCD has two kinds of help. Family support services (FSS) help the family: for example counselling, respite (a break from caregiving), and help with costs of getting to medical appointments. Child-focused services (CFS) help the child directly: for example aide support at home and in the community, specialized services from therapists, and health-related supports. Child-focused services need a fuller assessment first.

What the rules say

Alberta names the lead ministry as "Assisted Living and Social Services". The child "must be under 18 years", the applicant "must be the child's guardian", the child "must reside in Alberta" and be a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, and "Medical documentation must be provided confirming the child has a disability or is awaiting a diagnosis."

The FSCD Act sets the two kinds of agreement. Family support services need "a medical diagnosis, in a format satisfactory to the director" (s.3(1)). Child-focused services also need an assessment showing the disability "significantly limits the child's ability to function in normal daily living" (s.4). In both, the director "may" enter an agreement.

The Student Support Policy Framework (Education and Childcare, guidance) confirms that Assisted Living and Social Services "has the primary responsibility" for disability services including FSCD.

Source: alberta.ca, FSCD and FSCD eligibility (published 15 and 22 September 2026). Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act ss.3, 4, law. FSCD Policy Manual (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy, for the kinds of service. Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026), section 6 item 7.2.3, guidance.

Say this

"Is this something FSCD covers, or something the school covers? Who should I be asking?"

Ask for this in writing

From FSCD: which services your family's agreement covers and the name of your caseworker. From the school: which supports it provides during the school day.

If you don't get it

Call the Alberta Supports Contact Centre at 1-877-644-9992 and ask for the FSCD office for your area. School supports are in chapter 7.

Write this down

Date · FSCD caseworker name · services in agreement · school contact.

16.2 When to apply: before the diagnosis

You might be hearing

— "You need a diagnosis before you can apply."

— "Wait until the assessment comes back."

— "The waitlist is so long there's no point yet."

— "Your file was closed."

What's going on

You don't have to wait for a diagnosis. You can apply while your child is waiting for one. Waits are long, so the earlier you apply, the earlier the clock starts.

There is a catch. If your child is waiting for a diagnosis, FSCD's policy manual allows family support services for up to two years, and no child-focused services. If there is still no diagnosis after two years, the manual says the child is no longer eligible. That two-year limit is in the policy manual. It is not in the FSCD Act or Regulation.

If your file was closed less than 180 days ago, you can ask to reopen it rather than start again.

What the rules say

The FSCD manual and Alberta's eligibility page both say medical documentation must confirm the child "has a disability or is awaiting a diagnosis" (manual 4.1). The manual says: "Family support services may be provided for up to 2 years if the child is awaiting a diagnosis. Child focused services cannot be provided while awaiting a diagnosis," and "If after 2 years, the child does not have a confirmed diagnosis they are no longer eligible for the FSCD program." No such limit was found in the Act or Regulation. It is a manual-level rule, which can be changed without the Legislature.

FSCD can enter a family support services agreement once eligibility is confirmed, before the full assessment of needs (manual 6.4). A file closed less than 180 days ago can be reopened without a new application (manual 6.1 and 6.12).

How long families wait: in a survey of 746 Alberta families by Inclusion Alberta (October and November 2024), the eligibility decision took an

average of about 7½ months, and the estimated wait to full services was about 21 months. These are survey results, not government data.

Source: FSCD Policy Manual 4.1, 6.1, 6.4, 6.12 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy. alberta.ca, FSCD eligibility. Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act and Regulation (AR 140/2004), searched. Inclusion Alberta, Too Little, Too Late (January 2025), pp.2, 6, 7.

Say this

"My child is waiting for a diagnosis. I'd like to apply now under 'awaiting a diagnosis'. What can we get in the meantime?"

Ask for this in writing

The date FSCD received your application, the date eligibility was decided, and whether a family support services agreement can start now.

If you don't get it

If your file was closed, ask the caseworker named in the closure letter to reopen it within 180 days. If eligibility is refused, see 16.9.

Write this down

Date applied · diagnosis status · date eligibility decided · date FSS agreement started.

16.3 What you need to apply

You might be hearing

— "We're still waiting on your documents."

— "Your application isn't complete."

— "We can't accept that letter."

— "You'll have to pay the doctor for that."

What's going on

You apply online, and the application isn't complete until every supporting document has arrived. There is a time limit in FSCD policy: if the documents don't arrive in time, the file is closed. There is no FSCD

application form number on Alberta's pages; the application is made through the online portal, with help available by phone.

You may have to pay for the medical letter. FSCD doesn't cover it.

What the rules say

Alberta says to apply online and, for help or if you can't apply online, to call the Alberta Supports Contact Centre (1-877-644-9992; Edmonton 780-644-9992). Supporting documents include proof that your child is a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, proof of relationship where asked ("a guardianship order, birth certificate or adoption papers"), and medical documentation with your child's name and date of birth, the diagnosis, the date of diagnosis and the name of the professional. The application "is considered complete only after the application and all supporting documents" are received, and "applicants are responsible for any fees the health professional may charge to prepare the letter or report."

The FSCD Act requires "a medical diagnosis, in a format satisfactory to the director" (ss.3(1) and 4(1)(a)). The manual says: if supporting documents are not received within 90 calendar days of the application, the file is closed, and documents received without an application are destroyed after 90 calendar days (6.1). "The FSCD program is not responsible for costs associated with obtaining medical letters or assessment reports" (4.1).

There is no income test for FSCD eligibility. Income comes in for medical benefits: FSCD covers the cost above 2 per cent of the parents' combined net income, from line 23600 of the previous year's tax return (Regulation s.4(1)(k)).

Source: alberta.ca, FSCD How to apply (fetched 23 October 2026). Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act ss.3, 4, law. FSCD Regulation, AR 140/2004 s.4(1)(k), regulation. FSCD Policy Manual 4.1, 6.1 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy.

Say this

"Can you tell me which documents you have and which you still need, and the date my file closes if they don't arrive?"

Ask for this in writing

The date your application was received, the list of documents received and still needed, and the date by which the rest must arrive.

If you don't get it

Send the missing documents with a cover note listing each one, and keep proof of the date. If your file is closed, see 16.2 on reopening within 180 days.

Write this down

Date applied · documents sent (date each) · day 90 · date confirmed complete.

16.4 "FSCD can't help with school"

You might be hearing

— "FSCD can't help with school."

— "The school should be covering that."

— "Your aide hours can't be used at school."

— "Respite isn't for days they're sent home."

What's going on

FSCD says plainly, many times, that it does not cover the school day. Aide support, community support and developmental support aren't for school hours, lunch, recess or field trips. That is the school's responsibility (see chapter 7 and chapter 8).

There is one narrow exception. FSCD respite can be used, short term, when your child can't attend school because of their disability while the school sorts out an education program. It is not meant to replace school.

What the rules say

The FSCD Policy Manual says:

— "Aide supports are not intended for the purpose of tutoring, academic support, assistance in a school program or lunchtime supervision at school" (8.7).

— Community support can't be provided "For the purposes of support and supervision in educational activities that take place during regular school hours (for example, school field trips, lunch time, recess)" (8.7B).

— "Developmental support will not be provided in an educational setting such as the classroom, recess and lunch-time" (8.7D).

— "Aide services will not be provided if the child is eligible to receive the same service from another government department, such as Alberta Education or Alberta Health" (8.6C).

— "Respite services are not intended to address care needs related to the ability of the school division to provide an appropriate program for a child" (8.2), except where respite is "short-term pending the coordination of an education program" (8.2) for a child unable to attend "on a short-term basis due to their disability" (7.5).

Source: FSCD Policy Manual 7.5, 8.2, 8.6C, 8.7, 8.7B, 8.7D (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy, Assisted Living and Social Services.

Say this

"FSCD's manual says aide support isn't for school. Who at the school is responsible for this during the day?"

Ask for this in writing

From the school: who provides your child's support during the school day, including lunch, recess and field trips. From FSCD, if your child is out of school: whether short-term respite can be provided pending an education program, and for how long.

If you don't get it

School-day support is a school decision you can appeal (see chapter 12). If your child is being kept home, see chapter 8.

Write this down

Date · support needed · who the school says provides it · FSCD answer on short-term respite.

16.5 Specialized services: the ISP and the IPP

You might be hearing

— "The ISP and the IPP are basically the same thing."

— "The FSCD team will handle school goals."

— "The school can just use the ISP."

— "The team reviews it when they can."

What's going on

Some children with severe disabilities get FSCD specialized services: a team of professionals (such as an occupational therapist, speech-language pathologist, psychologist, behavioural specialist and aide) working with the child and family at home and in the community. Their plan is an ISP (Individualized Service Plan). Confusingly, Alberta's funding manual also uses "ISP" for an Instructional Support Plan, a school plan used in place of an IPP in some schools. They are different documents from different ministries.

The school's IPP (Individualized Program Plan) covers learning at school. The FSCD ISP covers goals at home and in the community. They should line up, but one does not replace the other.

What the rules say

FSCD: "The specialized services team works with you to develop an Individualized Service Plan (ISP)" (alberta.ca). The FSCD manual says an initial ISP is due within 90 calendar days of services starting, continuing ISPs 60 calendar days before the agreement expires, and ISPs are reviewed "minimally 4 times per year" (8.9). Those are policy-manual rules.

School: an IPP is required for every student identified with special education needs (2004 Standards, Standard 11(a)). Alberta's IPP guidance says IPP reviews "are generally scheduled three to four times per year".

Source: alberta.ca, FSCD Specialized services (published 3 June 2024). FSCD Policy Manual 8.9 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy. Funding Manual for School Authorities 2026/27, D2.3 criterion 8(d), for "Instructional Support Plan". Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 11(a). Individualized Program Planning (2006), Chapter 1 p.14, guidance.

Say this

"Can we line up the ISP and the IPP so the goals match? Can each team get a copy of the other plan, with my consent?"

Ask for this in writing

From FSCD: the date of the next ISP review and a copy of the current ISP. From the school: the date of the next IPP review. From both: agreement to share the plans, under a consent form you sign (see 16.6).

If you don't get it

Bring both plans to each meeting yourself. Ask that each plan list the other team's services under "coordinated support services" (an IPP requirement, see 4.2).

Write this down

Date · ISP review date · IPP review date · plans shared (yes/no) · consent signed (date).

16.6 Getting FSCD and the school to talk to each other

You might be hearing

— "We can't talk to the school without consent."

— "We don't usually speak to FSCD."

— "That's a separate system."

— "Just pass the reports along yourself."

What's going on

Alberta's school guidance says your consent is needed before your child's personal or health information is shared with another agency. That protects your child. It also means things often don't get shared until you sign something.

Read each consent form for three things before you sign: what is shared, with whom, and until when.

What the rules say

The Student Support Policy Framework (guidance) says consent is "Required for sharing of personal and health information and for external referrals" (section 7, item 2.1), and that "Parental consent is required in order to share clinical reports with the school-based teams" (5.3.1.1). For students with high-complexity needs it describes case coordination across

agencies, and says "Ideally, the first contact agency should be responsible for case coordination with the school-based team" (5.3.1).

The 2004 Standards require boards to "work together with members of the community ... regional health and children's services authorities" and to "obtain written informed consent from parents to provide coordinated services to students, when required, and as identified in students' IPPs" (Standard 6).

The FSCD Policy Manual's section on collecting, using and sharing information (3.1) was not read for this edition.

Source: Student Support Policy Framework (22 October 2026), 5.3.1, 5.3.1.1 and section 7, guidance. Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, Standard 6(a) and (c).

Say this

"I'd like the school and the FSCD team to share [these reports] with each other. What do I need to sign, and can I see the form first?"

Ask for this in writing

A copy of each consent form before you sign it, showing who can share what with whom and until what date, and a copy of the signed form for your records.

If you don't get it

Share the reports yourself by handing copies to each team, and ask each to note receipt in writing. Ask for a joint meeting (see chapter 10).

Write this down

Date · consent signed (to whom, what, until when) · reports shared · joint meeting date.

16.7 Paying for help: who can be paid, and at what rate

You might be hearing

— "Can't you just be paid to do it yourself?"

— "Grandma could be your respite worker."

— "The rate is whatever the market is."

— "Find your own worker and we'll reimburse."

What's going on

A parent cannot be paid by FSCD to care for their own child. Some other relatives can be paid for respite only, if the director agrees. FSCD doesn't publish an hourly rate for respite or aide workers.

What the rules say

FSCD Regulation s.2.1: services "must be provided by an adult who is not a relative," and a "relative" includes "a child's parent". An adult relative "except for a parent" may provide respite if the director considers them the most appropriate caregiver. The manual says: "FSCD does not provide funding for parents and guardians to act as respite service providers for their own child" (7.5).

On pay, the manual says only that "rates of pay should reflect their qualifications, skill level and community standards" (7.5). No hourly rate is published in the regulation, on the program pages or in the manual.

Source: FSCD Regulation, AR 140/2004 s.2.1, regulation. FSCD Policy Manual 7.5 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy.

Say this

"Who can be paid to provide respite for my child, and how do you decide what rate you'll cover?"

Ask for this in writing

The rate FSCD will cover for your child's respite or aide worker under your agreement, how it was set, and whether a named relative (not a parent) can be approved.

If you don't get it

A decision about the services in your agreement can be reviewed or appealed (see 16.9).

Write this down

Date · rate offered · how it was set · relative approved (yes/no).

16.8 Your agreement is ending

You might be hearing

— "Your agreement expired."

— "We'll renew it when we get to it."

— "Services stop until the new one's signed."

— "We need a new assessment first."

What's going on

FSCD agreements run for a fixed term and then have to be renewed. The review is meant to start well before the end date, so there is no gap. A gap between agreements counts against FSCD's own standards.

Put the expiry date in your calendar the day you sign.

What the rules say

From the FSCD Policy Manual: "The period of assistance for an FSCD agreement may be for a term of up to and not to exceed 3 years" (6.7). A family support services agreement may run up to 3 years, or 2 years if the child is awaiting a diagnosis (6.4). The agreement review starts "no less than 60 calendar days" before expiry (6.5). FSCD's Essential Program Standard 3 checks that, for existing files, the agreement was approved before the previous agreement expired (11.3).

The Act and Regulation set no maximum term. These are policy-manual rules.

Source: FSCD Policy Manual 6.4, 6.5, 6.7, 11.3 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy.

Say this

"My agreement ends on [date]. When does the renewal review start, and will the new agreement be approved before the old one ends?"

Ask for this in writing

The expiry date of your current agreement, the date the renewal review will start, and confirmation that the new agreement will be in place before that date.

If you don't get it

Within 60 days of expiry with no review booked, write to the caseworker and their manager quoting manual 6.5. If services lapse, see 16.9.

Write this down

Date agreement ends · day 60 before · date review started · date new agreement approved.

16.9 When FSCD says no

You might be hearing

- "Request a review first."
- "You can't appeal eligibility."
- "Services stop while you appeal."
- "There's no point appealing."

What's going on

FSCD has three routes when you disagree: talking it through (concern resolution), an internal review, and an appeal to an arm's-length panel. You can use more than one. But the appeal clock keeps running while a review is under way, so if you might need the appeal, you can file it first.

There is one more door, and it is narrow. If you think the FSCD appeal process itself was unfair, the FSCD manual names the Alberta Ombudsman. That is for an FSCD matter only. The Ombudsman can't take complaints about schools (see chapter 12).

What the rules say

The FSCD Act lets a guardian appeal a director's decision under s.3(1)(b), 4 or 5(1), within 45 days of being told of the decision (s.7(1) and (2)). The manual says a notice of appeal is filed within 45 calendar days of the written decision (10.4), and that the manual treats eligibility decisions as appealable (10.4).

A review of an FSCD program decision must be requested within 30 calendar days (manual 10.2). "The 45 calendar day time limit for submission of a notice of appeal is not suspended when a parent or guardian requests a review of an FSCD program decision" (10.2). "Access to

a review of an FSCD program decision or mediation will not limit or prevent access to an appeal" (10.1). "Other agreed upon FSCD services will continue to be provided while a parent or guardian is appealing a decision" (10.4).

Manual 10.4: "If parent or guardian is not satisfied with the process of the appeal hearing, they may choose to contact a lawyer to inquire about further legal remedies or they may contact the Office of the Ombudsman." The Ombudsman's own site says it "does not have jurisdiction to investigate complaints about schools".

Source: Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act s.7, law. FSCD Policy Manual 10.1, 10.2, 10.4 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy. Alberta Ombudsman, Complaint checker: Universities and Schools (ombudsman.ab.ca, read 23 October 2026).

Say this

"I'm filing a notice of appeal today so I don't miss the 45 days. I'd also like a review. Can you confirm both in writing?"

Ask for this in writing

The decision in writing with its date, the appeal deadline, and confirmation that your notice of appeal and your review request were received, with dates.

If you don't get it

Send the notice of appeal by a method that shows the date. The manual says you can have an advocate or support person at the hearing (10.4). School decisions are separate, and the Ombudsman is not a route for them (see chapter 12).

Write this down

Date of decision · day 30 · day 45 · appeal filed (date) · review requested (date).

16.10 From 16 to 18: FSCD's transition planning

You might be hearing

— "At 18 the file closes."

— "We'll talk about adult services closer to the time."

— "That's AISH's job."

— "Transition planning is optional."

What's going on

FSCD ends at 18. Its policy manual sets out transition planning from 16, with a written plan and meetings, so adult supports are ready on time. It is meant to happen for every youth, not only on request.

Adult programs (AISH, PDD, adult guardianship and co-decision-making) belong to The Alberta Disability System Breakdown's adult stream. This entry covers only what FSCD says it will do before 18. School transitions at 16 and 18 are in 14.10 and 14.12.

What the rules say

From the FSCD Policy Manual: "Transition to adulthood planning is the expectation for all youth starting at age 16" (9.1). A Transition to Adulthood Plan replaces the Individualized Family Support Plan at 16. The manual sets meetings at 16, 17 and 18½; caseworker help with a guardianship or trusteeship application at 17 and with an AISH application at 17½; and closes the file at 18 (9.1). Transition information may be shared "as early as when the child is age 9 years" (6.6).

Source: FSCD Policy Manual 6.6, 9.1 (read live on manuals.alberta.ca 23 October 2026), provincial policy, Assisted Living and Social Services.

Say this

"My child is [age]. When is the first transition-to-adulthood meeting, and who from the school will be invited?"

Ask for this in writing

The date of the first Transition to Adulthood planning meeting, a copy of the plan once written, and the names of everyone invited, including the school.

If you don't get it

Ask the caseworker's manager in writing, quoting manual 9.1. For adult programs, go to The Alberta Disability System Breakdown's adult materials.

Write this down

Date · child's age · TAP meeting date · school invited (yes/no) · copy of plan received.

16.11 The federal layer: the disability tax credit and the child disability benefit

You might be hearing

— "Have you applied for the disability tax credit?"

— "The child disability benefit is automatic."

— "Your doctor fills in the form."

— "That's a tax thing, not a school thing."

What's going on

The federal government runs two benefits most families of children with disabilities should know about. The disability tax credit (DTC) is a tax credit for people with disabilities and the family members who support them. The child disability benefit (CDB) is paid to families who get the Canada child benefit and whose child qualifies for the DTC. Both are separate from school and from FSCD.

For amounts and how to apply, see canada.ca, and the Children and FSCD section of The Alberta Disability System Breakdown's site, albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app. This book prints no dollar figures for them because they change.

What the rules say

The Canada Revenue Agency describes the DTC as "a non-refundable tax credit that helps people with disabilities, or their supporting family member". The application uses Form T2201, Disability Tax Credit Certificate.

For the CDB: "You must be eligible for the Canada child benefit (CCB)" and "Your child must be eligible for the disability tax credit (DTC)". "If you are already getting the CCB for your child who is eligible for the DTC, you do not need to apply for the CDB. You will get it automatically."

Source: Canada Revenue Agency, Disability tax credit (date modified 16 September 2025) and Child disability benefit (date modified 15 June 2026), canada.ca, federal program pages.

Say this

"Can you complete the medical part of the disability tax credit form for my child?"

Ask for this in writing

From the Canada Revenue Agency: the decision on your child's DTC application, with the years it covers.

If you don't get it

Ask the Canada Revenue Agency how to ask for a review of a DTC decision. See the Children and FSCD section at albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app.

Write this down

Date T2201 sent · date of decision · years approved · CDB started (date).

Letters you can copy

Short letters for the moments that come up most. Send them by email so there's a dated record. Change anything in square brackets. Keep them short: one letter, one issue, a date to answer by. Open with thanks for something specific, close with thanks, and never accuse anyone. The questions are sharp enough on their own.

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Letters in this section

Letter	Use it when	Entry
L.1	You want the draft IPP before the meeting	4.3
L.2	You need dates for when progress is measured	4.4
L.3	You're not signing the IPP yet	4.6
L.4	You want a copy of the student record	4.11
L.5	You want a correction to the record	4.7
L.6	You want a decision in writing	4.1
L.7	Summing up a meeting	chapter 10
L.8	Writing down an incident the same day	chapter 8
L.9	A goal or support changed without notice	4.8
L.10	Asking for a contact who wasn't part of earlier decisions	chapter 12
L.11	Appealing to the board	chapter 12
L.12	Asking the Minister to review a board decision	chapter 12

L.1 Asking for the draft before the meeting

Subject: [Child]'s IPP meeting on [date]: draft goals

Hello [name],
Thank you for setting up the meeting on [date]. Could you send me the draft IPP, or at least the draft goals and objectives, by [date, three school days before]? I'll read it properly and come with questions, so we can use the time well.
Could you also let me know who will be at the meeting and their roles?
Thank you, [Your name]

L.2 Asking for the dates

Subject: [Child]'s IPP: review dates and target dates
Hello [name],
Thank you for [something specific]. I have three questions about [child]'s IPP, and I'd be grateful for the answers in writing by [date]:

- What is the date of the next formal review of each goal, and who will do it?
- How often will [reading / the relevant goal] be measured, and with what measure?
- What target date is recorded against each short-term objective?

A date or a frequency is what I'm after. Ongoing doesn't let me see whether things are working.
Thank you, [Your name]

L.3 I'm not signing yet

Subject: [Child]'s IPP dated [date]: not signing at this time
Hello [name],
Thank you for the IPP dated [date]. I'm not able to sign it yet, because [one plain reason, for example: the goals have no target dates / the medical information doesn't match my registration form / my input from [date] isn't reflected].
I understand the school records the reasons when a parent doesn't sign, and what it's doing to resolve the difference. Could you send me a copy of what is recorded, and let me know when we can meet to fix [the reason]?
Thank you, [Your name]

L.4 Asking for the student record

Subject: Request for a copy of [child]'s student record
Hello [name],
Under section 56 of the Education Act, I'm asking for a copy of [child]'s student record, including every version of the IPP and any behaviour or health plan held about [child] this school year and last.
If there is a fee, please tell me the amount before you copy anything. Could you let me know by [date] when I can expect it?
Thank you, [Your name]

L.5 Asking for a correction

Subject: Correction to [child]'s record: [the item]
Hello [name],
Thank you for [something specific]. [Child]'s [IPP / record] says "[the exact words]". That isn't accurate. It should say "[the correct words]", as on [my registration form dated / the doctor's letter dated] [date], attached.
Under section 56 of the Education Act, I'm asking that this be corrected. Could you confirm in writing by [date] that it has been changed, and how this field is filled in, so it doesn't happen again?
Thank you, [Your name]

L.6 Asking for a decision in writing

Subject: [The request] for [child]: decision in writing
Hello [name],
On [date] I asked for [the request]. Could you let me know, in writing by [date], whether the answer is yes or no, who made the decision, and the reason?
If it's a no, I'd also like to know which policy or procedure it's based on, and how I can appeal.
Thank you, [Your name]

L.7 Summing up a meeting

Subject: Summary of our meeting on [date]
Hello [names],

Thank you all for meeting today. So we're all working from the same page, here is what I understood was agreed:

— [Action]. [Who]. By [date].

— [Action]. [Who]. By [date].

— [Action]. [Who]. By [date].

Still open: [question], which [name] will answer by [date].
If I've got anything wrong, please let me know by [date]. Otherwise I'll take this as our shared record.
Thank you, [Your name]

L.8 Writing down an incident the same day

Subject: [Child]: what happened on [date]
Hello [name],
I'm writing this down today so we have a record while it's fresh.
At [time], [what you were told or saw, plainly, no adjectives]. [Child] told me [what they said, in their words]. [What you did: for example, took a photo, called the doctor].
Please confirm in writing that this is on [child]'s file. I'd also like to know what happened from the school's side, and how I'll be told about anything like this in future.
Thank you, [Your name]

L.9 A goal or support changed without notice

Subject: Change to [child]'s IPP
Hello [name],
Comparing the IPP dated [date] with the one dated [date], I see that [goal / support / accommodation] has [changed / been removed]. I wasn't told about this before it happened.
Could you tell me in writing, by [date]: when it changed, who decided, what information the decision was based on, and what is in place instead? I have not agreed to this change, and I'm asking for it in writing.
Thank you, [Your name]

L.10 Asking for a new contact

Subject: Contact person for [child]

Hello [name],
Thank you for [something specific]. I'm asking that my contact for [child]'s program be someone who wasn't part of the earlier decisions on [topic], so we can look at it fresh.
Could you tell me in writing by [date] who that will be, and what that person can decide on, including staffing and supports?
Thank you, [Your name]

L.11 Appealing to the board

Check your board's own appeal procedure first. The Education Act requires every board to have one, and you usually have to go through the school's dispute process before you can appeal (see chapter 12).
Subject: Appeal to the Board: [child], [decision]
To the [Board name], through the Secretary-Treasurer / Superintendent,
Under section 42 of the Education Act, I'm appealing the decision of [name, role], made on [date] and communicated to me on [date], that [the decision, in one sentence].
This decision significantly affects [child]'s education because [one or two plain sentences].
Before appealing, I followed the school dispute resolution process: [dates and steps].
I'm asking the Board to [what you want it to decide].
Please confirm receipt, the date of the hearing, and what I need to provide.
[Your name, contact details]

L.12 Asking the Minister to review

For decisions of a board about your child's specialized supports and services, expulsion, or the student record. For supports and expulsions, send it within 60 days of being told the board's decision (Education Act s.43). See chapter 12 for where to send it.
Subject: Request for Minister review under section 43 of the Education Act
To the Minister of Education and Childcare,
Under section 43 of the Education Act, I'm asking the Minister to review the decision of the [Board name], made on [date] and communicated to me on [date], about [child]'s [specialized supports and services / expulsion / student record].

The decision: [one sentence].
Why I believe it was not reasonable in the circumstances: [two or three plain sentences].
Attached: the board's decision, my appeal, and [key documents].
[Your name, contact details]

The deflection dictionary

Every phrase in this book that sends a parent to an entry, in alphabetical order. Find the words you just heard, then turn to the entry. If you heard something close, look for the nearest match: the words change from school to school, the moves don't.

Last verified: October 2026

You're hearing	Turn to
"A private school would be better equipped."	15.7
"Accommodations for the test are decided by the school."	13.7
"ADHD doesn't qualify."	6.2
"Alberta Education requires it."	1.4
"Are you recording this?"	10.12
"At 18 the file closes."	16.10
"Bring it to school council."	1.6
"Can you come and pick him up?"	8.7
"Can you come in and change her?"	7.15
"Can you get us a letter from the doctor?"	9.2
"Can you get us something from the doctor?"	11.14
"Can you just sign here before you go?"	10.11
"Can you pick them up at lunch?"	2.9
"Can't you just be paid to do it yourself?"	16.7
"Charter schools have smaller classes."	15.9
"French immersion isn't a good fit for kids with IPPs."	2.12
"FSCD can't help with school."	16.4
"FSCD is through the school, right?"	16.1
"FSCD should cover that."	9.11
"Grade 1 is a fresh start."	14.4
"Have you applied for the disability tax credit?"	16.11
"Have you called your MLA?"	12.13
"Have you spoken to the principal?"	12.2
"Have you thought about	15.1

You're hearing	Turn to
homeschooling?"	
"Have you thought about the English program?"	7.11
"He can't have a reader on the PAT unless he uses one in class."	7.14
"He doesn't need an EA, he needs independence."	7.3
"He just had some time out of class."	8.6
"He needs three levels of support to qualify."	6.9
"He's been suspended from the bus."	7.13
"He's coded."	6.1
"He's not eligible for the bus."	7.12
"He's on a modified program."	7.6
"He's suspended for the rest of the week."	8.9
"His code doesn't qualify him for that."	6.5
"His EA was needed in another room today."	7.5
"Home might suit them better."	15.1
"I can't direct the school on staffing."	12.4
"I just do what I'm told."	1.8
"I'll have to check on that."	10.9
"I'll have to check with the division."	1.1
"I'm recommending expulsion to the board."	8.10
"If you don't consent, our hands are tied."	5.11
"In junior high, they need to learn to advocate for themselves."	14.7
"Inclusion is a philosophy, not a requirement."	2.3
"It pulls from your registration form."	11.3
"It was a mistake, it went to the wrong parent."	11.10
"It was handled."	8.4
"It'll just be a few of us from the team."	10.2

You're hearing	Turn to
"It'll transfer with him."	4.12
"It's a conflict, not bullying."	8.14
"It's a sensory break, not a time-out."	8.6
"It's a threat assessment, it's protocol."	8.12
"It's in the code of conduct."	2.5
"It's just a safety plan."	8.1
"It's just a screener, don't worry about it."	13.4
"It's just a screener, it's not a diagnosis."	5.9
"It's just until we get staffing."	8.8
"It's not a suspension, just a reset at home."	8.7
"It's ongoing."	4.4
"It's only to confirm you were at the meeting."	4.6
"It's too late to register for this year's funding."	13.6
"It's zero tolerance."	8.9
"Just sign here so the psych can see him."	5.2
"Kids will be kids."	8.14
"Kindergarten isn't part of the school system."	14.3
"Let's not go back over old history."	11.2
"Let's park that for another time."	10.6
"Let's try half days for now."	2.9
"Let's wait and see."	5.1
"Maybe next year."	5.4
"Medical needs are the parent's responsibility."	9.1
"No concerns to note today."	3.13, 11.4
"No decision has been made yet."	12.5
"None of our staff are trained for that."	9.7
"Not every teacher needs to see the IPP."	14.7
"Nothing happens over the summer."	13.13
"Now they're 16, they can sign for themselves."	14.10

You're hearing	Turn to
"Once they're 18, we deal with them, not you."	14.12
"Once you home educate, you're on your own."	15.2
"Once you home school, it's up to you."	1.12
"Online would take the pressure off."	15.6
"Only kids who need it do the spring screening."	13.11
"Only the office can give medication."	9.3
"Other kids with special needs get the same as your child."	2.11
"Our learning support teacher handles the IPP."	1.7
"Our OT only consults."	5.5
"Our procedures don't allow that."	1.3
"Parents have responsibilities too."	2.6
"Please see email."	11.4
"Preschool spots are limited."	14.1
"PUF is only for three years."	14.2
"Registration for next year opens in the new year."	13.9
"Registration for PUF has closed."	6.8
"Reports go home at the end of the term."	13.5
"Request a review first."	16.9
"School isn't the right place for them right now."	2.1
"She can't be here until the nurse is in place."	9.12
"She has support when needed."	7.2
"She was in the quiet room."	8.3
"She's a 54."	6.1
"Staff could be sued."	9.8
"Staff don't do insulin."	9.5
"Supports will look the same wherever they're placed."	14.5
"That assessment is out of date."	5.12

You're hearing	Turn to
"That came out of complexity funding."	6.7
"That isn't discrimination, it's a resourcing issue."	12.11
"That isn't something that can be appealed."	12.6
"That isn't something we'd put in the IPP."	4.2
"That mark was already there this morning."	8.13
"That part is auto-populated."	4.7
"That request is still being processed."	11.8
"That support was only ever meant to be temporary."	7.4
"That support was transitional."	14.5
"That's a division decision." / "That's really a school-level matter."	1.2
"That's a nursing task."	9.11
"That's a privacy matter."	12.10
"That's above my pay grade."	1.1
"That's an old version."	3.9
"That's best handled at the school level."	12.3
"That's division policy."	1.3
"That's just how we do it here."	1.4
"That's not how I remember it."	11.12
"That's not on the agenda today."	10.6
"That's not part of the student record."	3.4
"That's not severe enough for a 44."	6.2
"That's on PASI."	3.7
"That's only for severe codes."	6.5
"That's something you'd go through your doctor for."	5.5
"That's the professional's opinion. We can't change it."	11.9
"That's what PowerSchool shows."	3.6
"That's what's in the system."	3.1
"The -4 courses are a better fit."	14.9

You're hearing	Turn to
"The accommodations are in place."	7.7
"The behaviour plan is still in place."	3.10
"The board's decision is final."	12.7
"The calendar's on the website somewhere."	13.1
"The code was updated."	6.4
"The division team has a few recommendations."	10.8
"The EA will take care of that."	7.1
"The emergency plan is for the whole school."	9.13
"The EpiPen is in the office."	9.4
"The funding doesn't follow them to Grade 1."	14.4
"The IPP is a living document, it changes as we go."	4.5
"The IPP is just a planning document."	3.1
"The IPP is the report card."	4.9
"The ISP and the IPP are basically the same thing."	16.5
"The money doesn't follow the child."	6.6
"The portal is up to date."	3.6
"The psych will send a summary."	5.7
"The psychologist's report is with the division."	3.12
"The report card shows they're doing fine."	3.8
"The school should be covering that."	16.4
"The system doesn't track who changed it."	11.11
"The teacher has to make the referral."	5.1
"The team has already decided."	2.4
"The van comes at 2:15."	7.13
"The waitlist is so long there's no point yet."	16.2
"The winter screening is for everyone."	13.8
"Their code carries over automatically."	13.3

You're hearing	Turn to
"Their teacher couldn't make it, but I can speak for them."	10.7
"There are several adults circulating in the room."	7.2
"There are special schools for kids like yours."	15.8
"There's a fee for copies."	11.5
"There's a long waitlist for the psychologist."	5.4
"There's no deadline on that."	13.14
"There's no deadline, take your time."	12.15
"There's no funding for an aide."	6.6
"There's no funding for that."	2.2
"There's no room in that program."	2.12
"There's nothing in the file you haven't seen."	3.3
"They age out at 19."	14.11
"They won't get a diploma if you don't follow the curriculum."	15.4
"They'll still graduate."	14.8
"This is a meeting for parents and staff only."	10.3
"This placement isn't the right fit."	7.10
"Those are just my own notes."	10.14
"Those are just recommendations."	5.8
"Those are just the teacher's notes."	3.4
"Those are recommendations, not requirements."	5.6
"Trustees don't get involved in individual cases."	12.8
"Try the Ombudsman."	12.12
"Under the new provincial framework..."	2.7
"Under the School Act..."	1.5
"We adjusted that goal, it wasn't appropriate any more."	4.8
"We all met beforehand to get on the same page."	10.7

You're hearing	Turn to
"We already have that on file."	3.2
"We assess on an ongoing basis."	4.4
"We call it an ISP here."	4.1
"We can't change what's in the record."	3.5
"We can't code her until the psych assessment is done."	6.10
"We can't do anything until there's a diagnosis."	5.10
"We can't meet their needs here."	2.8
"We can't release the video."	11.6
"We can't talk to the school without consent."	16.6
"We could do part days here and part at home."	15.5
"We didn't have coverage, so can you pick her up?"	7.5
"We don't allow recording in our meetings."	10.12
"We don't have a seizure policy."	9.6
"We don't have an EA for the trip."	8.11
"We don't have staff for toileting."	7.15
"We don't have to provide that."	2.2
"We don't really use the laptop in class."	7.8
"We don't share codes."	6.3
"We don't take minutes at these meetings."	10.14
"We don't test for giftedness until later."	6.11
"We follow the provincial diabetes guidelines."	9.5
"We had to call the police."	8.12
"We had to hold him for his safety."	8.3
"We have no record of that."	11.13
"We have those recorded at school."	3.13, 8.4
"We have to try the lower tiers first."	4.13
"We just want to touch base."	10.1

You're hearing	Turn to
"We missed the lunchtime dose, but he seemed fine."	9.3
"We need to do six weeks of intervention before we can refer."	5.3
"We need you to sign the safety plan."	8.5
"We think a specialized class would suit him better."	7.9
"We think a specialized program would suit them better."	2.3
"We took the plan off, things have been going well."	8.2
"We updated the plan."	9.10
"We use our own format."	4.2
"We write the IPPs in October."	13.2
"We'll call 911 and then call you."	9.9
"We'll fold it into the next IPP."	5.8
"We'll get you to sign it later."	4.6
"We'll go over it all at the meeting."	10.5
"We'll go through the goals when we meet."	4.3
"We'll place an alert on the file."	3.11
"We'll send a summary."	10.13
"We'll send everything after the meeting."	10.1
"We'll sort out supports once we get to know them."	13.1
"We'll take it under advisement."	5.6
"We'll talk about next year in June."	13.10
"We'll wait for the file from the old division."	14.6
"We're a Catholic school, it's different here."	1.9
"We're a charter school, those rules don't apply."	1.10
"We're a private school."	1.11
"We're accommodating them as much as we can."	2.10

You're hearing	Turn to
"We're doing everything we can."	10.9
"We're going to put a behaviour plan in place."	8.1
"We're going to try half days for now."	8.8
"We're not medical professionals."	9.1
"We're still looking into it."	12.5
"We're still using last year's plan."	8.2
"We're still waiting on your documents."	16.3
"We're using the updated one."	3.9
"We've drafted it for you to review."	4.10
"We've had to move some staff around."	7.4
"We've put an alert on the file."	9.2
"What exactly are you looking for?"	3.14
"Whatever's in the system goes with him."	9.9
"Who should I even complain to?"	12.1
"You can always come back."	15.10 and 15.11
"You can file a complaint against the teacher."	12.9
"You can't just look at the file."	11.5
"You don't need to keep all that."	11.1
"You get funding for home education."	15.3
"You haven't gone through our process yet."	12.3
"You need a diagnosis before you can apply."	16.2
"You need to start with the teacher."	12.2
"You need to work with us."	2.6
"You seem upset. Should we take a break?"	10.10
"You'd have to take us to court."	12.14
"You'll get a copy once it's finalized."	4.11
"You'll get the final IPP in the fall."	13.12
"You'll have to put in a FOIP."	11.7
"You're welcome to come along as his support."	8.11

You're hearing	Turn to
"Your agreement expired."	16.8
"Your child can translate for you."	10.4
"Your child will have an IPP this year."	4.1
"Your file was closed."	16.2

The words they use

What the words in school meetings, letters and plans mean, in plain language. Each one points to the entry where it matters most.

Last verified: October 2026

People and places

Board, school board, division. The elected body that runs your public, Catholic (separate) or francophone schools, and the organization it runs. The board makes the decisions the Education Act gives it. See 1.1.

Trustee. An elected member of the school board. Board meetings are held in public, though a board can vote to meet privately for part of a meeting. See 12.8.

Superintendent. The board's chief executive officer and chief education officer: the most senior staff member in the division. See 12.4.

Principal. Runs the school. The 2004 Standards make principals accountable for delivering special education programming in their school. See 1.1.

Learning support teacher, inclusive education lead, student services. Different divisions use different names for the staff who coordinate support for students with extra needs. Ask what your division calls them. See 1.7.

EA (educational assistant). An adult who works with students under a certificated teacher's direction. Also called aide or teacher assistant. See 7.1.

Learning team. Everyone who plans your child's program: teachers, you, your child where appropriate, and others as needed. See 4.10.

School council. A group of parents and staff that advises the principal and board. It does not decide your child's program. See 1.6.

Charter school. A public school run by a society or company under a charter, with its own focus. Not covered by the 2004 Standards. See 1.10.

Independent (private) school. A school not run by a board. Only some parts of the Education Act apply to it. See 1.11 and 15.7.

DSEIS (Designated Special Education Independent School). A private school approved by the province to serve students with severe needs. See 15.8.

Plans and documents

IPP (Individualized Program Plan). The written plan for a student the school has identified as needing specialized supports and services. Some divisions call it an ISP (instructional support plan). See 4.1.

ISP. Two different things share these letters. At school, an instructional support plan, another name for an IPP. In FSCD, an Individualized Service Plan for specialized services. See 4.1 and 16.5.

Behaviour plan, PBSP (positive behaviour support plan), safety plan. A plan for how staff prevent and respond to behaviour. No provincial rule fixes the name or the form. See 8.1.

Health care plan, emergency response plan. A plan for a medical need at school. Anaphylaxis has its own law. See 9.1 and 9.4.

Student record. The official record a board must keep about your child, including the IPP and every amendment to it. You can see it and get a copy. See 3.3 and 11.5.

PASI. The province's student information system. It holds your child's Alberta Student Number, enrolment and special education code. See 3.7.

ASN (Alberta Student Number). Your child's nine-digit provincial number. See 3.7.

MyPass. The province's website where students, and parents with access, can see provincial records such as test results. See 3.7.

Parent portal. The division's own website or app (for example, PowerSchool). It shows some information. It is not the student record. See 3.6.

Registration form. The form you fill in when your child enrols. Keep a copy every year. See 3.2 and 4.7.

Programs and support

Specialized supports and services. The legal name for support beyond what every student gets, when a student's needs impair their ability and opportunity to learn. See 2.2.

Accommodation. A change in how your child is taught or tested, without changing what they are expected to learn. See 7.6.

Adapted programming. Your child works on the regular curriculum with changes to how it's taught. See 7.6.

Modified programming. Your child's learning outcomes are significantly different from the regular curriculum. It can affect credits and diplomas later. See 7.6 and 14.8.

Continuum of supports and services. The range of support a board must provide, consistent with inclusive education (Education Act s.33(1)(e)). See 2.2.

Universal, targeted, individualized (the tiers, the pyramid). The province's way of grouping support: for everyone, for small groups, for one child. Individual support does not depend on finishing the lower tiers first. See 4.13 and 5.3.

Specialized setting, congregated class. A class or program just for students with particular needs. Guidance says it should be considered only when essential. See 7.9.

Assistive technology. Tools that help a child access learning or communicate, from pencil grips to speech-to-text. See 7.8.

Special education code. A number the school enters in PASI to report a student's needs to the province (for example, 41 to 48 for severe needs, 51 to 59 for mild and moderate). It can be missing or wrong. See 6.1.

PUF (Program Unit Funding). Provincial funding for preschool and kindergarten children with severe needs. See 6.8 and 14.1.

ECS (Early Childhood Services). Preschool and kindergarten. Children in ECS are not "students" under the Education Act, but some rights still apply. See 14.3.

Assessment

Screening. A short check given to many children, like the new literacy and numeracy screenings. Not a diagnosis. See 5.9.

Specialized assessment, psychoeducational assessment. A formal assessment by a qualified professional, such as a psychologist or speech-language pathologist. The school must get your written consent first. See 5.1 and 5.2.

Current level of performance. Where your child is now, measured, stated so you could compare it next time. See 4.4 and 4.9.

Target date. The date by which an IPP objective is meant to be met and reviewed. See 4.4.

Reporting period. The times in the year the school reports progress, usually three or four. See 4.9 and 13.5.

Rights and rules

Act. A law passed by the Legislature, like the Education Act. Binding.

Regulation. Rules made under an Act, like the Student Record Regulation. Binding.

Ministerial order, standard. Rules the Minister makes under the Education Act, like the Standards for Special Education (2004). See 1.4.

Guidance, framework. Documents that say what the province expects, like the Student Support Policy Framework (2026). Not law. See 2.7.

Administrative procedure (AP), division policy. Your division's own rules. Binding on its staff. Ask to see them. See 1.3.

Informed consent. You have all the information, you agree in writing, and you can withdraw your agreement at any time. See 4.6.

Independent student. A student who is 18 or older, or 16 or older and living independently or under certain agreements. Parents' rights under the Act pass to the student. See 14.12.

Specialized supports and services, determination. The board's decision that your child needs specialized supports. See 2.2.

Complex Education Needs Tribunal. A panel the Act allows the Minister to set up when a board says it cannot meet a student's needs. None had been found established as of October 2026. See 2.8.

Suspension. Removal from class, school, the bus or activities by a teacher (one class) or principal (up to 5 school days). See 8.9.

Expulsion. A board decision, only on a principal's recommendation, made within 10 school days of the suspension. The board must still provide an education program and supports. See 8.10.

Seclusion. Involuntary confinement of a child alone in a room or area they cannot freely leave. Only as a last resort for imminent danger of serious physical harm, never as punishment. See 8.3.

Time-out. A behaviour intervention, which is not the same as seclusion. See 8.6.

Complaints and appeals

School dispute resolution policy. The board's process for concerns at school level. You must use it before appealing to the board. See 12.3.

Appeal to the board (section 42). Your right to appeal a staff decision that significantly affects your child's education. A failure to decide counts as a decision. See 12.6.

Minister review (section 43). Asking the Minister to review a board's decision about specialized supports, expulsion, the student record or which board is responsible. See 12.7.

ATPC (Alberta Teaching Profession Commission). Handles complaints about a teacher's or school leader's own conduct or competence. Not about whether a program or IPP is good enough. See 12.9.

OIPC (Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner). Reviews access-to-information decisions and privacy complaints. See 12.10.

ATIA, POPA. The Access to Information Act and the Protection of Privacy Act. They replaced FOIP on 11 June 2025. See 11.7 and 11.10.

AHRC (Alberta Human Rights Commission). Takes complaints of discrimination, including disability discrimination in services like education. One-year limit. See 12.11.

Ombudsman. Cannot investigate complaints about schools. It can look at the fairness of some government processes, like an FSCD appeal. See 12.12 and 16.9.

Outside school

FSCD (Family Support for Children with Disabilities). Provincial program, run by Assisted Living and Social Services, that supports families of children with disabilities. Separate from school. See 16.1.

Family support services, child-focused services. FSCD's two kinds of help: support for the family, and support aimed at the child. See 16.1.

TAP (Transition to Adulthood Plan). FSCD's plan from age 16. See 16.10.

Every entry in this book

Entries are numbered, not paged. The number is the same in every copy and every edition, so “turn to 4.7” always means the same entry. Chapter page numbers are in the contents at the front.

1. How school works in Alberta

1.1 You don't know who decides what

1.2 The principal says it's a division decision and the division says it's the school's

1.3 They say it's division policy: ask to see it

1.4 Is this a rule or a preference?

1.5 The rule they're quoting is out of date

1.6 You're told to take it to the school council

1.7 Nobody can tell you who is in charge of your child's plan

1.8 The EA says they can't change anything

1.9 Your child goes to a Catholic (separate) or francophone school

1.10 Your child goes to a charter school: which rules apply

1.11 Your child goes to a private (independent) school

1.12 You're home educating or using an online school

2. Your child’s rights and the school’s duties

2.1 Your child's right to go to school, and how long it lasts

2.2 "We don't have to provide that"

2.3 They want to move your child to a special class or another school

2.4 They decided without talking to you

2.5 They point to the code of conduct

2.6 "Parents have responsibilities too"

2.7 They quote the new provincial framework at you

2.8 "We can't meet their needs here"

2.9 They want your child on a shortened or partial day

2.10 Is this discrimination? The Human Rights Act

2.11 They compare your child to other kids with special needs

2.12 Your child is turned away from the school or program you chose

3. The paperwork

3.1 Two documents say different things. Which one counts?

3.2 The registration form
3.3 Nobody will tell you what's in the student record
3.4 They say those notes aren't part of the record
3.5 Something in the record is wrong
3.6 The portal says one thing and the IPP says another
3.7 PASI, the Alberta Student Number and MyPass
3.8 The report card and the IPP don't tell the same story
3.9 There are two different versions of the same plan
3.10 The behaviour plan describes a classroom your child isn't in any more
3.11 You were promised a health plan and got "an alert on the file"
3.12 You never got a copy of the assessment
3.13 The daily note says "a good day" and the school's own log doesn't
3.14 Asking for the whole file

4. The IPP

4.1 What an IPP is, and who gets one
4.2 What the IPP has to contain
4.3 You haven't seen the goals before the meeting
4.4 They won't give you a date for when progress is measured
4.5 "It's a living document"
4.6 The IPP has no parent signature on it
4.7 The medical information is wrong or missing
4.8 A goal changed or vanished and nobody told you
4.9 "The IPP is the report card"
4.10 You weren't part of writing it
4.11 Getting your own copy, and keeping it
4.12 What happens to it when your child changes school
4.13 They want to try everything else first

5. Assessment: getting your child identified and tested

5.1 You think your child needs to be assessed
5.2 They want you to sign a consent form
5.3 They want to try the lower tiers before they'll refer
5.4 "There's a long waitlist"
5.5 Who does which assessment
5.6 Paying for a private assessment, and whether the school will use it

5.7 Getting the report, and having it explained
5.8 The assessment never made it into the IPP
5.9 The new reading and math screening, Kindergarten to Grade 3
5.10 "We can't do anything until there's a diagnosis"
5.11 You said no to an assessment, or want to limit it
5.12 "That assessment is out of date"

6. Codes and money

6.1 What a special education code is
6.2 What each code needs
6.3 You don't know your child's code
6.4 The code is wrong, missing, or changed without telling you
6.5 "His code doesn't qualify him for that"
6.6 "There's no funding for an aide"
6.7 Where the money for support comes from
6.8 Preschool and kindergarten: Program Unit Funding
6.9 Charter and private schools: severe disabilities funding
6.10 Coding while you wait for a diagnosis
6.11 Gifted and talented (Code 80)

7. Support in the classroom

7.1 What an EA is, and who directs them
7.2 Who is with your child, and for how long
7.3 "He doesn't need an EA, he needs independence"
7.4 The EA was removed or cut mid-year
7.5 Your child's EA is pulled to cover, or is away
7.6 Accommodations or modifications: which program is your child on
7.7 Accommodations on the IPP aren't happening
7.8 Assistive technology
7.9 They want to move your child to a specialized class
7.10 "This placement isn't the right fit"
7.11 French immersion and support
7.12 Getting a bus that works for your child
7.13 Trouble on the bus, or the bus cuts the school day
7.14 Accommodations on provincial tests and diploma exams
7.15 Toileting and personal care at school

8. Behaviour, safety, and being sent home

8.1 They want to put a behaviour plan in place

8.2 The behaviour plan is out of date, or it vanished

8.3 What the rules on restraint and seclusion allow

8.4 Your child was restrained or secluded: what you should get afterwards

8.5 They want your consent to a plan that includes restraint or seclusion

8.6 Time-out, the hallway, the office, the "calm room"

8.7 They keep calling you to come and get your child

8.8 Your child is on a shortened or partial day

8.9 Your child has been suspended

8.10 The principal is recommending expulsion

8.11 Your child was left out of a field trip or activity

8.12 Police or emergency services came to the school

8.13 Your child came home hurt

8.14 Your child is being bullied

9. Health and medical needs at school

9.1 Who is responsible for your child's medical safety at school

9.2 There's "an alert on the file" but no plan

9.3 Medication at school

9.4 Life-threatening allergies

9.5 Type 1 diabetes

9.6 Seizures

9.7 "None of our staff are trained for that"

9.8 "Staff could be liable"

9.9 When 911 is called: what goes with your child

9.10 Something in the health plan changed and nobody told you

9.11 Nursing-level care: whose job is it at school?

9.12 Kept home because medical needs "can't be met"

9.13 The school's emergency plan doesn't mention your child

10. Meetings

10.1 You've been called to a meeting and don't know what it's about

10.2 You don't know who'll be in the room, or who can decide anything

10.3 You want to bring someone with you

10.4 You need an interpreter, or someone to explain the words

10.5 "We'll go over it at the meeting"
10.6 "That's not on the agenda today"
10.7 You're outnumbered, and some of them have never met your child
10.8 A case conference with division staff
10.9 You keep getting answers that aren't answers
10.10 Keeping your own notes, and keeping your footing
10.11 They want you to sign something at the table
10.12 Recording the meeting
10.13 After the meeting: the follow-up email
10.14 Asking for the minutes or notes

11. Records and evidence

11.1 What to keep, and how to keep it
11.2 The chronology: date, what happened, source
11.3 Keep the registration form, every year
11.4 Daily notes and the home-school book
11.5 Getting your child's student record
11.6 Video and recordings the school holds
11.7 Making an access request to the school board
11.8 They haven't answered, or they held things back
11.9 Something in the record is wrong
11.10 Your child's information went somewhere it shouldn't
11.11 Who changed it, and when: audit trails
11.12 Written at the time, or remembered later
11.13 Their documents don't agree with each other
11.14 Records made outside the school

12. When it goes wrong: the ladder

12.1 Which door? Keeping each problem in its own lane
12.2 Start with the teacher, then the principal
12.3 The school's dispute resolution policy
12.4 The superintendent and the division office
12.5 Nobody will make a decision
12.6 Appealing to the school board
12.7 Asking the Minister to review the board's decision
12.8 Trustees and public board meetings

12.9 A complaint about a teacher's or principal's conduct
12.10 Privacy and access: the Information and Privacy Commissioner
12.11 Disability discrimination: the Alberta Human Rights Commission
12.12 The Ombudsman and the Child and Youth Advocate
12.13 Your MLA
12.14 The courts, and the Complex Education Needs Tribunal
12.15 The deadlines, in one table

13. The school year, month by month

13.1 Before school starts: August
13.2 September: the new IPP
13.3 September: count day and your child's code
13.4 Late September and October: the fall screening
13.5 October and November: the first reporting period
13.6 November: the preschool funding deadline
13.7 November and December: test accommodations for January
13.8 January: the winter screening and the second semester
13.9 February and March: registration and the June test deadline
13.10 April: planning next year starts now
13.11 May: the spring screening and the end-of-year meeting
13.12 June: tests, the year-end summary and the last copies
13.13 Summer: what keeps running
13.14 The clocks that don't follow the school calendar

14. Transitions

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14.2 "PUF is only for three years"
14.3 Starting kindergarten
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14.7 Junior high: many teachers, one plan
14.8 Senior high: diploma, certificate, or neither
14.9 A program change that closes a door later
14.10 Turning 16
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15. Other paths

15.1 "Have you thought about homeschooling?"
15.2 What a school board owes a home-educated child
15.3 The money in home education
15.4 Following the curriculum, or not, and what it means for credits
15.5 Part at school, part at home: shared responsibility
15.6 Online school
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15.8 Designated special education private schools
15.9 Charter schools
15.10 What you keep and what you give up when you leave
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16. Outside school: FSCD and the rest of the support stack

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16.3 What you need to apply
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16.8 Your agreement is ending
16.9 When FSCD says no
16.10 From 16 to 18: FSCD's transition planning
16.11 The federal layer: the disability tax credit and the child disability benefit

Letters

L.1 You want the draft IPP before the meeting (4.3)
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L.4 You want a copy of the student record (4.11)
L.5 You want a correction to the record (4.7)
L.6 You want a decision in writing (4.1)
L.7 Summing up a meeting (chapter 10)

L.8 Writing down an incident the same day (chapter 8)

L.9 A goal or support changed without notice (4.8)

L.10 Asking for a contact who wasn't part of earlier decisions (chapter 12)

L.11 Appealing to the board (chapter 12)

L.12 Asking the Minister to review a board decision (chapter 12)

Where this book gets its answers

The source index.

Every one of the 207 entries in this book ends with a line beginning "Source:". That line names the exact document the entry rests on, the section or page inside it, which version was read, and whether it is law, a regulation, a standard, policy or guidance. Nothing in this book asks you to take its word for anything.

This index gathers those documents in one place, strongest first, so you can go and read any of them yourself — or hand the name and section to a school and ask them to.

Law — Acts of the Alberta Legislature

Education Act, SA 2012 c.E-0.3 Cited in 95 entries, chapters 1–15. This edition read the version current as of 11 December 2025 and 1 September 2026. open.alberta.ca/publications/e00p3

Alberta Human Rights Act, RSA 2000 c.A-25.5 Cited in 10 entries, chapters 1–2, 7–9, 12–13, 15. This edition read the version current as of 1 April 2023.

Protection of Students with Life-threatening Allergies Act, SA 2019 c.P-30.6 Cited in 7 entries, chapters 3, 9. This edition read the version current as of 1 September 2025.

Access to Information Act and Protection of Privacy Act (replaced FOIP, 11 June 2025) Cited in 7 entries, chapters 10–12. This edition read the version current as of 11 December 2025 and 18 December 2025.

Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act and Regulation Cited in 6 entries, chapters 13, 16.

Regulations — made under an Act

Student Record Regulation, AR 97/2019 Cited in 27 entries, chapters 1, 3–6, 9–11, 14. This edition read the version current as of 1 September 2025.

Home Education Regulation, AR 89/2019 Cited in 7 entries, chapters 1, 15. This edition read the version current as of 1 September 2025.

Ministerial orders and standards — binding on school boards

Standards for Special Education, Amended June 2004, under Ministerial Order 015/2004 Cited in 95 entries, chapters 1–16. open.alberta.ca/publications/0778537781

Standards for Seclusion and Physical Restraint in Alberta Schools, appendix to Ministerial Order 042/2019 Cited in 9 entries, chapters 3, 8.

Provincial policy and guidance — not law

Student Support Policy Framework, Education and Childcare, 22 October 2026 Cited in 51 entries, chapters 1–2, 4–11, 14–16.

Alberta Education, Individualized Program Planning (2006) Cited in 36 entries, chapters 3–5, 7–8, 10–11, 13–14, 16.

Guide to Education: ECS to Grade 12 Cited in 23 entries, chapters 1, 3–4, 6–7, 10–11, 14–15. This edition read the version current as of 18 December 2025.

Funding Manual for School Authorities, and the funding profiles Cited in 19 entries, chapters 6–7, 13–16.

Special Education Coding Criteria Cited in 13 entries, chapters 3, 5–6, 13.

Other Alberta Education publications, and pages on alberta.ca Cited in 21 entries, chapters 1–4, 7–11, 13–14.

Case law

Moore v. British Columbia (Education), 2012 SCC 61, [2012] 3 S.C.R. 360 Cited in 1 entry, chapter 2.

Where to find them

Acts and regulations. The official consolidated text is published by the Alberta King's Printer. Search the Act or regulation by name. The consolidation date is printed on the first page: that is the thing to compare against the date in an entry's Source line.

Ministry publications — standards, guides, frameworks, funding manuals. open.alberta.ca. Search the exact title. Older documents are listed by their ISBN, which is why two of the addresses above look like numbers.

Current policy. alberta.ca. This is where a framework or a guide is replaced without the old one being taken down, so check the date on what you are reading.

Court decisions. Free at canlii.org, by the citation given above.

Checking whether an entry is still good

You do not need a lawyer to do this, and it takes about five minutes.

1. Read the Source line under the entry. It names the document, the section, and the version that was read.
2. Find that document using the addresses above.
3. Compare the consolidation or publication date on the copy you have found with the one in the Source line.
4. If the dates match, the entry is reading the same text you are. If the copy you have found is newer, read the section itself — it may be unchanged, and most of the time it is.
5. If it has changed, write to the address at the back. That correction goes up on the live chapter page first and into the next edition after that.

Every address in this index is kept current at albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app/guide/sources, because a printed web address goes stale and a printed citation does not. The document names and section numbers above are the part that lasts.

About the author

Chantal Trepanier is a grassroots advocate and a parent in St. Albert, Alberta.

She did not set out to write any of this. She set out to get her children through school. What she found on the way was that the information a parent needs is public, binding and almost never handed over — and that the parents who eventually find it are the ones who fought long enough, late enough and at enough kitchen tables to piece it together alone.

She founded **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** so that other families would not have to pay that price. Its work runs the length of a life: birth to grave. Early intervention and FSCD. School, from the first IPP to the last. AISH, ADAP, PDD and the appeal routes out of all of them. Guardianship and trusteeship. Aging, continuing care, and what happens to a disabled adult when the people who have been holding the file are gone.

Everything she publishes is sourced. Every claim names where it came from and when it was last checked, so that anybody can verify it, quote it, or take it into a meeting and put it on the table. Nothing is behind a paywall. Nothing asks for a donation.

She wrote this book because she needed it and nobody had written it.

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Inform. Connect. Empower. Create change.

A grassroots project documenting how Alberta's disability systems actually work, and where they break.

What's there. Sourced reports on AISH, ADAP, FSCD, PDD, Indigenous disability services and disability appeals. Printable flyers and tools. Plain-language breakdowns of the rules. Every figure carries its source and the date it was checked.

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Speak up. Speak out. Be heard.

Corrections, and the next edition

This book is reissued once a year, because the rules change and because a reference that is not re-checked becomes a liability to the person holding it.

If something here is wrong, out of date, or no longer matches the rule it cites, write to AlbertaDisabilityBreakdown@outlook.com with the entry number — 4.7, 12.15, L.9 — and what you found. Corrections go up on the live chapter page first, and into the next annual edition after that. You will be credited unless you ask not to be.

If a school or division tells you that something in this book is wrong, ask them for the section number they are relying on, and send that to the same address. That is how the next edition gets better: not from argument, but from citations.

Edition: 2026–27 school year. Last verified: October 2026.

You signed it.

Nobody told you what it said.

A small chair at a small table. Someone slides a document across with your child's name on it, and everyone in the room already knows what it means.

This is the book that tells you what it said.

Turn here when you're hearing:

- *"Let's wait and see."*
- *"There's no funding for that."*
- *"We're still using last year's plan."*
- *"You don't need to keep all that."*
- *"Have you thought about homeschooling?"*

207 entries across 16 chapters. Every one names the rule it rests on, where that rule is written, and how binding it actually is — law, regulation, standard, or just how we do it here.

Each gives you four things: what's really going on, what the rule says, what to say out loud in under forty words, and what to ask for in writing.

Twelve letters you can copy. A dictionary of the phrases above.

Every source named and dated, so you can check it yourself.

It isn't angry. A book that argues can be argued with.

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